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This book reopens a subject which has been virtually unapproachable through substantial works in English for over fifty years. It deals mainly with the inland aspects of Napoleon's Continental Blockade, and draws widely on French and German sources to offer a more general reappraisal of the topic. Its regional focus is on the frontier province of Alsace (the departments of the Bas-Rhin and Haut-Rhin), where the aims and effects of the Blockade stand in interesting contrast to the rather sombre view from the beleaguered Continental coastline. It looks beyond the Blockade as a 'coast system' or a 'war machine' to assess its importance in the heartland of Napoleonic Europe as well.

The author examines the achievements and reverses of Alsatian trade and industry from the rupture of the Peace of Amiens in 1803 to the disintegration of the Blockade in 1813. In so doing he reveals that the Blockade had more positive and constructive effects than has generally been supposed. Confined to the Continent by the naval superiority of Britain, and deprived of their colonial markets and sources of supply, French merchants and manufacturers were forced back on the resources of the Continental mainland. The French military successes of 1805-7 seemed to open up new opportunities for them to conquer Continental markets beyond the imperial frontiers, just as they already enjoyed full official protection at home.

The author brings up to date the long-neglected history and historiography of the Continental system; he significantly modifies accepted views on the effect of Napoleonic policy on the French economy during the wars and their aftermath, and provides an important, detailed bibliography to serve the needs of specialized researchers in this field.

Dr. Ellis is Fellow and Tutor in Modern History at Hertford College, Oxford.

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NAPOLEON'S CONTINENTAL BLOCKADE:

The Case of Alsace

BY

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TO MY FAMILY

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PREFACE

This book is the result of research first launched in the later 1960s, the backbone of which was my Oxford D.Phil. thesis presented in 1972. Since then it has undergone the inevitable and I can only hope profitable process of revision and recasting for publication in the present series. My original interest in and concept of the subject formed at a time when Britain had not yet entered the European Economic Community, and indeed when French opposition to our entry was well known. The very crude analogy with Napoleon's Continental Blockade, however superficial and misleading it might have been, assimilating modern peacetime conditions and attitudes to much earlier wartime ones, was yet too tempting not to indulge.

I ask for the reader's tolerance of such licence. The Napoleonic power bloc roughly corresponded, at least in its most secure parts, to the area of the original Common Market of our own time. Spain, Portugal, the Illyrian provinces, and the duchy of Warsaw, though part of the 'Grand Empire' too, did not experience the continuity and immediacy of French rule to which subject Germany, the Benelux countries, and Italy were exposed. The image of a great Continental *Zollverein*, with its back perforce turned to *le grand large* and with Britain shut out, came naturally to one projecting himself from an English university into the archives and libraries of France. And yet, of course, Napoleon's aim was not to create a European Common Market, but rather a protected one at home and (so far as possible) a preferential one for France abroad. Its internal features, quite apart from its economic prematurity, hardly square with those of the Common Market in de Gaulle's time. It seemed nice, then, to stand the analogy on its head and present an image of Napoleon's 'Uncommon Market'. How well that motif has weathered the intervening years, with Britain now a member of the Community and my own chosen base of Strasbourg the very seat of its first democratically elected assembly, my

readers may judge for themselves. Certainly, something of the topicality of the analogy has been lost; but of the reality of the market question in Napoleon's Blockade policy I remain as convinced as I ever was.

It is a pleasure to acknowledge my debt to colleagues and friends from whose criticism and advice I have benefited in the present undertaking. Professor Richard Cobb, who supervised my thesis, has given me much more than help and encouragement. By communicating in his unique way the love and joy of France and its archives, a privilege all his research students have known, his friendship has been a constant stimulus to me. Dr Angus Macintyre was kind enough to read the typescript of this work before its submission to the publishers and his advice was invaluable. Dr John Roberts gave me critical guidance at an early stage of my research, when — just conceivably — it might have taken a rather different route into the obscure recesses of Rhenish *réfractairisme*. I was also immensely fortunate to have the helpful criticism of Professor François Crouzet and Dr Patrick O'Brien at the oral examination of my thesis, and both subsequently advised me on particular details. Professor Louis Bergeron and Professor Maurice Lévy-Leboyer have kindly allowed me to use the matter which appears in my Table 9 on p. 190. My debt to the participants at Richard Cobb's graduate seminar over the years, and to so many pupils, is happily and gratefully acknowledged. It would be a churlish return for such kindnesses if I did not dissociate all those named from the shortcomings of this study.

On the institutional side, I should like to thank the many archivists and librarians who have helped me in this research, not least at the departmental and communal archives in Strasbourg and Colmar. I am particularly indebted to the Chamber of Commerce and Industry in Strasbourg for allowing me access, both in 1969 and 1970, to the detailed minutes of meetings held during the Napoleonic period. I would similarly thank the Dean and Students of Christ Church, Oxford, for leave of absence and financial assistance in 1968-9, when the basis of my thesis was laid in France, and when the Blockade seemed at times barely distinguishable from the barricades and tear-gas of another quarrel. I should also like

to thank the University of Durham for a travel and study grant in 1974, which enabled me to begin the serious revision of my thesis text for publication.

But I leave till last my greatest debt of all, which is to my wife and family, whose patience and encouragement have been exemplary. They at least will rejoice at the final product, whatever its reception, and welcome their liberation from its periodic quarantines. Napoleon's Blockade was never more real than in their experience of it, and I thank them in full measure for sharing its confinement so cheerfully.

*Hertford College,
Oxford
August 1980*

G.J.E.

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ABBREVIATIONS

1. *Citation of Archival Sources*

A.D. (B-R)	Archives Départementales du Bas-Rhin (Strasbourg)
A.D. (H-R)	Archives Départementales du Haut-Rhin (Colmar)
A.N.	Archives Nationales
Arch. comm. Colm.	Archives communales/de la ville de Colmar
Arch. comm. Mulh.	Archives communales/de la ville de Mulhouse
Arch. comm. Strasb.	Archives communales/de la ville de Strasbourg
Min. i-viii	Minutes of the Chamber of Commerce and Industry in Strasbourg, volumes i to viii (1803-13)

2. *Titles of Periodicals*

<i>Als. fr.</i>	<i>Alsace française</i>
<i>Ann. É.S.C.</i>	<i>Annales: Économies, Sociétés, Civilisations</i>
<i>A.h.R.f.</i>	<i>Annales historiques de la Révolution française</i>
<i>Bull. Soc. ind. Mulh.</i>	<i>Bulletin de la Société industrielle de Mulhouse</i>
<i>Dte. Rev.</i>	<i>Deutsche Revue</i>
<i>Ec. H.R.</i>	<i>Economic History Review</i>
<i>Ec. J.</i>	<i>Economic Journal</i>
<i>Eng. H.R.</i>	<i>English Historical Review</i>
<i>J. Ec. H.</i>	<i>Journal of Economic History</i>
<i>J.M.H.</i>	<i>Journal of Modern History</i>
<i>R. d'Als.</i>	<i>Revue d'Alsace</i>
<i>R. éc.</i>	<i>Revue économique</i>
<i>R. Ét. nap.</i>	<i>Revue des Études napoléoniennes</i>
<i>R. d'H. dip.</i>	<i>Revue d'Histoire diplomatique</i>
<i>R. d'H. Doctr. éc. et soc.</i>	<i>Revue d'Histoire des Doctrines économiques et sociales</i>
<i>R. d'H. mod. (et contemp.)</i>	<i>Revue d'Histoire moderne (et contemporaine)</i>

<i>R. h.</i>	<i>Revue historique</i>
<i>R. Inst. Nap.</i>	<i>Revue de l'Institut Napoléon</i>
<i>Schmollers Jahrbuch</i>	<i>Jahrbuch für Gesetzgebung, Verwaltung und Volkswirtschaft im deutschen Reiche herausgegeben von Gustav Schmoller</i>
<i>Vjs. f. Soz.- u. Wirtsch.</i>	<i>Vierteljahrschrift für Sozial- und Wirt- schaftsgeschichte</i>
<i>Zs. f. d. Gesch. d. Oberrh.</i>	<i>Zeitschrift für die Geschichte des Ober- rheins</i>

QUOTATION AND TRANSLATION

Apart from extracts, phrases, and terms which could be Englished without loss of sense or idiom, quoted French passages are not translated. The original spelling and punctuation are kept wherever the meaning is clear. Quotations from German sources are translated, except where the original form (for instance of technical terms or idiomatic phrases) seems preferable.

SPELLING OF PLACE-NAMES

Wherever an accepted English spelling of a foreign place-name is available, this is the usage adopted. Otherwise, the convention used is official spelling according to the political divisions of today. Thus towns and other place names within the present-day frontiers of France keep their French form; while those which now lie within West Germany, Italy, Belgium, Holland, etc. appear in the official spelling of these countries.

DATES

Until 1 January 1806 France was administered according to the Revolutionary calendar. Since many decrees, reports, and events are more familiar in this form, it seems desirable to keep it. To avoid the inconvenience of frequent consultation of the *Concordance*, the corresponding dates of the Gregorian calendar are given in brackets.

I

INTRODUCTION

A title linking Napoleon's Continental Blockade with Alsace may look odd at first glance. If the combination seems unlikely, and even perhaps self-contradictory, this is due no doubt to a traditional lopsidedness in the historiography of Napoleon's economic war with Britain. When dealing with the Blockade,¹ most writers of the nineteenth century concentrated on what might be called its 'sea aspects'. They saw it as primarily an episode, albeit a protracted and far-reaching one, in a much wider maritime conflict. So far as it touched the Continent, their main concern was with its counter-effects on the sea ports of the Empire² and of the subject and allied states, and with its generally unhappy consequences for the ancillary industries of those coastal regions. Its 'land aspects', or its bearing on the industry and trade of the Continental mainland, attracted much less attention.

That was not at all a mistaken approach to the subject; but it was, and remains, a restricted one. It is germane, for instance, to the long controversy over Free Trade v. Protection during the last century. For most of the early polemicists, the Blockade was a convenient shuttlecock to bandy about, whether in support of selective embargoes and protectionist tariffs or (more commonly) as a classic example of their ultimate futility. The polemical overtones of all this carried over well into the present century, but fortunately much more of the historical substance of the subject has also come to light.

¹ The 'Blockade' (with a capital B) refers throughout this study to the Continental Blockade of 1806-13. Like so many of Napoleon's contemporaries, writers over the years have tended to use the term loosely as a synonym for the 'Continental System'. For good reason (discussed below, pp. 108-9) a distinction between the two can and should be made. Both also need to be distinguished from the British naval blockade officially in force along specified stretches of the Continental coastline during that period.

² The 'Empire' (with a capital E) and the adjective 'imperial' refer, unless otherwise stated, to the Napoleonic Empire or to the emperor himself.

We are now better informed on the aims, the working, and the effects of the Blockade in the inland parts of Napoleonic Europe, as indeed we are on its maritime aspects. Yet if the historiographical balance has been adjusted in this way, it is still far from even. The dominant image of the Blockade remains that of a 'coast system', a far-flung imperial 'dike' pushed out to stem the tide of British trade with the Continent, an extraordinary 'war machine' set in motion on the land to quarantine the Continent from British maritime supremacy. Marcel Dunan speaks of 'la lutte entre le Continent et l'Océan pour la domination ou l'équilibre du monde'.³ This vision of a titanic confrontation of two elemental powers was once impressive, but it has been reduced by over-use to a melodramatic platitude.

The persistence of the lopsidedness in Blockade studies is not, perhaps, difficult to explain. One thinks first of British maritime power, French land might, and the many economic conflicts which the Revolutionary and Napoleonic wars brought to a head. The context of Anglo-French hostilities fits into, or itself absorbs, that of long-standing industrial and commercial rivalries. Britain's particular advantages over France then lay in clear naval superiority, a lengthening industrial and technological lead, a more widespread and expanding foreign trade, a more developed and flexible financial system both at home and abroad. One thinks also of the obverse: Napoleon's overbearing military power on the Continent, following his successive victories of 1805-7 and the reconstruction of subject Europe, which alone made the Blockade conceivable in the first place. Unable to strike at Britain effectively by sea, he withdrew from any consistent pursuit of the early Boulogne flotilla project. Implicitly after Trafalgar (21 October 1805) and explicitly after the Berlin decree (21 November 1806) his attack was directed at British trade, whose bases on the Continent were of course the principal target. The strategic idea was to 'conquer England by excess': that is, to induce industrial and commercial surpluses there by forcing her out of Continental markets,

³ *Napoléon et l'Allemagne. Le Système continental et les débuts du royaume de Bavière, 1806-1810* (Paris, 1942), 369.

to drain off her bullion reserves in payment for essential imports, and so to precipitate the kind of inflation that would destroy her ability to continue the war or finance new coalitions against France. Thus presented, the 'drama' of the Blockade certainly seems most striking in its 'sea aspects'. Professor F. E. Melvin, for instance, thought that Napoleon's 'navigation system' was 'preëminently a controlling factor' of his rule.⁴ In his opinion, 'a study of the diplomacy of the Consulate and Empire furnishes incontrovertible proof that its navigation policy was the dominating element of the Napoleonic régime'.⁵ This is a typical statement of the most familiar approach in earlier studies of the Blockade.

If such an approach accentuates the 'sea aspects' of the topic, one might conclude *prima facie* that this merely reflects the nature of the primary sources. If Frenchmen at the time themselves thought of the Blockade in those terms, then it must surely have been the part of it which counted most with them. And indeed it has to be said that the crude mass of primary material copiously supports this view. The two main documentary series for the subject in the Archives Nationales, F¹² and AF^{IV}, weigh heavily in that direction. The departmental series M for industry and trade in the Empire as a whole has the same disparity specifically in relation to the Blockade. There are innumerable documents on the imperial maritime ports (by their own lamentations the 'villes-martyres de l'Empire') and their problems, on British and neutral shipping, on the Orders in Council and naval blockade of the Continental coastline, on the plight of French oceanic trade and the uncertainties of even coastal traffic, on the chronic issue of smuggling and difficulties in the imperial customs surveillance, on the 'licences' and 'permits', especially in the years 1810-13, and so forth. The balance of the printed primary sources leads similarly to the conclusion that the 'sea aspects' of the Blockade were predominant. The published reports, *exposés*, tracts, letters, petitions, and memoirs of officials and private commentators alike offer a great reservoir of material, and already they have

⁴ *Napoleon's Navigation System. A Study of Trade Control during the Continental Blockade* (New York, 1919), Foreword, xi.

⁵ *Ibid.* 350.

been widely used by writers approaching the subject in the traditional way. The crude weight of Napoleon's own directives on the matter,⁶ again chiefly in the period 1810-13, also suggests that the maritime details of his Blockade commanded most attention.

Altogether, then, the traditional emphasis in Blockade studies seems fair.⁷ It applies as much to the scattered and sparse English writings on the subject as to the more substantial works in French and German, at least until the decade or two preceding the First World War.⁸ Indeed, from that time to the present there has been a steady flow of works in which the main focus has been on the familiar 'sea aspects' of the question.⁹ No leading contributor would better deserve the current title of '*doyen du sujet*' than Professor François Crouzet. The main direction of his research illustrates the present point as clearly and massively as any other. His exhaustive account of the Blockade's impact on Britain's foreign trade, and so on her domestic economy more generally, is an indispensable source.¹⁰ More than twenty years

⁶ Notably the official *Correspondance de Napoléon Ier publiée par ordre de l'Empereur Napoléon III* (32 vols., Paris, 1858-69). An important supplement to this is *Lettres inédites de Napoléon Ier (an VIII-1815)* (ed. L. Lecestre, 2 vols., Paris, 1897). The volume *Napoléon Ier: Lettres au comte Mollien ministre du trésor public du 16 mars 1803 au 9 juin 1815* (ed. J. Arna, Rochecorbon, 1959) has much crucial material on Napoleon's financial and closely related commercial policies.

⁷ This is not the place for a substantial analysis of secondary literature in the field. My historiographical review, 'Napoleon's Continental Blockade in History and Historiography', will appear in the *Historical Journal* shortly. Along with a more detailed citation of the major titles, it offers a critique of the central themes and controversies in Blockade studies, past and present. The chance to publish an up-to-date bibliography at the end of this study (below, pp. 308-21) also enables me to lighten footnote coverage of that sort in these introductory pages. Full title references here are confined to the most important works and to the acknowledgement of specific matter from other sources. Full details of studies alluded to only by authors' names, where not subsequently cited here, appear in the bibliography.

⁸ See e.g. the titles, in order of publication, given under Rocke, Lumbroso, Hitzgrath, Baasch, Bertin, Holland Rose, Levasseur, Höniger, Drottboom, Stuhr, and Kiewning.

⁹ Prominent among them, again in order of publication, are those by Peez and Dehn, Vogel, Tarlé (early works), Schäfer, Conrad, Masson, Melvin, Heckscher, Völtzer, Remigolski, Mohrhenn, Bohlmann, de Jouvenel, Riba, Thomazi, Roustit, Heils, Engelsing, Bonnel, Butel, Röhlk, and Kutz.

¹⁰ *L'Économie britannique et le Blocus continental (1806-1813)* (2 vols., Paris, 1958).

after publication it remains much the most authoritative statement on this particular regional detail of the topic. It is primarily concerned, as are his later articles,¹¹ with the 'sea aspects' of the question, which was of course implicit in the nature of his subject and his sources.

Crouzet's thesis filled what up to then had been far and away the largest and most surprising gap in the whole sequence of Blockade studies. That is itself a comment on the abject state of our own contributions to them, at any rate since the 1930s. Why the subject has attracted so little detailed research here, when the Blockade threatened such potential disasters and at times in the years 1810-12 certainly exacerbated the discomfort of the British economy, has often puzzled writers across the Channel. It is fair to say that the topic is virtually unapproachable through a substantial and recent work in English. The writings of John Holland Rose, published mostly before the First World War, are still very readable, but they cannot be regarded now as more than bold pioneer sketches. As might be expected, there is useful information to be quarried in the celebrated pages of Tooke's *History of Prices* and Smart's *Economic Annals*, but its relevance to the Blockade is incidental. Much the same could be said of the works of J. H. Clapham, R. G. Hawtrey, T. S. Ashton, E. V. Morgan, and Arthur Redford, among others, where the specific coverage is slight. Other economic textbooks, as well as J. Steven Watson's Oxford 'History', offer only basic facts and general comment on the question. One notable exception here is the collaborative study of A. D. Gayer, W. W. Rostow, and A. J. Schwartz, which has important statistical material on the British economy during the Revolutionary and Napoleonic wars.¹² Another is Judith Blow Williams' wide-ranging survey of British overseas trade, which has useful sections on smuggling and the impact of war during the same period.¹³

¹¹ The most influential of these (all listed in the bibliography) has probably been 'Wars, Blockade, and Economic Change in Europe, 1792-1815', *J. Ec. H.*, xxiv (1964), 567-88.

¹² *The Growth and Fluctuation of the British Economy 1790-1850* (2 vols., Oxford, 1953).

¹³ *British Commercial Policy and Trade Expansion, 1750-1850* (Oxford, 1972), 345-418.

In most of the writings of those named, aspects of the Blockade are presented as part of much broader overviews. This has the merit of situating it relative to the longer-term business cycles and is a necessary reminder against myopic inferences from a particular episode, however dramatic, within them. But it is not much help in explaining the critical issues of 1803-13 and contemporary responses to them under existing conditions. It is, for instance a truism that the Blockade was an extraordinary contrivance born of war, of economic *dislocation*, and would have been unthinkable in a peacetime context. And yet in so many of the works which condemn it as a form of doctrinaire economic retrogressivism, that conjuncture is overlooked, as is the equally plain evidence of French naval eclipse. The Blockade of 1806-13 was unique to its power-base. Given Napoleon's wish to come to terms with his most elusive enemy, whose economic liquidity on the Continent was also a major lubricant of the allied coalitions, a policy like the Blockade was no doubt seen as an unavoidable *pis aller*.

The Blockade as such has generally come out rather better in the more substantial American accounts, though most of these are dated now.¹⁴ Like the British, they focus invariably on the 'sea aspects' of the subject. For a time between the wars there was even what could be called an American tradition in Blockade studies, and the University of Pennsylvania was then its most fashionable seat; but such energies were soon dispersed. Apart from the usual passing references and occasional discussion in American books and articles of wider range,¹⁵ recent Anglo-Saxon contributions to the topic have been singularly few and thin. David Landes's masterly account of the comparative conditions and development of early European industrialization still seems to me to offer the best long-term perspective on the Anglo-French economic disparity in the later eighteenth and early nineteenth

¹⁴ Apart from Melvin's *Navigation System*, the major work, two substantial theses are W. F. Galpin, *The Grain Supply of England during the Napoleonic Period* (New York, 1925) and P. A. Heath, *Napoleon I and the Origins of the Anglo-American War of 1812* (Toulouse, 1929).

¹⁵ See e.g. those by N. J. Silberling, R. G. Albion, Geoffrey Bruun, S. B. Clough, G. S. Graham, and A. H. Imlah. An article by R. Ruppenthal on the Continental System in Denmark is more specific, but short.

centuries.¹⁶ Articles by Herbert Kisch on the textile industries of the Rhineland and Silesia have an obvious bearing on the inland significance of the French hegemony. Otherwise, the scattered English writings on the question, whether seen in economic, diplomatic, military or naval terms, have had a maritime orientation. This reflects, for example, in the articles by G. W. Daniels on the English cotton trade and more recently by A. N. Ryan on British naval involvements in the Baltic. The European range of J. M. Sherwig's study of British foreign aid in the wars with France (1793-1815) is broader, but its coverage of the Blockade as such is restricted. Our standard English textbook on the topic remains the not impartial account by E. F. Heckscher, the Swedish economic historian, and is now fast approaching its sixtieth anniversary.¹⁷

* * *

Studies of the Blockade across the Channel, especially those in French, present much more convincing evidence of its full regional importance, both in aim and effect. What, then, may be said of the 'land aspects' in the present state of the subject there? The first reply must be that, in themselves, the primary sources for inland industry and trade during the Napoleonic period are vast enough, and that they repay the effort of close inspection. Their very mass indeed has demanded a rather specialized topical or regional approach in the better secondary accounts already available. As for the latter, historiographical emphases are of course relative too, and the implication of my earlier general comments is not that the 'land aspects' have had no serious attention at all. Many worthy attempts to examine these aspects, until the early 1930s perhaps chiefly by German-speaking historians, and since then very largely by French-speaking ones, might be mentioned. Several of the best among them date from

¹⁶ Vol. vi of the *Cambridge Economic History of Europe* (1965), revised and enlarged as *The Unbound Prometheus. Technological Change and Industrial Development in Western Europe from 1750 to the Present* (Cambridge, 1969), chaps. 1-3.

¹⁷ *The Continental System. An Economic Interpretation* (Eng. edn., Oxford, 1922).

before the First World War, in certain cases from the 1880s and 1890s, but still merit their central place in the historiographical roll-call of the Blockade.

Thus, for instance, Louis Bein, Albin König, and Wilhelm Stieda all focused their attention on the Saxon industries, and an early history of the Leipzig fairs by Ernst Hasse still offers useful material on the Napoleonic period. Hermann Freymark's old text on Prussian trade and tariff reform (1800-21) has also worn well. While Paul Darmstädter and Charles Schmidt looked at the economic effects of French rule only as part of much bigger works on two of the satellite states in Germany,¹⁸ Otto Redlich (for Berg), Aloys Vollmer (for Essen more specifically), and Anton Schmitter (for Frankfurt¹⁹) produced studies more directly linked with the Blockade. Similar regional works by Max Voretzsch on Altenburg, by Richard Zeyss on the department of the Roer (Rur),²⁰ by Hans Roemer on the Silesian cotton enterprises, and by Johann Slokar on the Habsburg industries²¹ also date from about that time. Bernard de Cérenville's account of the Swiss economy under Napoleonic rule is probably still the best-known general text on that country, though it is slanted and unreliable.

The twenty or thirty years preceding the First World War were altogether a productive period in Blockade studies. With a few exceptions like Bertin, Collignon, Charléty, and especially de Lanzac de Laborie, German historians had very clearly been the most active in this research.²² The war itself

¹⁸ Darmstädter's *Das Grossherzogtum Frankfurt. Ein Kulturbild aus der Rheinbundzeit* (Frankfurt, 1901) and Schmidt's *Le Grand-duché de Berg (1806-1813). Étude sur la domination française en Allemagne sous Napoléon Ier* (Paris, 1905) are works of great learning and understanding.

¹⁹ Unless otherwise stated, the reference throughout this study is to Frankfurt am Main.

²⁰ His volume *Die Entstehung der Handelskammern und die Industrie am Niederrhein während der französischen Herrschaft. Ein Beitrag zur Wirtschaftspolitik Napoleons I* (Leipzig, 1907) was influential in both content and method.

²¹ *Geschichte der österreichischen Industrie und ihrer Förderung unter Kaiser Franz I.* (Vienna, 1914.)

²² Much the best short review of 19th- and early 20th-century writings on the Blockade is Marcel Dunan, 'Le Système continental. Bulletin d'histoire économique (1900-1911)', *R. Ét. nap.*, iii (1913), 115-46. No major study up until virtually the outbreak of the war escaped his scrutiny. Dunan contends here that of all the lands subjected to the Blockade, Germany was the one in which

influenced the approach to the topic in two main ways. It brutally demonstrated that blockades are not always localized naval affairs and that even those which appear so can have complex economic repercussions much further inland than the immediate *hinterländer* of the beleaguered ports or estuaries. It also prompted some writers to tendentious analogies between the wartime blockades and the famous Napoleonic precedent for the illustration of 'lessons for our time'. The comparisons, for instance in the works of Conrad, Lulvès, Sommerlad, and Rocke during or just after the war, were often sadly wrong-headed. Many of the more polemical writings had been provoked by the current of Anglophobia which, stimulated by wartime propaganda, spilled over well into the peace, carrying such *zeitgebundene Schriften* along with it.

Happily, however, the tradition of serious scholarly work on the Blockade in Germany also survived the war. Throughout the 1920s and early 1930s in fact the subject enjoyed something of a vogue as material for inaugural and other lectures, or else for more substantial theses, in German universities. If Decker, Völtzer, Remigolski (at first), Mohrhenn, and Bohlmann all then chose mainly maritime angles to it, a fresh interest in its mainland details also developed. This reflects in the works of Robert Naumann on Silesia, Josef Strauch on the woollens of Aachen, Hans Saring on Prussia, and Hugo Arenz on Frankfurt. These writers and others like them are little known nowadays, least of all in the Anglo-Saxon countries, and yet their early efforts remain the standard introduction to some of the Blockade's 'land aspects'.

Such an introduction, moreover, is not confined to German works. Marcel Dunan's publications before the First World War had been limited to bibliographical essays of short compass, but in many ways Charles Schmidt's cited volume²³ had set a model for German and other scholars. Good Alsatian that he was, he drew on a vast knowledge of the German sources, and before his death in 1956 he produced

its effects were most complex. He adds, fairly, that German accounts of the subject had been up to then the most advanced in depth and method.

²³ *Grand-duché de Berg*.

a number of articles on the Blockade. Some are regional surveys; others deal with celebrated critics of Napoleon's economic policy; all are rooted in rich archival learning. His contributions to Alsatian economic history during the Revolutionary and Napoleonic period have been particularly useful to my own research. Eugène Tarlé was another who kept up a productive interest in the subject. His original Russian work was mostly concerned with the Blockade's maritime aspects,²⁴ but it was soon followed by a substantial and seminal essay on Franco-German trade in all its dimensions.²⁵ He widened his range still further after the war in several articles, all of them useful secondary references,²⁶ and a major study of the Blockade in Italy.²⁷ Of the other inter-war publications in French, Marcel Blanchard's work on the strategic Alpine passes covered new ground. So did Melitta Pivec-Stelè's account of the Illyrian provinces, where the economic coverage is necessarily 'amphibian' in range.

The mainstream of German historiography on the Blockade, from whatever angle, ran out rather abruptly in 1933. There has been surprisingly little work specifically on the topic in that country since then. Neither the spate of clumsy analogies between Hitler and Napoleon nor the Berlin crisis of 1949 aroused any serious academic interest in Blockade studies there. Ludwig Beutin, Hermann Kellenbenz, and Percy Schramm occasionally touch on the subject, but only in passing and usually within a much broader sweep of German maritime history.²⁸ All show a particular interest

²⁴ *Kontinentalnaia Blokada* (Moscow, 1913), which has detailed references to Blockade studies up to that time but is regrettably not available in a western European language.

²⁵ 'Deutsch-französische Wirtschaftsbeziehungen zur napoleonischen Zeit', in *Schmollers Jahrbuch*, new ser., xxxviii/1 (Munich and Leipzig, 1914), 667-726.

²⁶ Notably 'Napoléon Ier et les intérêts économiques de la France', *Revue du XIXe siècle: Napoléon*, xv (1926), 117-37; 'L'Union économique du continent européen sous Napoléon', *R.h.*, clxvi (1931), 239-55; and 'Russland und die Kontinentalsperre', *Zeitschrift für die gesamte Staatswissenschaft*, xciv (1933), 70-106.

²⁷ *Le Blocus continental et le royaume d'Italie. La situation économique de l'Italie sous Napoléon Ier* (Paris, 1931).

²⁸ An important exception is Schramm's 'Kaufleute während Besatzung, Krieg und Belagerung (1806-1815). Der Hamburger Handel in der Franzosenzeit, dargestellt an Hand von Firmen- und Familienpapieren', *Tradition*, iv (1959), 1-22, 88-114. This has much more obvious bearing on the Blockade as such.

in the Hanse towns, that is in the 'sea aspects' of the question. The same wide canvas characterizes the volume by A. Jacobs and H. Richter on wholesale prices in Germany between 1792 and 1934, which appeared a year after its terminal date. More recently, Wolfram Fischer, Herbert Milz, Wolfgang Zorn, Herbert Hassinger, Hermann Ringel, and Knut Borchardt have all added substantially to our knowledge of early German industrialization, but they deal with the Blockade itself only incidentally and with a view to earlier or later developments.²⁹ The statement on it in Wilhelm Treue's *Wirtschaftsgeschichte der Neuzeit* is just a brief outline, as befits such a handbook. The essays by Rolf Engelsing (on the Silesian linen trade through Bremen and the commerce of the Baltic ports) and by Manfred Kossok (on the Prussian linen trade to Spanish America) are most noteworthy in connection with the maritime aspects of the Revolutionary and Napoleonic wars. The two outstanding German studies on the topic in recent years are by Frauke Röhlk³⁰ and Martin Kutz.³¹ Both have full statistical appendices and detailed bibliographies, but their central focus is again plainly on the 'sea aspects'. Equally thorough and well-supported accounts of the economic fortunes of towns like Frankfurt, Leipzig, Brunswick, Breslau, and Berlin still await their modern Blockade historians.

An up-to-date reappraisal of the Blockade's effects in Germany as a whole, and by a native of that country well versed in its considerable archival and library material, is long overdue. A survey by F.-G. Dreyfus gives some interesting pointers to the long-term effects of the wars and the Blockade

²⁹ Fischer's *Der Staat und die Anfänge der Industrialisierung in Baden 1800-1850* (Berlin, 1962) has rather more material on the Napoleonic period. An essay by him, one by Zorn, and two by Hassinger in the collected volume *Die wirtschaftliche Situation in Deutschland und Österreich um die Wende vom 18. zum 19. Jahrhundert* (Forschungen zur Sozial- und Wirtschaftsgeschichte, vol. vi, Stuttgart, 1964) discuss the problems of German and Habsburg industry and trade during the French wars. These deal mainly with inland economic structures and are useful to the study of the Blockade in that context.

³⁰ 'Schiffahrt und Handel zwischen Hamburg und den Niederlanden in der zweiten Hälfte des 18. und zu Beginn des 19. Jahrhunderts', *Vjs. f. Soz.- u. Wirtsch.*, suppl. no. 60 (1973).

³¹ 'Deutschlands Aussenhandel von der französischen Revolution bis zur Gründung des Zollvereins. Eine statistische Strukturuntersuchung zur vorindustriellen Zeit', *ibid.*, suppl. no. 61 (1974).

there,³² for instance on the fluctuation of agricultural prices in selected towns and on the statistical evidence of their 'crises' in 1794-5, 1804-5, 1812, and 1817. Its treatment of German agricultural production and of industrial output and wages is more slender, however, and really just a rough guide to regional variations. So far as such evidence suggests a clear trend, Dreyfus concludes that the balance of German development was mainly positive up to 1805 and largely negative from then until 1820. Other regional angles to the impact of the French wars on Germany were discussed at a conference in Bremen in September 1969 which marked the bicentenary of Napoleon's birth.³³ But there again the cause of the Blockade was served mostly by French scholars,³⁴ and four of the six papers which had any direct bearing on it focused on the already familiar area of the Hanse towns, which was appropriate to the venue.³⁵

Since the 1930s, at any rate, French-speaking historians have made by far the most important contributions to Blockade studies. One of the weightiest, first published during the Second World War and the more remarkable for its scholarly impartiality, is Marcel Dunan's great work on Bavaria.³⁶ Not long afterwards Fernand L'Huillier's detailed volume on Napoleonic Alsace appeared,³⁷ and he followed

³² 'Bilan économique des Allemagnes en 1815', *R. d'H. éc et soc.* xliii (1965), 433-64.

³³ The papers of and a summary of proceedings on that occasion were published by the sponsoring body, the Deutsches Historisches Institut in Paris, in the first volume of its journal *Francia* (1973), 369-622 and 747-55.

³⁴ Viz. Jean Vidalenc, Jean Mistler, Michel Bruguière, Roger Dufraisse, and Louis Bergeron. The lone German contributor to the subject was Reinhard Patemann.

³⁵ The notable exceptions are Dufraisse, 'La contrebande dans les départements réunis de la rive gauche du Rhin à l'époque napoléonienne', loc. cit. 508-36; and Bergeron, 'Remarques sur les conditions du développement industriel en Europe occidentale à l'époque napoléonienne', *ibid.* 537-56.

³⁶ *Napoléon et l'Allemagne*. Regrettably, a second volume of this study, the latter part of Dunan's thesis which was to have appeared as 'La Bavière dans le Système continental 1810-1813', has never been published. Notice of its preparation was given in his article, 'Napoléon et le Système continental en 1810', *R. d'H. dip.*, lx (1946), 72 n., but apparently the only sequel was a paper for the Académie des Sciences morales et politiques in 1954, reprinted as 'Napoléon, l'Italie et le Système continental', *R. Inst. Nap.*, no. 96 (July 1965), 176-90. These articles are a mere *soupçon* of what might have been.

³⁷ *Recherches sur l'Alsace napoléonienne de brumaire à l'invasion (1799-1813)*

this up a few years later with a more specific Blockade study of Baden.³⁸ The 1940s also saw the publication of three more general textbooks on this or closely related subjects. The first was by Bertrand de Jouvenel and was uneven in quality, combining some interesting ideas with too much uncritical stock-piling of quotations and some banal over-simplifications.³⁹ It has little to say on the question outside France, and the fact that it trails off after the summer of 1810, leaving the economic crisis of 1810-11 and its aftermath virtually unexplained, suggests an unbalanced view of the problem. Odette Viennet's account published soon after the war remains a standard text on the crisis of 1810-11 and has a useful bibliography,⁴⁰ but its treatment of the Trianon tariff and the imperial 'licences' of 1810-11 seems inadequate to me in not making it clear that much of the industrial trouble lay in *over*-production rather than in shortage of supplies. Alexandre Chabert's wider survey two years later gives a rather too optimistic assessment of French economic achievements under Napoleon.⁴¹ As some reviewers noted at the time, its sources are idiosyncratic and its account of the economic crises, especially that of 1810-11, is suspect.

During the last twenty-five years or so a number of more regionally or topically restricted studies have filled in details of the Blockade's effects, sometimes in a chronological context broader than its own immediate one. Of those concerned with France, the familiar seaboard perspective is best re-defined in Paul Butel's researches on Bordeaux.⁴² A more inland orientation is offered by Jean Vidalenc in his work on (Strasbourg, 1945), whose economic sections are discussed substantially in later chapters here.

³⁸ *Étude sur le Blocus continental. La mise en vigueur des décrets de Trianon et de Fontainebleau dans le grand-duché de Bade* (Paris, 1951).

³⁹ *Napoléon et l'économie dirigée. Le Blocus continental* (Paris and Brussels, 1942).

⁴⁰ *Napoléon et l'industrie française. La crise de 1810-1811* (Paris, 1947).

⁴¹ *Essai sur les mouvements des revenus et de l'activité économique en France de 1798 à 1820* (Paris, 1949), esp. 361-97.

⁴² 'L'Armement en course à Bordeaux sous la Révolution et l'Empire', *Revue historique de Bordeaux et du département de la Gironde*, new ser., xv (1966), 17-64; 'Crise et mutation de l'activité économique à Bordeaux sous le Consulat et l'Empire', *R. d'H. mod. et contemp.*, xvii (1970), 540-58; and 'Guerre et commerce: L'Activité du port de Bordeaux sous le régime des licences, 1808-1815', *ibid.*, xix (1972), 128-49.

Norman economic history and on the French Midi,⁴³ by Jean Labasse in his study of the silk industry and trade of Lyons,⁴⁴ and by Roger Dufraisse in several essays on the Rhenish departments to the north of, and sometimes including, Alsace.⁴⁵ An active group of historians, represented by Jan Voortman, Pierre Lebrun, Jean Dhondt, Jean Craeybeckx, Fernand Leleux, and Robert Devleeshouwer, among others, has made Belgian development under Napoleon one of the most detailed areas of research in the early industrialization of western Europe. Their writings, which admittedly are not Blockade studies in any precise sense, have superseded the old texts of Léon de Lanzac de Laborie and Paul Verhaegen. There have also been shorter but important contributions on Italy by Max Tacel,⁴⁶ Rosalba Davico,⁴⁷ and Pasquale Villani,⁴⁸ on the Russian cotton industry by V. R. Iatsounski,⁴⁹ and by Barbara Grochulska on the duchy of Warsaw.⁵⁰

In view of the very evident importance of French scholars in Blockade studies since the last war, and of French as the current medium of publication for other scholars engaged in this research, it is ironic that no up-to-date general textbook on the subject is available in that language. In his bibliographical review some fifteen years ago, Roger Dufraisse reaffirmed Georges Lefebvre's opinion that 'le grand livre' on the Blockade remained to be written.⁵¹ The point still

⁴³ Chiefly apropos of the fairs of Beaucaire in 'La vie économique des départements méditerranéens pendant l'Empire', *ibid.*, i (1954), 165-98.

⁴⁴ *Le Commerce des soies à Lyon sous Napoléon et la crise de 1811* (Grenoble, 1957).

⁴⁵ As these materially concern my own regional focus, they are more fully discussed in the appropriate chapters later.

⁴⁶ 'La place de l'Italie dans l'économie impériale de 1806 à 1814', in *Napoléon et l'Europe* (ed. M. Dunan, Commission Internationale pour l'Enseignement de l'Histoire, Paris/Brussels, 1961), 21-39.

⁴⁷ 'Prix et conjoncture: la "période" napoléonienne en Piémont. Quelques réflexions au sujet d'une crise', *R.h.*, ccxlviii (1972), 25-48; and 'Mines et usines en Piémont au début du XIXe siècle', *A.h.R.f.*, xlix (1977), 618-34.

⁴⁸ 'Quelques aspects de la vie économique italienne à l'époque napoléonienne', *ibid.* 587-617.

⁴⁹ 'De l'influence du Blocus continental sur l'industrie cotonnière russe', *ibid.*, xxxvi (1964), 65-77.

⁵⁰ 'Sur la structure économique du duché de Varsovie (1807-1813)', *ibid.* 349-63.

⁵¹ 'Régime douanier, Blocus, Système continental: essai de mise au point', *R. d'H. éc. et soc.*, xlv (1966), 542-3.

applies, and one would surely also agree with Dufraisse that no general textbook of that kind will suffice until the regional spread of the subject is more even than now. The best French reference book on the Blockade, as indeed on the Continental System in its widest sense, remains Lefebvre's long-serving *Napoléon*.⁵² There was some discussion of the topic at the Twelfth International Congress of Historical Sciences in Vienna in 1965, but only as one outline sketch among its 'grands thèmes'. The important conference held at the Sorbonne in October 1969 to mark the Napoleonic bicentenary brought some major new research to light,⁵³ and some of it touches the Blockade directly. Apart from the contributions of Paul Butel,⁵⁴ Robert Devleeshouwer,⁵⁵ and Barbara Grochulska,⁵⁶ Louis Bergeron's paper on that occasion was a useful bibliographical digest of recent themes in Napoleonic economic history and an indicator of further possibilities within it.⁵⁷ The relevant sections of his subsequent textbook⁵⁸ also give an excellent survey of recent work on French industry and trade under Napoleon, including some fruitful new leads on the interpretation of the Blockade and its related policies. But his major original contribution to this broad field lay in the substance of his eagerly awaited doctoral thesis.

The latter was published in typographical copy in the year following its presentation.⁵⁹ While it cannot be called a

⁵² Vol. xiv in the series 'Peuples et Civilisations' (5th rev. edn., 1969 impr.), esp. Bk. III, chap. 1; Bk. IV, chaps. 1, 3, 4; Bk. V, chap. 2; and Bk. VI, chap. 1.

⁵³ The papers of participants were published a year later by the sponsoring society in the special no. 'La France à l'époque napoléonienne' of *R. d'H. mod. et contemp.*, xvii (1970), 329-920, and esp. 469-638. This was far and away the most important academic product of the bicentenary, and most of these conference papers were also published in the *A.h.R.f.*, xlii (1970).

⁵⁴ Art. cit., *R. d'H. mod. et contemp.* (1970).

⁵⁵ 'Le Consulat et l'Empire: Période de "take-off" pour l'économie belge?', *ibid.* 610-19.

⁵⁶ 'L'Économie polonaise et le renversement de la conjoncture (1805-1815)', *ibid.* 620-30.

⁵⁷ 'Problèmes économiques de la France napoléonienne', *ibid.* 469-505.

⁵⁸ *L'Épisode napoléonien. Aspects intérieurs 1799-1815*, vol. iv in the series 'Nouvelle histoire de la France contemporaine' (Paris, 1972), esp. 178-214.

⁵⁹ *Banquiers, négociants et manufacturiers parisiens du Directoire à l'Empire* (2 vols., Paris, 1975). Its main themes are summarized in part of a short statement presented at his *soutenance* and published in the *R. d'H. éc. et soc.*, lii (1974), 239-46.

Blockade study in a specific sense, it is unquestionably the work of recent years which offers most to historians of the subject. It carefully analyses what can be extrapolated from the finely intermeshed elements of high finance, commercial ventures, manufacturing enterprise, and proprietary wealth of the Parisian banking élite during the Directory, Consulate, and Empire. It looks equally at the social, economic, and regional framework (*structure*) and at the particular case histories (*conjoncture*) of that intricate and so often private world. The author had also traced some of the eighteenth-century background to his central thesis topic at a conference of economic historians in October 1973,⁶⁰ at which the maritime sector of French trade before the Revolutionary upheaval once again commanded most attention.⁶¹

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The researches of Louis Bergeron and Roger Dufraisie are important moves in the direction of a more balanced view of the Blockade's regional variations. They have come not before time, as some of the old German texts on its inland aspects are so obscure that they are not accessible even in major repositories like the British Library and the Bibliothèque Nationale. These aspects still await the sort of definitive treatment which the maritime details have attracted, most of all in François Crouzet's writings. He has himself pointed to the crucial links between those aspects, chiefly in his articles, but it is fair to say that his coverage of the inland details is comparatively slight. Now, Roger Dufraisie has devoted much of his work, as I have, to the Rhenish regions of the Napoleonic Empire. It is surely significant that from this inland angle, and quite independently, we should have reached what seem rather similar conclusions on the main

⁶⁰ 'Paris dans l'organisation des échanges intérieurs français à la fin du XVIII^e siècle', in *Aires et structures du commerce français au XVIII^e siècle* (ed. Pierre Léon: Colloque national de l'Association française des historiens économistes, Paris, CNRS, 4-6 octobre 1973: Centre d'Histoire économique et sociale de la région lyonnaise, Lyon, 1975).

⁶¹ Exceptions here are the essays by François-Yves Le Moigne (on Alsace, the Trois-Évêchés, and Lorraine) and by Maurice Garden (on the Lyonnais), which have a more inland focus: *ibid.*

gaps and future possibilities in Blockade studies.

The area of the subject still most urgently in need of comprehensive review, it seems to me, lies in mainland Germany. The point is made not simply for the Rhenish departments of the left bank which were part of the Empire itself, or for the Confederation of the Rhine across the river, but also for the truncated Prussian lands and even with licence for certain Habsburg dependencies. In topical coverage, the most neglected detail is the structure and working of inland markets under the regime of the wars and of the Blockade. Whole sectors of French trade and industry then either had to turn from traditional connections overseas towards alternative supply-lines and outlets on the Continental mainland, or to rely on the precarious lifeline of the neutral carriers and contraband traffic, or else go under. Some suffered permanent damage through the prolonged and brutal dislocation of their local economies.⁶² But the obverse of this is that, for many inland parts of the Empire, the plight of the maritime ports and their immediately dependent industries was remote anguish. On the transcontinental trade routes by river and road, and in the inland markets which they served, business was often brisk and the results of the Blockade were on the whole more positive. Within the more or less free trade area of the Empire itself, old commercial relationships on the mainland were reinforced. Foreign trade was certainly not helped by the erratic moods of the *douaniers*, and the whole weight of the official prohibitions, restrictions, and tariffs bore down on it, placing artificial barriers in the way of natural and traditional intercourse. Yet somehow, by legitimate circumvention or if necessary by illicit trade, the old links survived the rigours of the customs and in several of the more favoured branches were actually strengthened. To these links the Blockade added newer currents of deflected traffic as the sea lanes were formally closed to France and her allies.

The main beneficiaries of this reorientation of the trade routes were the inland entrepôts. In the manufacturing

⁶² On this see Crouzet, 'Les origines du sous-développement économique du Sud-Ouest', *Annales du Midi*, lxxi (1959), 71-9; and 'Les conséquences économiques de la Révolution: A propos d'un inédit de Sir Francis d'Ivernois', *A.h.R.f.*, xxxiv (1962), 182-217, 336-62 (text).

sector, the opportunities for expansion were best in the industries whose markets traditionally lay or could be cultivated on the Continental mainland, in the presumed absence of British competition. The Rhenish regions were at the hub of that process. Commenting on the effects of the maritime wars and of the Blockade, François Crouzet goes so far as to speak of a 'shift of industry from the seaboard to the heartland of western Europe' which was so marked that by 1814 'the axis of the Continental economy had now moved from the Atlantic toward the Rhine'.⁶³ Louis Bergeron leads into the same theme in his conference paper of 1969, arguing that the cumulative effects of the wars and the inland thrust of Napoleon's policies were to 'reorganize by force' what he calls 'l'espace politique et économique de part et d'autre du Rhin'.⁶⁴ In his *grand livre* indeed he sets out to show just how far one orbit, 'le milieu parisien des affaires, outre son attachement à une structure traditionnelle des échanges, même dégradée, a porté attention aux possibilités d'une réorientation des échanges vers un marché européen "le dos à la mer"'.⁶⁵

Those are the broad brush strokes of a picture whose local and topical details need to be filled in if we are to have a full view of the Blockade's aims and effects. It is unlikely that such details will conform to the major theme in all particulars, but the current hint of a shift of the historiographical limelight towards the Continental interior is in itself a good thing for Blockade studies. For it is a plain fact that the great mass of the Continental people at that time, as today, did not inhabit the maritime ports. They lived inland, at various distances removed from the naval blockade and coastal batteries. They did not experience the conflict of the Blockade directly through the interruption of maritime trade, whether that of France or of any other state, but by more oblique repercussion. For most of them the familiar orbit

⁶³ 'Wars, Blockade, and Economic Change in Europe', 586-7. Some of the more controversial implications of Crouzet's strongly worded point are taken up by Richard Tilly in his 'Discussion' of this article in *J. Ec. H.*, xxiv (1964), 589-90, and by Dufraisse in 'Régime douanier, Blocus, Système continental', esp. 539.

⁶⁴ 'Conditions du développement industriel', *Francia* (1973), 552.

⁶⁵ *Banquiers, négociants et manufacturiers parisiens*, ii. 766.

of production was differently directed, or at least was capable of redirection, given the primacy of agriculture as an economic sector and the predominance of home markets in the normal pattern of supply and demand. The primary sources, not least those of the departmental archives and the various local repositories, offer abundant evidence of this. My own work on the detailed minute-books of the Chamber of Commerce in Strasbourg, an active inland entrepôt during the Empire, suggests that a study of similar material elsewhere on the mainland trade routes will cast new light on the Blockade's significance there.

The present study is a contribution to the inland range of the subject. It spans the period from the rupture of the peace of Amiens in 1803, with some brief glimpses further back, to the final collapse of the Blockade in 1813. Its starting assumption is that the latter was never solely a 'coast system', either in aim or effect, but had inland facets of a more positive kind. The caricature of Napoleon playing King Canute with the tide of British trade needs to be redrawn. Altogether, this work presents the Blockade more as a market design (*dessein des marchés*) than as a war-machine (*machine de guerre*). The implication, emphatically, is *not* that the market objectives were more important than the military ones, *nor* that the inland areas were necessarily more crucial than the maritime ports. It would be equally false to insist on a rigid distinction between the Blockade's 'sea aspects' and 'land aspects'. The premiss is rather that the whole historiographical balance of the subject needs to be redressed in the present direction. This, in effect, is to pursue the Blockade as a double-edged sword, what Albert Sorel once called a 'machine à double détente'.⁶⁶

The ramifications of the whole market question have only a slender base in earlier secondary works. It remains true, as Bertrand Gille remarked more than twenty years ago, that the evolution of market structures on the Continent in the first half of the nineteenth century has not been examined in much detail.⁶⁷ More specifically, there is no substantial

⁶⁶ *L'Europe et la Révolution française* (8 vols., Paris, 1885-1904), vii. 114.

⁶⁷ 'Les archives d'entreprises', *R. h.*, ccviii (1952), 201; and *Recherches sur la formation de la grande entreprise capitaliste (1815-1848)* (Paris, 1959), 46. Gille's

account of French market aims in the '*Outre-Rhin*'⁶⁸ during the Blockade. This study attempts to mark out some general features of that obscure terrain, although it covers only a relatively short period and deals with commercial and industrial fluctuations rather than with the internal structure and working of markets as such. Its emphasis is on commodity markets, not capital markets, to which Maurice Lévy-Leboyer's detailed work is an authoritative introduction.⁶⁹ An analysis of the internal structure and operations of commodity markets in the Rhineland would have been entirely appropriate to these chapters, but alas that would also have required a book of twice the present length.

So far as it is possible to generalize for the Napoleonic period itself, the problem of French markets lay both in the insecurity of their tenure, especially those with any maritime associations, and in the variability of their demand. Before the Revolution, almost a third of the total export trade of France had consisted of colonial re-exports, while at peak times like 1787-8 anything up to a quarter of French industrial production had had outlets in the Antilles and the Spanish colonies. About three-quarters of French colonial exchanges in the 1780s had been with Santo Domingo, 'the jewel of the Caribbean'.⁷⁰ But France had lost nearly all of that trade as a result of the maritime wars and her successive colonial ruptures. It was of course a cumulative loss, which came in stages and in fact preceded the Blockade by several years. The problem was basic to the battle of French industry and trade against British and other foreign competition from the renewal of hostilities in 1803 to the peace of 1815, and indeed beyond it.

It is suggested here that the loss of French transmarine markets and sources of supply had some influence on the own chapter on the topic, '*Les déformations du marché concurrentiel*' (ibid. 147-62), is confined to the post-Napoleonic period.

⁶⁸ This term recurs frequently in contemporary documents, where it is used adverbially and written '*outré Rhin*'. I use it as a proper noun, in an adapted form, and as shorthand for the German *hinterland* beyond the Rhine.

⁶⁹ *Les Banques européennes et l'industrialisation internationale dans la première moitié du XIXe siècle* (Paris, 1964), esp. 116-82.

⁷⁰ The foregoing familiar estimates are reproduced, e.g., in Crouzet, '*Angleterre et France au XVIIIe siècle: Essai d'analyse comparée de deux croissances économiques*', *Ann. É.S.C.*, xxi/1 (1966), 264-5.

aims of Napoleon's Blockade. If the vacuum left in the French economy was to be filled, the key to recovery seemed to lie in the resources of the Continental mainland. New, and it appeared inevitably non-oceanic, supply-lines and outlets had to be found to give the imperial economy the stimulus for expansion, especially when from 1807 onward neutral trade lay in the stranglehold of the belligerent Powers. Napoleon's aim to 'conquer the sea by mastery of the land', or to 'conquer the colonies by the land', was grandiloquent and no doubt rousing stuff. The 'logistics' of the Blockade may well have implied an extravagant route to the eventual regeneration of French sea power, being as it were a strategy of 'remote control', reminiscent of the marquis d'Argenson's plan to 'conquer America in Germany'. But its emphasis throughout was on exerting pressure nearer home, within the *de facto* orbit of imperial power. Like Bismarck's map of Africa later in the century, Napoleon's map of the world lay in Europe. His priorities were essentially Europocentric, for if his power was land-based, it was also land-locked.

And so, of all the symbolical motifs which have been advanced to incapsulate the essence of Napoleon's ambition — 'mirage de l'Orient', 'idéal romain', 'grandeur universelle', and the like — none fits the facts better than the Carolingian analogy. This properly stresses the essentially Latin and Teutonic bases of the Grand Empire. It also points to Napoleon's practical and, what is more, practicable interest in a 'German policy'. His work in Italy was important by any standards and had far-reaching effects; yet Marcel Dunan seems to me right when he argues that, outside France, 'la grande idée de Napoléon c'est la réorganisation de l'Allemagne', and that this was the main function of his pre-occupation with 'la question anglaise' after 1806.⁷¹ The Blockade, its market design, or the Continental System more widely made sense only in terms of his control of the vast German *hinterland* beyond the Rhenish frontier.

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⁷¹ *Napoléon et 'les Allemagnes'* (extract from the Institut Napoléon, Paris, 1946), 8. The point is discussed more fully in his *Napoléon et l'Allemagne*, 273 ff., and esp. 289-304.

All this may explain the inland orientation of my research, but it does not quite answer the particular question: why *Alsace*? A formal reply might be that the economic history of this French province, which had been divided into the departments of the Bas-Rhin and Haut-Rhin early in the Revolution, is almost entirely unapproachable through English works of whatever vintage. Apart from an interesting survey of the pre-Revolutionary background in the capital city by Franklin Ford,⁷² and some more specialized articles by Szajko Frydman (Zosa Szajkowski) on the Alsatian Jews,⁷³ I know of none which bear on the present subject at all. Yet the main reason for my choice of region is the central importance of Alsace to the whole direction of French economic aims in the *Outre-Rhin*. There, too, the kicks and the kindnesses of the Blockade were less unevenly delivered than in the beleaguered coastal regions. In other words, Alsace was squarely in the picture during the formative period of the French Continental market design, and it is also an exemplary case of the Blockade's more positive effects. Summing up his account of Alsatian economic history under Napoleon, Fernand L'Huillier speaks of 'une surprenante impression d'effort et, dans l'ensemble, de réussite'.⁷⁴ That was substantially the same conclusion reached at the start of this century by a German scholar to whose work we are all indebted.⁷⁵

By Napoleon's time, Alsace had long since ceased to be a geographical cipher sandwiched between two great Powers which played tug-of-war for its affiliations and resources. It had also lost its earlier status as *une province à l'instar de l'étranger effectif*. Former customs anomalies outside the *cinq grosses fermes* had been suppressed during the Revolution, and Alsace had been assimilated to the reformed national system. Within the extraordinary power structure of the Grand Empire, it was not the peripheral point of French

⁷² *Strasbourg in Transition 1648-1789* (Cambridge, Mass., 1958), esp. 131-57.

⁷³ Published since the 1950s, these are listed in the Alsatian section of my bibliography below, pp. 321-6.

⁷⁴ *Alsace napoléonienne*, 466.

⁷⁵ Paul Darmstädter, 'Die Verwaltung des Unter-Elsass (Bas Rhin) unter Napoleon I. (1799-1814)', *Zs. f. d. Gesch. d. Oberrh.*, lvii (1903), 286-330, 538-63; lviii (1904), 122-47, 284-309, and 631-72.

influence it had once been. It was a crucial, in some ways *the* crucial link between the territorial unit known as '*l'ancienne France*', the so-called '*pays réunis*' of the Rhenish left bank,⁷⁶ and the subject and allied states of central Europe. As contemporaries liked to think, it had become '*le boulevard de la France*', and Strasbourg in particular had developed into '*la ville des routes*', as one historian puts it.⁷⁷ Alsace was the base of the fifth imperial military division and a focal point for the movement of troops and transports in the east. As a frontier province it was a major post in the imperial customs cordons. It was also a nerve-centre of the imperial intelligence network and of secret diplomacy. In short, it had assumed a much more influential role than that of a mere outlying province.

The commercial and industrial ramifications of this are the principal concern here. Alsace was the main meeting-point of the routes which carried trade from Paris, Lyons, and the French Midi to Germany, and from there to the north, to Poland, and on to Russia. Throughout the Blockade, Strasbourg was the major imperial entrepôt for exports and re-exports to those parts. It was also the leading entrepôt for imperial imports from the *Outre-Rhin* and Switzerland. Until the summer of 1811 it was the chief and at times the exclusive inlet for cotton expeditions from the Levant, which arrived overland via the Habsburg territories and the southern states of the Rhenish Confederation. Its merchants also had a stake in the carrying trade of the Rhine valley between the Low Countries and Switzerland, where there was a link to Italy. Alsatians as a whole, and the Strasbourgeois in particular, were thus at the crossroads of the transcontinental routes carrying both regular and illicit traffic during the Blockade. They had long-standing ties with Mainz and Frankfurt, by river on the Rhine and on the Main, and with the Swabian *hinterland* and Switzerland to the east and south. One local historian speaks of '*l'orientation de la production alsacienne vers l'extérieur*' as a central theme in the

⁷⁶ Namely, the four predominantly German-speaking departments of Mont-Tonnerre (Mainz), Sarre (Trier), Rhin-et-Moselle (Coblenz), and Roer (Aachen).

⁷⁷ L'Huillier, *Alsace napoléonienne*, 20.

province's history and refers to its traditional 'mission exportatrice'.⁷⁸

None of this, however, should conjure up an unreal image of the Alsatians as international citizens or detract from the clear preponderance of their home markets in Napoleonic times. The evidence of the economic sources suggests that the great majority of them remained as local in their preoccupations and mentality as ever before. In terms of national awareness, of the Empire at large, they seem to have made little advance on their stand in the *cahiers de doléances* of 1789, which all commentators agree had displayed a regional particularism second to none in France. The cotton town of Mulhouse, 'le Manchester français' of a later age, is a case in point. For several years under the Convention and the Directory its citizens had fought hard to preserve what they could of their political independence. In doing so they had suffered the worst economic constraints, as Mulhouse was enclosed in French territory, and they had finally succumbed to the pressure for political 'reunion' with France in 1798 largely for reasons of economic survival.⁷⁹ Other Alsatian towns had a similar sense of local independence, and some had come through the Revolutionary upheaval almost as traumatically.

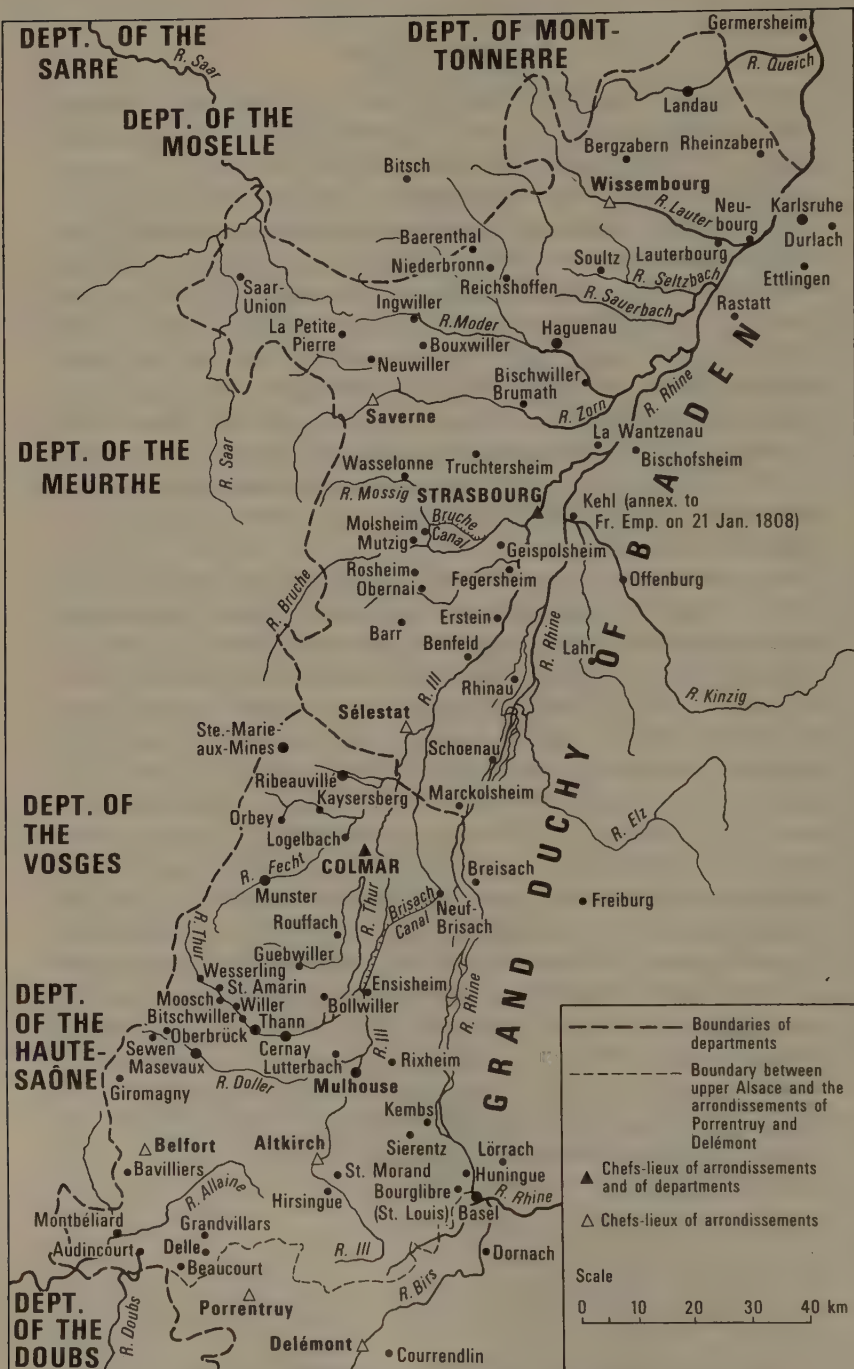
To talk of Alsatian particularism is, then, itself an oversimplification. It lumps together a mass of local particularisms, so small and at times so fierce, that even the conventional distinction between the 'commercial interest' of the Bas-Rhin, the 'industrial interest' of the Haut-Rhin, and the ubiquitous 'agricultural interest' of both seems too glib. Alsace tended to subdivide into fairly small units of economic identification,

⁷⁸ W. Rinckenberger, 'L'Exportation, tradition alsacienne', in *Études strasbourgeoises* (publ. by the Chamber of Commerce and Industry, Strasbourg, 1953), 122, 123. L'Huillier puts the same theme forward for the Haut-Rhin in 'Deux siècles d'exportation textile haut-rhinoise (1750-1950)', *Bull. Soc. ind. Mulh.*, cxxiv (1950), 111-22.

⁷⁹ The importance of French markets to the printed calicoes of Mulhouse is outlined in J.-J. Hémardinquer, 'Aspects du marché français des indiennes au début du XIXe siècle: une "Mulhouse extérieure"', *Actes du quatre-vingt-douzième Congrès national des Sociétés savantes, Strasbourg et Colmar 1967*, Section d'hist. mod. et contemp., vol. ii, *Le Commerce et l'industrie* (Paris, 1970), 313-26.

especially in times of stress. In this its inhabitants were not untypical of the many local communities which made up the polyglot Empire. Yet what might be called the 'frontier complex' of the Alsatians strengthened their own belief that their position was unique, and by a simple extension of that presumption they felt entitled to special treatment. This gave rise to simmering disaffection with the policies of the central government. It also fuelled a popular economic mythology, one inbred in and invoked by Alsatians at all levels of sophistication, in which fabulous allusions to other 'more favoured' regions or to former 'more prosperous' times present the historian with the problem of rhetorical exaggeration, with frequent diversions from the hard economic reality behind the public façade, in short with elaborate histrionics rather than history.

The details of this economic mythology, however, are crucial to an understanding of local attitudes and aspirations. Along with the endless protests, petitions, and the archetypal language of complaint, they were all part of the legendary 'esprit frondeur des Alsaciens', not least among their merchant and industrial classes. The official reports by prefects, sub-prefects, mayors, and — *par excellence* — the record of the Chamber of Commerce in Strasbourg should be seen in that light. Alsatians as a rule viewed their fortunes more in relation to their foreign neighbours across the Rhine and their newly acquired compatriots of the lower left bank than to their fellow-countrymen across the Vosges. In professing their hardships, they were predisposed to seek and find ironic counterpoises elsewhere on their frontier and to present these in theatrical contrast. This idiosyncratic mask, so often sour, so seldom benign, has its hazards as well as its fascination for the historian. The following chapters are an attempt to penetrate that mask, to distinguish the real history and meaning of the Blockade in Alsace from the conceits of local lore.



The two Alsatian departments at the time of the first Blockade decrees (1806-1807)

II

ALSACE AND THE CENTRAL GOVERNMENT 1803-1807: A PORTRAIT OF ECONOMIC DISTRESS?

The Bas-Rhin and Haut-Rhin reflect many of the economic troubles widely current in the French Empire shortly before and at the time of the Blockade decrees. They also mirror problems more closely associated with its inland and frontier regions. This chapter examines the various reactions of Alsatian merchants and manufacturers to those problems, analyses the nature of and assesses the validity of their grievances. The primary sources are ample enough but present the elementary difficulty of trustworthiness. It was common for local notables, economic commentators, interested parties, and not least the departmental officials to exaggerate the hardships caused in their regions by the policies of the central government. One must make due allowance for such overstatement of local difficulties, such exaggeration *for effect*. On the other hand, it was often true that the central government underestimated and seemed insensitive to local problems. Part of the explanation here is that the ministries in Paris were constantly preoccupied with the sheer weight of other business, and no department any distance from the capital could expect special attention all the time. But, equally, they were genuinely concerned to formulate a national policy, one that could be applied uniformly in the departments. Allowances should then be made for such assimilation of pressing local problems into the routine operations of the central government.

i. *The Chamber of Commerce in Strasbourg: one 'official' record*

According to several types of Alsatian record, the economic condition of the province during the years preceding the Blockade decrees was woeful. It is fitting to consider first the

minutes of the Chamber of Commerce in Strasbourg. Apart from the disparately classified material in the central sub-series F¹² and AF^{IV}, and the more ordered matter in the departmental series M, the minutes are by far the most detailed source for Alsatian economic history during the Empire. Though naturally concerned with Strasbourg above all, they have much that applies to the Bas-Rhin and to Alsace more generally. Composed of or at any rate representing the city's commercial and industrial notables, the Chamber was the obvious forum for local grievances. The departmental officials relied heavily on its records and services in drawing up their numerous reports.

From its foundation in March 1803¹ to late in 1807, it seems that the Chamber could find virtually no reason to think well of Alsatian economic fortunes. Its minutes recount endless grievances and reveal a dismal preoccupation with local troubles. Two general statements, taken from the hundreds available, illustrate their mood during the months preceding the Blockade.² In the first, dated 7 January 1806, the verdict is that 'le commerce du département du Bas-Rhin, très florissant avant 1789, a été constamment en péril-clitant depuis cette époque, et il est maintenant réduit à peu de choses'. The second, of 30 September following, only six weeks before the Berlin decree, refers baldly to 'l'état de

¹ Before its creation, a number of institutions had performed similar functions on behalf of the city's trade and industry. The *Corps des marchands* of the pre-Revolutionary period had resigned in 1789, following the sacking of the Hôtel de Ville. In 1790 the local *Comité de commerce* or *Bureau consultatif* had been appointed. Its functions had been widened in 1795 and its title changed to *Bureau de correspondance du commerce*. More changes had come with the Consulate: first the *Conseil de commerce* (14 Prairial IX/3 June 1801) and then the *Conseil consultatif de commerce* (24 Germinal X/14 Apr. 1802) had been established. The consular *arrêté* ordering the formation of the Napoleonic chambers of commerce in twenty-two towns was issued on 3 Nivôse XI (24 Dec. 1802): A.N. F¹² 915-18 and A.D. (B-R) XII M 34. The inaugural meeting in Strasbourg was held on 2 Germinal XI (23 Mar. 1803): Min. i. For details of the Chamber's early organization and composition, see *ibid.*, A.N. F¹² 916, and A.D. (B-R) XII M 34. For the changes in membership between 1803 and 1813: Min. i-viii and A.D. (B-R) XII M 37. The most useful secondary works on the Chamber are H. Haug, *Die Handelskammer zu Strassburg i.[m] E.[lsass] 1803-1903* (a *Festschrift* on the centenary of its foundation, Strasbourg, 1903) and *Études strasbourgeoises* (a collection of essays published by the Chamber of Commerce and Industry in Strasbourg to mark its 150th anniversary in 1953).

² A.D. (B-R) III M3. Both occur in prefectoral reports to the Minister of Police.

langueur et de nullité' from which the city's trade was reportedly suffering. Indeed, judging from the Chamber's minutes for the years 1803-7 as a whole, one is left with the unavoidable impression of recession and distress in the major sectors of the local economy. This is explained generally in terms of the Revolutionary upheavals and, more pointedly, of the severities of Napoleonic policy itself. The issues were closely interrelated, and the categories which follow here are simply one attempt to bring order to their complexities.

* * *

One of the most recurrent problems was the official regulation of Strasbourg's entrepôt and transit trade. Local merchants attributed some of the difficulties to the inadequacy of the consular government's commercial concessions to the city. Others, they believed, were due to a malfunctioning of the prerogatives actually allowed them. The legal technicalities governing the trade of Strasbourg were so complex that confusion over their enforcement was not surprising. One can sympathize alike with the merchants who chose to work within their rules, where they did so, and with the local officials who somehow had to apply them uniformly, where this was in fact their honest motive.

After a period of severe commercial restraint under the prohibitions of the Convention and the Directory, the consular government had allowed Strasbourg certain concessions. An *arrêté* of 20 Prairial IX (9 June 1801) had granted the city a limited entrepôt status, which rather belatedly brought it into line with the prerogatives granted on 9 Floréal VII (28 April 1799) to other Rhenish ports. The latter measure had conceded restricted entrepôt and transit facilities to Cologne, Coblenz, and Mainz in the carrying trade from Holland which eventually passed through the Alsatian customs posts at Bourglibre³ and Bourgfelden⁴ to

³ 'Bourglibre' was the Revolutionary name for the frontier post of Saint-Louis. Strategically placed on the 'route de Strasbourg' at the approach to Basel, it was also a junction for the Alsatian town of Huningue.

⁴ The neighbouring post of Bourgfelden (usually referred to in contemporary documents as 'Bourgfeld' or 'Bürckfeld') was situated on the road linking Basel with Hirsingue and Altkirch in the Haut-Rhin.

Switzerland. Across the Rhine, moreover, Rastatt, Stuttgart, and Ulm had also benefited from this trade at Strasbourg's expense. The Neckar and Danube had grown in importance, albeit only briefly, as waterways for Switzerland's import trade in colonial goods from Holland. Strasbourg had won limited transit rights on 2 Pluviôse X (22 January 1802). These had been modified and slightly widened by the laws of 3 Thermidor X (22 July 1802), 22 Vendémiaire XI (14 October 1802), and 4 Pluviôse XI (24 January 1803).⁵ But the crucial *arrêté* was that of 8 Floréal XI (28 April 1803),⁶ and it formed the basis of Strasbourg's entrepôt and transit status for the rest of the Napoleonic period.

Now, what the local merchants had wanted and petitioned for on many occasions was the restoration of their commercial privileges under the old regime. Ideally, they would have liked Strasbourg to have the same facilities of a free port for foreign dealings as it had enjoyed while Alsace was *une province à l'instar de l'étranger effectif*.⁷ They would also have wished for the restitution of their pre-Revolutionary prerogatives in the transit trade between foreign states. This had meant the right to participate freely in the river traffic of the upper Rhine, as well as in the overland carrying trade between the Low Countries and Switzerland or Italy along the stretch between Oppenheim and Basel. Within weeks of the peace following the Marengo campaign, the Strasbourgeois had voiced hopes of recovering their former commercial position. An example of their optimism is the house of J.-M. Papelier, tobacco processors, merchant bankers, and commissioners. Their confidence in happier times ahead had shown in a new advertisement of their services to old clients soon after the treaty of Lunéville.⁸ According to Papelier's notice, the firm had 'tous les jours des rouliers en charge pour tous les points de la France et de l'Allemagne, et nous

⁵ A.N. F¹² 503. For a brief discussion of the consular *arrêtés* affecting Strasbourg's commercial rights, see F. L'Huillier, 'Le Rhin dans la France napoléonienne', *Als. fr.*, xxxiv (10 Aug. 1939), 202; and R. Dufraisse, 'Les fonctions commerciales de l'Alsace napoléonienne', *Saisons d'Alsace*, special no. 5 entitled 'Napoléon et l'Alsace', viii (Winter, 1963), 39-54.

⁶ A.N. F¹² 503; Min. i.

⁷ Dufraisse, art. cit. 40-1.

⁸ A copy of the notice, dated 10 Floréal IX (30 Apr. 1801), was sent to the merchant house of Briansiaux in Lille. It is kept among the full dossiers of the Briansiaux correspondence under 'Papelier & Cie' at A.N. 3 AQ 339.

pouvons garantir aux arrivages pour quelques destinations qu'elles puissent être, une expédition sûre et prompte'. It added that Rhenish navigation had already resumed and would be as safe and economical as before. The cheerful prediction was that 'notre ville va redevenir une place d'entrepôt qui doit fixer l'attention du commerce français'.

Such hopes, however, had not materialized. The position as defined by the consular *arrêtés* was that of a restricted entrepôt and an even narrower transit status for Strasbourg. One need not doubt that those measures were in fact very limiting. The entrepôt concession, for instance, was confined to a maximum period of six months for the clearance of any one expedition, whereas the status of an *entrepôt réel* normally allowed a year. Furthermore, as a rule only trade in goods not formally prohibited was granted, with import dealings in *toiles peintes*, muslins, and certain types of tobacco (*tabacs en feuilles* and *tabacs en carottes*) specifically forbidden. *Entrepôts réels*, by contrast, were allowed to receive even banned goods, provided they were held in transit and ultimately destined for a foreign state.

The commissioners and middlemen of Strasbourg would have welcomed similar rights. Admittedly, the law of 8 Floréal XI did allow some modest facilities of an *entrepôt réel*. The city had the right, for example, to receive such goods of French colonial origin as sugar (*sucres têtes* and *sucres terrés*), coffee, cocoa, and pepper, on the condition that these were in transit to another destination. The goods were also subject to complicated procedures of verification and 'naturalization', which in practice meant tiresome customs delays. Certain other permitted foreign goods fell within the range of the city's regular transit dealings, though they were subject to the same provisos. For official purposes, 'transit' was defined as 'le passage sur le territoire français d'une marchandise expédiée de l'étranger à l'étranger'. In all cases the essential condition of Strasbourg's transit status was that the goods should travel to the city by land, enter the Empire either there or at Bourglibre, and leave in a direct routing via Oppenheim for the *Outre-Rhin*. The reverse sequence was allowed for the transit trade from north to south.

Otherwise, Strasbourg was bound by the official customs restrictions. The limited entrepôt and transit concessions not surprisingly failed to satisfy the local merchants, particularly the houses dealing on commission with foreign suppliers and clients. Several of their spokesmen stated publicly that their rights were illusory. Pressure for reform through official protests and petitions to Paris started at once. The government responded with two measures. One, dated 6 Brumaire XII (29 October 1803), in effect added insult to injury. It granted entrepôt facilities to Mainz and Bourglibre, but not Strasbourg, for the trade in cotton yarn and cloth of either cotton or cotton and linen. The other measure was issued on 28 Frimaire XII (20 December 1803) and slightly extended the range of goods permitted in transit through Strasbourg, but the basic position as laid down on 8 Floréal XI was not changed.

Entrepôt and transit rights became one of the most vexed issues debated by the Chamber in Strasbourg during the following few years. A sarcastic comment early in 1804, once it had become clear that the government was not going to make any further concessions of substance, was that 'celui qui a été accordé par la loi du 8 floréal n'est rien, absolument rien, et l'expérience démontre tellement cette vérité que tel négociant de la ville et du département dont les relations en affaires sont multipliées ignore si le transit existe ou non'.⁹ Observations on the matter were received and debated. Many reports and petitions were drafted for the prefects to send on to Paris. For what their support was worth, both Laumond¹⁰ and Shée¹¹ strongly backed the Chamber's case in their own reports and recommendations to the Minister.

A full statement of what the Strasbourgeois were demanding

⁹ Report to the prefect of Pluviôse XII, A.D. (B-R) XII M 3; report to the Minister of the Interior of 24 Ventôse XII (15 Mar. 1804), A.N. F¹² 6397.

¹⁰ The prefecture of Jean-Charles-Joseph Laumond lasted from Mar. 1800 to Sept. 1802. On him see the brief details in L. Spach, 'Die Reihenfolge der Präfekten des niederrheinischen Departements', *Moderne Culturzustände im Elsass* (3 vols., Strasbourg, 1873-4), i. 6-7; and M. de Fourcauld, 'Un préfet du Bas-Rhin sous le Consulat', *Als. fr.*, xvii (24 Mar. 1929), 275-6.

¹¹ The prefecture of Henri Shée lasted from Sept. 1802 to Feb. 1810: Spach, *op. cit.*, i. 7-8.

was made in a special report of 17 Prairial XII (6 June 1804).¹² It began by referring to the lucrative carrying trade through Alsace before the upsets of the Convention and the Directory. The value of that trade in 1791 was estimated at 1.4 million francs.¹³ As a result of the subsequent disturbances, it was claimed, the Alsatian carrying trade had been virtually annihilated. Hostilities along the Rhenish frontier and a succession of commercial embargoes had undermined it. Alsace had felt the counter-effects of the stringent entrepôt restrictions imposed on Holland and of the continuing ban on British goods. It had also suffered from the cutting of the overland transit trade from Frankfurt to Switzerland via Oppenheim and Bourglibre. Whole classes of goods, including Brazilian (Pernambuco) cotton, colonial foodstuffs, and industrial primary materials had been proscribed by the successive customs laws. Permitted goods had been heavily taxed. The earlier benefits of the trade had passed to merchants on the Rhenish right bank. The consular government had done little to right these difficulties and much which actually worsened them.

Altogether, the Chamber's view was forcefully put, and the report ended with a string of suggestions for practical reform. These fairly sum up the major points of earlier and later petitions on the same question. All goods either produced in or forming part of the traditional commercial exchanges of the Rhine valley should be allowed to pass freely through the entrepôts at Cologne, Mainz, and Strasbourg. The transit of goods formerly permitted along the Oppenheim-Strasbourg-Basel connection, and vice versa, should be restored. Only competing British goods like cottons, woollens, linens, and

¹² Meeting of the same date, Min. i.

¹³ Cf. the assessment that the annual transit trade had been worth between 1.4 and 1.5 million francs to Strasbourg alone before the Revolutionary troubles: Chamber's report for Nivôse, meeting of 4 Pluviôse XII (25 Jan. 1804), Min. i; and A.D. (B-R) XII M 3. The figure of 1.5 million francs was repeated in the prefect's letter of 7 Jan. 1806 to the Minister of Police, A.D. (B-R) III M 3; also in the *Annuaire du Bas-Rhin* for the Year XIV-1806, 163. According to Dufraisse, from 5,000 to 7,000 wagons in Alsace had carried up to 50,000 quintals a year along the route between Strasbourg and Basel on the eve of the Revolution. The trade from Holland to southern Germany and Switzerland had been so active that Strasbourg's north-south trading axis was then its principal interest. 'Fonctions commerciales de l'Alsace napoléonienne', 40.

silkstuffs should be prohibited outright. The customs procedures for verifying cargoes should be overhauled and generally eased by a new system of *acquits à caution*. In the case of dutiable goods, special tariff rates should be granted to consignments in bulk — the suggested standard was carts drawn by four or more horses — passing through Strasbourg from Mainz to Basel or in the opposite direction. All these requests amounted to a petition for Strasbourg to be allowed the commercial standing of an *entrepôt réel*. Since they were repeated in the *Annuaire du Bas-Rhin* for the Year XIV-1806,¹⁴ the Chamber apparently saw no impropriety in making them public. Earlier in the Consulate its members had noted with dismay that Strasbourg had been passed over when Cologne and Mainz were granted *entrepôts réels* for a short period.¹⁵ They became more disgruntled still when Cologne was declared a 'free port' for some specified goods on 27 Fructidor XII (14 September 1804).¹⁶

In spite of its protests, the Chamber's petition of 17 Prairial was turned down in Paris,¹⁷ perhaps mainly because the *Conseil général de commerce* did not support it.¹⁸ During the next few years the Strasbourgeois, to say the least, chose not to suffer in silence. More protests, more petitions, and more predictions of imminent catastrophe poured into the prefect's office for dispatch to Paris. Shée agreed with them, sent them on to the ministries concerned, and himself wrote

¹⁴ Op. cit. 165.

¹⁵ L'Huillier wrongly dates the applicable *arrêté* as 23 Thermidor IX (11 Aug. 1801): *Alsace napoléonienne*, 292. The consular measure, which followed the recommendation of the *Conseil d'État*, was issued in fact on 23 Thermidor X (exactly a year later): A.N. AF^{IV} 67. On certain conditions Cologne and Mainz were allowed 'un entrepôt réel de marchandises et denrées étrangères prohibées et non prohibées, coloniales et autres', but this had ended with the new prohibition of 7 Thermidor XI (26 July 1803): A.N. AF^{IV} 101.

¹⁶ That was the date of the local chamber's formal petition to Napoleon during an audience in the city. The concessionary decree, which in effect restored to Cologne its status as an *entrepôt réel* and some facilities of a 'free port', followed two days later: A.N. AF^{IV} 138. The new position was effective as from 20 Germinal XIII (10 Apr. 1805), as the Chamber in Strasbourg noted at its meeting of 27 Germinal following, Min. i. Mainz, however, did not recover its former status until 11 Feb. 1809, as recorded by the Strasbourgeois on that day, Min. iv.

¹⁷ Minister of the Interior (Champagny) to Shée, 5 Fructidor XII (23 Aug. 1804): meeting of the Chamber on the second *Jour complémentaire* following (19 Sept. 1804), Min. i.

¹⁸ Negative decision of 2 Frimaire XIII (23 Nov. 1804): A.N. F¹² 190.

several letters on the city's behalf. The details varied with events, but the central demand for more liberal entrepôt and transit rights was the same. On 4 Prairial XIII (24 May 1805), for example, the Chamber focused on refined sugar and tobacco twists (*tabacs en carottes*) — 'qui de tout tems formaient la cargaison principale de la Hollande sur le Rhin pour le transit en Suisse'.¹⁹ It wanted these articles to be added to the goods whose transit through Alsace was permitted. On 3 Nivôse XIV (24 December 1805) the petition was repeated, but on this occasion the Chamber thought that Mainz, Oppenheim, and Bourglibre should also be intermediate points for the trade in question.²⁰ Or again, on 19 and 25 June 1806 a case was made for the right to import cotton plaincloth from Holland and the duchies of Cleves and Berg through Strasbourg.²¹

The Chamber's supporting arguments also remained substantially the same. One hardy annual was the notion of a natural geographical function. In the cited petition of 4 Prairial XIII, for instance, the Chamber noted that Strasbourg was admirably placed to be an intermediate station in the trade from Belgium to the upper Rhine. This raised hopes that traffic from Antwerp would soon be stimulated, since the freedom of the Scheldt was expected to boost the Rhenish exchanges between Cologne and Strasbourg. So, too, in its appeal of 7 Vendémiaire XIV (29 September 1805) the Chamber wrote that 'la part que la nature des chûses assigne à l'Alsace dans le commerce général de l'Europe, lui est marquée par sa position topographique. C'est un vallon le long du Rhin qui sert de communication commerciale de la Hollande à la Suisse et souvent à l'Italie . . .'.²² By simple inference from that premiss, the Strasbourgeois argued that the city should be allowed a more active role in such traffic.

The point of this kind of reasoning was that happier fortunes lay ahead for local merchants if the government granted their petitions. Yet to reinforce their demands by ironic contrast, the Chamber never failed to emphasize

¹⁹ Min. i.

²⁰ Ibid.

²¹ Min. ii; A.D. (B-R) XII M 4.

²² Extract from the petition whose publication was agreed at the meeting of that day. This direct appeal to Napoleon was entrusted to the intermediary Rémusat: Min. i.

existing hardships. In the same report of 7 Vendémiaire it gave a bleak account of the city's trade during the preceding years. The current position was described in this and many later petitions as appalling. So apparently it remained. Strasbourg received no satisfaction on the issue of its entrepôt and transit status before the Blockade and its accompanying policies gave a new harsh twist to the regulation of Rhenish trade. The petition of 7 Vendémiaire was not only rejected; it evinced a sharp rebuke from the Minister of the Interior.²³ He announced that the duties of the local chambers of commerce were 'administrative'. It was for the central government to decide which matters needed to be publicized and which petitions printed.

Given that the prefects nearly always and the *Conseil général de commerce* sometimes backed the Chamber's requests,²⁴ one might wonder why the government denied Strasbourg entrepôt and transit rights beyond those of 8 Floréal XI. Unquestionably the fact of war, linked with the mounting attack on British trade and Continental merchants in touch with it, is part of the explanation. Fernand L'Huillier suggests that another reason was Napoleon's greater concern for Alsatian agriculture, especially after Austerlitz.²⁵ The argument here is that the restrictive policy towards Alsatian trade was designed to help local agriculture by holding down the potential competition of foreigners and so maintaining good prices for home producers. This interpretation, however, does not explain why Strasbourg rather than Cologne and Mainz, whose *hinterländer* also had important agricultural interests, was commercially so penalized. It is, moreover, a *non sequitur* that the interests of Alsatian agriculture could be best served by a restrictive commercial policy. More generous concessions to Strasbourg might have stimulated local agriculture to greater things and given a timely boost to what was already an important export trade in its products.

²³ Letter of 31 Mar. 1806: meeting of 9 Apr., Min. ii.

²⁴ The Council for example supported the Chamber's petition of 27 Aug. 1806 for the local entrepôt to be opened for fuller trading relations with Holland, Berg, and other states of the Rhenish Confederation. It even thought some exceptions might be made in the case of prohibited goods, believing that this was in the national interest. A.N. F¹² 609-10.

²⁵ *Alsace napoléonienne*, 298-9.

A more plausible explanation of the government's strict line, noted already in another connection, was the genuine concern in Paris to have the official customs policy applied as nationally and as uniformly as possible. This resolve hardened as the war on British trade intensified. There was no outstanding reason why Strasbourg should be allowed special favours. It seems, furthermore, that the government did not yet rate the city's commercial potential equally with that of Cologne and Mainz. It sometimes made the irritating point that Strasbourg was not literally 'on the Rhine' but lay on the river Ill some three miles away. As ministers were loath to duplicate the more precisely defined Rhine allocations, this pedantic argument was useful. It served as a long-stop to disqualify Strasbourg from becoming an *entrepôt réel* or 'free port' like other towns actually on the Rhine.

* * *

The second broad group of Alsatian economic troubles, often barely separable from the first, involved the range of import and export restrictions applicable throughout the Empire on certain goods. As frontier people all Alsatians, not only the Strasbourgeois, felt their pressure directly. Frontier provinces were more immediately exposed to the disruption of traffic implied by the prohibitions or stiff tariffs.

The Chamber's general stance *vis-à-vis* the customs restrictions and import duties had formed well before the Blockade. Briefly put, its feeling was that:

. . . les partisans du système prohibitif assure[nt] qu'il favorise l'industrie nationale et nuit au commerce rival. L'expérience détruit ces assertions; les objets prohibés sont introduits, la bonne foi n'admet aucun doute sur ce point, et dès lors la prétendue faveur accordée aux manufactures est illusoire . . . La seule et unique cause de la contrebande est dans le système prohibitif . . .²⁶

The problems posed by the Napoleonic customs laws were discussed by the Chamber frequently and at length. Sometimes its minutes move laboriously through masses of small local detail of only technical importance. Yet often, as in the

²⁶ Meeting of 14 Floréal XI (4 May 1803), Min. i.

typical passage quoted, they make sweeping declamations against the whole dead weight of official regulations and their baneful effects on Alsatian industry and trade. The Chamber thought that the only solution lay in a comprehensive review of existing laws. It favoured *ad valorem* duties ranging from 10 to at most 15 per cent.²⁷ This petition was often repeated when, from the final rupture of the peace of Amiens in May 1803 to the Continental Blockade late in 1806, the list of banned goods grew and the import duties on others were stepped up. The codifying tariff of 30 April 1806 seemed grossly excessive to the merchants of Strasbourg. If total prohibition was necessary at all, they believed, it should have been confined to British goods and those of proven British colonial origin. The government's fiscal motives were considered, at best, as self-defeating.²⁸

Of the official export restrictions, those applicable to certain raw and semi-worked products caused most dissatisfaction in Alsace. There was, first, the normal ban on grain exports. As the Bas-Rhin usually produced a surplus,²⁹ well-to-do farmers and grain merchants often pressed for export concessions. In very good years the government obliged,³⁰ but generally not. One effect was the recurrence of illegal speculation in grain. This sometimes induced artificial fluctuations in market prices, a problem further complicated by

²⁷ Meeting of 14 Floréal XI (4 May 1803), Min. i.

²⁸ Meeting of 27 Germinal XIII (17 Apr. 1805), Min. i.

²⁹ According to the *Annuaire du Bas-Rhin* for the Year XIII (p. 145), the harvest of the preceding year had totalled 7,075,272 myriagrammes, of which 6,510,895 satisfied local needs. The surplus of 564,377 myriagrammes was thus roughly a twelfth of production, although later estimates put the annual grain surplus as high as one-sixth of the normal yield. An authoritative account of this topic under the early Consulate is F. Ponteil, *La Situation économique du Bas-Rhin au lendemain de la Révolution française* (Strasbourg, 1927), esp. 75-7.

³⁰ Between 25 Prairial XII (14 June 1804) and 15 June 1810 grain exports were allowed, on certain conditions, where the home price of a hectolitre of wheat had fallen below 24 francs. The *arrêtés* of 25 Prairial XII, 2 July 1806, and 24 Mar. 1809 named the permitted points of exit, and the export duties on wheat and other grains were graded according to home prices. These are discussed in R. Dufraisse, 'Contrebande . . . de la rive gauche du Rhin', *Francia* (1973), 510. Official papers on the subject for the Years VIII-1811 are kept at A.D. (B-R) IX M 1. For further details of the run of good harvests of 1806-9 and subsequent exports from the Bas-Rhin, see especially A.D. (B-R) IX M 106 and 107; for the decree of 24 Mar. 1809, A.N. F¹² 503. Similar documents on the grain laws in the Haut-Rhin are kept at A.D. (H-R) I M 102a, 103/1, and 106a.

large-scale military provisioning, and provoked from the government diatribes against the whole 'capitalist' fraternity. Another effect was an active illicit traffic in grain, helped by the proximity of the frontier and by the collusion of foreign dealers. Close vigilance by the *police des grains* and heavy penalties could not stop the Rhenish smuggling or fraudulent trade in grain.

On the whole, though, Alsatian farmers, manufacturers, and merchants were more vexed by the laws bearing on the trade in tobacco and hemp. The tobacco question involved much more than export restrictions and is discussed more fully in the next sub-section. The focus here is on hemp. As the Bas-Rhin was one of the Empire's main hemp-producing regions, its economic notables felt that interested parties were entitled to generous concessions in their trade with Rhenish and Swiss customers. The chief points of their petitions might be illustrated from the Chamber's minutes for many a debate between 1803 and 1806, but the fullest discussion of the issue took place on 18 Pluviôse XII (8 February 1804).³¹ Again current difficulties were stressed by a nostalgic account of earlier prosperity. In those happier times before the Revolutionary upheavals, it was argued, Alsatians had enjoyed a lucrative trade to Germany and Switzerland in raw hemp and a range of semi-worked or finished hempen products. Cloth for domestic use (*toiles de ménage*), cheap working clothes, handkerchiefs, sailcloth, and rope had all sold well there. The main demand for 'grey hemp' had come from Swiss clients, that for 'white hemp' from German ones. Alsatian manufacturers had in turn imported semi-finished hempen articles from these dealers and worked them up for disposal on their local market. The associated benefits to merchant carriers and middlemen had been important. But the Revolutionary wars had undermined this trade, in which Strasbourg, Brumath, and Bischwiller had suffered the worst losses.³²

³¹ Min. i; A.D. (B-R) XII M 3.

³² In its report for Nivôse XII (Dec. 1803-Jan. 1804) the Chamber estimated that those three cantons had once produced 20,000 quintals of hemp annually, but it added that output had long since dropped, with the loss of traditional employment to many rural labourers: A.D. (B-R) XII M 3.

Félix Ponteil's figures,³³ drawn from the official sources, illustrate the decline of this branch of the Alsatian economy. In 1778 some 60,000 quintals³⁴ of hemp had been produced in the Bas-Rhin and a total of 194 towns and villages had been engaged in its cultivation. Until 1802 about half of the total output had been exported to Germany and Switzerland, a trade worth around 2.25 million francs to the department each year. Apart from the Revolutionary losses, the most serious set-backs had come during the Year IX. In 1802 output had slumped to 37,500 quintals, itself indeed the immediate reason for the official ban on exports of raw hemp. According to the cited account of 18 Pluviôse XII, the export restrictions had quashed all hopes of reviving the old trade and had also encouraged speculative abuses and frauds.³⁵ Official policy, the Chamber complained, was misguided as well as unfair. On the one hand, Alsatian output exceeded any conceivable military or naval needs, so that there was no good reason to fear that the latter would be jeopardized if the export ban was lifted. On the other, the export concessions asked for applied to a type of hemp (*chanvres gris*) which was considered unsuitable for naval use in any case, and so the restriction seemed pointless.

During the years preceding the Blockade, the Alsatian hemp problem lay not in the capacity to produce but in markets. Faltering demand on the local or even the wider home market left all branches of this industry chronically underemployed. The interests of growers and manufacturers alike were linked in a circular problem of market default. So were those of the middlemen serving them, although they usually had other irons in the fire to fall back on. As the

³³ *Situation économique du Bas-Rhin*, 74-5.

³⁴ All figures given in these pages are as originally cited. Unfortunately, the primary sources and some secondary ones based on them do not always make it clear which unit of measurement is being used. Contemporary documents sometimes distinguish between the 'old quintal' (hundredweight) and the 'metric quintal' (100 kg). My assumption is that the latter applies, unless otherwise specified, since it was the official unit of weight adopted under the Empire for production in bulk.

³⁵ The relevant measures were those of 26 Messidor XI (15 July 1803), prohibiting exports of raw hemp until 1 Vendémiaire XII (24 Sept. 1803), and 30 Fructidor XI (17 Sept. 1803), extending the ban permanently until the peace: A.N. F¹² 503.

Chamber explained in a letter to Decrès,³⁶ Minister of the Marine,

Les marchés de Strasbourg abondent en toiles communes, que les cultivateurs y apportent, et qu'ils colportent même dans les maisons des particuliers. Où donc en serait le débouché si la fabrication pouvait en être augmentée, ce qui d'ailleurs . . . est impracticable dans ce Département? Ce ne sont donc plus les enlèvemens en chanvre qui diminuent ou nuisent à la fabrication des toiles, puisqu'il est avéré qu'on en fabrique autant qu'il est possible.

There were not enough manufacturers in the department to draw out the productive potential of the growers, while the former could have increased their demand for raw hemp only if an improving market for their own products had materialized. Unfortunately, the market for Alsatian hemp and hempen goods was static, or worse. Output in the 150 communes of the Bas-Rhin still engaged in the industry varied on the eve of the Blockade from 2.5 to at most 3 million kilogrammes. Its annual value of around two million francs was less than that of the former export trade alone.³⁷ Everywhere the bugbear of glut intruded into production plans and profit margins were generally low. Competition from Germany, Switzerland, and Holland meant that Alsatian producers were not assured of easy sales beyond the frontiers even if the government relaxed its export ban.

One instance of market trouble in the Alsatian hemp industry is particularly illuminating. It is the case of Gau frères, an enterprise specializing in sailcloth and based near Strasbourg. Its annual consumption of hemp was put at around 1,500 quintals, rising to 2,500 quintals when the navy increased its demand during preparations for combat.³⁸ It was clear to all observers, as Gau frères themselves often pointed out, that the firm had the technical capacity to treble or even quadruple output, given the incentive. But that, precisely, was the problem. Laumond had reckoned in 1802 that the Toulon fleet, the largest buyer of sailcloth from the Bas-Rhin, took only 60,000 *aunes* on annual

³⁶ It followed the discussion of 18 Pluviôse and is recorded verbatim in the minutes of that meeting.

³⁷ These figures are taken from the retrospective tables compiled by the Chamber in 1813: A.D. (B-R) XI M 185.

³⁸ Chamber's cited letter to Decrès of 18 Pluviôse.

average.³⁹ This demand could be met by forty or fifty active installations (*métiers*), whereas the prefect believed that the department had the capacity to produce 300,000 *aunes* a year if required. After 1805 the orders placed by the Toulon fleet were modest, and Gau frères reluctantly settled for an output level well below their full potential. The firm was as it were 'leashed' by unfavourable market conditions and as such was typical of many imperial enterprises at that time. In turn, its own demand for primary materials like hackled hemp and rope had to be cut back, with the result that all their suppliers also found themselves working below full capacity. In this cumulative sense the hemp industry of the Bas-Rhin could be seen as one distant victim of the Empire's naval eclipse.

Yet if the absence of new markets was a major restraint, loss of old ones was perhaps still more serious. The Chamber in Strasbourg argued that because of the French ban on raw hemp exports, manufacturers beyond the frontiers had taken their custom elsewhere.⁴⁰ Although the rope-makers had traditionally found supplies of stripped hemp on the right bank, since Alsace did not produce much of this primary material, clients for the 'grey hemp' which the province could produce in quantity had also turned elsewhere to satisfy their needs. Most of the earlier benefits of the Alsatian hemp trade to Switzerland and Germany, it was claimed, had thus passed to the right bank. The Breisgau, for example, was said to be prospering as Alsace languished.

The recommended answer to the problem was familiar enough. The export ban on 'grey' and hackled hemp at least, and if possible that on 'white' hemp as well, should be lifted forthwith. Local producers should receive more practical encouragement to recover their foreign markets. Specifically, they needed the incentive to send their products to the potentially good markets in Saxony, the Franconian lands, and Switzerland. These staple requests were repeated with several different embellishments and as often refused in Paris with none. A special petition signed by fifty-nine hemp manufacturers of Bischwiller on 10 Thermidor XIII (29 July

³⁹ *Statistique du département du Bas-Rhin* (Paris, 1802), 48-9. An old French *aune* (or ell) was equivalent to 1.19 metres.

⁴⁰ Cited letter to Decrès.

1805) had no more success than the Chamber's efforts, notwithstanding strong prefectoral backing.⁴¹ A freer hemp trade was one of the many unsatisfied demands made by the Strasbourgeois and others on whose behalf they spoke for the rest of the Napoleonic period, and the problem continued under the Bourbon Restoration.

* * *

The Alsatian 'tobacco question' was raised and publicized by the chamber so often and in such detail, and was the object of so many petitions to Paris, that it must be rated as a crucial local issue throughout this period. It was also a particularly sensitive one, for as the Empire's largest producer of tobacco, the Bas-Rhin was most affected by the constraints of official policy. On many occasions the Chamber described tobacco as the 'principal branch' of the department's trade, and some thought of it as the 'hereditary cultivation' there. Their views on this matter, or on the related question of Dutch and American tobacco imports, were relentlessly argued years before the annexation of Holland to the Empire in July 1810 and the new State monopoly of the following December.

Laumond's account had located the heartland of tobacco farming in the Bas-Rhin in the region of Barr.⁴² There were also large plantations in and around Strasbourg, Benfeld, Marckolsheim, Erstein, Obernai, Molsheim, Soultz, Oberhausbergen, and Truchtersheim. The processing or curing of tobacco was concentrated chiefly in Strasbourg, with smaller enterprises active in the more rural communes of Barr, Benfeld, Bischwiller, Marckolsheim, Haguenau, Ingwiller, and Sélestat. The department's annual crop had amounted to 120,000 or 130,000 metric quintals early in the Consulate, and the total value of this yield had then been put at between 5 and 6 million francs.⁴³ Laumond had thought the producers

⁴¹ It was supported by the Chamber in a letter of 10 Fructidor XIII (28 Aug. 1805): meeting of 3 Fructidor XIII (21 Aug. 1805), Min. i. The official refusal from the Minister of the Interior, acting on the advice of Decrès, was noted at the Chamber's meeting of 19 Oct. 1806: Min. ii.

⁴² *Statistique*, 15.

⁴³ *Ibid.* 23.

of the Bas-Rhin capable of doubling these figures, given more official encouragement.

Thus heartened by earlier prefectoral backing, the Chamber lost no time in pressing their case to his successor. Writing to Shée on 7 Floréal XI (27 April 1803),⁴⁴ it claimed that the annual tobacco yield in lower Alsace before the Revolution had been between 90,000 and 100,000 metric quintals. From a fifth to a quarter of the crop had been exported to Swiss and German clients. Fifteen large and as many lesser enterprises had built up their interests in the processing industry, and an associated trade in imported leaves had also been a lucrative source of income to local merchants. Then followed the familiar story of disruption during the Revolution. If there had been no appreciable drop in the area under cultivation, indeed rather the opposite, the processers and merchant expeditioners had certainly been hit. Laumond had estimated that of the 80,000 metric quintals of processed tobacco previously exported to Germany, notably to Frankfurt, between 18,000 and 20,000 at most had been sent there during the Year IX.⁴⁵ The greater part of the export earnings formerly worth around 3 million francs to lower Alsace each year had been lost. Laumond's account was reproduced in a long report written on behalf of the *Conseil général d'agriculture, arts et commerce du Bas-Rhin* by Louis Wangen, soon to become the Chamber's first secretary, and dated 11 Ventôse XI (2 March 1803).⁴⁶ He added that whereas 36 processing enterprises in Strasbourg had normally been in service before the Revolutionary upsets, at the time of writing only 18 were still active. Their combined employment had dropped from between 8,000 and 10,000 to 3,000 workers.⁴⁷

Another guide to the decline of this branch is Shée's report to the Minister of the Interior of 12 Vendémiaire XI (4 October 1802).⁴⁸ The prefect claimed that 365 fewer tobacco presses (*presses de fabrication*) had been active in the Year X

⁴⁴ Meeting of 28 Floréal XI (18 May 1803), Min. i; A.D. (B-R) XI M 194; A.N. F¹² 511a.

⁴⁵ *Statistique*, 17.

⁴⁶ A.D. (B-R) XII M 2.

⁴⁷ The leading processing enterprises and clearing-houses for tobacco in Strasbourg were those of Trawitz & Heisch, Mannberger, Dillemann, Marocco, Arroy, Mayno, Wappler, Sarselle, Baumann, Hecht, and Martin Papelier: Chamber's meeting of 8 Oct. 1808, Min. iii.

⁴⁸ A.D. (B-R) III M 3.

than during the preceding twelve months, with a consequent drop in output of some 25 per cent. These details found their way into the Chamber's report of 7 Floréal XI noted already, along with the less discreet conclusion that the tobacco policy of the consular government had made recovery impossible. The Chamber spoke of 'alarming decline', and this lugubrious refrain was taken up a year later at the important debate of 3 Prairial XII (23 May 1804).⁴⁹ The minutes here record that the current consumption of Strasbourg's 26 processing firms was running at 1,000 to 1,200 metric quintals of tobacco a year. Since the import of two basic primary materials (*tabacs en feuilles* and *tabacs en carottes*) was illegal, this branch of the city's trade had been virtually extinguished. At its meeting of 4 Prairial XIII (24 May 1805) the Chamber described the government's tobacco policy as 'a local calamity for the town of Strasbourg'.⁵⁰ Worse rural unemployment in the industry was feared. The traditional agricultural cycle of corn-tobacco-hemp and crop rotations dependent on it had been undermined.

The disgruntlement of the Chamber in this whole matter intrudes to the point of tedium. Its statistics of catastrophe varied a good deal, but its conclusions and demands for redress had a gloomy similarity. The specific causes of its distress cannot always be recognized in such pervasive darkness, but some are too recurrent in the minutes to be missed. For a start, the Directory's unpopular restriction and processing duty (*taxe de fabrication*) of 22 Brumaire VII (12 November 1798) had not been repealed under the Consulate. Indeed, it had been stepped up on 29 Floréal X (19 May 1802), when the excise had been fixed at 4 *décimes* the kilogramme, or 40 francs the 100 kilogrammes, on all leaves used for processing. A law of 5 Ventôse XII (25 February 1804) had confirmed the excise, and another of 24 April 1806 had doubled it. What rankled most with Alsatian processors was that the Revolutionary measures, so often decried at the time, appeared in retrospect much less demoralizing than the consular and early imperial laws. Legal obstacles had then been less bothersome than the disruption of home and foreign

⁴⁹ Min. i.⁵⁰ Ibid.

markets. Imports of unprocessed tobacco had actually been helped for a time by the law of 5 September 1792. That of 22 Brumaire VII had banned foreign processed tobacco, ostensibly to compensate home curers for the excise, and it had not saddled imports of raw leaves with an excessively heavy duty. Alsatian exports during the pre-Blockade years were in leaf rather than processed form, because the applicable export duty was much lower. It was only 1.50 francs the 100 kilogrammes during the Consulate and early Empire. Local merchants considered the tax wrong in principle, but at least it was not as stifling as the import duties on permitted foreign tobacco or the home excise on processing.

The Chamber often argued that the duties and excise restrained the demand for tobacco on the home market at a time when Alsatian varieties were up against the pressure of American competition. The government's fiscal gain, reckoned at 30,000 francs a year from the Bas-Rhin — 'that insignificant sum' — was no match for the department's loss.⁵¹ The Chamber asked for the abolition of the excise on processed tobacco and its replacement by a system of special patents. It also wanted the suppression or at least drastic reduction of the import duties on permitted imports, and an end to the ban on certain foreign tobacco products. To assure the local processors plentiful and cheap supplies, it requested an export duty of 16 francs the metric quintal on raw tobacco (*feuilles de cru*) leaving the department for the *Outre-Rhin*. At the same time it pressed for an export bounty (*prime*) of 8 francs the metric quintal on processed tobacco (*tabacs fabriqués*) over a two-year period, so as to help the local branch apparently most in need of a boost.

Now, the Chamber's stance *vis-à-vis* the government might have been more acceptable in Paris if it had been broadly representative of Alsatian tobacco interests. In fact, however, this industry was, like several others in the province, not a coherent interest. The needs of its various branches did not always square, and bad feeling was quite often aroused

⁵¹ Cited letter of 7 Floréal XI. An extract from the minutes of the *Conseil général du Bas-Rhin* for 17 Floréal XI (7 May 1803) put the total revenue from tobacco in France at 1.2 million francs a year: A.D. (B-R) XI M 194; A.N. F¹² 511a.

between growers and processors. Furthermore, all the requests made in the petition of 7 Floréal XI scarcely disguised the fact that the Chamber was voicing the interests of the tobacco processors and clearing-houses alone. This was not surprising in view of the close professional links many of its members had with the large enterprises in question. The processors and merchant expeditioners who served them — some firms of course performed both functions themselves — constituted a powerful and vociferous lobby in Strasbourg. It was little inconvenience for interested parties to cover the short distance to the Chamber's meeting-rooms at Place Gutenberg to press their case. Alternatively, they could count on members of the Chamber being willing to do so for them. Several of their petitions openly differed from those of the tobacco farmers who, being more widely spread out in the department, did not have the Chamber's ear or such close professional ties with its members. The growers were understandably in favour of the ban on or heavy taxation of competing foreign leaves, and in this had a fundamental disagreement with the other group. They would hardly have objected to the prospect of an export bounty for processed tobacco, since any stimulation of that branch was likely to boost their own sales of the raw material. But they were altogether opposed to a stiffer export duty on unprocessed leaves. Had the suggested figure of 16 francs the metric quintal been imposed, it would have amounted to more than a tenfold increase of the existing duty. Faced with such divergent interests in the Bas-Rhin, the government tended to opt for the *status quo*, at any rate until the *Régie* was set up.

As for that, a prefiguration of the State tobacco monopoly had haunted the Chamber for years before it eventually materialized on 29 December 1810.⁵² Indeed, the debates on the issue during the earlier period offer a rather curious study in historical prolepsis drawn in the image of the Bourbon precedent. The State monopoly of 1789 had confined tobacco farming to the so-called *pays conquis* (Alsace, Franche-Comté, Hainault, Cambrésis, Flanders) and trade in the

⁵² The working of the Napoleonic tobacco monopoly in Alsace is discussed more fully below, pp. 257-60.

product to members of the Farmers-General. After protests from all the interested regions, the tobacco trade had been freed again by Roederer's law of 30 March 1791. Private enterprise was allowed in both the cultivation of the plant and the trade that linked the growers with the processors directly or through middlemen. Here, then, in contrast to its more usual demands for drastic change, the Chamber in Strasbourg wholly supported the maintenance of the system of private enterprise.

Yet the monopoly was merely a worrying possibility at the time of the Blockade decrees. The Chamber's more immediate concern was with the working of existing tobacco laws. Besides warning the government of the mischief that further restrictions on imports and exports would bring, it also protested at the way in which customs officials were applying existing regulations.⁵³ The ban on the import of tobacco from Holland continued to give offence to Alsatian processors and merchants, but repeated requests for permission to import Dutch leaves and twists were refused.⁵⁴ Another series of petitions emanated from the Chamber when the issue of an export duty on processed tobacco came to a head in 1806-7. The decision to impose such a duty of 20 francs the metric quintal was taken in September 1806. The Chamber bitterly predicted that it would kill the department's tobacco trade completely, since local prices were already becoming uncompetitive beyond the frontiers.⁵⁵ A fortnight later it brazenly declared that the fiscal takings would be 'illusory'.⁵⁶ A similar protest to the director-general of the *droits réunis* had little more success. While Strasbourg's processors were granted certain exemptions from the duty, these did not last long apparently. Late in 1807 the Chamber was again disseminating alarm on that front.⁵⁷ It

⁵³ e.g. the complaint to Magnier-Grandprez, customs director in Strasbourg, at the technical difficulties in applying the *arrêté* of 7 Ventôse XII (27 Feb. 1804): meeting of 2 Germinal XII (23 Mar. 1804), Min. i.

⁵⁴ Meetings of 23 Germinal XI (13 Apr. 1803), 8 Frimaire XII (30 Nov. 1803), 25 Vendémiaire XIII (17 Oct. 1804), 4 Prairial XIII (24 May 1805), and 3 Nivôse XIV (24 Dec. 1805), Min. i.

⁵⁵ Meeting of 19 Sept. 1806, Min. ii.

⁵⁶ Report to Shée of 3 Oct. 1806: A.D. (B-R) XII M 4.

⁵⁷ Meeting of 7 Dec. 1807, Min. ii.

claimed that the concessions had been ignored during the preceding months, that the duty had in fact been levied and even made retroactive to April that year. Turckheim (père), the city's representative on the *Conseil général de commerce* in Paris, was urgently instructed to use all his influence to have the lethal duty suppressed.⁵⁸ But in spite of the Council's backing of the Chamber in this case and Shée's almost automatic support of its various petitions, the government was unmoved. The presumption of fiscal gain was strong. The export duty on processed tobacco was not repealed during the next few years, only modified in technical ways from time to time.

On the 'tobacco question', as in the case of the hemp trade, the Chamber used the ploy of rhetorical contrast. It claimed that the government's measures had driven the profits of the tobacco industry abroad. Dealers across the river, finding their former connections with the Bas-Rhin cut or else too costly, had been forced to look for supplies elsewhere and even to develop their own. As a result the Bas-Rhin had lost many of its old clients, and the hope of recovering them under existing conditions was fast receding. The Chamber often predicted that more liberal tobacco laws across the Rhine would lead to an eventual self-sufficiency in the product among the German states. Even if French policy was then relaxed, it would be too late to save the home producers from a miserable decline into obscurity. In particular, the Strasbourgeois feared the potential of the tobacco factory at Lahr in Baden. Its proprietor, Lotzbeck, was said to be improving his trade each year. Given more unintended help by the French government, the Chamber warned, this enterprise would soon erase the memory of Germany's former tobacco dealings in Alsace.⁵⁹

The Haut-Rhin was not an important tobacco-producing department. Official policy raised much less protest there

⁵⁸ Bernard-Frédéric (later Baron) Turckheim had been so nominated at the meeting of 23 Floréal XI (13 May 1803), Min. i. In Aug. 1806 he was reappointed, and Pierre-Michel Saglio was also then nominated, Strasbourg having been granted two seats on the Council: Min. ii; A.N. F¹² 521-2.

⁵⁹ For details of the tobacco industry in Baden, Württemberg, and Bavaria in 1806, see A.D. (B-R) XI M 194. These include a report by Shée, dated 8 Oct., observing how much lower tobacco prices were across the Rhine than in France.

than in the Bas-Rhin. As the prefect Desportes⁶⁰ wrote to the chief of police Pelet on 8 August 1806, provisions in tobacco were drawn almost entirely from the other Alsatian department.⁶¹ His own apparently had only one tobacco enterprise worthy of the name, though paradoxically he did not name it. Two-thirds of its annual output was exported to Switzerland, the rest consumed locally or in the French interior. Altogether, then, what might be called the 'politics' of the Alsatian tobacco lobby during the Napoleonic period was virtually confined to the Bas-Rhin. And in that lobby the large processors and clearing-houses of Strasbourg had the predominant voice.

* * *

The complexities of one last category of economic problems raised by the Chamber almost defy brief analysis. Yet some attempt at such must be made here, for this class of issues on the whole transcended all others. In its various forms it dominated the Chamber's debates. Scarcely a month passed in the years 1803-13 without some aspect arising in discussion. By far the greatest wordage of the minutes is devoted to its details, and in a variety of ways: routine reports and inquiries, the findings of special commissions, the drafting of petitions, lengthy transcripts of all relevant commentaries, and recorded opinions. It recurred most frequently in the Chamber's correspondence with the prefects of the Bas-Rhin and other Rhenish departments, with the directors-general of the Rhenish octroi and of the *droits réunis*, with the director of customs in Strasbourg, and with other chambers of commerce. In this connection, too, some of the Chamber's fullest and most important statistical surveys were made. The range of issues may be summed up, as it usually was by contemporaries, under the generic heading of 'Navigation du Rhin'.

The whole structure and operation of Strasbourg's river trade on the upper Rhine were involved here. In perhaps its

⁶⁰ The prefecture of Nicolas-Félix Desportes lasted from July 1801 to March 1813. On him see T. Walter, 'Félix Desportes baron de l'Empire, préfet du Haut-Rhin 1801-1813', *R. d'Als.*, lxxvii (1930), 651-61.

⁶¹ A.D. (H-R) I M 116a/1.

most typical form, the question concerned the traditional relations between Strasbourg and Mainz in navigation rights on the upper Rhine and on the Main. Under the old regime disputes between those ports had sometimes led to diplomatic rupture. The rights of Frankfurt and Cologne were also often a factor in such quarrels, for during 1803 and 1804 the whole corpus of traditional laws, rights, and customs in force on the Rhine, especially in its lower and middle reaches, came under review.⁶² The process started in earnest at the 'recess' of the German Empire (*Reichsdeputations-Hauptschluss*) in February 1803. Article 39 of the treaty which followed provided for a new Rhenish octroi system, to apply from Basel to the Dutch frontier. The upshot was the 'Convention de l'Octroi de la Navigation du Rhin', signed on 27 Thermidor XII (15 August 1804) and put into effect on 1 November 1805.⁶³

The contracting parties to the convention were the French government and the 'German Empire'. This ensured that it was from the start a political and diplomatic quite as much as a commercial agreement. In line with a decision reached at the 'recess', the old *péages* at thirty-three points on the Rhine were suppressed. In their place twelve new *bureaux d'octroi* were set up, six on each bank: Neubourg, Mainz, Andernach, Cologne, Homberg, and Griethausen on the left; Mannheim, Welmich, Thal, Linz, Düsseldorf, and Wesel on the right

⁶² The clearest modern account of the topic for the pre-Revolutionary period and the years 1792-1805 is R. Dufraisse, 'Les organisations professionnelles de la batellerie à Cologne: des tribus de l'ancien régime à la guilde napoléonienne', *Actes du quatre-vingt-douzième Congrès national des Sociétés savantes, Strasbourg et Colmar 1967* (Section d'histoire moderne et contemporaine, vol. ii, *Le Commerce et l'industrie*, Paris, 1970, 179-98).

⁶³ Copies of the treaty text in French and German are available at A.N. F¹² 619. An important contemporary commentary on its terms is the essay by Eichhoff, director-general of the octroi, entitled *Considérations sur le traité du 27 thermidor an XII connu sous le nom de la Convention de l'Octroi de la Navigation du Rhin* (Cologne, 1804; reprinted in 1812): A.N. F¹² 608. Two standard secondary sources for the subject are C. Eckert, *Rheinschiffahrt im XIX. Jahrhundert* (Staats- und sozialwissenschaftliche Forschungen, ed. G. Schmoller, Leipzig, 1900), 1-93; and E. Gothein, *Geschichtliche Entwicklung der Rheinschiffahrt im XIXten Jahrhundert* (Schriften des Vereins für Socialpolitik, ci, Leipzig, 1903), 29-64. The best short account of the convention treaty and its enforcement is again Dufraisse, op. cit. 199-216. It wrongly dates the signing of the treaty as 15 Apr. [read Aug.] 1804, but otherwise my account in these pages owes much to its excellent analysis.

(article 46). All dues and other charges hitherto levied in respect of special rights and privileges were to cease from the moment the new octroi took effect. Apart from the abolition of many anomalies current at the old *péages*, perhaps the most useful reform was the standardization of dues by weight (metric quintal or German centner) rather than value.

The direction general of the Rhenish octroi was established at Mainz (article 45), and generally the terms of the convention were heavily weighted in favour of that town and of Cologne. Thus, for instance, the French negotiators secured the maintenance of the *droit d'étape*⁶⁴ at both towns, which kept their status as the 'ports de station', chiefly in relation to Frankfurt and Düsseldorf. They also successfully pressed for confirmation of the *tour de rôle*⁶⁵ in Mainz and Cologne, and at the same time provision was made for the bargees' Associations (*corps de bateliers*) to be reformed there. The historic division of the river into three parts for official purposes was maintained. That is, the 'Rhin supérieur' or 'Oberrhein' was defined as the stretch up river of Mainz, in which the Strasbourgeois were directly involved. The 'Rhin moyen' or 'Mittelrhein' was the stretch between Mainz and Cologne, and the 'Rhin inférieur' or 'Niederrhein' that between

⁶⁴ The *droit d'étape*, *droit de relâche*, or *Stapelrecht* had become entrenched as a traditional privilege enjoyed by Mainz and Cologne. It had been recognized ultimately by all the Rhenish merchant corps, and article 3 of the convention treaty formally reaffirmed it with a few modifications. Briefly, it enabled the authorities in each port to make all bargees from other parts participating in 'la grande navigation' (which see below) call there and unload, both on down- and up-river journeys. This requirement did not affect passengers but applied to most classes of goods, which were then transferred to barges belonging to local patrons. As the latter might thus exercise special carrier rights, the privilege amounted to an obligation on others to change bargees (*droit d'échelle* or *Umschlagsrecht*) in the local interest. However, certain types of goods (baking clay, construction materials like timber for civil or naval use, milk, butter, eggs, fruit and green vegetables, charcoal, peat, firewood) had traditionally been exempt from this provision.

⁶⁵ The *tour de rôle* or *Rangfahrt* enabled licensed master-bargees in both ports to arrange the sequence of their journeys as they saw fit. It was in fact a rotary system applicable to the freight traffic of 'la grande navigation'. It obliged all clients from other ports to employ the services of the master-bargee who had reached the top of the list at any given point, as only one barge at a time might be loaded. The maximum loading period was ten days, whether or not the barge in question was fully laden. Article 18 of the convention treaty allowed any master-bargee to skip a turn on the *tour de rôle*, and also imposed limits on the size of cargoes.

Cologne and Holland. The former distinction between two sorts of freight traffic on the Rhine was also upheld. Article 19 of the treaty defined 'la grande navigation' as that which, extending from one official stretch of the river to another, had to pass Mainz and Cologne in either direction. It was regarded as the preserve of the Associations in those ports, and technically article 14 confined it to their licensed members. In practice, allowance was again made for the range of goods normally exempted from the *droit d'étape*. 'La grande navigation' was operated on the whole in vessels of larger tonnage, usually of from 750 to 2,000 metric quintals capacity, though occasionally more.

'La petite navigation', often referred to formerly as 'la navigation intérimaire', had a number of meanings and is not summarized easily. Generally it referred to the relations between ports and towns on one bank of the Rhine, or between both banks, which did not pass through the two 'ports de station'. In principle, then, it applied to traffic between ports *within* one of the official stretches, although direct dealings between one of the staples and another port up or down river of it were not excluded from this category. Article 20 of the treaty allowed any bargee on either bank to engage in such traffic, subject to his having a navigation licence duly issued by his sovereign. Article 21 further permitted him to trade freely in any port on his own stretch of the river, on condition that he did not pass the two staples. This right extended even to ports below Cologne in traffic to and from the Dutch frontier. As in former times, 'la petite navigation' was considered a privilege granted by the public authorities to craft not subject to the guild regulations.

Finally, the convention treaty recognized three clear lines of authority in the regulation of Rhenish navigation. At the local level, the chambers of commerce had powers to supervise shipping in their respective ports. Above them, French officials and more particularly the prefects exercised authority. But the body which had the superior powers of regulation was of course the direction general of the octroi. The work of all these bodies increased enormously and became more difficult as the Napoleonic tariffs and commercial embargoes multiplied in and after 1806. Customs officials

had to rely on the help of the navigation authorities; conversely, where surveillance lapsed and contraband traffic was rife, the customs men were not the only ones to blame. In spite of the penalties, corruption among the Rhenish customs and octroi personnel seems to have been common. In cases of professional misconduct by the bargees themselves, the punishment might amount to the forfeiture of their livelihood. For in such instances, duly proven, the bargees and not the owners of goods were held accountable. In addition to reimbursing the latter for any losses, the bargee was liable to have his vessel confiscated. At the very least he might expect to forfeit his cautionary deposit and find his name struck off the *tour de rôle*.

Altogether, the agreements of 1804 and the following years did not satisfy the Strasbourgeois. From their point of view the difficulties of the existing system had several forms. Sometimes the problem was how, when, and where to summon a new Rhenish convention to revise the treaty of August 1804. Sometimes it concerned the freight charges, or the rules governing the arrival and dispatch of the barges, or lengthy customs formalities in the ports, or the inspection and verification of cargoes in transit. It sometimes touched on the hazards of Rhenish shipping (accidents, safety precautions, and periods when the river was impassable because of ice or floods) and on the laws binding the various bargees' Associations. It often had to do with the allocation of costs of upkeep: the maintenance of trade depots, planking, jetties, embankments, bridges, ditches, and the like. Whatever the immediate difficulty, the broader issue nearly always involved the regional interests and rivalries of the major Rhenish ports. This alone explains its complexity, as the fortunes of many merchant communities were at stake. And so if new plans were always under discussion, nothing could be rushed through in the way of reform.

The technical details of all this are daunting, but at least the general principle involved is easily stated. It was enunciated by Jeanbon Saint-André, among others, in words reminiscent of the saws of Friedrich von Gentz on the European communities: 'Aucune des parties de la rive gauche du Rhin depuis Basle jusqu'à Nimègue ne peut, ne doit exister

isolément. Tous les points de cette ligne sont par la nature mises [*sic*] en contact immédiat, et la politique agira sagement quand elle renforcera ces liens naturels de toute la force des institutions administratives.⁶⁶ Few on the left bank, or surely even on the right, would have been churlish enough to begrudge lip-service to such fair sentiments. But Saint-André was more insistent, calling for common effort in the shape of money and labour. Here lay the rub. Though acceptable in principle, 'la chose publique' tended to break down on matters of hard detail.

The respective navigation rights of Strasbourg and Mainz on the upper Rhine, for example, had been laid down at a joint convention concluded on 25 Brumaire XIII (16 November 1804) — in other words after, not at, the great octroi convention. That agreement in the event raised as many problems as it solved. Mainz and Cologne fought a running war of words with Frankfurt, when they were not quarrelling with each other, over the working of the *droit d'étape* and *tour de rôle* during the Napoleonic period. Cologne had additional disputes with the Dutch ports on the navigation rights of the lower Rhine. The Dutch bargees for their part, like their counterparts in Coblenz, more than once complained that the Colonnais were using their legal prerogatives to engross the traffic of the lower and lower middle Rhine. Coblenz, equally, was often at loggerheads with Metz over navigation rights on the Moselle. Düsseldorf had perennial grievances (not unjustified ones in fact) against several of the left-bank ports on the 'favoured' side of the imperial customs frontier. On 5 October 1805 Chaptal wrote to assure the chamber in Cologne that 'l'Empereur a manifesté son intention bien arrêtée de ne sacrifier aucune des villes de la rive gauche [du Rhin] en faveur de la rive droite'.⁶⁷ This principle hardly appealed to merchants on the right bank; nor did it preclude persistent squabbles among the left-bank communities for a larger share of the imperial favour.

⁶⁶ Saint-André was then prefect of the Mont-Tonnerre at Mainz. The quoted passage is from his letter to Laumond of 30 Germinal X (20 Apr. 1802): A.D. (B-R) XII M 49.

⁶⁷ Quoted in Gothein, *Geschichtliche Entwicklung der Rheinschiffahrt*, 18; and in Dufraisse, 'Batellerie à Cologne', 198.

Whatever its achievements, the convention treaty of 1804 was inadequate in scope and short-sighted in purpose. Its confirmation of the *droit d'étape* and *tour de rôle* not surprisingly provoked remonstrations against Mainz and Cologne in other Rhenish ports, as well as in Frankfurt,⁶⁸ from the start. In theory, Mainz had sufficient legal authority to monopolize the through traffic ('la grande navigation') of the upper Rhine, as officially defined. Cologne had the same rights in the through traffic of the lower Rhine, while the middle stretch was shared by the two staples. In practice, however, the volume of Rhenish traffic was too great and the official controls too cumbersome for such monopolies to work. Cologne thus tended to concentrate increasingly on the lower Rhine, Mainz on the middle Rhine and on the Main, dividing the latter and upper Rhine traffic with Strasbourg. It was common for bargees from other ports to try and circumvent the forced stops by claiming the status of 'la petite navigation' within the permitted limits of the two staples. But conversely, the port authorities there, alerted to the risk of fraudulent trade, often applied rather arbitrary rulings on cargoes at the expense of bargees genuinely engaged in 'la petite navigation'. Another problem was that the *tour de rôle* tended to exclude poorer bargees, who had only 'la petite navigation' and the variable passenger traffic to fall back on, and generally lengthened the gap between dispatches. The favoured proprietors naturally did not wish to embark without a full load, with the result that clients wanting a prompt service were inconvenienced. The loading period did not *have* to be the permitted maximum of ten days, and the larger the barge, the longer the wait for others on the roster.

Yet the main anomaly from Strasbourg's point of view was that the city had not been a party to the octroi convention of 1804, a major cause of later friction.⁶⁹ The effect was that

⁶⁸ Detailed dossiers on this regional aspect are available at A.N. F¹² 608 and 619; and in the Stadtarchiv, Frankfurt, at Ugb. (alte Bezeichnung) C 38 Nr. 43 a-b and 47 b (Handel und Handelseinrichtungen, Messe und fremde Fahrmärkte). The latter dossier contains a copy of Montalivet's blunt letter to the comte de Beust of 16 Nov. 1809, upholding the *droit de relâche* that Mainz enjoyed in through traffic to and from Frankfurt.

⁶⁹ See for instance the Chamber's 'Note sur les motifs pour lesquels la navigation de Strasbourg n'a pas été comprise dans la Convention sur l'Octroi du Rhin,

as non-signatories the Strasbourgeois had no legal basis for engaging in the through traffic of the Rhine. The local bargees were confined to Rhenish traffic up river of Mainz, unless they were delivering goods there, and to direct trade with Frankfurt. On their round journeys they had to call at Mainz and unload all goods destined for local consumption or for transport to points further down the Rhine, but could continue up the Main to Frankfurt and back with cargoes directly intended for the two ports. That such trade was technically part of 'la petite navigation' seems like a juridical quirk. It bore no relation to the volume or value of Strasbourg's traffic to and from Frankfurt.

Furthermore, the procedures for revising the treaty of 1804 were cumbersome. Article 129 stipulated that any amendment of the original terms could be agreed only at a new convention summoned for that purpose. This precluded the possibility of any quick and effective reform. In spite of continuous debate, none was achieved until the Vienna settlement of 1815, and then only nominally. Developments such as the proposed assimilation of Holland into the imperial customs system after its annexation in 1810 had not been catered for. When the imperial decrees of 21 December 1810 and 21 October 1811 extended the octroi regulations to the new Dutch departments, disputes predictably followed. The Strasbourgeois of course had no direct river trade with those parts, or with the north German departments formed in 1810-11, but they were affected by events there. As intermediaries on the upper Rhine — commissioners, expeditioners, and merchant carriers — their interests were caught up in any changes lower down the river and on its northernmost tributaries.

Whatever their differences, however, the Strasbourgeois were united with the Associations in the staples in opposing any plans to 'free' the navigation of the Rhine. Current regulations often annoyed them, but from another angle touched their interests benignly. At least they had the assurance that the profession of a master-bargee (*maître-batelier*) on the upper Rhine would not be open to any aspirant who

sur ses relations postérieures avec l'administration et sur ses réclamations près du gouvernement': meeting of 24 Sept. 1810, Min. v.

happened to present himself. The mere cost of acquiring and equipping a barge suitable for such traffic (the normal size in Strasbourg was 1,500 metric quintals capacity) effectively confined membership of the local Association to the better-off merchant carriers. Yet unlike its counterparts in Mainz and Cologne,⁷⁰ it was also exclusive to local residents, who moreover had to ensure the personal supervision of their barges at each stage of their round journeys down river of La Wantzenau, at the confluence of the Ill and Rhine. It was felt that this eliminated the abuses of 'capitalist' landlubbers in the profession. Throughout the Napoleonic period the Association in Strasbourg remained a closed and rather inbred body, of precisely the sort which, secure in its rights, became set in its ways.⁷¹ As such, it was not very different from the old 'Anchor', the exclusive bargees' guild of the pre-Revolutionary period.⁷² Some at least of the difficulties which hampered Strasbourg's commercial turnover stemmed from that same determination to keep the *status quo*. The latter had long stamina, for the clause of the Vienna settlement which 'freed' the navigation of the Rhine proved to be a dead letter. The guilds in fact survived, as did many of the old navigational restrictions. What eventually forced a change was the steamship. The 'freedom' of the Rhine took on practical meaning only after the settlement of 1831, and even then by slow degrees.⁷³

ii. *The themes of Alsatian protest: a synthesis of generalities*

Within the vast area of Alsatian economic activity covered by the foregoing account, the most forceful rhetorical arguments

⁷⁰ Official figures dating from 1808 and 1813 and quoted in Dufraisse (op. cit. 206-7 and 208-9) exemplify the 'inter-urban' and 'international' character of the Associations in those ports, in which non-residents were an important element.

⁷¹ Of the twenty-four bargees officially registered with the Association in 1810, the names Busch, Eckert, Helck, Kieffer, and Meyer recur twice each, while that of Zabern appears six times: *Annuaire du Bas-Rhin* for that year, 367.

⁷² The standard work on the subject for that period is C. Löper, *Die Rheinschiffahrt Strassburgs in früherer Zeit und die Strassburger Schifffleut-Zunft* (Strasbourg, 1877).

⁷³ On Rhenish shipping after 1815, besides the cited works by Eckert and Gothein, see M. Altmeyer, *Die Rheinschiffahrt Strassburgs im XIX. Jahrhundert* (Cologne, 1902).

are also the most recurrent in the Chamber's minutes. They stand out as the central themes, the preferred hobby-horses, bearing the weight of local protest. They are briefly identified here.

There is, first, the common belief that Alsace was a victim of the Revolutionary disturbances and the subsequent strictures of Napoleon's economic policies. In his survey of Ventôse XI (February–March 1803) Shée reported fairly typically that 'en général, on ne remarque plus, à la campagne et dans les petites villes du Bas-Rhin, cette aisance qui distinguait le peuple alsacien avant la révolution'.⁷⁴ Many Alsatians, chiefly the Strasbourgeois, looked back nostalgically to an era they construed as magnificently prosperous, before the blight of the more recent past. They publicly bewailed their lost fortunes and were not shy in harping on current hardships. They felt that the consular and imperial government had forfeited the opportunity to help them recover their former prosperity. Their grievances varied in pitch from the plea of reason unrequited to the pessimism of despair. This theme is summed up as the 'Alsatian golden age conceit', with 'missed opportunities' and 'the pessimism of circumstance' as two familiar variations.

Following on from these, Alsatians often argued that much of their earlier prosperity had crossed the Rhine. What Alsace had lost, they claimed, the states of the right bank had gained. This tack was most commonly used by the Strasbourgeois to highlight their grievances by ironic and rhetorical contrast. They did so with the fluctuations of the transit, tobacco, and hemp trade foremost in view. This theme is called the 'Alsatian right-bank foil', and it was used whenever the threat of competition across the Rhine seemed a handy prop to bolster up repeated requests for local redress.

Equally, the Chamber's minutes often refer to problems arising from Alsatian dealings with the French left bank of the Rhine. The two 'classic' forms of this issue were Strasbourg's traditional rivalry with Mainz, which always inspired Alsatian notables to a jealous vigilance, and the carrying trade to and from the Low Countries and Switzerland. Entrepôt

⁷⁴ A.D. (B-R) XII M 2.

and transit rights were the nub of this problem, while the specific objects of complaint were the law of 8 Floréal XI and the various restrictions on Strasbourg's Rhenish shipping. The theme here may be referred to as the 'Alsatian lower left-bank foil' and the gravamen of local protests as 'reason unrequited'.

Another recurrent argument was that Alsace, as a frontier province, was unusually vulnerable to the counter-effects of the imperial customs policy. Local merchants felt entitled to special concessions on this score. As so much of their normal business depended on easy communication with foreign states, they sought exemption from the official import and export restrictions and from the many trade embargoes. This theme is best summarized as the 'Alsatian frontier complex'. It was played out whenever the government's import and export measures came up for discussion. The grim vision of a mounting war of commercial embargoes and/or exorbitant tariffs often appeared at the Chamber's meetings. The export trade in wines and imports of Levantine cotton, German or Swiss meat and livestock were always particularly touchy nerve-points. Any regulations which threatened their movement across the frontier provoked an immediate and angry response from Alsatian dealers. Sometimes, however, it was admitted for rhetorical effect that stiffer duties across the Rhine were simply measures taken in self-defence against the imperial prohibitions and the preferential tariffs.

Another familiar bogey is the problem of Alsatian markets. It stalks the minutes, as presumably it haunted the Chamber, from year to year, and not always with the grace of seasonal tact. Its main features were the loss of old markets, a serious default of new ones, and a circular reaction of falling demand within existing markets. Every major branch of the Alsatian economy was affected by it in some way. This central theme of my study is referred to simply as 'market trouble'. Two ancillary variations are the notion of the 'leashed industries', enterprises held back by artificial restraints from growing to their full potential, and the spectre of 'epidemic glut', or the periodic surpluses caused by a sudden weakening of demand.

Lastly, one should note the evidence of internal divisions in the Alsatian economy, especially in times of stress. Different local interests were often set against one another, and the tensions within and between the various economic branches were quite as pronounced. This was the symptom of a splintered market structure and of predominantly local economic priorities, where the most powerful motive was *sauve qui peut*. If charity began at home, there too it ended. This theme is called 'economic fragmentation'.

One exemplary document is worth quoting in detail because it pulls all the foregoing themes together in a concentrated and illuminating way. It is a specimen extract from one of many reports drafted by the Chamber on the state of Strasbourg's four annual fairs.⁷⁵ The leading themes and their variations are identified in square brackets in the key passage, which reads:

La décadence extrême des foires de Strasbourg est notoire [golden age conceit], lorsque cependant une circonstance avantageuse, celle de l'enclavement des 4 nouveaux départemens réunis [lower left-bank foil], pouvait en favoriser le développement, si un système convenable de franchise y eut été adopté [missed opportunities] . . . Chacun sent le mal et chacun en cherche le remède dans le cercle étroit de ses relations [economic fragmentation, *sauve qui peut*]. Laissant à part toutes les considérations d'intérêt particulier, nous dirons avec franchise et vérité [reason unrequited] que le régime actuel des prohibitions douanières et de la triple ligne qui en est une conséquence, est absolument incompatible avec la prospérité d'une foire [frontier complex]; il écarte tous les négocians et fabriques étrangers [frontier complex, right-bank foil] et contrarie extraordinairement les fabriques nationales [market trouble, leashed industries, epidemic glut] . . . Aussi longtems que ces événemens et des considérations politiques exigeront le maintien de ce système [reason unrequited], il sera impossible d'espérer une amélioration et superflu de la tenter [pessimism of circumstance].

This kind of textual commentary could be performed on dozens of similar documents dating from that time.

iii. *The historical record of economic fluctuations in Alsace*

The Chamber's presentation of local grievances was clearly intended to give the impression of mounting economic

⁷⁵ Report to Shée of 1 Prairial XII (21 May 1804): meeting of 24 Germinal XII (14 Apr. 1804), Min. i; A.D. (B-R) XII M 80.

troubles and of the central government's unsympathetic response to them during the Consulate and early Empire. The next question is how far that record squares with the facts, how fair its gloomy assertions on behalf of Strasbourg, the Bas-Rhin, or Alsace as a whole actually were. Now, it is in a way deceptive to insist on a study of all other sources for an assessment of the Chamber's reliability. As so much of the primary material in the departmental and national archives had originated in the Chamber, or been based on information it had itself supplied, one often finds its evidence there once or twice removed. Yet other more independent evidence, especially for the Haut-Rhin, is available and ought to be considered. It is surely also in order to examine the internal consistency of the Chamber's record, as such, and point out any discrepancies.

Although this chapter is mainly concerned with the years 1803-7, two important background details should not be passed over without some comment.⁷⁶ One is the Alsatian 'golden age conceit', the other the belief that the Revolution had been an economic disaster without parallel in the province. On closer inspection the age of pre-Revolutionary prosperity appears to have been much less splendid than was claimed. Though time had embellished this myth, it now appears that at least some of the difficulties facing lower and upper Alsace had applied before the Revolution, in certain cases for many years. According to one historian, the 1770s had been hard for the poorer inhabitants of Strasbourg.⁷⁷ As from 1770-1, he concludes, 'le malaise économique et social gagne toute la ville. Sous-emploi et mendicité deviennent pour le Magistrat de Strasbourg des préoccupations majeures.'⁷⁸

⁷⁶ They are more fully discussed in Laumond, *Statistique*; Ponteil, *Situation économique du Bas-Rhin*; Ford, *Strasbourg in Transition*, 134 ff., which has references to the useful works of Fritz Kiener and Ernst Lehr on Alsatian economic history of the 18th century; and F.-Y. Le Moigne, 'Le commerce des provinces étrangères - Alsace - Évêchés - Lorraine dans la deuxième moitié du XVIIIe siècle', in *Aires et structures du commerce français*, 173-200.

⁷⁷ F.-Y. Le Moigne, 'Population et subsistances à Strasbourg au XVIIIe siècle', in *Contributions à l'histoire démographique de la Révolution française* (Commission d'Histoire économique et sociale de la Révolution, Paris, 1962).

⁷⁸ Ibid. 13.

If that is thought too plebeian a view of the city's fortunes, one may further cite evidence of trouble among the better-off classes before the Revolution. There is, for example, little to enthuse about in H. Lévy-Bruhl's account of their Rhine shipping under the old regime.⁷⁹ Franklin Ford shares this pessimism for part of the period at least, arguing that the troubled cycle in Strasbourg's river trade had begun in 1775 due to a dispute with Mainz and the competition of Kehl across the Rhine.⁸⁰ François-Yves Le Moigne also depicts a much more variable river trade in the old *provinces étrangères* than the 'golden age' myth suggests.⁸¹ Roger Dufraisse reaches a similar conclusion even on the showing of the Alsatian transit trade, that object of so many fabulous tales in the later lore of the Chamber in Strasbourg. He speaks of a 'crisis' in the overland carrying trade of the city on the eve of the Revolution.⁸² It was the result of a conjunction of factors, of which the progress of rival carriers was perhaps the most significant. Alternative routes on the right bank for the overland traffic from north to south, and the Moselle and Saar river routes for the carrying trade from the French interior to the north, had drawn off a sizeable share of the business that otherwise might have passed through Strasbourg. The *péages* on the Rhine had helped the land-borne transit trade of the right bank and of Kehl, Strasbourg's immediate neighbour, in particular. Thus, for instance, 71,427 quintals had travelled up the Rhine valley towards the Breisgau and Switzerland in 1785, but only 29,701 quintals (41.5 per cent) via Strasbourg, as against Kehl's handling of the rest.⁸³ Again, some two-thirds of the goods which had left the Rhine at Schroeck in 1786 had taken the right-bank road to Kehl for the next stage of their journey. Competition from the bargees of the Moselle and Saar had made a similar impact on the trade from Holland and Westphalia to Lorraine, and on that travelling in the opposite direction. This routing had meant that the ores and

⁷⁹ 'Strasbourg et la décadence de la navigation du Rhin au XVIIIe siècle', *La navigation du Rhin*, x (1932), 253-8.

⁸⁰ *Strasbourg in Transition*, 143.

⁸¹ 'Alsace-Évêchés-Lorraine', 189 ff.

⁸² 'Fonctions commerciales de l'Alsace napoléonienne', 41-2.

⁸³ *Ibid.* 42.

iron products of the Saar destined for the French Midi were transported by sea from Rotterdam rather than inland through Alsace. Conversely, colonial goods and particularly coffee had travelled from Rotterdam to Saarbrücken, whence they were moved on to Frankfurt and Leipzig. It seems then that the more numerous *péages* on the Rhine had certainly diverted expeditioners to the Moselle route wherever this was practicable. 'Ainsi', Dufraisse concludes, 'le transit par l'Alsace n'était pas, à la veille de la Révolution, dans une situation parfaitement brillante'.⁸⁴

Looking similarly at the position of Alsatian industry before the Revolution, one finds that it too had a darker side. The most reliable secondary accounts, at least, do not credit it with any undisturbed progress. The only branch which may not have conformed to the typical pattern of periodic ups and downs is the cotton industry, and even here advances had not always been smooth.⁸⁵ The standard work on the Alsatian cotton industry remains Robert Lévy's old text,⁸⁶ and its case cannot be lightly dismissed. Arguably, though, its account of eighteenth-century developments is too optimistic. Fernand L'Huillier, for one, tends to take it at face value in calling the years 1770-90 'l'âge d'or' of the textile industries in upper Alsace, before their sad decline 'en léthargie'.⁸⁷ In a later article, while noting that exports from Mulhouse to France fell by some two-thirds after 1790, he allows that this had been preceded by a drop of more than a third between 1786 and 1788.⁸⁸ The partisan notion propagated in some old German textbooks that Alsace underwent a kind of economic ice-age during its first century of French rule is unacceptable. Yet so is the overdrawn line in some competing French writings that the period was blessed with unbroken prosperity. Common sense, as well as the historical statistics,

⁸⁴ Dufraisse, op. cit. 42.

⁸⁵ On this see H. Herkner, *Die Anfänge der Baumwollindustrie im Ober-Elsass* (Strasbourg, 1886), which concentrates on the 18th century.

⁸⁶ *Histoire économique de l'industrie cotonnière en Alsace* (Paris, 1912).

⁸⁷ *Alsace napoléonienne*, 25.

⁸⁸ 'Deux siècles d'exportation textile haut-rhinoise', 113. A more detailed account for this period is P.-R. Schwartz, 'Les débuts de l'indiennage mulhousien', *Bull. Soc. ind. Mulh.*, cxxiv (1950), 21-44; cxxv (1951), 33-56; and cxxvi (1952), 5-18.

point to a more mixed assessment. It appears that the decade before the Revolution had not been conspicuous for any general industrial expansion in Alsace. The 'golden age conceit' of later years was, to say the least, a nostalgic hyperbole.

The historical record is also at variance with bland generalities about the Revolution's disastrous effects on the Alsatian economy. If Mulhouse suffered without doubt from the customs disputes of the 1790s, until 1798 it had chosen after all to stay outside the French Republic. Its plight had been worsened less by the Revolution as such than by the self-imposed if understandable struggle for political independence. The French commercial blockade of the town in 1796 had brought its crisis to a head and finally forced it to accept incorporation in the Republic. Yet even Lévy's generally favourable account concedes that the cotton industries of Mulhouse had passed through an unsettled cycle since 1785, following earlier customs quarrels with the *cinq grosses fermes*.⁸⁹ Indeed, the Alsatian cotton industry as a whole had been hit by the slump in French textiles in 1787-9, which is often but not always fairly attributed to the Eden-Vergennes trade treaty of 1786.⁹⁰

Official figures compiled retrospectively for the Haut-Rhin point to a sharp drop in the number of active tables, total sales, and generally of output values in the calico-printing industry during the years 1787-90. The *Annuaire du Haut-Rhin* for the Year XIII illustrates the point,⁹¹ and another important statement on the earlier troubles is included in Desportes's prefectoral tables compiled early in 1806 and dated 29 April of that year.⁹² This shows a marked drop in the number of printing tables active in Mulhouse shortly before and during the early years of the Revolution.⁹³ Whereas the total had been 794 in 1786, an acceptable base-year, it fell to 584 in 1787 and to only 200 in 1788, before recovering to around 360 in 1789 and 1790. The consequent decline in production was less sharp at first: in 1788 the total number of *toiles peintes* sold had been 127,682, as against

⁸⁹ *Industrie cotonnière en Alsace*, 180-225.

⁹⁰ *Ibid.* 85.

⁹¹ Colmar, 1805, 316.

⁹² F¹² 1564.

⁹³ For the relevant details, see Appendix A below, p. 275.

146,544 in 1786 and 140,532 in 1787; but in 1789 and 1790 sales had slumped to 59,180 and 79,858 articles respectively. The prefectoral table also indicates that most of this decline had been due to a sharp cut-back in sales to France: 109,544 articles in 1786; 65,682 in 1788; and only a little over 39,000 in 1789 and 1790. Exports on the other hand had held up quite well until 1788, but in 1789 the number of articles sold abroad was 20,000, compared with an annual average of some 34,700 in 1786-8, a drop of over 42 per cent. Yet in 1790, in spite of the smaller number of active tables, some 40,500 articles had been exported, which was just over half the total sales that year.

Another interesting detail of Desportes's evidence is that between 1786 and 1788 the value of articles imported into Mulhouse had exceeded that of its exports by nearly 300 per cent. In 1789 the ratio had fallen to 2:1, and in 1790, for the first time, the value of exports (1,458,000 *livres*) had topped that of imports (1,316,888 *livres*). Altogether, if the Revolution had had a disruptive effect on the major industries of Mulhouse, most of the trouble was due to problems in the French market. Yet the downward trend of sales here, as well as the steady drop in imported articles, had begun in 1787. Desportes himself admits as much in referring to 'the progressive decline' over the years 1786-90. While he was right in linking the ruin of several Mulhouse firms with the Revolution, his own figures point to serious set-backs at least one year before 1789.

There is similar evidence of widespread economic malaise in Strasbourg and the Bas-Rhin just before and during the early years of the Revolution.⁹⁴ Brunschwig estimates that of the city's total population of around 50,000 in 1790, those who were too poor to pay any taxes or who were assessed on the equivalent of only one or two days' wages numbered, along with their families, some 22,000. They relied heavily on public charity and were a constant worry to the authorities. A third of the bourgeoisie of Strasbourg are described as 'very poor' and were able to eke out a livelihood only

⁹⁴ See e.g. H. Brunschwig, 'Histoire de la crise économique de 1788 à 1790 à Strasbourg', *Als. fr.*, xvii, no. 441 (23 June 1929), 540-2; xviii, no. 454 (22 Sept. 1929), 830-1, no. 456 (6 Oct. 1929), 869-70, and no. 461 (10 Nov. 1929), 954-6.

because their trades were protected by the guild regulations.⁹⁵ As for the department's agriculture, the harvest of 1787 had been poor and that of 1788 only mediocre. Grain exports had been stopped as the fears of shortage intensified. The wine harvest of 1788 had been spoilt by 'scalding' (*échaudage*) during the hot summer and was generally regarded as a failure. The notoriously harsh winter of 1788-9 had harmed the potato crop and fruit trees, prevented peasants from going to market, and even for a few months kept the normally lucrative illicit traffic in grain ice-bound. A scarcity of meat had added to the furore over the unpopular butchery laws of 1787 in Strasbourg. Brunschwig concludes that on the whole 'an extremely serious crisis' had overtaken Alsace in the years 1787-90.⁹⁶ In such surroundings we are a long way from the 'golden age' of plenty.

* * *

The periodicity of Alsatian economic troubles in the more conventional accounts is too glib in other ways. It will not do to construe the whole Revolutionary decade from 1789 to 1799 as a time of unrelieved disaster. An important chronological distinction can and should be made at 1793. Until the controlled economy of the Year II, Alsatian manufacturers and merchants had experienced the benefits as well as the shocks of the Revolution. The Constituent Assembly's liberal reforms, notably the comparatively generous entrepôt and transit concessions of 10 July 1791⁹⁷ and 7 September 1792, had been welcomed by many Strasbourgeois. Laumond remarked later that a 'prodigious quantity' of goods of all sorts had travelled along the route from Speyer to Basel in terms of the former law, and that Strasbourg had become the focal point of this transit trade.⁹⁸ The city's merchants looked back on it later as a most enviable concession, one

⁹⁵ Art. cit. 540.

⁹⁶ Ibid. 542.

⁹⁷ Having abolished the corporations on 16 Feb. 1791, the Assembly proclaimed the liberty of navigation on all home rivers on 14 July following. It appears, though, that these measures were partly disregarded, at least to the extent that the old bargees' associations on the Rhine continued to function. It should also be remembered, however, that at this stage Mainz, Coblenz, and Cologne had not yet been annexed to France.

⁹⁸ *Statistique*, 120-1.

unhappily ended by the *représentants aux armées* in the eastern departments in 1793. Here indeed the 'golden age conceit' and the accompanying lament about the Revolution's catastrophic effects on Alsatian trade seem to be crossed in the Chamber's later minutes. If the law of 10 July 1791 had pleased most merchants of Strasbourg, then clearly their misfortunes had not run the whole length of the Revolution. It seems that their main difficulties had set in during the course of 1793, and more particularly after its notoriously restrictive law of 24 July. With these had come, in due course, the excesses of the Terror, massive emigration, the physical disruption of war, and the *assignat* crisis. The worst of the Revolutionary troubles had stretched thus from the summer of 1793 to the *coup d'état* of Brumaire.

The suppression of the old customs barriers in 1790, furthermore, had not had the expected results. That decision had been taken in spite of strong protests from all the Alsatian deputies, following repeated petitions in their *cahiers de doléances* of 1789. Local notables, always their own worst prophets of doom, had expressed grave fears that the *recullement des barrières* would ruin Alsatian trade. Some evidence suggests, though, that the over-all effects of that policy may have been more salutary than otherwise. Some privileged individuals and corporations had indeed lost their exclusive toll dues without compensation, but the merchant class as a whole had benefited from the opening up of the Vosges as something like a commercial freeway from the French interior to lower Alsace and so on to the *Outre-Rhin*. The point was noted by Bottin, the almanac editor,⁹⁹ and not long afterwards Laumond felt able to write that 'depuis la suppression des barrières qui longeaient la chaîne des Vosges, cette branche [internal carrying trade] est bien plus étendue'.¹⁰⁰ Certainly, the repeal had not distributed the profits of a privileged few evenly through the local population; but at least it had removed the obsolete patchwork of internal tolls. It had enabled many more merchants of middling or lesser means, including a great many pedlars

⁹⁹ *Annuaire du Bas-Rhin* for the Year VII, 123.

¹⁰⁰ *Statistique*, 120. See also on this R. Werner, *Le Rattachement douanier de l'Alsace à la France* (Paris, 1950).

(*colporteurs*), to move about and trade more freely, if only for a time. Where facility of internal traffic and of links between Alsace and the French interior was concerned, the Revolution had cleared away the worst of the old obstacles. In this sense it had helped to prepare the ground for later commercial expansion.

Such evidence hardly squares with Ponteil's conclusion that the suppression of the *barrières* had sacrificed local interests without any real commercial compensation.¹⁰¹ L'Huillier in my view also overstates his case in arguing that the repeal had 'overturned' the Alsatian economy.¹⁰² The transit trade had not in fact 'died', as he claims. Both writers are apt to overlook the commercial showing of 1790-3. They base their accounts too narrowly on the lamentations of the notables and on the undeniable losses of the later Revolutionary years. They do no justice to the fortunes of the middling and lesser merchants, who were the majority, or to the benefits of freer internal traffic and the widening of Alsatian contact with the French interior. Once the anomalous status of Mulhouse had been put right, to the economic advantage if not the political wish of its inhabitants, the home market was to become much the most important outlet for its industrial production.

All in all, it is not an exaggeration to speak of an economic upheaval in Alsace before Napoleon and not unreasonable to link this with the Revolutionary events. But it seems equally clear that the later notion of a sustained 'golden age' followed by an enduring decline is naïvely simple. Those times were of course premature for any elaborate theory of the business cycle, and yet it offends common sense to imagine that merchants and manufacturers of the Napoleonic period, as earlier, were unaware of periodic fluctuations in trade and all related business. Professional experience alone must have taught them that, on the biblical analogy, there were periods of fat and lean kine in such affairs. When trade was in a downward phase, reduced profits, higher unemployment, or even temporary losses and financial embarrassment were not necessarily synonymous with insolvency or the incapacity

¹⁰¹ *Situation économique du Bas-Rhin*, 12-13.

¹⁰² *Alsace napoléonienne*, 21.

to survive. At the same time, most of the evidence points to a period of lean kine and economic dislocation from 1793 until the Consulate. Popular hardship associated with the re-metallization of the French currency in 1796-8 was not the least of those troubles. Seen from a point around 1800, the Alsatian economy was not obviously flourishing. 'La note finale est pessimiste': perhaps, after all, Ponteil's conclusion on the long-term effects of the Revolution in the province holds good.¹⁰³

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Even Ponteil's account bears the sub-heading 'destruction *partielle* de l'outillage économique',¹⁰⁴ however, just as Laumond had referred in 1802 to 'la perte *momentanée* du commerce'.¹⁰⁵ It might then be said that the Alsatian economy had been down, not out, at the start of the Napoleonic period. The emphasis is on set-backs rather than on annihilation. The problem is one of scale, which in turn implies a quantitative answer. Regrettably, the present state of Alsatian economic records for the period rules out any exact statistical analysis. The scattered and often unreliable figures available have to be treated cautiously, and they should also be set against the more 'descriptive' or 'impressionistic' records from which they frequently diverge.

In the light of all such evidence, it appears that the Alsatian economy had fared less dismally during the first six or seven years of Napoleonic rule than the minutes of the Chamber in Strasbourg would suggest. Admittedly, recovery had not always been fast or steady, and new upsets unquestionably accompanied the hostilities of 1805-7. Yet compared with the stunted years 1793-9 the period from 1800 to 1805 had seen some economic headway and, in certain branches, signal expansion. Contemporary records suggest that the potential for improvement had been present from the start. Laumond, speaking for the Bas-Rhin, had counted a total of almost 7,000 industrial enterprises at the

¹⁰³ *Situation économique du Bas-Rhin*, 141-2.

¹⁰⁴ *Ibid.* (my italics).

¹⁰⁵ *Statistique*, 90 (my italics).

time of the Consulate's formation. These, large and small, were broadly classified into 65 separate branches. Their combined employment was around 30,000 men and women, and their circulating capital was put at roughly 20 million francs a year.¹⁰⁶ On L'Huillier's reckoning, furthermore, the value of the Alsatian carrying trade at the beginning of the Consulate had totalled some 70 million francs annually.¹⁰⁷ Over a million had been made up of service charges, to the benefit of the local middlemen and merchant carriers. The four annual fairs in Strasbourg had added another 4 million francs-worth of trade, counting both retail and 'invisible' earnings.

Now, as these figures cannot be verified precisely, they can hardly be regarded as infallible. Of the 6,974 industrial enterprises in the Bas-Rhin, for example, nearly half (3,365) were small-scale weaving affairs, rurally dispersed and technically incapable of rapid expansion. They scarcely merit the description of 'enterprises', and indeed in contemporary documents they are usually referred to as 'establishments'. Yet even as an approximate guide the cited figures suggest that there was a firm basis on which to build a more versatile industry. Laumond at the time believed that the Bas-Rhin had recovered well from the earlier reverses, that commercial interest rates of between 6 and 8 per cent were an encouraging augury, and that the department was already approaching 'the old equilibrium'.¹⁰⁸ In the event his optimism was not unfounded. In spite of the Chamber's protests against the entrepôt and transit restrictions, Strasbourg's carrying trade had emerged from its Revolutionary crisis.

The authority for the last claim lies, ironically, in the Chamber's own statistical records. Admittedly, these were not published at the time but compiled retrospectively and appended to its minute-book for 1813. As such they may well be suspect, but as the relevant details reproduced in Table 1 and in Figure 1 show, the volume of Strasbourg's

¹⁰⁶ These figures, along with a detailed breakdown into the individual branches and estimates of their respective employment, capital assets, and annual trade values, appear in the 'État nominatif . . . des fabriques . . .' of Laumond's *Statistique*, 131-63 and specifically 162. Some are reproduced in the *Annuaire du Bas-Rhin* for the Year IX, 4-5; and in Ponteil, *Situation économique du Bas-Rhin*, 113.

¹⁰⁷ *Alsace napoléonienne*, 20.

¹⁰⁸ *Statistique*, 195-6.

Table 1. Volume of trade to and from Strasbourg in regular barges 1797-1806*

Year	METRIC QUINTALS			No. of voyages	
	Down-river traffic	Up-river traffic	Total traffic	Down river	Up river
V	7,461	1,879	9,340	9	6
VI	33,527	18,786	52,313	30	33
VII	22,359	10,920	33,279	16	15
VIII†	—	—	—	—	—
IX	36,441	27,521	63,962	34	31
X	39,565	34,773	74,338	31	36
XI	51,360	35,834	87,194	32	38
XII	55,353	33,159	88,512	34	56
XIII	70,083	39,312	109,395	31	32
XIV-1806‡	101,270	53,957	155,227	45	39

*SOURCE: Meeting of the Chamber of Commerce in Strasbourg, 12 Dec. 1813: Min. viii, 360-1 and 366-7. The figures in each column of the table include a branch of road traffic which the minutes record vaguely as 'route'. This varied from as much as 36 per cent of the combined down- and up-river traffic in the Year V to as little as 6 per cent of that total in the Year XI. The annual average of this branch during the period from 22 Sept. 1796 to 31 Dec. 1806 was around 13 per cent of the total, but it was nearer 10 per cent if one excludes the exceptionally high figure for the Year V. The down-river figures have a higher proportional share of road traffic in the Years VI, VII, IX, X, and XI; in the Years V, XII, XIII, and XIV-1806 the proportions are greater in the up-river figures.

†The minutes have no record of figures for the Year VIII.

‡23 Sept. 1805 to 31 Dec. 1806.

river trade between 1800 and 1806 was hardly 'stagnant' or 'decadent'. Notwithstanding the absence of figures for the Year VIII, the evidence of commercial recovery under the Consulate and early Empire seems clear.¹⁰⁹ Successive prohibitions and/or stiffer tariffs may have limited the range of legitimate imports, but incoming traffic was not at a standstill. Permitted colonial goods had arrived in increasing quantities from Antwerp, the Dutch entrepôts, and especially

¹⁰⁹ The Chamber's figures, which are fully reproduced up to the year 1813 in Appendices B and E (below, pp. 276-7 and 283 respectively) do not go back beyond the Year V (22 Sept. 1796 to 21 Sept. 1797).

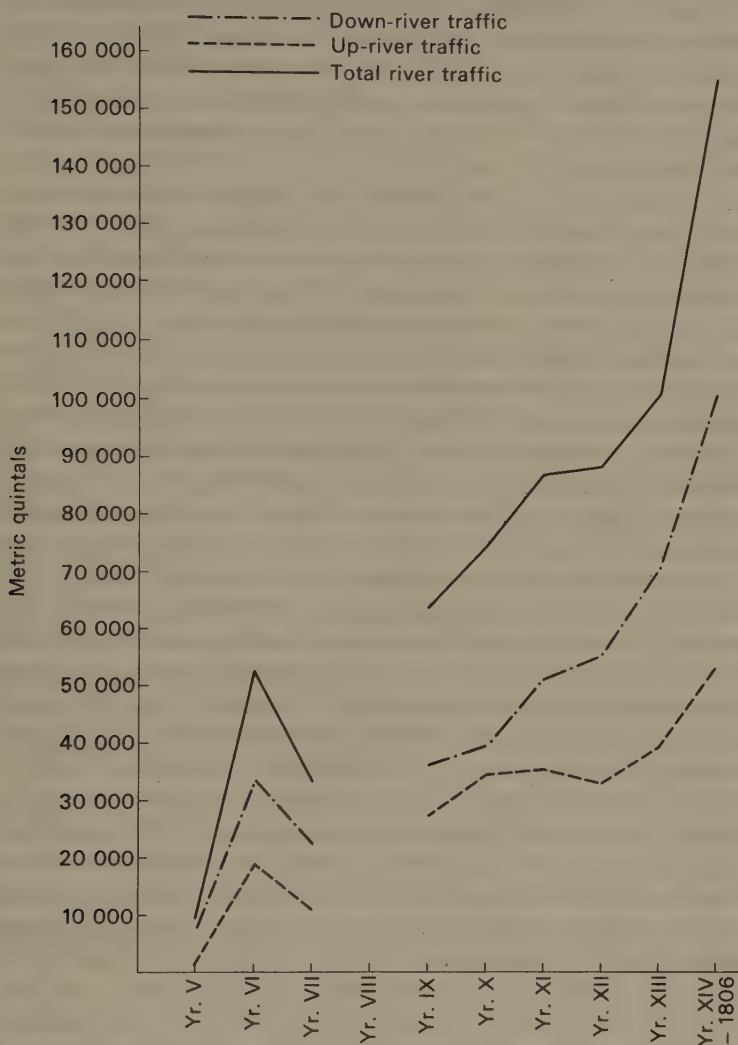


Fig. 1. Annual fluctuation of the volume of river trade to and from Strasbourg in regular barges 1797-1806 (based on the figures in Table 1)

from Frankfurt. The figures moreover exclude what all contemporaries recognized as an active traffic in contraband. The main improvement in the city's legitimate trade had been registered in the down-river sector heading for Mainz and up the Main to Frankfurt. A year before the Berlin decree Fargès-Méricourt¹¹⁰ observed that this commercial branch was 'very active'.¹¹¹

The same account enables us to identify the main commodities of the department's trade and their value in 1805. Fargès-Méricourt alas gives no specific estimate of the outgoing trade in wines, other agricultural products, and industrial goods, but he states that the balance of trade was favourable. Exports and re-exports must then have exceeded the sum of 21,277,500 francs, which is his figure for total imports that year.¹¹² Of this traffic, the largest shares were made up of meat (4.5 million); horses and livestock (2.5 million); groceries and drysaltery (2.8 million); wool and woollen goods (2.2 million); linens, muslins, silkstuffs (together 1.6 million); firewood (1.5 million); wines for re-export (1.5 million, largely from the Haut-Rhin); hats, hosiery, secondary metal products, mercery, jewellery (together 1.2 million); and salt (4 million kg worth 1,117,500 francs). The remaining items (grain, tanned goods, glass- and crystalware, mirrors, ornamental ceramics, German hops) varied in value from 450,000 to 200,000 francs. The implication of all this is that if the Bas-Rhin could pay for its incoming trade to that extent and still register a positive balance, its export and re-export trade in 1805 must have been far from 'decadent'. Against this background, the Chamber's gloomy reports and anxious petitions appear as a deliberate public relations exercise, or orchestrated variations on the theme of doomsday.

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¹¹⁰ The author of the *Annuaire du Bas-Rhin* from the Year XIII to the end of the Napoleonic period and beyond.

¹¹¹ *Annuaire* for the Year XIV-1806, 58.

¹¹² *Ibid.* 168-9. 'Imports' here means goods brought into the department, whether from foreign states or from other French regions.

The industrial record of the Bas-Rhin between 1800 and 1806 also does not square with the Chamber's more descriptive accounts, while the official statistics are not always consistent within themselves. The main manufacturing branches can be identified as cottons, woollens, linens, primary and secondary metallurgy, and all undoubtedly recovered from the later Revolutionary losses during those years. As the Chamber itself noted on one occasion,¹¹³ the iron foundries were 'flourishing' and fully active. If labour and combustibles could be had at a reasonable price, the expansion of these enterprises was assured. Mechanization had been extended in the larger textile firms, though on only a modest scale when compared with other imperial enterprises.

The industrial headway had been concentrated chiefly in Strasbourg, and most conspicuously in the cotton-spinning works of Jean Malapert, who had started this business in December 1801. Shée's statistical tables and accompanying comments on the cotton industries of the Bas-Rhin, dated 30 March and compiled in response to the ministerial circular of 30 January 1806, testify to Malapert's progress.¹¹⁴ The first manufacturer to introduce machine spinning into the department, he had increased his mule-jennies from 6 to 14 and his teasel-heads (*cardes*) from 4 to 8 between September 1803 and January 1806. During the same period his work-force of men, women, and children had risen from 102 to 160, and in the latter year his expected output was given as 8,000 kg of yarn. The prefectoral tables also refer to the enterprises of Bronner and J.-H. Stupfel as noteworthy in cotton spinning. Both were based in Strasbourg, and the latter had set up business undaunted in 1789. They owned no jennies and from the official description seem to have operated mainly on the putting-out system. Their fortunes over the years 1803-6 apparently changed little, and their combined employment is given invariably as 700 men, women, and children, who worked with small spinning wheels and were widely dispersed around Strasbourg. Their combined output was estimated at about 16,000 kg a year.

The main interest in cotton weaving, according to the same

¹¹³ Meeting of 4 Prairial XIII (24 May 1805), Min. i.

¹¹⁴ A.N. F¹² 1504 and 1564; A.D. (B-R) XIII M 27.

prefectoral record, focused on the Strasbourg firms of Martin Bucher, Braun, Zollicoffre & Cie, and Gasser. No precise details were available on the last-named, then still in the process of establishment. The others had been set up in 1805, although Bucher had been printing calicoes since 1802. Both were small concerns, but Shée rated their prospects favourably. Bucher had 30 weaving tables (*métiers à tisser*) and 52 employees in January 1806; Braun-Zollicoffre had 24 and 35 respectively. The latter, with annual production set for 19,000 metres of plaincloth, was the more concentrated. If Bucher's current target was put at no more than 4,000 to 5,000 metres, the prefect thought he was technically equipped to produce 36,000 metres a year in the plaincloth line. The main activity of this firm, however, was concentrated in the industrial range called 'nankeens' (*nankins*). On a current output of some 1,500 articles a month, its total expectation was as high as 18,000 such items a year.

The cotton hosiers of the Bas-Rhin, of whom sixteen are named in Shée's tables and others referred to collectively, had no outstanding leader. Various based in Strasbourg, Molsheim, and Bischwiller, they worked either on their own account or with at most a handful of apprentices. All, it appears, were supplied in yarn by Malapert, and none was credited with a profit exceeding 2,400 francs a year. Three admitted to net gains of over 1,000 francs, but the rest had returned figures varying from 780 to as little as 88 francs. Altogether, this branch of the department's cotton industry was based on small-scale, domestic workshops, of some collective importance but without magnates. Six of the named houses dated from before the Revolution, three from the 1790s, and the rest had started later. While most had pushed up production during 1804 and 1805, none had enough capital to mechanize production more ambitiously. In the nature of their work they were not geared for rapid growth.

The prefectoral details on the manufacturers of printed calicoes are skimpy. Martin Bucher's name features here as the only producer of note, though Pierre Schlienger of Strasbourg is also mentioned. Bucher's employment in this line of manufacture varied from year to year, and so did his output. Shée made a point of linking his ups and downs with

the decree of 22 February 1806 banning imports of cotton fabrics suitable for printing. Bucher himself had expressed uncertainty about the annual output of his tables, since the total depended on commissions and the type of *toiles peintes* required. If orders were for goods of the same sort, he claimed to be able to produce 50 articles a day, but this level dropped to 16 at most when clients wanted articles of more varied range. Sales were effected chiefly in Strasbourg through a retail store attached to his workshop, but he also had customers in Besançon, Nancy, Metz, and as far afield as Ghent.

Of the Bas-Rhin's other textile branches, woollens and linens were mainly small-scale local industries, rurally dispersed and subject to seasonal fluctuation. Yet Shée could record that J.-G. Dietsch in the former category and the house of Vetter in the latter had achieved some distinction. Both were based in Strasbourg, and Dietsch was in fact the department's largest producer of woollen goods, mainly for the army's account. As the expansion of this firm was to come chiefly during the years 1807-10, for reasons closely associated with the military market, it is fitting to leave a fuller discussion of its performance till a later chapter.¹¹⁵

Altogether, twenty-five enterprises in the Bas-Rhin sent products to Paris for display at the industrial exhibition of 1806. A few won medals, and several received an honourable mention.¹¹⁶ Among the former was the firm of Coulaux frères, manufacturers of *armes blanches*, which was widely respected in France and abroad for the quality of its products. Output was concentrated at Klingenthal, Mutzig, and Molsheim, but its major trading depot was in Strasbourg. It employed between 500 and 600 persons at the time of the Blockade. While its market lay mainly in military orders, commercial sales of sabres and lances were also important. Contemporary statistics for this firm show that its major expansion came after the proclamation of the Blockade. There were considerable increases of production in 1807 and 1811-14, with a peak in 1813 of 84,369 weapons,

¹¹⁵ See below, pp. 216-17.

¹¹⁶ A.D. (B-R) III M3 and XII M 15; *Annuaire du Bas-Rhin* for 1807, 201-6. The Haut-Rhin's exhibits are specified in A.D. (H-R) I M 119/1.

mostly sabres. In 1806, according to the same source, the firm manufactured 19,419 sabres, fewer than in the Years XI (21,750) and XIII (20,469) but more than in the Year XII (15,921). These figures do not include its output of bayonets, which were added to its production of firearms and classified separately.¹¹⁷ All contemporary accounts confirm that Coulaux frères were regarded as among the leading entrepreneurs of the Bas-Rhin and that they had achieved a national importance as well.

A prefectoral table drawn up about a month after the Berlin decree provides more comparative industrial figures.¹¹⁸ Being of its kind the document most contemporaneous with the decree, it merits particular attention. It is rather like a crude 'photograph' of the department's major industrial branches at the beginning of the Blockade, as the details in Table 2 show.

Now, Shée's table has obvious inadequacies. Merely to list the number of enterprises in the Bas-Rhin and the share accounted for by Strasbourg in each branch is no guide to the volume and value of their output, which would have been more satisfactory indices of their relative importance. Though more numerous in individual enterprises, some branches listed (especially the top half dozen or so) consisted mostly of small firms catering for restricted local markets. It is unfortunate that, unlike Laumond's statistics five years earlier,¹¹⁹ Shée's table gives no estimate of the number of small rural spinners and weavers who worked on a seasonal basis. They produced for the account of putters-out in both the cotton and hemp industry. Clearly, Shée's entries for the spinning of cotton and wool and for the manufacture of woollens include only the enterprises of some size. His details on the copper- and ironworks are unsatisfactory too, since it is not clear what he included under the description 'usines', or how these enterprises could be distinguished from those

¹¹⁷ Archives de l'Artillerie (Fort de Châtillon), 4 f 44. I am grateful to Professor Crouzet for informing me of the figures here quoted.

¹¹⁸ 'État numérique approximatif des fabriques et manufactures du département du Bas-Rhin', compiled by Shée for the Minister of the Interior and dated 23 Dec. 1806: A.D. (B-R) XII M 27.

¹¹⁹ 'État nominatif . . . des fabriques . . .' in his *Statistique*, 131-63.

Table 2. Industries of the Bas-Rhin in December 1806

Branch	No. of enterprises in the department	Of which no. in Strasbourg
Cooperage	800	many
Brewing	300	70
Tanning	240	30
Rope-making, hempen goods	200	36
Pottery	150	25
Dyeing	120	25
Hosiery (<i>bas au métier</i>)	120	22
Tobacco processing	80	36
Basket-making, wickerwork	80	17
Candle-making	50	20
Spinning (of cotton and wool)	36	29
Copper- and ironworks (<i>usines</i>)	35	27
Copper-smiths, boiler-makers	30	9
Woollen manufacture	30	?*
Arms factories	26	?†
Brush-making	24	17
Hatters	11	7
Madder-wort processing	11	?‡
Coloured paper manufacture (<i>papiers peints</i>)	4	4

*22 of these were based in Bischwiller.

†Coulaux frères of Klingenthal and Mutzig are named here, so presumably the reference is to the manufacturers of *armes blanches* as well as firearms.

‡Most of these were based in Haguenau.

counted under the heading of copper-smiths and boiler-makers.

Yet perhaps the biggest gap in Shée's table lies in primary metallurgy. Presumably the important firm of Dietrich & Cie, the largest ironworks in the department, is included under the 'usines' of that description, though 'forges' and 'fourneaux' might have stated its activity more accurately. It had lost its titular head through execution during the Terror, and though still nominally owned by Dietrich's widow, was in fact managed throughout the Napoleonic period by Louis Drion. Based principally in Niederbronn, it had branches in Reichshoffen, Zinswiller, Jaegerthal, and Baerenthal. Another of Shée's prefectoral tables is more helpful in identifying the Bas-Rhin's main metallurgical and closely

related industries.¹²⁰ It is not dated, but its classification suggests that it was compiled around the time of the Blockade decrees. It gives estimates of the department's annual output and crude value of coal, lignite, iron and steel, lead, asphalt, alum, and iron sulphate. The highest values given are for lead (1,099,291 francs), pig-iron (374,050 francs), wrought iron (322,812 francs), alum (280,695 francs), and lignite (129,765 francs). The department's output of bituminous coal was very small: just 1,835 metric quintals a year, worth about 5,000 francs. As its annual consumption was put at 248,638 metric quintals, almost all its needs had to be satisfied elsewhere. Shée reckoned that 142,910 metric quintals were supplied by French producers, the remainder imported. At first the Ronchamp mine in the Haute-Saône was the main supplier, but increasingly the Saar fields took over this role. Whatever the reliability of these figures, it is clear that Dietrich & Cie accounted for most of the Bas-Rhin's coal consumption and iron output. Incidental references in reports by the Chamber and by Shée give the impression that the firm was far from abject on the eve of the Blockade and had by then recovered well from the Revolutionary upsets. And this indeed is my general conclusion on the industrial condition of the Bas-Rhin at that time, *pace* the Chamber's verbal protests to the contrary.

iv. *Industrial recovery in the Haut-Rhin 1800-1806*

The evidence of industrial headway in the Haut-Rhin during the Consulate and early Empire is more convincing still, although again there is no doubt that the manufacturers had had their difficulties. The peace of Amiens had been too brief to allow them any chance of re-establishing links with former markets overseas. Far more seriously, the hostilities of 1805-7 had affected their inland trade. The imperial decree of 22 February 1806, which forbade whole classes of imported cotton goods, was a common grievance among them. This prohibitive measure, along with the increasingly stiffer duties on permitted Swiss and German plaincloth and finely woven

¹²⁰ A.D. (B-R) XIII M 38.

articles for printing, had made economical production more difficult. Inadequate local supplies of primary materials had also handicapped the linen and 'mixed' textile industries. According to Desportes's prefectural report of 29 October 1806, manufacturers of the articles known as *siamoises*¹²¹ in Sainte-Marie-aux-Mines and Mulhouse were hampered by their dependence on finer hempen cloth from foreign suppliers at a time when hostilities and heavier duties threatened such imports.¹²² Most of the producers of *siamoises*, the prefect observed, used foreign cloth and had no access to a suitable alternative locally.

Yet in spite of those obstacles, the Haut-Rhin's industries had moved forward at least by comparison with the blighted years 1793-9. Where capital assets allowed, progressive mechanization had helped the larger enterprises to economize on labour costs. The process was modest in scale, being confined to the more ambitious and better-endowed enterprises. Some of the machine-models introduced had been known for decades in Britain, where they were already obsolete, and in this Alsace reflects the French technological 'lag' in the textile industries of that time. The first mill using mules and throstles, for instance, had been built in Mulhouse in 1802, and the fly-shuttle did not make its appearance in weaving establishments until 1803. The type of machine most commonly installed in the Alsatian cotton-spinning works was known as the 'mule-jenny'. A hybrid device, like its local name, it combined the essential functions of the old spinning jenny and the mule. Though its mechanical equivalents were already on the way out in Britain, Alsatian manufacturers considered the 'mule-jenny' a powerful new device for boosting their output of yarn and plaincloth.¹²³ The main impact of the newer English textile machinery and of British mechanics in Alsace came only towards the end of the Restoration, as André Brandt has shown.¹²⁴

¹²¹ These, otherwise described as *toiles de coton rayées*, were of mixed cotton and linen fabric, worked up into coloured stripes. ¹²² A.D. (H-R) I M 91/1.

¹²³ On the early history of industrial mechanization in Alsace, see the *Histoire documentaire de l'industrie de Mulhouse et de ses environs au XIXe siècle* (2 vols., publ. by the Société industrielle de Mulhouse, 1902); and Lévy, *Industrie cotonnière en Alsace*, *passim*.

¹²⁴ Notably in 'Apports anglais à l'industrialisation de l'Alsace au début du

The chief spur to recovery in the cotton industries of the Haut-Rhin between 1800 and 1806, in spite of so many advertised inhibitions, was the growth of the home market. For the Mulhousiens in particular, this was the master-key to higher production. For the department in general, a drop in the number of individual establishments had been outweighed by an expansion of the active installations within each. In other words the cotton industries, particularly the branch specializing in printed calicoes (*toiles peintes* or *indiennes*), had become more concentrated. According to some sources,¹²⁵ output in Mulhouse during the Year XII (September 1803 to September 1804) had begun to approach the level of 1786-8 for the first time.¹²⁶ The evidence here is contradictory, however, as Desportes believed that there had been a decline in the crucial calico-printing sector during the same year,¹²⁷ due to maritime losses and the competition of British manufactured goods in Continental markets. He thought that the decree of 22 February 1806 had worsened matters by reducing supplies of essential primary materials (*toiles blanches*) for printing. While his evidence of a fall in employment between September 1803 and January 1806 is clear, he did not though establish the decline in terms of output. Indeed, the statistical statement of 29 April 1806 is at variance with his later reports, notably that of 17 January 1807.¹²⁸ Altogether, it is far from certain that 1804 and 1805 were depressing years for the leading *indienneurs* of Mulhouse and of the Haut-Rhin more generally. If there *was* a downturn, it came not during the Year XII but after the decree of 22 February 1806.

XIXe siècle', *Bull. Soc. ind. Mulh.*, cxli/1 (1967), 27-41; and 'Travailleurs anglais dans le Haut-Rhin dans la première moitié du XIXe siècle', *Actes du quatre-vingt-douzième Congrès national des Sociétés savantes* (1967), vol. ii (Paris, 1970), 297-312.

¹²⁵ Specifically the *Annuaire du Haut-Rhin* for the Year XIII, 317 ff.; and L'Huillier, *Alsace napoléonienne*, 315-16.

¹²⁶ L'Huillier later adds: 'On peut résumer ainsi l'évolution du tissage haut-rhinois de l'an XII au début de 1806: essor réel à Mulhouse.' *Ibid.* 364.

¹²⁷ See his tables on the Haut-Rhin's cotton industries compiled early in 1806 and dated 29 Apr. of that year: A.D. (H-R) I M 136/3; A.N. F¹² 1564. His details on the major branch in Mulhouse in 1803-6 are reproduced in Appendix C below, pp. 279-80: cf. the pre-Revolutionary position given in Appendix A below, p. 275.

¹²⁸ A.N. F¹² 1568.

Beyond their home sales, some *indienneurs* were able to export articles, though such outlets were certainly much more difficult after the Continental hostilities of 1805. During the Consulate and the first year of the Empire at least, demand from Frankfurt am Main, Leipzig, Frankfort an der Oder, and Russia had revived after the Revolutionary lull. Exports to the fairs of Zurzach, Berne, Milan and other Italian towns had also improved. It appears that the mule-jennies used in Mulhouse were of a cut above the primitive jennies and water-frames installed in other more remote parts of the department. The crucial innovation in a town whose manufacturers specialized in *toiles peintes* was cylinder printing, which spread quickly as from 1805. Seeing the prospects for future growth in the Haut-Rhin, a number of Swiss financial houses had helped to make the industrial recovery of 1800-6 possible through advances of capital. They had been willing in effect to play the role of sleeping partners while the department's manufacturers went ahead with the practical job of extending their enterprises or setting up new ones. Some entrepreneurs, like Ziegler, Greuter & Cie of Guebwiller and Petitpierre, Robert & Cie of Thann, had left Switzerland and set up business in the Haut-Rhin during 1805 in the belief that its grass was greener. So, at the time, it proved to be.

Outside Mulhouse, expansion had been quickest in the mountain valleys, where natural conditions were favourable. Water for bleaching and to power the mills, the availability of wood, charcoal, and, in places, coal, access to supplies from domestic spinners and weavers, proximity to Swiss markets and to roads (like that from Thann to Mulhouse) or canals (like that of Brisach), poorer agricultural soil — all these factors had helped to shape the map of industrialization in upper Alsace from its earliest days. An area of concentrated activity was the upland expanse sometimes referred to as 'l'Alsace vosgienne', from Masevaux in the south-west on the river Doller, north-westwards from Cernay up the river Thur through the valley of Saint-Amarin (Thann, Bitschwiller, Willer, Moosch, Saint-Amarin, and on to Wesserling), and northwards towards Munster, the Logelbach near Colmar, Kaysersberg, Ribeauvillé, and Sainte-Marie-aux-Mines in the

north-west corner of the department. All these towns had not progressed as quickly as Mulhouse, but by 1806 they had certainly made advances on their position at the time of Brumaire. The four branches of the cotton industry (spinning, weaving, hosiery, printing) together employed 37,409 persons of both sexes at the start of the Year XII, and their combined output was then worth between seven and eight million francs.¹²⁹

One sign of better industrial heart in the Haut-Rhin after Brumaire is the founding of new enterprises. According to L'Huillier, of the 22 major firms specializing in printed calicoes, 4 had been established between 1799 and 1804, and 2 more were in the process of being launched at the latter date.¹³⁰ According to a prefectoral list of 22 July 1810, which names the 25 'most distinguished' industrial and merchant houses in the Haut-Rhin, 9 had been founded between 1795 and 1805.¹³¹ More significantly, of these nine, Daniel Dollfus-Mieg, Laurent Weber, Paul Blech, and Nicolas Koechlin were among the dozen wealthiest magnates in the department.¹³² Of the older houses which had made progress, most concentrated similarly on calico-printing and the manufacturing branches immediately serving it: first among them Gros, Davillier, Roman & Cie of Wesserling, the largest firm in the whole department;¹³³ André Hartmann of Munster,

¹²⁹ Report by Desportes of 1 May 1806: A.D. (H-R) I M 119/1. L'Huillier, opting no doubt for the nearest round figure, puts the total work-force at 40,000: op. cit. 319.

¹³⁰ Ibid. 315-16.
¹³¹ F.-A. Stackler of Sainte-Marie (1795); J. Zuber of Rixheim (1796); L. Weber of Mulhouse (1797); D. Dollfus-Mieg of Mulhouse (1799, but active chiefly after 1802); J. Wichelhausen of Colmar (1800); N. Koechlin & frères of Mulhouse (1802); P. Blech & Cie of Mulhouse (1804); Lischy Dollfus & Cie of Bollwiller (1805); and J.-B. Migeon of Grandvillars (1805). A.D. (H-R) I M 128/1, and Appendix J below, pp. 290-1.

¹³² On the business and family alliances between the three important Alsatian houses of Dollfus, Hofer, and Koechlin, see Y. Zuber, 'Notice nécrologique sur M. Jean Dollfus', *R. d'Als.*, xl (1889), 507-24; A. Penot, 'Nicolas Koechlin', *ibid.*, xli (1890), 101-13; and A. Brandt, 'Une famille de fabricants mulhousiens au début du XIXe siècle: Jean Koechlin et ses fils', *Ann. É.S.C.*, vi/3 (1951), 319-30.

¹³³ For further details of its Alsatian interests and links with a sister house (Gros, Davillier & Cie) in Paris, as well as with business associates elsewhere, see E. Zuber, 'Notice nécrologique sur M. Jacques-Gabriel Gros', *Bull. Soc. ind. Mulh.*, xxxiv (1864), 145-54. An important recent summary of these connections is Bergeron, *Banquiers, négociants et manufacturiers parisiens*, ii. 452-9 and 551-2.

a notable patron of the artists and designers who worked for the *indienneurs*,¹³⁴ Jean Hofer & Cie of Mulhouse; and Jean and Jean-Michel Haussmann frères of the Logelbach, whose recovery after near extinction during the Revolutionary upsets had been outstanding.¹³⁵ Altogether, the '*fabricantocratie*' of the Haut-Rhin and more especially of Mulhouse had thus taken shape before the Blockade. It could hardly have done so in an economic context stamped by 'decadence' or 'stagnation'. Prima facie, the evidence points in another direction.

* * *

Whatever their inadequacies, the available statistics support the more descriptive evidence of industrial recovery in the Haut-Rhin during the Consulate and early Empire. Several quite detailed documents offer an account of the industrial position of the department shortly before and after the issue of the Berlin decree. However, they also show that if there had been recovery and expansion under Napoleonic rule, the momentum was slowing up in some branches during the last quarter of 1806 and the first two quarters of 1807. News of the Berlin decree broke in a context of something like an industrial slack. As in other imperial departments, notably in Belgium, the Nord, and Normandy, the trend was most sharply defined in the cotton industries. It appears that this wider industrial lull during the winter of 1806-7 had a slightly earlier effect in the Haut-Rhin. In some cases 1806 was a less satisfactory year than 1805, and in nearly all it was anticipated that 1807 would be less satisfactory still.

These mixed fortunes are borne out by the prefectural reports of 29 March, 1 May, and 3 July 1806,¹³⁶ as well as by the cited statistical tables of 29 April on the cotton

¹³⁴ Hartmann's development of a rich blue cloth (*lapis*) in 1804-5 had a considerable influence on calico-printing in the Haut-Rhin, as illustrated by H. Lebert in 'Notice sur les développements du dessin d'impression des toiles peintes en Alsace', *R. d'Als.*, xvi (1865), 5-16, 70-80.

¹³⁵ Paul Leuilliot has assembled most of the material available on this firm in his 'Note sur les Haussmann et la manufacture du Logelbach jusqu'en 1830', *Annuaire de la Société historique et littéraire de Colmar*, ii (1951-2), 85-99.

¹³⁶ A.D. (H-R) IM 119/1; A.N. F¹² 1564.

industries.¹³⁷ Some 15,000 persons were then employed in cotton spinning in the valleys of the Vosges. Most were domestic hand-spinners working for putters-out, and the value of their combined production was estimated at around 200,000 francs a year. The average value of output per head was therefore only 13.33 francs, a clear indication of the very limited capacity of those operatives. Partly for that reason a number of houses had installed spinning equipment to serve the immediate needs of their weaving works, just as others had their own weaving installations to supply their printing tables. Desportes's record of 29 April names only two spinning enterprises of any size: Lischy Dollfus of Bollwiller and Gros, Davillier & Roman. Both also had important weaving works, and the Wesserling firm was the Haut-Rhin's foremost producer of printed calicoes. As an enterprise founded in the July preceding Desportes's inquiry, Lischy Dollfus had not yet had time to establish a pattern of production. In January 1806 it had seven active mule-jennies, together operating 1,404 spindles, and 72 employees. Its anticipated annual output of yarn was given as 13,000 to 14,000 kg, plus anything up to 10,000 plaincloth articles suitable for printing. The expansion of the spinning works at Gros, Davillier & Roman had been stimulated by the firm's own need for yarn. Compared with its 7 spinning machines and 60 spinners in September 1803, it had 36 and 185 respectively in January 1806. Some later reports for 1806, however, point to a slackening that year.¹³⁸

Desportes's tables of 29 April are rather unspecific and probably incomplete in the weaving sector.¹³⁹ No clear distinction is made, for instance, between the weaving of cotton plaincloth for calico-printing and the range of articles known generically as '*tissus*' which were destined for the department's fifteen leading manufacturers of *siamoises*. The two genres are vaguely lumped together in the tables and, in consequence, there is a suggestion of double counting

¹³⁷ A.D. (H-R) I M 136/3; A.N. F¹² 1564. These tables and the prefect's accompanying report are published in Charles Schmidt (ed.), 'L'Industrie cotonnière dans le Haut-Rhin en 1806', *Bull. Soc. ind. Mulh.*, lxxxix (1911), 63-100.

¹³⁸ A.D. (H-R) I M 119/1; A.N. F¹² 1564.

¹³⁹ The relevant document is Table no. 2 headed '*Tissus de Coton*': *ibid.*

in the number of outworkers thus employed. The total number of men, women, and children engaged in cotton weaving and *siamoises* is put at 16,159 in January 1806, of whom 10,000 are attributed to a single Mulhouse firm. Yet in the prefect's accompanying report of 1 May 1806 the outworkers employed in the production of *tissus* (with or without a linen component) are estimated at between 15,000 and 16,000 and are credited with a combined output of 28,000 articles in a normal year.¹⁴⁰ Clearly, these are no more than crude pointers to the ubiquity of such work, as is the comparable estimate for outworkers in cotton spinning. Most of this group were part-time domestic operatives, and some may even have doubled up as spinners, implying a further overlap in Desportes's counting.

We need, then, to be wary when assessing trends in the widely dispersed context of rural outwork and when linking those popular supply-lines with their urban markets. For what the official estimates are worth, the total of 16,159 is a considerable advance on the 10,414 employees recorded for September 1803. The over-all increase here is some 55 per cent, a trend confirmed by the nearly equivalent rise in the number of active weaving installations from 1,244 to 1,903 during the period. Unfortunately, one cannot plot the increase in output exactly, since production figures are not given for the earlier date, but it seems reasonable to infer that the trend in 1804 and 1805 had also been expansionary. At any rate, the estimated annual production levels recorded for January 1806 are 21,760 articles in plaincloth (each of from 18 to 19 metres in length) and a further 28,080 articles classified as dimities, quilts, and muslins.

As for the individual details, of the 19 weaving firms named in the same table, 10 were based in Sainte-Marie. Of these, the largest were J.-G. Reber & Cie, Schoubart frères, and Schwartz & Cie. All had increased the number of their active installations slightly by January 1806 and then had more employees than in September 1803. Reber and Schoubart frères, whose houses dated from 1755 and 1780 respectively, each used 160 tables in January 1806, and both then

¹⁴⁰A.D. (H-R) I M 119/1; A.N. F¹² 1564.

employed 400 workers. The first reckoned on an annual output of 1,200 articles of plaincloth; the second had put his production of *siamoises* and coloured handkerchiefs at 5,390 articles a year. Schwartz had 125 active tables in January 1806, only five more than in September 1803, and his workforce had also advanced only slowly from 288 to 300. Its estimated output at the later date was 5,000 *siamoises*, dimities, quilts, and muslins a year. A significant feature of the weaving enterprises of Sainte-Marie is that 9 of the 10 named dated from before the Consulate, and of these, 6 had been founded during the supposedly miserable conditions of the 1790s.

By contrast, only one of the four named weaving enterprises in Mulhouse dated from before 1800. Laurent Weber had set up business in the Year IV and, according to Desportes's figures, was far and away the Haut-Rhin's largest employer in that sector. As against 450 installations at his central workshop in September 1803, he had 540 in January 1806, and it was he who reportedly employed the services of 10,000 outworkers in the valleys of the Vosges and Mont-Terrible¹⁴¹ at the latter date, a rise of 2,000 on the earlier estimate. If these entries are reliable, he was a putter-out extraordinary, almost a universal provider (or perhaps a *Diable à ressort*) of the uplands, and presumably he operated there through roving middlemen. The estimated annual output of his workshop in Mulhouse was 8,000 *siamoises*, each of 48 metres, and was the second largest recorded in Desportes's tables. His nearest local rival was the house of Hartmann frères, which had 112 weaving installations, 2,000 employees, and produced 3,600 articles a year on the estimate of January 1806.

In the weaving sector, however, the lead in output was again held by Gros, Davillier & Roman. This firm had also made much the fastest headway between September 1803 and January 1806, increasing its weaving installations from

¹⁴¹ Porrentruy had been the seat of the prince-bishop of Basel until the French occupation of 1792. After a short transitional period as the 'République de Rauracie', it had become the *chef-lieu* of the department of Mont-Terrible on 23 Mar. 1793, and later a sub-prefecture of the Haut-Rhin. In 1815 the whole of the bishopric of Basel was incorporated in the canton of Berne.

15 to 250 and the relevant work-force from 30 to 392. At the latter date its annual production of plaincloth was estimated at 12,000 articles. In default of comparable figures for 1803, it is not clear whether its growth had been intensive or extensive, but all sources show that the Wesserling firm had expanded its spinning and weaving branches to meet the growing demand of its calico-printing tables. The new machines were therefore not intended to cut back on existing employment levels, and on the estimate of January 1806 the output per head of these weavers was some thirty articles a year. This alone is a caution against inferring too much from the absolute figures. No firm in the Haut-Rhin had a better average in the weaving sector, and nearly all the others had a comparable level of only single figures. If Desportes's tables are to be believed, several enterprises employed weavers who produced an average of less than one article a year, which, even allowing for the size of individual *pièces*, seems unlikely.

What is not in doubt is that the total output of the Haut-Rhin's weavers was well below the normal requirements of its *indienneurs*. Desportes's table no. 4 of 29 April 1806 gives the annual production of the department's twenty-two largest calico-printing firms as 247,762 articles.¹⁴² In other words, relative to the earlier total of 21,760 articles of plaincloth, the Haut-Rhin could supply only one-eleventh of the primary materials essential to its most dynamic industrial branch.¹⁴³ This explains the mounting protests from the *indienneurs* and their repeated plea for access to other indispensable supplies. They believed that the ban or high duties on foreign (more particularly Swiss) cloth suitable for printing threatened their future, for which reason the decree of 22 February 1806 was heartily disliked. The effects on current production were noted in the tables of 29 April and in the prefect's covering letter of 1 May 1806.¹⁴⁴ The latter estimated that in 1805 printed calicoes had been worth six

¹⁴² A.N. F¹² 1564. Cf. Desportes's tables of 17 Jan. 1807 for the year 1806, which give the combined output of those houses as 255,142 articles. Of this figure, nearly half (120,000) was produced by the fourteen Mulhouse enterprises. A.N. F¹² 1568.

¹⁴³ The same fraction is cited in Lévy, *Industrie cotonnière en Alsace*, 72.

¹⁴⁴ A.D. (H-R) I M 119/1; A.N. F¹² 1564.

million francs to the department, excluding 'invisible' earnings, but that their value was expected to fall in 1806 and to be lower still in 1807. Total employment by the twenty-two magnates had similarly dropped from 8,509 workers in September 1803 to 6,449 in January 1806.¹⁴⁵ The promising momentum at the start of the Year XII had apparently slackened, but again the absence of comparative production figures for the earlier date leaves the matter in doubt.

And yet it is fair to conclude that if calico-printing was the Haut-Rhin's most dynamic economic branch, it was also the main 'leashed industry' at the time of the first Blockade decrees. As so much of the department's expansion in the years 1807-10 was to be achieved in this branch, a closer inspection of Desportes's tables of 29 April seems in order. His identification of and information on the twenty-two magnates are of crucial importance here.¹⁴⁶ The first obvious point is that these were neither fly-by-night concerns nor the products of a mushroom growth. It is true that six of the twenty-two (Dollfus-Mieg, Nicolas Koechlin, Schoening & Cie, Paul Blech, Petitpierre-Robert, and Baumgartner & Cie) were of Napoleonic foundation. All of them, however, had emanated from established family businesses, and Petitpierre-Robert had been active in Neuchâtel before transferring to Thann. The remaining sixteen firms all dated from before the Revolution. If some had been badly stretched by its disruptions, for instance through the liquidation of debts owed them in depreciating *assignats*, they had adequate capital to ride out those troubles. In this respect the industrial magnates of the Haut-Rhin had an economic security lacking to those of their merchant brethren in Strasbourg who at the time had nominally bigger fortunes committed to more speculative dealings in colonial goods, provisioning, and smuggling.

Another prominent feature of the tables is the high

¹⁴⁵ Desportes's own returns of 17 Jan. 1807 give discrepant details even on employment. Here the total work-force of the same *indienneurs* is put at 7,939 in 1806. Well over half (4,796) were based in or near Mulhouse, and another 1,120 worked for Gros, Davillier & Roman. A.N. F¹² 1568.

¹⁴⁶ See Appendix C below, pp. 279-80. See also Schmidt (ed.), 'L'Industrie cotonnière . . . en 1806', 65-87 for the full text of the tables, and 88-100 for his commentary.

concentration of calico-printing in Mulhouse. Of the fourteen firms based there, four (Dollfus-Mieg, Schwartz, Hofer & Cie, Jean Hofer, and Nicolas Koechlin) were among the largest in the department and also important employers. Elsewhere, enterprises varied in size and employment, but three at least were outstanding. One was of course Gros, Davillier & Roman, whose work-force in Wesserling produced some 50,000 finished articles in 1805. Another was François Verdan of Biel (Bienne), who in 1782 had acquired a firm founded in 1746, and whose reported annual output of 35,000 articles was the second highest in the department, in spite of a comparatively small work-force. André Hartmann of Munster, finally, ranked fourth both in employment (600 workers in January 1806) and production (26,000 articles a year).

Yet Desportes, spelling out the individual details of the departmental totals cited earlier, also noted that with few exceptions the *indienneurs* of the Haut-Rhin had lower employment levels in January 1806 than in September 1803. If Gros, Davillier & Roman and another large firm, Haussmann frères of the Logelbach, show little or no change here,¹⁴⁷ other magnates had had to cut their work-force appreciably. Dollfus-Mieg had reduced his level from 800 workers to 715 (that is by 10.6 per cent), Nicolas Koechlin from 444 to 350 (21.1 per cent), André Hartmann from 800 to 600 and Jean Hofer from 460 to 345 (25 per cent in each case), Petitpierre-Robert from 522 to 375 (28.1 per cent). But the sharpest falls had occurred at J.-J. Zürcher & Cie of Cernay, whose dramatic cut-back from 600 to 100 employees was the highest recorded, and in François Verdan's enterprise, where the level had fallen from 425 to 122. Now, in view of advances in mechanization, comparative production figures would have been a better index of industrial performance between the two dates, and the absence of any for September 1803 is regrettable. Desportes's tables do however allow a crude comparison to be made between the *productivity*

¹⁴⁷ Haussmann frères were credited with a complement of between 1,300 and 1,400 employees and an annual export trade of over 600,000 francs in printed calicoes before the Revolution. Their recovery of a pre-eminent position by 1806, after serious reverses in the 1790s, was particularly commended.

of the leading *indienneurs* in January 1806. Annual output per head at the four largest firms ranked as follows: François Verdan (286 articles),¹⁴⁸ Dollfus-Mieg (47), Gros, Davillier & Roman (44), and André Hartmann (43). In the middle group Lhuillier frères of Sainte-Marie led the way with 42 articles per head per year, followed by Petitpierre-Robert (36), Schwartz-Hofer (31), Jean Hofer (30), Nicolas Koechlin (28), Kielmann & Cie (25), and Haussmann frères (17). Of the remaining eleven smaller firms, Baumgartner of Mulhouse (43 articles per head per year) and Appenzeller & Cie of Ribeauvillé (41) were the most concentrated. Productivity was lowest at Blech, Fries & Cie of Mulhouse (17 articles) and at J.-J. Zürcher (15).¹⁴⁹

Desportes's tables further show that the market for the Haut-Rhin's printed calicoes since 1803 had been largely confined to France. A few houses still had direct dealings with clients in Frankfurt, Leipzig, Italy, and Spain — Haussmann frères are named specifically — but all relied primarily on home sales. Demand came chiefly from the two Alsatian departments, from those of the Vosges and the Meurthe, and from Paris. Gros, Davillier & Roman not surprisingly used its sister house in the capital to boost sales. Hartmann also benefited from a parent house there and from business links with Bordeaux. Payment was normally made by the article, often staggered over an agreed period. The manufacturers generally produced on commission for known clients; they did not risk speculative output in the hope of finding customers afterwards.

The remaining branch of the cotton industry was hosiery, and it was closely linked with the local manufacture of linen and hempen goods. Supplies of flax and hemp were drawn mainly from the Bas-Rhin, the Vosges, and Flanders. Raw cotton was imported from the Levant through Strasbourg and, like the flax used, was worked manually on old-fashioned

¹⁴⁸ The exceptionally high figure for this firm is due to the very low employment level in Jan. 1806. If one divides the total output of 35,000 articles by the figure of 425 recorded for Sept. 1803, then production per head comes out at the more plausible level of 82 articles, still easily the best of all.

¹⁴⁹ Desportes noted that Zürcher had been particularly embarrassed by the decree of 22 Feb. 1806, having bought over 6,500 articles of plaincloth from Swiss suppliers shortly before it.

spindles (*fuseaux*) or wheels (*rouets*). Since the Haut-Rhin's hosiers apparently believed that spinning by machine produced too fine a thread for their purposes, they can hardly be placed in the vanguard of technological expansion in the department. Desportes's relevant table (no. 3) and report of 29 April 1806¹⁵⁰ suggest a norm of relatively small-scale industries producing a variety of garments (stockings, trousers, skirts, caps, underclothes, and gloves) largely for unrefined local markets. The prefect harked back to a flourishing export trade in such products before the Revolution, chiefly to Spain and the French Caribbean. But times had changed, and as he remarked with some irony, 'quelques modifications dans le Tarif des Douanes et le rétablissement du commerce maritime sont les moyens que ces fabricans regardent comme indispensables pour rendre à leurs ateliers l'activité et la prospérité dont ils ont joui avant la Révolution'.¹⁵¹

Desportes's statistical details show none the less that the fortunes of the Haut-Rhin's hosiers had improved between September 1803 and January 1806. Leydecker & Caesar of Sainte-Marie, the most prominent firm, had increased the number of active installations from 70 to 83 and their workforce from 210 to 250 during those years. None of the six other producers named employed more workers, though the unnamed twenty-two manufacturers of Sainte-Marie who worked on their own account and on a modest scale may have had a higher combined output. Collectively, they were credited with a net annual value of 10,000 francs, as against the estimate of 8,900 francs for Leydecker & Caesar. Taken as a whole, the hosiers had increased their active installations by nearly 72 per cent between September 1803 and January 1806. In the same period their total employment had risen from 457 to 801 persons, or by more than 75 per cent, and the net annual value of production at the latter date was put at 41,500 francs. Though of course a *net* figure, this was only a small benefit when compared with the 200,000 francsworth of export trade which Leydecker & Caesar alone had enjoyed before the Revolution.

* * *

¹⁵⁰ A.N. F¹² 1564.

¹⁵¹ Ibid.

Other industrial branches of the Haut-Rhin are less fully documented than cottons in the official reports and statistics. Being also on the whole less mechanized, they operated with smaller working capital and fewer employees, and were not so sensitive to the more acute fluctuations of consumer demand. Their markets were with few exceptions local ones. Most of them appear to have been less affected than the cotton industries by the slackening of 1806. The woollen industries, for example, with 80 installations in Mulhouse and 16 in Sainte-Marie, then had a combined total of 4,000 employees.¹⁵² Supplies of raw wool, often of German, Bohemian, Polish, and Wallachian origin, were usually found in Basel or Strasbourg. Some local accounts suggest that woollens in the Haut-Rhin did not escape the temporary lull of 1806-7. Gaspard Dollfus, for instance, president of the trade tribunal in Altkirch, believed that woollens had suffered set-backs during most of 1806, before recovering during its last quarter.¹⁵³ What he calls a 'general calm' in the imperial woollen industries had depressed the demand for raw wool, whose price had then dropped. On the other hand, Dollfus observed, this had had the compensatory effect of a cut-back on imports, and during 1806 the Haut-Rhin's *drapiers* had bought most of their supplies in France.

The primary sources are skimpier on the position of other towns and other industrial branches of the department around the time of the Blockade decrees. Colmar, the administrative and legal capital of the Haut-Rhin, and also then its largest town with a population of some 14,000, was not an expanding industrial centre. Its woollens, tanneries, primary metal works, potteries, and brickworks were mostly small-scale affairs catering for local demand. Its commercial role, especially as a distributive centre for wines and for the salt trade to Switzerland and southern Germany before the State monopoly of 1806, was more prominent. At least two local merchants, G.-B. Herr (woollens) and Jean Wichelhausen (cottons), were among the wealthiest in the department.

¹⁵² Desportes's report of 3 July 1806: A.D. (H-R) I M 136/3. The estimated annual output of some 12,000 articles in all did not match that of any large calico-printing firm.

¹⁵³ Report to Desportes of 17 Mar. 1807: A.D. (H-R) I M 128/1.

Both had export dealings with Swiss and German clients.¹⁵⁴

Desportes's report of 3 July 1806¹⁵⁵ noted that the six main 'establishments' in the Haut-Rhin for mining and primary metallurgy were based at Courrendlin, Bellefontaine, Audincourt, Bitschwiller, Oberbrück, and Belfort. Together they employed 1,452 men in 1806. The prefectoral tables of 17 January 1807¹⁵⁶ give fuller details of this branch. There is no entry for Oberbrück, but three other enterprises are named: in Weegscheid, Grandvillars, and Sewen. The most productive firm was George & Cugnotet of Courrendlin in the *arrondissement* of Delémont, whose 360 employees annually turned out 10,000 metric quintals of cast and 6,000 of wrought iron, along with a little steel. Bornèque & Meiner of Bellefontaine in the *arrondissement* of Porrentruy employed 300 men and had a principal output of 7,000 metric quintals, of which 5,000 were wrought iron. Rochet of Audincourt needed 400 workers to achieve an annual production of 6,000 metric quintals of cast iron, a figure Antonin & Vieillard of Belfort could reach apparently with only 308. The same tables give the department's total workforce in these industries as 1,532. Total output was then 29,000 metric quintals of cast and 13,700 of wrought iron.

Of the other industrial branches, Desportes stressed the importance of clock- and watch-making, on which the Haut-Rhin relied for much of its foreign earnings. Some 4,000 craftsmen and others were employed in it during 1806, while its visible trade was worth at least 200,000 francs annually and its total value perhaps as much as a million.¹⁵⁷ Japy's enterprise at Beaucourt, much the largest of its kind in the department, alone employed 500 skilled workers and others. It exported to most European countries, though Desportes hinted at smaller sales in 1806. The manufacturers of silk ribbons, braids, taffeta, and floss-silk increased production that year, and some new workshops were opened. The two houses of sufficient stature to be named in the tables of

¹⁵⁴ Arch. comm. Colm., REH 5/a-f and REH 10; on the salt trade with Switzerland and Baden, A.D. (H-R) I M 113/1-2 and 116a/1.

¹⁵⁵ A.D. (H-R) I M 136/3.

¹⁵⁶ A.N. F¹² 1568.

¹⁵⁷ Desportes's report of 3 July 1806: A.D. (H-R) I M 136/3; but cf. the figure of 5,500 craftsmen and others in his tables of 17 Jan. 1807: A.N. F¹² 1568.

17 January 1807 were Debarry & Bischoff of Guebwiller, who employed 150 workers, and Legrand frères of Saint-Morand, who had 210. The former at least enjoyed an export trade to Germany. The producers of plain or coloured paper also did well in 1806, with J. Zuber & Cie of Rixheim and Rupertsweiler similarly benefiting from a brisk trade to Germany. The tanneries, however, had not progressed, mainly because the price of South American leather rose as the maritime war intensified. One would like to know more of the department's secondary metallurgy, that vast range of household ware usually referred to generically as *quincaillerie* and *dinanderie*, but Desportes's report of 3 July 1806 and tables of 17 January 1807 give no precise details on these. Nor does he say anything about the potteries of Colmar.

As the prefectoral tables of 17 January are the most contemporaneous with the early Blockade decrees, it is useful to see how they break down by industrial branch. My Table 3 reproduces the essential details. What stands out most plainly is the vital importance of the cotton industries and *siamoises* to industrial employment in the Haut-Rhin. Of the 51,898 industrial employees active in 1806, the five entries for the cotton branches make up 25,026, nearly half. The real proportion was much higher, since many of the workers included separately under *siamoises* were partly or even principally engaged in cotton weaving. If the applicable figure of 14,981 is added in, the familiar level of just over 40,000 employees is reached, and it represents over 75 per cent of total industrial employment. Together with the figures for woollens and the various items under *rubanerie*, the total of 44,083 textile workers amounted to about 85 per cent of the department's industrial work-force in 1806.

It would be interesting to know how this compared with agricultural employment, but alas no serviceable statistics for the latter are available. We know however from the industrial records that most of the domestic hand-spinners and weavers were also part-time agricultural labourers, at least during the spring and summer. Desportes's figure for the total population of the Haut-Rhin at the beginning of 1806 is 404,018, excluding the 10,247 men on military service

Table 3. Employment in the Haut-Rhin by industrial branch in 1806*

Branch	No. of manufacturers ^a	No. of employees
Cotton spinning by hand ^b		15,400
Cotton spinning by machine	4	257
Cotton weaving ^c	7	619
Calico-printing (<i>toiles peintes</i> or <i>indiennes</i>)	22	7,939
Cotton hosiery	39	811
<i>Siamoises</i>	15	14,981
Woollen cloth manufacture	26	3,716
Ribbons, braids, taffeta, floss-silk, etc. (<i>rubanerie</i>)	2	360
Mining and primary metallurgy ^d	7	1,532
Clock-making	several	5,500
Tanning	116	230
<i>Maroquineries</i>	20	26
Paper-making	4	481
Glass-making	2	46
Total	264+	51,898

^aFigures in this column include master-craftsmen, self-employed manufacturers, and owners of workshops.

^bThe main employers here were the same as those numbered under calico-printing, *siamoises*, and cotton hosiery. Most of the employees were women, children, and aged persons who spun on a part-time basis in winter. The spinning by hand of hemp, flax, and wool is also referred to, but exact figures were apparently unavailable.

^cRefers to workshops in which cotton weaving was carried on as more or less intensive work. The mass of small-scale rural weavers is omitted, but the latter are almost certainly included under cotton hosiery and especially *siamoises* below.

^dRefers to the number of individual works (*usines*) and their employees.

*SOURCE: Desportes's prefectoral tables of 17 Jan. 1807: A.N. F¹² 1568.

there.¹⁵⁸ If, then, the figure of 51,898 given in Table 3 is taken as the divisor, recorded industrial employees made up nearly 13 per cent of that total. If one divides by the later estimate of 56,774,¹⁵⁹ the result is just over 14 per cent. The

¹⁵⁸ Report of 3 July 1806: A.D. (H-R) I M 136/3. The figure is also quoted in the *Annuaire physico-économique et statistique du département du Haut-Rhin* (Colmar, 1812), 209, for 1805; and in L'Huillier, *Alsace napoléonienne*, 556. Further details of the Alsatian population under Napoleon are given in Appendix L, below, p. 294. ¹⁵⁹ Estimate of 8 Sept. 1808 for 1805-6: A.D. (H-R) I M 127/1.

actual percentage must surely have been higher, since not all wives and children of industrial employees will have been included in Desportes's estimates.

v. *Market trouble in the Haut-Rhin 1806-1807*

Granted the importance of the cotton branches and *siamoises* in the Haut-Rhin's industrial inventory, its main market trends ought to be reflected in those sectors. Official inquiries conducted during the spring of 1807 offer a good view of the calico-printing enterprises, based on a collection of reports and opinions sent to Desportes by the twenty-two leading *indienneurs* in April-May that year.¹⁶⁰ These are of unique importance, being the nearest approximation to official company reports *by the manufacturers themselves* outside the extant private archives.

The first main point of general concern is that nearly all the *indienneurs* considered 1806 a less satisfactory year for their enterprises than 1805 had been, and most predicted further reductions of output and employment during 1807. It is useful to have such detailed confirmation of what the earlier prefectural tables and reports had only been able to hazard by way of forecast. On the manufacturers' own evidence, the slightly lower employment levels of 1806 had in fact implied a proportionate drop in production that year. The scale of such decreases varied from case to case, but the average was somewhere between 25 and 40 per cent. It appears, too, that labour costs were high in spite of the lay-offs and further mechanization, because of the shortage of skilled workers. Some manufacturers favoured a controlled immigration policy to meet their needs. While all complained of the threat which sluggish markets posed for their houses, several had the more pressing worry of actual surpluses. Most blamed the continuing hostilities and the ban or stiff duties on imported primary materials as the cause of their difficulties. Just as the tougher customs decrees had forced them to turn to Paris, Rouen, Saint-Quentin, and other

¹⁶⁰ Along with the prefect's tabular synopsis (7 June) and summarized report to Champagny (8 June 1807), these documents are kept at A.D. (H-R) I M 127/1. Desportes's table and summary are also to be found at A.N. F¹² 1569.

imperial towns for supplies, so existing impediments to exports had restricted their sales very largely to the home market.

The tabular synopsis and summarized report by Desportes give a statistical estimate of the manufacturers' losses. 'In ordinary times', he states, the combined annual value of output at the twenty-two leading firms was expected to reach some 16 million francs. At the time of writing, however, unsold articles represented not less than 2,901,525 francs-worth, or nearly a fifth of local sales. As this figure was based on incomplete returns, the real value of the surpluses was probably higher. The departmental output target for 1807 had been lowered consequently from the 227,960 articles produced in 1806 to 198,900. Again, in June 1807 only 6,080 employees were active at the same enterprises, compared with 7,098 a year earlier. If these estimates are assumed to be more or less reliable, they hardly testify to a major 'crisis' in the calico-printing industry in 1806-7. But it does seem that the news of the Berlin decree broke during a fairly obvious industrial lull in that and in other of the Haut-Rhin's cotton branches.¹⁶¹ This was due most of all to the difficulty in finding adequate primary materials and to the slowness of markets during the current hostilities. In other words, the *indienneurs* then faced major problems of supply *and* demand. This, much more than technical capacity to expand, was the root of their difficulties.

The individual reports show that market contraction was if anything a more serious obstacle than short supplies of primary materials. Evidence of actual surpluses suggests that there was no direct relationship between lower supplies of plaincloth and the demand for printed calicoes. The latter had not apparently shrunk because of bottle-necks in

¹⁶¹ The report by the president of the trade tribunal in Colmar to Desportes on 25 Jan. 1807 made the same points. It named the branches of the department's economy most in need of a boost as *toiles peintes, siamoises ordinaires*, and the rather vaguely described 'commerce en gros et en détail'. The president believed that the fault lay with the heavy import duties on or prohibition of essential primary materials, 'dont l'entrée devait être libre et exempte de tous droits, si nos fabriques d'indiennes et de cotonnade veulent prospérer, trouver des débouchés à l'étranger et soutenir même la consommation intérieure . . .'. A.D. (H-R) I M 128/1.

production; nor, given the surpluses, could manufacturers recoup themselves through higher prices. Gros, Davillier & Roman, for instance, had managed to push up production from 46,000 articles in 1805¹⁶² to 52,000 in 1806 largely by technical improvements. Yet, according to their report,¹⁶³ output in 1807 was being confined to the home market, and as A.-P. Roman commented, 'c'est là la véritable cause de la stagnation dont les manufactures de toiles peintes en général ont eu à souffrir'. The slackening of business had been more marked at the workshops of André Hartmann in Munster. His production had dropped by nearly half to some 14,000 or 15,000 articles in 1806 compared with the year before, and at the later date his employment level of 400 persons represented a similar drop. Haussmann frères had experienced a fall in output and employment of nearer a third. All their foreign markets had been lost, and they identified their difficulty as above all 'un manque de vente presque absolu'. Blech-Fries took up the same refrain, alluding in their report to a 'prodigious decline' in sales. Their figures bear this out: of their regular work-force of 600 in 1805, only 250 had been active during 1806, and at the time of writing the number was down to 140. Jérémie Risler of Mulhouse, who had recently acquired the enterprise of Kielmann & Cie, had been unable to maintain its former output and employment levels. Here was one case where current set-backs could be linked with the loss of transmarine markets; François Verdan of Biel was another.

For Schlumberger, Koenig & Cie of Mulhouse, 'la stagnation provient uniquement de la difficulté de vendre les objets fabriqués'. One of the reasons given for the slump in trade values was that goods could not be brought back to France free of duties if they remained unsold in foreign states. This had been a major discouragement to houses which, hit by smaller orders on commission, might have been willing to try and dispose of goods at the Frankfurt and Leipzig fairs. But at least, having laid off workers for over a year, Schlumberger-Koenig were thankful not to have actual surpluses on their

¹⁶² Cf. the figure of 50,000 for 1805 cited earlier from Desportes's tables (no. 4) of 29 April 1806: A.N. F¹² 1564.

¹⁶³ A.D. (H-R) I M 127/1.

hands. Another Mulhouse enterprise, that of Jean Hofer, was less fortunate. In addition to current employment of 40 per cent below the level of 1806 and an anticipated drop in production during 1807 of 20 per cent, he was stuck with thousands of articles which his normal commissioners were unable to sell. 'Pour rendre une nouvelle activité à nos manufactures', Hofer wrote,

il sera nécessaire que ce qui a été imprimé de trop pendant les derniers tems soit consommé, ou qu'il se présente de nouveaux débouchés . . . Il seroit possible, si l'Angleterre restoit longtems en état de blocus continental . . . [and if] l'Allemagne et l'Italie offriroient de nouveaux débouchés aux manufactures de toiles peintes; mais nous sommes encore trop éloignés du moment où cette concurrence pourra être établie . . .

He added that maritime outlets would be a welcome stimulus to production and that market opportunities in Spain were worth pursuing.

Perhaps the most explicit statement of market trouble and its accompanying problems came in the report by Lhuillier frères from Sainte-Marie. 'Les matières premières ne nous manquent pas', they noted, and then went on:

nous pensons même les avoir aussi bon marché que nos voisins; notre main d'œuvre ne doit pas être plus chère, mais il paroît que l'industrie étrangère est alimentée par des cotons filés anglais ou autres, à des prix bien plus favorables que nos établissemens de filatures françaises n'ont pu nous les fournir jusqu'à présent. Cette même raison s'oppose à ce que nous puissions même songer aux exportations . . . Il y a partout abondance de marchandises fabriquées. Il paroît que l'éloignement des armées ralentit la circulation du numéraire en diminuant la consommation des denrées; la guerre restreint les débouchés extérieurs de tous les produits français, qui s'accumulent et surpassent de beaucoup tous les besoins de la consommation intérieure . . .

Lhuillier frères were talking from local experience, but their difficulties reflect a more widespread problem facing French industry, cottons not least of all, at that time. Louis Bergeron's detailed account of the fortunes of Oberkampf, the *indienneur* of Jouy-en-Josas whose business in the capital was considerable, similarly attests to market trouble in 1806-7.¹⁶⁴

¹⁶⁴ *Banquiers, négociants et manufacturiers parisiens*, ii. 597-711, and esp. 691-4 for Oberkampf's gloomy letters of 1806-7.

Now, in summing up the earlier effects of the Revolutionary wars on France, François Crouzet writes that 'ce qui manquait à la France au début du Consulat, c'était les débouchés extérieurs, et non la capacité productrice, dont, malgré les pertes subies pendant la Révolution, une bonne partie était inemployée.'¹⁶⁵ The point, I think, applies as well to the Haut-Rhin's manufacturers at the time of the Blockade decrees. While they had certainly recovered well in the years 1800-6 from the turmoils of the 1790s, their reports of 1806-7 nearly all testify to new anxieties. Default of markets was plainly foremost among them.

One notable exception among the twenty-two company reports of April-May 1807 was the account sent in by the largest entrepreneur of Mulhouse, Dollfus-Mieg, according to which the firm had actually progressed during the same difficult period. In 1806 it had employed 715 persons and produced 22,000 articles; in April 1807 employment was up to 1,020 and the production target for that year had been set at between 28,000 and 30,000 articles. Expansion had been achieved in spite of a total cut-back on exports, for as the report bluntly put it, 'notre débouché est en France seulement'. Clearly the exceptionally good showing of Dollfus-Mieg had been dependent on widening sales on the home market.

On the whole, however, the manufacturers' mood was none too optimistic in the spring of 1807. Desportes duly passed on their protests and worries to Champagny, who in turn informed Napoleon. In his report to the emperor of 18 June 1807 the Minister emphasized the two central problems of market default and actual surpluses in the Haut-Rhin.¹⁶⁶ Taking Desportes's lead, he blamed the disruption of foreign trade, especially of exports to Germany, for those difficulties. He also mentioned the failure of the cotton manufacturers to secure the 'drawback' on exports provided for in the decree of 22 February 1806.¹⁶⁷ His comments on the other industrial

¹⁶⁵ 'Les conséquences économiques de la Révolution', 215.

¹⁶⁶ A.N. AFIV 1060.

¹⁶⁷ The decree had banned outright all imports of cotton yarn (*cotons filés pour mèche*), plaincloth, muslins, and printed calicoes. A duty of 7 francs the quintal had been placed on all fine-quality sewing cotton (*cotons filés autres que*

branches of the Haut-Rhin were more encouraging, however. Woollens were said to be improving with increased orders from Switzerland and Italy. *Siamoises*, silk weaving, the paper trade, and iron production were all apparently doing well. There had even been signs of recovery in cotton spinning and weaving. If by the middle of 1807 there had still been no obvious advances in the critical sector of calico-printing, the prospect of peace was promising. How far that promise was realized during the Blockade needs detailed investigation, but first we should look more closely at the French economic aims on the Continental mainland.

pour mèche) and another of 60 francs the quintal on raw cotton (*coton en laine*) imported. The latter duty was offset to some extent by what was called a 'draw-back' arrangement: manufacturers who had paid the full import duty on raw cotton might reclaim whatever share corresponded to the production of articles for subsequent export, and at a rate of 50 francs the metric quintal.

III

THE FRENCH CONTINENTAL MARKET DESIGN

i. *Clarification of terms*

This chapter is best introduced by some preliminary caveats, lest recurring terms mislead the reader. First, if the present work focuses mainly on the industrial and commercial sectors of the Alsatian economy, it should not obscure the essential fact that agriculture was the predominant resource almost everywhere. In relative terms, industry and trade were sectors of secondary importance in the Napoleonic Empire, and were often referred to as such in official directives. They were themselves dependent to a great extent on agricultural performance for their raw and primary materials, their foodstuffs and semi-worked industrial products, and for their markets. The point holds equally well for markets as such. The great majority were small-scale agricultural affairs, local in character and not accustomed to the kind of business dealings associated with the larger national and international entrepôts. This agricultural context, then the economic norm on the Continent, should be stressed as the fundamental background of what follows here.

The detailed official survey compiled by Montalivet in 1813,¹ not admittedly the most reliable source, puts the gross agricultural values between three and four times higher than the industrial ones, although no estimate of specifically commercial income is given. Nevertheless it appears from this statistical assessment that upwards of three-quarters of the imperial Gross National Product probably derived from agriculture and its immediately related services. As for French trade itself, Abel Chatelain has warned us against regarding

¹ *Exposé de la situation de l'Empire français, et des comptes de finances publiés à Paris, en février et mars 1813* (Paris, 1813). Sir Francis d'Ivernois's *Exposé de l'Exposé de la situation de l'Empire français* (2nd edn., Paris, 1814) is a scathing attack on the Minister's account.

'le grand commerce' as the norm.² It was only the most dynamic branch of that sector, and it was not dynamic all the time. Chatelain rightly stresses the essentially rural and scattered nature of French markets until the mid-nineteenth century, at least, when the railways and steamships opened up provincial towns to a wider trading network than had been possible under the old methods of transport.

That agriculture was the basis of the Alsatian economy under Napoleon, measured in terms of gross output values and numbers employed, would not be seriously disputed.³ Of the Bas-Rhin's forty-one cantons in 1800, for instance, thirty-two were almost wholly agricultural. Only the other nine (Barr, Benfeld, Bischwiller, Geispolsheim, Haguenau, Niederbronn, Obernai, Strasbourg, and Wasselonne) had manufactories of any note. When the consular government decided on 3 Nivôse XI (24 December 1802) to set up the new chambers of commerce, and on 22 Germinal and 10 Thermidor XI (12 April and 29 July 1803) to create similar consultative chambers for manufacture, arts, and crafts, Alsace had few contenders for such recognition. Strasbourg of course was large and important enough to qualify for a chamber of commerce,⁴ but it was the only Alsatian town which did so. Haguenau in the Bas-Rhin and Mulhouse and Sainte-Marie-aux-Mines in the Haut-Rhin alone were considered of sufficient industrial importance to merit the foundation of local consultative chambers.⁵ Backing its decision to nominate only Haguenau in the Bas-Rhin, the Chamber of Commerce in Strasbourg argued that the

² 'Pour une histoire du petit commerce de détail en France. Lutte entre col-porteurs et boutiquiers en France pendant la première moitié du XIXe siècle', *R. d'H. éc. et soc.*, xlix (1971), 359-84.

³ The best accounts of Alsatian agriculture at that time are given in the *Annuaire du Bas-Rhin* (Strasbourg, 1811), 65-112; Ponteil, *Situation économique du Bas-Rhin*, 44-105; L'Huillier, *Alsace napoléonienne*, 415-65 and 468-516; and in the volume of collected essays, *Paysans d'Alsace* (publ. by the Société savante d'Alsace et des Régions de l'Est, with the help of other bodies, Strasbourg, 1959).

⁴ For details of the Chamber's foundation in Mar. 1803 see above, p. 28 n.

⁵ In Haguenau on 12 Germinal XII (2 Apr. 1804), A.D. (B-R) XII M 26-7; in Mulhouse and Sainte-Marie not till 1806, A.D. (H-R) I M 117a. Mulhouse did not receive a chamber of commerce properly so called until 1828, when it also gained an official *bourse* for the first time.

department was 'almost wholly agricultural'.⁶ On 30 November 1807 it similarly reported to Shée that only Strasbourg was worthy of a trade tribunal 'dans un département dont l'industrie est principalement vouée à l'agriculture'.⁷

Now, one would wish to qualify such statements if they were extended to the Haut-Rhin, where the seasonal links between agricultural and domestic industrial labour were often too close to be separated. Both in Mulhouse and in the valleys of the Vosges the concentrations of industrial labour were not insignificant beside the wider agricultural (and not least viticultural) employment of the department as a whole. Even so, the ratio of agricultural to industrial labour was probably in the order of 4 or 5 to 1. Mulhouse, Sainte-Marie, or even Wesserling were no more norms of the Haut-Rhin's production and market structure than Strasbourg was of the Bas-Rhin's. The discussion of these pages applies to the industrial and commercial branches immediately in view. Terms like 'market trouble', 'market objectives', 'market design', 'imperial home market', 'domestic demand', and so on are used as a form of shorthand and are, of course, relative to the scale and to the priorities of the European economies prevalent in Napoleon's time. They are not meant to suggest provocative analogies with more developed industrial economies of later periods, or, *a fortiori*, with modern 'consumer societies'. They do not imply that Napoleon and his ministers had made a conscious and elaborate calculation of marketing techniques: how, for example, to advertise French products to best advantage, when good wines needed no bush; how to relate consumer demand to crude arithmetical growth of population⁸ or to fluctuations in income per head; how to determine ratios between consumption and investment; or even how to introduce simple economies of scale. The

⁶ Meeting of 12 Vendémiaire XII (5 Oct. 1803), Min. i; A.D. (B-R) XII M 26.

⁷ A.D. (B-R) XII M 39.

⁸ Napoleon's successive annexations added something like 16 million subjects to the 28 million inhabitants of '*l'ancienne France*' at the time of the Blockade decrees. The total population of the subject and allied states (excluding Russia and other nominal allies in the east) was over 38 million. Theoretically, then, imperial producers might have aimed to exploit a potential consumer demand within a politically and militarily dependent area of over 80 million inhabitants. Further details of the population of the Grand Empire are given in Appendix M below, p. 295.

Napoleonic statistics are an inadequate basis for such approaches to the question of markets.

Most industrial and commercial dealings in Napoleonic Europe did not occur on public occasions like town fairs or even the larger international ones. The latter would give a rather too concentrated picture of normal trading practice, and their success indeed was partly due to their infrequency. Most business took the form of regular and routine exchanges carried on throughout the year, with allowances for seasonal variations, either directly in *dépôts de vente* or on commission.⁹ The manufacturer or merchant manufacturer was as likely as not to be his own agent, although middlemen played an increasing role in such dealings. Besides their local sales, most of the larger houses also traded further afield, employing the services of other commissioners for distant transactions. Accredited carters or bargees similarly catered for the transport of goods to destinations other than the local market.

The industrial norm in the Empire was not the factory with its growing proletariat producing for mass markets; it was the small workshop or cluster of workshops providing for mainly local needs. The language of contemporary documents ranges from the ubiquitous *industrie à domicile* to the intermediate *atelier* or *manufacture* and so on to the larger *fabrique* or *entreprise*. Often the unit of production referred to is no more specific than *établissement*, which could mean anything from a simple installation in a peasant's home to a large mill or printing workshop. The commercial norm was not the big international entrepôt like Paris (for fashion and luxury goods, cottons, colonial products, and wines), or Strasbourg (for textiles, tobacco, raw cotton, hemp, madder, colonial goods, and wines), or Lyons (for silks and silkstuffs); it was the small local market. Financial capitalism, furthermore, was still in an early phase of its development. Before the annexation of Holland in 1810 and of the Hanse towns in 1811, the Empire's only capital market worthy of the description was Paris.¹⁰ Its *Bourse* was the only major

⁹ The papers of the merchant house of Briansiaux of Lille (A.N. series 3 AQ) massively illustrate this point. It had regular contact with commissioners and expeditioners in dozens of western European towns.

¹⁰ The subject is now handsomely covered in Bergeron, *Banquiers, négociants et manufacturiers parisiens*, esp. chap. X, ii. 714-802.

stock market, although some provincial cities later acquired smaller institutions of that sort. In spite of attempts to expand its business from time to time, the Bank of France still operated largely as the Bank of Paris. Since credit was generally tight in France and liable to periodic freezes, the trade dependent on it was exposed to sudden fluctuations and crippling disruption.

Another caveat concerns the use of phrases like 'imperial economy', 'imperial industry', and 'imperial trade'. These are not intended to imply a degree of national economic coherence which did not exist. The description 'imperial' is used frequently and specifically in preference to 'French' where the reference is to the whole area of the formal Napoleonic Empire, as distinct from '*l'ancienne France*', or from the Grand Empire, which included all the subject states not directly annexed to France. Just as the social and cultural complexion of the Empire was diverse, so the term 'imperial economy' could not mean any uniform system. It subsumes an assortment of often very different regional economies over which the central government had difficulty in applying a co-ordinated policy. The climatic variations within such a large political and customs unit alone demanded some flexibility of economic control. The fragmentary nature of French markets, what David Landes has called 'a mosaic of semi-autarkic cells',¹¹ must again be stressed. It remains the essential context here, even where broader terms are used for more general points about the 'imperial economy'. Granted this, there is no reason to persist with the inverted commas.

The last caution applies to the historiographical custom of using the terms 'Continental Blockade' and 'Continental System' as synonymous and interchangeable. The practice need cause no confusion, of course, for Napoleon and his contemporaries often barely separated the two. A distinction can and should be made, however, and it is essentially that between a part and a whole. 'Continental Blockade' or 'Blockade' here refers to that part of Napoleon's economic policy concerned with the aims, working, and effects of the Berlin and Milan decrees, along with their later modifications.

¹¹ *Unbound Prometheus*, 46.

'Continental System' subsumes not only all this but much more besides. It refers to the whole gamut of Napoleon's policies on the Continental mainland: the military and diplomatic alliances, the family marriages and new dynastic placements, the fiscal and administrative reforms in the subject states, the theoretical suppression of surviving feudal practices in the lands of certain vassals and the actual endowment of a new imperial nobility in others, the introduction of the codes, and the tapping of resources in the satellite states. Altogether, the distinction once made has to be maintained, as much in my account of the 'Blockade' would not apply without qualification to the 'System' more widely.

And yet the same distinction is itself not fully comprehensive. Roger Dufraisse in his reappraisal distinguishes the 'Blockade' and the 'System' from a third central factor, French customs policy.¹² As he rightly reminds us, of the 32 laws which made up the 'economic arsenal' of France from 1793 onwards, 9 had been issued before Brumaire, 17 more between the *coup* and the Berlin decree, and only 6 thereafter.¹³ This means in effect that something very like the Blockade had applied to France *vis-à-vis* Britain well before 21 November 1806. But I cannot see why Dufraisse should infer from this that the phrase 'Continental Blockade' can have meaning only if it refers to a geographical area beyond France.¹⁴ If he had made more than a passing reference to the British naval blockade,¹⁵ he might have advanced it as a fourth major element of the topic. The *Continental* Blockade, seen as a land-based 'self-blockade', was different in nature from the British naval blockade. In that sense it applies as much to France as to her 'reunited', 'conquered', and 'allied' states.

¹² 'Régime douanier, Blocus, Système continental', 533-7. The development of French customs policy from the 1790s, chiefly in relation to cotton goods, is more fully discussed in his 'La politique douanière de Napoléon', *Rev. Inst. Nap.* (1974), 3-25.

¹³ 'Contrebande . . . de la rive gauche du Rhin', 509.

¹⁴ 'Régime douanier', 535, and repeated in 'Contrebande', 509.

¹⁵ 'Régime douanier', 537.

ii. *The military and political context of the French market design*

If these preliminary qualifications are allowed, the Blockade in its more positive and constructive aspects amounted to a French Continental market design. In the nature of French power this looked mainly towards inland markets. It was broadly directed, at least in theory, to the whole arc of satellite states stretching from Holland through the Rhenish Confederation to Switzerland and Italy, and south-westward into the Iberian peninsula. It also reached beyond the vassal states to include the Habsburg lands, Prussia, Poland, Russia, and even the Levant. It grew out of the extraordinary structure of Napoleon's land mastery in the years 1805-7. At the time of the first Blockade decrees, the political outline of the Empire squared with the 'natural frontiers' of France and also directly incorporated Piedmont, Genoa, and Tuscany. Napoleon's army was triumphant and loyal. Eugène de Beauharnais ruled the kingdom of Italy as his viceroy. Joseph and Louis Bonaparte were respectively kings of Naples and of Holland. Napoleon was 'Mediator' of the Swiss Confederation, following the constitutional settlement of 1803. The Habsburg threat to the inland frontiers of the Empire had been blunted, for the present, in the remarkable power sequence of Ulm-Austerlitz-Pressburg. Earlier still, at the 'recess' of the Habsburg diet of 1803, many German principalities on the Rhenish right bank had been 'mediatized', or secularized, and detached from Austrian overlordship.

A greater strengthening of French power had followed during 1806. In June, Joachim Murat had taken charge of the newly formed grand duchy of Berg. In July, the crucial extension of French authority in Germany had taken shape in the Rhenish Confederation, and in August the historic Holy Roman Empire had been formally dissolved. At first the Confederation consisted of sixteen redrawn states and had a combined population of some 7.5 million under French tutelage.¹⁶ Napoleon had special military agreements with its

¹⁶ Later accessions to the Confederation, especially by the kingdoms of Saxony (Jan. 1807) and of Westphalia (July 1807), increased its population to over 12 million by the summer of 1807.

princes, both severally and collectively, and was also officially their 'Protector'. In particular he had close links by family marriage with Berg and a firm alliance with the new kingdom of Bavaria. Some of the confederates, notably Bavaria, Württemberg, and Baden, had been favoured with important territorial acquisitions at the expense of the Habsburgs or the dispossessed ecclesiastical princes. Prussian neutrality in all these developments had been secured at first by the use of Hanover as an acceptable territorial bribe. But when Frederick William III took the rash decision to mobilize his army against France, Prussia had suffered the humiliating defeats of Jena and Auerstädt in October 1806. Quite apart from the military catastrophe, Frederick William lost many of his lands. A year later, after the Eylau-Friedland-Tilsit sequence, he had been deprived of roughly 5 million subjects, almost half his former population, and had no allies. Napoleon then had command of the Weser, Elbe, Trave, Oder, and much of the coastline to the Vistula. Most important of all, perhaps, in 1807 Napoleon came to terms with Russia. Who got the better of whom at the famous Tilsit meeting it is difficult to say; but the immediate upshot was that Alexander I agreed to enforce the Blockade decrees against Britain as the condition of his French alliance. Napoleon thereupon proceeded to an important realignment of lands in northern Germany. Some were ceded to Holland, others to Berg; the rest were formed into the new kingdom of Westphalia and their rule entrusted to Jérôme Bonaparte (July 1807). Like the duchy of Warsaw which took constitutional form at the same time, the kingdom of Westphalia was a kind of territorial security for Tilsit.

When the Blockade decrees were first applied in the Grand Empire, the Bourbons in Spain and the house of Braganza in Portugal were still nominally in power. Yet already Napoleon had begun the machinations designed to impose a French alliance on them. In February 1807 Spain officially accepted the Blockade decrees. In the following November, after the secret Franco-Spanish treaty of Fontainebleau in October, Junot was sent to subjugate Portugal. He was proclaimed governor-general of that country in February 1808, and in the course of that year far more traumatic sequels

overtook the house of Braganza and the Spanish Bourbons. By their renunciation at the 'ambush of Bayonne' in May, following Godoy's secret stratagem, Ferdinand and his father Charles IV gave up all rights to the Spanish crown. In June, Joseph Bonaparte was appointed king of Spain, being replaced at Naples by Murat. Denmark, finally, was also under intermittent pressure from Napoleon and the British navy. Frederick VI had been battling against impossible odds to preserve the precarious neutrality of his kingdom. At last in September 1807, unable to equivocate any longer, he opted for a French alliance, fearful otherwise of military occupation or even outright annexation of his kingdom. Retribution soon followed. In the same month Copenhagen was bombarded by the British fleet, an event which quickly sealed the ratification procedures, and Danish neutrality came thus to a violent end.

Altogether, by the end of 1807 'l'ère de l'alliance confiante' had begun on a grand scale. By then only Sweden among Napoleon's potential allies in Europe had not come over to him, and was not to do so until 1810. In military terms the alliances meant that the imperial frontiers in northern and central Europe were secured well east of the official line, which ran with the Rhine. In northern Germany they stretched effectively to the Oder, in southern Germany to the Inn. The rivet of Napoleon's system of alliances was not Russia, in spite of much asseveration at Tilsit and at Erfurt the following year; it was the Bavaria of Max Joseph and Montgelas. This was the corner-stone of the Rhenish Confederation and the base of his German policy. Of the 63,000 troops which the Confederation had agreed to raise for Napoleon in the event of war, the Bavarian share was 30,000. In Max Joseph's own words, Bavaria was 'un grand avant-poste du Grand Empire'.¹⁷ It was potentially the 'Third Germany' of which some contemporaries spoke, a counterpoise in French control to confront Vienna and Berlin alike. This aspect became more prominent as the new kingdom

¹⁷ Quoted in Dunan, *Napoléon et l'Allemagne*, 207. Max Joseph also had the kingdoms of Naples, Italy, and Holland in mind. The first chapter of Dunan's book is the most useful source for further details of Napoleon's German and other alliances in 1805-7.

grew with Napoleon's rewards; yet shrewdly he had also erected counterweights to it within the Rhenish Confederation. One was the kingdom of Westphalia; another was the Saxony of Frederick Augustus, which became a kingdom on 1 January 1807.

Undeniably, then, Napoleon had military, political, and diplomatic mastery of the Continent by the time of the Blockade decrees. The irony, however, was that France did not have an economic predominance on the Continent commensurate with the might of her arms. Lacking it, the French hoped to build one on the other bases of Napoleonic power. In a prefectoral circular of 21 February 1806, for example, Desportes emphasized the need '[d']égaler notre prospérité commerciale à la gloire de nos armes'.¹⁸ For that reason it may well seem attractive to explain the precise timing of the Berlin decree tendentiously in terms of current economic difficulties. It would also be misleading to do so. Many of those troubles had applied during the Revolutionary disturbances and could be seen as the cumulative effects of wartime irregularities in the French economy. Others had followed more directly from the rupture of the peace of Amiens in 1803. The Bank panic of 1805 may be explained as a '*crise de structure*', but it was hardly likely to reassure manufacturers and merchants that the foundations of the imperial financial system were unshakeable. It demonstrated, yet again, what perils were involved in quasi-heroic maritime adventures. Within this wider perspective, 1806 was a typically rather than an exceptionally uncertain year for imperial industry and trade. In some departments it was a high point of industrial production, but in others it was marked (as in Alsace) by an over-all slackening of expansion.

The timing of the Berlin decree should be linked mainly with developments in Napoleon's military and political position between the start of the Austerlitz campaign and November 1806. Among the theoretical projects which had steered him towards the hard line of the Blockade, the confidential reports and other writings of Montgaillard appear to

¹⁸ A.D. (H-R) I M 119/1.

have been particularly important. The first use of the phrase 'Blocus continental' indeed is usually attributed to this writer. The whole strategy of the Berlin decree had been anticipated in his *mémoire* of 25 July 1805 and its supplement of 24 March 1806.¹⁹ He saw British trade as an immense system of piracy, as phantom wealth, or what the *mémoire* of 25 July called 'une véritable hydropisie politique'. This recalls another polemical image, common among Anglophobes, of British commercial power resting on fragile foundations (*colosse à pieds d'argile*). As the Napoleonic armies advanced their land might in 1805 and 1806, the wish to assault and expose a maritime enemy thus caricatured intensified. By the end of 1806 the military prerequisites of the Blockade had been laid, and it is difficult to see how the Berlin decree could have been proclaimed before their achievement. In that sense the Continental market design, though a distinguishable element of the Blockade, was grafted on to the wider structure of French power which formed in 1805-7. In so far as it depended on that structure, it cannot properly be isolated from its unique power-base.

iii. *Theoretical variants of the market design*

Like the plan for a 'coast system', or an extended ban on British trade, the theory behind the market design had a pedigree. The 'plan Delacroix' under the Directory had been one such scheme to develop a chain of market interests overlapping with the satellite states along the periphery of the French Republic.²⁰ Delacroix himself had drawn on similar though less officially formulated ideas of men like Sieyès, Merlin de Douai, and Pelet de la Lozère during the Year III. All prefigured the market designs variously advanced in the writings of, among others, François de Neufchâteau, Chaptal, and Montgaillard himself under the Consulate and early Empire.

¹⁹ Both are published in the *Mémoires diplomatiques de Montgaillard (1805-1819)* (ed. C. de Lacroix, Paris, 1896).

²⁰ The 'plan Delacroix' is discussed in detail in G. Dejoint, *La Politique économique du Directoire* (Paris, 1951), 161-223 (with accompanying appendices, 263-8).

What had been envisaged was in effect the blueprint for a cordon of markets drawn to serve the interests of French manufacturers and merchants. Historians have described such aims variously as 'commercial colonization', 'industrial imperialism', 'economic nationalism', and the like. Even where it is not explicitly stated, the principle of 'la France avant tout' may easily be read back into the earlier plans. The intention is the same: the creation of outlets for French products and also of tributaries to boost the flow of revenue for national needs. During the Revolutionary wars the satellite states had been expected to help pay France's way as well as all their own in men, supplies, and money. From the time of the Convention's *Commission d'extraction* in Belgium, the annexed and in due course the subject states had been harnessed to the French economy. Part of their wealth and income had been commandeered, so to speak, whether for military or other purposes. French relations with the allied states had been influenced by similar aims, and the market design also drew more directly on policies which Napoleon had applied in dealings with foreign states between 1800 and 1806. An example is his insistence on one condition as the *sine qua non* of any alliance with France: that all other contracting parties should close their ports and inland frontiers to British trade. Such alliances had often been followed up with preferential trade treaties which in practice benefited France more than her partners.²¹

It would be misleading, on the other hand, to present the French market design after 1806 as simply a natural outgrowth from the earlier projects. There were quantitative and qualitative differences between them. Quantitative — because unlike the 'plan Delacroix' and other schemes before it, the market design of the Blockade theoretically embraced nearly the whole Continent. It was aimed at much more than the economic reinforcement of the 'natural frontiers', reaching well beyond that *fait accompli* towards a still vaster area of

²¹ e.g. with Naples (18 Mar. 1800); Spain (21 Mar. 1801); Portugal (29 Sept. 1801); Russia (8 Oct. 1801, renewing the treaty of 1787); Turkey (25 June 1802); and with Spain again (Oct. 1803). One might add Napoleon's prohibitive decrees of 4 June 1803 (renewed on 27 July 1805) and of 10 June 1806 against imports from Britain and from Continental states other than France into Italy.

economic resources. The qualitative differences from earlier projects lay in the fact that the power structure of 1806-13 was unique. The market design of the Blockade was altogether a more vastly conceived and doctrinaire *tour de force* than its predecessors. Bertrand de Jouvenel thinks that Napoleon, in declaring the Blockade, wanted to crown his 'coast system' with an 'ideological manifesto'.²² It seems to me that, in the context of 1806-7, his purpose was more mundane. Never before had French military might been so predominant and French political frontiers been so far-flung. Never before had a system of Continental alliances been so much in French control. But, conversely, the power structure of 1806-7 is also distinguished from that before and after it by the fact of Napoleon's naval eclipse. Never before had France been so effectively cut off from the open sea, so forcibly severed from her colonies and other transmarine links. The chamber of commerce in Marseilles, writing some three months before the Berlin decree and under the impact of local maritime losses, acknowledged as much.²³ 'La perte de notre principale colonie', it remarked with reference to Santo Domingo, 'doit faire attacher encore plus de prix aux débouchés que nos fabriques et nos manufactures peuvent conserver en Europe'. It looked to Italy and Spain for alternative outlets nearer home, and it pressed for a preferential treaty with the latter similar to the one agreed with the kingdom of Italy on 10 June 1806.²⁴

Since Napoleon's power was land-locked, the French market design had clear physical limitations from the start. The aim was to develop on the mainland, within the French military and political domain, economic outlets and sources of supply to fill the vacuum left by the successive transmarine losses. Whatever the ideological motifs of its advocates, it was an *ad hoc* attempt to solve the practical problem of industrial and commercial markets in the face of continuing

²² *Économie dirigée*, 242.

²³ Report to Champagny of 22 Aug. 1806: A.N. F¹² 534.

²⁴ The same *carton* contains a report by the *Conseil général de commerce* of 29 Aug. following, in which French market aims in Spain are positively projected: 'Ce que la France peut désirer', it wrote for instance, 'c'est de fournir si non la totalité, du moins la majeure partie de tous les objets de manufactures que l'Espagne consomme et dont elle approvisionne ses colonies'.

maritime weakness. If in one way it was obviously a policy born of strength, in another it was an oblique reflection of French economic vulnerability. It may seem to have broad similarities with earlier and later policies, but these should not obscure the fact that it was as extraordinary as the power complex which formed its hard base.

The Blockade was announced in an atmosphere of immediate military triumph. Another infusion of 'la grande espérance', a tense but optimistic expectancy, was current in the Empire.²⁵ Frenchmen anticipated a favourable peace and hoped for new economic benefits from it. In setting out to cultivate the 'markets of replacement' on the Continent, they believed they could stimulate all branches of the imperial industry and trade. The government's presumption was that what the Empire could not absorb of its own production, economically dependent neighbours might do. Another presupposition was that the markets of the allied states further afield could be opened up to imperial trade as a condition of their formal friendship with France. Reports from the Rhenish Confederation, at one receiving end of the market design, encouraged such hopes. Even before the Berlin decree, on 12 August 1806, the French minister Otto in Munich wrote that the expansion into Bavarian markets had begun four or five years earlier.²⁶ He referred to a large number of commissioners from Lyons, Paris, the Beaune, and Rheims who regularly travelled through southern Germany in search of further trade. French wines, especially burgundies and champagne, were selling well in Bavaria. The potential market for silkstuffs, porcelain, bronzes, furniture, and a variety of other products was said to be good. Otto claimed that nine out of every ten Bavarian travellers in France were there to do business.

The meaning of such evidence might be shown by mixing a later metaphor. If France could not yet replace Britain as 'the workshop of the world', at least she might aspire to supersede

²⁵ The early response to the Blockade and the official optimism at the end of 1806 and the beginning of 1807 are discussed in Dunan, *Napoléon et l'Allemagne*, 327 ff. De Jouvenel entitles the relevant section of his book 'La grande opportunité', *Économie dirigée*, chap. 9.

²⁶ The applicable passage from the *Correspondance bavaroise* is quoted in Dunan, *Napoléon et l'Allemagne*, 347.

her as 'the workshop of Europe'. This ideal, later referred to by Montalivet as 'cette grande pensée',²⁷ frequently recurred during the Blockade. The Minister anticipated that the growth of French power would enable the national industries and trade to attain 'un degré d'accroissement incalculable, et les faire arriver au point d'être *les magasins de l'Europe entière*'.²⁸ By 1810, indeed, the original plan had been extended from French agricultural products and manufactured goods to include the whole entrepôt trade in colonial goods allowed under the 'licences'. As such, it illustrates the development and modification of the Blockade policy and of its market design first formulated in 1806-7.

On another textbook analogy, France lacked the means to supplant Britain as 'the engine of growth' and 'the school-master of industrial Europe'; but at least the market design might help her to narrow the gap. If nothing else, it was hoped, British competition would be contained within bounds that would leave French producers free to make up something of their technological leeway. In this sense the Blockade might even be seen as a holding operation, a play for time, an attempt to stop the clock, to slow down the industrial revolution and force Britain into a rate of growth incommensurate with her real capacity, to regulate the pace of the Continent's economic development effectively enough to keep France in the race for markets. This 'time-to-catch-up' view of the Blockade and of the market design has not been argued in much detail before, though some writers have made the suggestion in passing.²⁹ The hypothesis was that if France achieved those aims, *she* would then be able to set the clock in motion again and would become the industrial pace-maker of Europe. Napoleon would succeed, where the Jacobins had ultimately failed, in safeguarding the interests of the small-scale producer and of the traditional handicrafts. A preliminary remark in the official *Tarif des droits de douane et de navigation maritime*³⁰ is interesting in this connection.

²⁷ Report to Napoleon of 11 June 1810: A.N. AFIV 1241.

²⁸ Ibid.

²⁹ See e.g. Viennet, *Napoléon et l'industrie française*, 188; and Bergeron, 'Problèmes économiques de la France napoléonienne', 499.

³⁰ Published in Paris in 1804 and revised in 1806.

'L'industrie étrangère', it stated, 'sera repoussée de notre territoire pendant le tems qui est nécessaire aux fabriques françaises pour réparer leurs pertes et consolider leurs établissements'.

* * *

The French market design rested from the outset on the bold presumption that the most troublesome British competition could be eliminated from Continental markets. Granted an effective Blockade, it might be asked hypothetically how French industry and trade would have stood around 1806-7 in a wide market area quarantined from British competition. That indeed was what the 'self-blockade' or 'boycott' logically implied. What then was the position of French industry and trade in relation to that of other Continental states at the time of the Blockade decrees?

It is a fair answer that, *vis-à-vis* its Continental rivals, the French economy was stronger than conventional comparisons with Britain might suggest. Within the vast area brought under its domination, the Empire clearly had more industrial and commercial potential than its vassal or allied states. One problem immediately facing French manufacturers, however, was the risk involved in converting their industries to more mechanized production. Since so many of their cotton products (let alone their luxury articles) were expensive and likely to attract only the better-off class of client, market expansion seemed to imply the manufacture of cheaper goods. The problem was how to sell on a large scale in wider markets at a relatively low profit rather than on a small scale at a comparatively high one. The industrial adjustment involved (capital outlay and the social risks of unemployment among unskilled workers if machines were progressively installed) was not matched by an obvious indication of where the new mass markets were to be exploited.

Yet, in spite of this, many of the more successful textile houses did in fact mechanize their production more and more. In an attempt to effect the necessary conversion of their enterprises, they used machine-models and production criteria then common in Britain. In some parts of the Empire,

Belgium especially, British expatriates themselves gave the lead.³¹ Industrial reconnaissance expeditions were sent to Britain secretly, to investigate the new techniques, to persuade technicians to bring their skills to the Empire, and even to smuggle out machines. As for the home manufacturers, the imperial government gave them what backing it could. Its propaganda actively sponsored the pursuit of industrial and commercial combat as an integral part of the imperial war effort. Some of Napoleon's utterances at the time conjure up an image of the French industrial soldier. As he is reported to have declaimed to the *indienneur* Oberkampf, whose works at Jouy-en-Josas he visited in 1806 and 1810, 'vous et moi nous faisons une bonne guerre aux Anglais; vous par votre industrie, et moi par mes armes. C'est encore vous qui faites la meilleure.'³² One is reminded here of Metternich's later remark that Napoleon was eager to protect the French corsairs because he regarded them as 'military merchants' and their vessels as 'nobler shops than those of peaceable citizens'.³³ Champagny similarly used a military metaphor in his important report of 5 August 1807 on the purpose of the Rhenish Confederation. He alluded to an 'arsenal des chancelleries' in French service across the Rhine, and went on to embellish the idea in terms which recalled the military ethic of the old German Confederation.³⁴ Or again, there is Chaptal's reminiscence of Napoleon's attitude towards French trade: 'il prétendait le faire manœuvrer comme un bataillon et exigeait de lui une soumission aussi passive'.³⁵ The whole framework of the *livret*

³¹ A useful introduction to this question, with much individual illustration, is W. O. Henderson, *Britain and Industrial Europe 1750-1870: Studies in British Influence on the Industrial Revolution in Western Europe* (2nd edn., London, 1965).

³² The statement has been widely quoted, though with variations, in secondary works. See e.g. Tarlé, 'Les intérêts économiques de la France', 135-6. In a direct allusion to the Jouy pronouncement Ternaux frères, manufacturers of woollens in Rouen, headed their *mémoire* of 30 Nov. 1807 with the epigraph: 'Et nous aussi, nous faisons la guerre à l'Angleterre.' A.N. F¹² 618.

³³ Letter to Stadion of 18 Jan. 1808, quoted in Dunan, *Napoléon et l'Allemagne*, 311.

³⁴ A.N. AFIV 1060.

³⁵ *Mes Souvenirs sur Napoléon* (published by his great-grandson, Paris, 1893), 275.

system adds further character to this image of the French industrial soldier.

* * *

In the same connection it is still unfortunately necessary to dispose of a familiar red herring in earlier Blockade studies. This is the notion that the Blockade was primarily a 'war on cottons'. As such it has been construed as a frontal assault on the genre, *qua* genre, of what had become the most successful branch of British industrial exports. Sometimes there is a suggestion of industrial and commercial paranoia in France, of a persecution complex inbred in the response of her manufacturers to the British challenge. Sometimes again the implication is rather that the advocates of the Blockade were a breed of economic puritans, a view especially common among free traders later in the nineteenth century. The 'war on cottons' and to some extent also the 'war on colonial goods' were seen thus as part of a more general attack on all 'exotic' merchandise. If Napoleon had had his way, the argument continues, the silk, woollen, and linen industries would have enjoyed all the imperial favour and killed off the cotton industries altogether. What frustrated him in this retrogressive campaign was the pressure of current fashion, the caprice of public taste, and in particular the lure of *Anglomanie*.

Now, there is some rather flimsy evidence in contemporary writings to support the free traders' later caricature of the Blockade. One of the most illuminating examples, since it amounted to a clash between an old-fashioned theorist whose answer lay in the native soil and a practical industrial expert, is the dispute between François de Neufchâteau and Liévin Bauwens in 1808. The first threw down the gauntlet in a printed letter of 1 January to Herwyn, deputy of the Lys department to the legislative body in Paris.³⁶ For the redoubtable senator, who had long since declared his support for the campaign 'pro Agricola', the issue was not least a

³⁶ A.N. F¹² 533. The letter was published in the *Journal du commerce, de politique et littérature du département de l'Escaut*, no. 949, 18 Feb. 1808.

test of one's patriotism. 'Vous êtes', he told Herwyn, 'par excellence dans le pays du Lin', and then went on:

Les questions que l'on y traite sur le Coton et sur le Lin, méritent d'être approfondies, sur-tout dans cette circonstance où le Gouvernement désire de tourner les efforts de notre industrie vers l'exploitation de vos matières indigènes, que nous ont fait trop négliger des caprices de modes et des fantaisies exotiques, accréditées à nos dépens par une aveugle anglomanie. Autrefois tout votre pays était un peu esclave de ces goûts étrangers. Tous ces rapports étaient faussés. Loin d'être tournés vers la France, vos routes, vos canaux et vos communications se portaient vers d'autres rivages. Aujourd'hui réunis à la famille primitive de cette grande nation, vous devez revenir à nous de toute manière. C'est retourner vers votre source.

Having thus exhorted the emperor's Belgian subjects to do their national duty, de Neufchâteau warned of the misadventures of any further infatuation with the industrial charms of the enemy. Such flirtation, he insisted, would worsen the baneful effect of the 'dumping' of *toiles de coton* and *mousselines des Indes* on the Continent by British merchants. Already prejudiced by that practice, the rival industries of the Empire would be turned away completely from a manufacture based on home-grown primary materials (flax and hemp) unless the trend to cotton production was checked. They otherwise faced permanent enslavement to British competitors in the frivolous cult of cottons.

Liévin Bauwens, a large-scale cotton spinner who had interests in Passy, Ghent, and other centres, was quick to take up the challenge. His printed pamphlet of 15 March 1808³⁷ was a point-by-point rebuttal of de Neufchâteau's public letter and made several angular allusions to 'son affection pour la culture du Lin'. Basing his case on the historical record, he argued that all attempts by the British government to prevent foreign manufacturers from installing machines for cotton spinning in their enterprises had failed. He recalled his own efforts which, in spite of the official ban on the

³⁷ 'Observations de Liévin Bauwens à Gand, Fondateur du premier Établissement de Filature à *mule-jennies* en France, Propriétaire des Filatures de Coton des Chartreux et Tronchiennes, etc. sur une Lettre de S. Excell. Mr. le Sénateur François de Neufchâteau, Titulaire de la Sénatorerie de Bruxelles, Par laquelle Son Excellence s'efforce de prouver à Mr. Herwyn, Membre du Corps Législatif, les avantages de la Culture du Lin et les désavantages de l'établissement rapide de la Filature de Coton dans la Belgique': A.N. F¹² 533.

export of textile machinery from Britain, had brought 'mule-jennies' to Passy in 1798. This feat, he claimed, had been the true beginning of mechanized spinning in France. So far from making him an industrial puppet of the enemy, he invoked the evidence of Lord Erskine's remark at the time of the event that 'this was a conspiracy of the highest importance and an attempt to deprive us of that branch of manufactory, so dear to us as the very balls of our eyes'. He contested the point that 'dumping' by the British was tantamount to the sacrifice of national independence by imperial manufacturers, observing that the branded goods were often of inferior quality and that French enterprises in any case had access to alternative supplies of cotton from the Levant. Nor, he went on, could the cotton industry in the Empire be fairly accused of exercising a growing monopoly over other textile branches. There was evidence of expansion among the producers of both silkstuffs and linens: '... La construction des Filatures mécaniques de Coton n'est pas du tout incompatible avec la culture du Lin ... mais ... seulement l'usage du Lin, son emploi, le mode de consommation, sont changés depuis quelques années; les fabriques de soieries de Lyon, de Nîmes, du midi de la France et de l'Italie, en consomment des quantités prodigieuses qu'elles mêlent avec la soie.' Bauwens ended with a vindication of his warrior spirit. 'Nous combattons', he declared, 'pour la liberté des mers, pour notre Commerce et pour celui de tous les peuples, en un mot pour sécouer [*sic*] à jamais le joug de l'Angleterre'.

Of the two positions, de Neufchâteau's was the more emotional, but at least one detail of Bauwens's counter-blast seems doubtful on factual grounds. While French silkstuffs may have shown no signs of permanent eclipse by the cotton industry, and the silk manufacturers no craven hearts in fighting for their markets, the supposed buoyancy of imperial linens must be questioned. Their markets were uncertain, and the Spanish insurrection of 1808 was further to undermine one of their traditional outlets. François Crouzet has shown, from an analysis of the available statistics, that of all the sectors hit by the loss of overseas markets during the Revolutionary wars, French woollens and linens had been the

most affected.³⁸ Woollens had recovered well under the Consulate and early Empire, but Napoleonic rule could offer the linen manufacturers little cheer. Like the rope-makers and refiners of colonial cane-sugar of the Gironde, they were never to recover the position they had enjoyed in the 'Atlantic sector' of French trade before the Revolutionary wars. Their decline was evident in Valenciennes, Cambrai, Douai, and other towns of the Nord, in the Aisne, and in almost the whole of the west of France, especially Brittany. Apart from the loss of transmarine markets, which deprived it of substantial working capital, the French linen industry was still based largely on the putting-out system and had a low capacity for technical conversion. It was, in Crouzet's assessment, 'an archaic industry which was doomed anyway'.³⁹ Altogether, there was little basis for Bauwens's optimism about its prospects in 1808.

The champions of French linens and enemies of the cotton industry kept up their polemical campaign. One need not doubt that Napoleon and his officials would have liked to see cotton goods replaced by silkstuffs, woollens, and linens in Continental usage. It is easy also to see why: France was well provided in the latter industrial range. She had many enterprises specializing in cambrics and lawns as well as in silkstuffs, and of course she was not dependent here on primary materials from overseas. Realism, however, had to prevail. Cottons were not only in fashion; they were cheaper and often more serviceable than other textile articles. The best thing then was to make the Continent safer for imperial cotton manufacturers, in other words to encourage rather than turn against them. The government was optimistic, at any rate at the time of the first Blockade decrees, that wider markets could be found for all imperial industries. The Blockade was a 'war on cottons' only in the sense that it was a war on *British* and the more competitive Swiss and German cottons in Continental markets. As such it was only a part of the much broader offensive against all British goods. François Crouzet's reference to cottons as the 'strategic sector' of the

³⁸ 'Conséquences économiques de la Révolution', 202-3 and 214; 'Wars, Blockade, and Economic Change in Europe', 572 and 586.

³⁹ 'Wars, Blockade, and Economic Change', 572.

Anglo-French industrial conflict is apt.⁴⁰ So far from being a quasi-ideological attack on cottons, *qua* cottons, the Blockade could be seen as among other things a war on behalf of imperial cottons.

Of Napoleon's contemporaries with views on the issue, Claude-Anthelme Costaz gave one of the most sensible statements of the official position. As the head of the *Bureau des arts et manufactures* within the second division of the Ministry of the Interior,⁴¹ he had his ears to the ground. His opinion carried weight with the government and is worth a closer look. It was expressed for instance in the *Moniteur* of 24 September 1806, of which the following passage applies most directly:⁴²

La préférence que nous donnons au coton dans nos habillemens a causé les plus grands maux à notre industrie; elle a détruit nos manufactures de petit lainage, où tout était profit pour nous, puisque nous recueillons dans notre territoire la matière première; elle a porté un coup funeste à nos manufactures de toiles de chanvre, de lin, de linon et de batiste, qu'elle a privées d'une grande partie de leurs débouchés; enfin elle a diminué considérablement la consommation de nos étoffes de soie, genre d'industrie dans lequel nous l'emportons sur les autres nations . . . L'administration ne s'est point dissimulée ces inconvéniens et elle n'a rien négligé pour y parer. Mais qu'opposer au torrent de la mode? Ne pouvant empêcher l'usage du coton elle a dû chercher les moyens de le rendre le moins ruineux possible pour l'État, elle a fait les dépenses nécessaires pour procurer à nos manufactures les meilleures machines et gagner ainsi la main d'œuvre. Ce n'est pas exagérer de dire que la consommation du coton exige une somme annuelle de 150 à 160 millions.

Such reasoning is the nearest approach in the primary material to a dispassionate assessment of how official industrial policy took account of conflicting interests. Since cottons could not be ignored, they had to be made profitable to the Empire. They were an important detail of the French Continental market design from the start.

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⁴⁰ 'Wars, Blockade, and Economic Change in Europe', 579.

⁴¹ He was to be appointed as head of the third division (Fabriques et Manufactures) when the new Ministry of Trade and Industry was formed in January 1812.

⁴² It is also quoted among the 'pièces justificatives' in d'Ivernois, *Exposé de l'Exposé de . . . 1813*, 147-8 n.

The Blockade and the market design had both short-term and long-term aims. Among the first were all objects immediately concerned with the imperial war effort and the urgent need to find markets to compensate for transmarine losses. The purpose was somehow to increase the economic breaking-point of the area deliberately placed under the 'self-blockade'. Most writers have opted for this emphasis in interpreting the Blockade's significance. In Eli Heckscher's opinion, for instance, 'the Continental System mainly had immediate ends in view'.⁴³ Indeed, for contemporary commentators and for Napoleon himself, the immediate aims seemed easily the most important. Thus we have this oracle among many: 'dans des circonstances extraordinaires, il faut des mesures extraordinaires. La législation est pour les besoins de la vie.'⁴⁴ The world, as it were, was out of joint; and the Blockade was the cursed spite born to set it right. The accent here is on its military objectives, on the element of emergency and siege warfare. In this sense the Blockade meant blood, sweat, and tears. Its ultimate test was which side could hold out longer. Supporters of the Blockade expected it to deliver a swift knock-out blow on the enemy's trade and, as Gaudin put it in his financial report of 19 September 1807, to force Britain 'to succumb soon'.

Yet the longer-term aims of the Blockade and of its market design should not be overlooked. It was to be at once the executioner of British industrial and commercial supremacy and the harbinger of a new economic order of things in Europe. As Montgaillard wrote in his *mémoire* of 23 February 1806, 'la puissance de l'Angleterre est . . . nécessairement au moment d'éprouver des atteintes mortelles sur le continent européen et le commerce de l'Empire doit s'accroître précisément dans la même proportion que celui de sa rivale diminuera'.⁴⁵ This view is also interesting for the implicit idea, very common among French theorists reared on mercantilist doctrines, that the total stock of the world's wealth was static. The prosperity or poverty of states was therefore determined by a kind of felicific calculus inversely

⁴³ *Continental System*, 364.

⁴⁴ Napoleon to Cambacérès on 26 Mar. 1807, *Correspondance*, xiv, no. 12176, p. 122.

⁴⁵ *Mémoires diplomatiques*, 167.

proportioned: the more one lost, the more one's enemies gained relatively, and vice versa. The Blockade was to be the first step, taken in wartime conditions, towards a massive economic replanning which would follow at the peace. Albert Sorel makes the point in his reference to 1806 as 'le point de départ de sa [Napoleon's] *rénovation économique*'.⁴⁶ F. E. Melvin is more assertive still: 'in the ultimate analysis', he writes, 'the Berlin decree is chiefly important as the beginning rather than the end of a program'.⁴⁷ The long-term aims might even be seen as the industrial and commercial variant of the 'masses de granit', Napoleon's metaphor for a solid and enduring base on which to build his Empire. His purpose was not to redress the balance of some natural economic order which the British nation had purportedly overturned, not to establish an equilibrium fair to all, but rather to build a French economic hegemony on the ruins of the old. In other words, he aimed at a new economic *imbalance* of power weighted in the French interest.

Whatever the official optimism, however, the task facing the French at the beginning of the Blockade was enormous. One implication of the 'self-blockade', for instance, was that they undertook to provide many primary materials, semi-worked and finished articles, and foodstuffs which had been supplied hitherto mainly by British or by neutral trade. At the same time they had to find somewhere on the Continent enough of the same goods for their own use. Part of the plan was to encourage the 'new' or 'substitute industries' like beet-sugar, chicory, pastel and madder-wort dyes, and even cotton plantations in the kingdom of Naples. Although these initiatives came rather late in the day and had only variable results, the practical difficulties of trying to play the role of provisioner to the Grand Empire might have been foreseen in 1806-7. For the Continent as a whole, the price of French policy was certainly high from the start. On even the most cautious reckoning French industrial costs and retail prices were generally higher than those in other European countries. The protection of French markets at home, and the attempt to 'reserve' the markets of the subject states so far as possible

⁴⁶ *L'Europe et la Révolution française*, iii. 477 (italics mine).

⁴⁷ *Navigation System*, 10.

for imperial exporters, in effect implied the protection of French price levels, since these determined profit margins and the *bénéfice d'entreprise*.

It is hardly surprising, then, that the Blockade and the French market design were from the start received with mixed feelings by the Empire's Continental competitors. The latter might have hoped to gain like the French from the exclusion of British goods and to boost their own output; but at the same time they were officially denied access to primary materials and many semi-worked articles which were most cheaply available from British suppliers. It soon became clear, too, that the French were prepared to exert whatever pressure they could to impose conditions favourable to their trade, while foreign rivals had no prospect of ever being able to participate freely in the imperial market. For them, as indeed for many imperial consumers, the French market design looked rather like a *marché de dupe*. It bore the aspect of a huge contrivance aimed at thrusting the relatively high French cost of living on the Continent at large. The breaking-point was reached during and after the economic crisis of 1810-11, itself precipitated largely by other factors, but by then there had been mounting protest against rising costs in the subject states and a ubiquitous resort to smuggling.

For those reasons all allusions to the Napoleonic market design as a would-be 'French Zollverein' should be treated with caution.⁴⁸ It is a fair enough analogy where the formal unit of the Empire applies, and admittedly some primary sources also suggest that the idea can be extended to the Continent more widely. In practice, however, the Blockade decrees, the preferential tariffs, and the '*marchés réservés*' showed how little the imperial government intended to share any economic benefits with partners beyond the national frontiers. It was ready to allow imports of, for instance, Italian raw silk, Levantine cotton, and (until 1810) 'vegetable'

⁴⁸ See for example Melvin's chapter entitled 'The Continental Zollverein' (*Navigation System*, 211-34); de Jouvenel's remark that 'le Zollverein français passe dans l'Histoire comme le rêve d'un bon esprit sans lendemain efficace' (*Économie dirigée*, 220); and Dunan's brief reference to the imperial customs unit as 'une sorte de Zollverein' (*Napoléon et l'Allemagne*, 327).

soda from Spain or Sicily only where imperial manufacturers had become dependent on them and were inadequately supplied at home. Even then, many of the goods concerned were heavily taxed on entry and were liable to strict verification procedures by the French customs officials. The motto of the market design might well have been: ACHETEZ FRANCAIS! Just as Napoleon wanted political and military vassals rather than independent partners, so he wanted economic dependencies and tributaries, not competitive allies.

Altogether, the French aim was in effect to build a great Continental 'Uncommon Market' in which buying and selling would operate according to imperial interests. Louis Bergeron has described the plan rather nicely as 'une sorte de "marché commun à sens unique"', au sein duquel des traités de commerce imposés ou des décisions unilatérales organisent les échanges en fonction des seuls intérêts économiques de la France'.⁴⁹ British exclusion from it was to be axiomatic from the start. In the same letter in which he spelt out the principle of 'la France avant tout',⁵⁰ Napoleon also instructed Eugène de Beauharnais that 'vous ne devez jamais perdre de vue que, si le commerce anglais triomphe sur mer, c'est parce que les Anglais y sont les plus forts; *il est donc convenable, puisque la France est la plus forte sur terre, qu'elle y fasse aussi triompher son commerce*;⁵¹ sans quoi tout est perdu'. In polemical abstract the French Continental market design resembled a macrocosm of the 'thèse autarkiste', of what Fichte for instance had had in mind for much smaller national units in his essay *Der geschlossene Handelstaat*.⁵² Professor Sloane once called the latter Fichte's 'contribution to the literature of Utopias',⁵³ but the French market design of Napoleon's time, resting as it seemed on a secure military base, is not so easily dismissed.

iv. *The market design in the 'Outre-Rhin'*

The populous expanse of the *Outre-Rhin* was potentially a promising target for imperial exporters hoping to boost their

⁴⁹ *Épisode napoléonien*, 195.

⁵⁰ 23 Aug. 1810: *Correspondance*, xxi. 70.

⁵¹ Italics mine.

⁵² Published in Tübingen in 1800.

⁵³ 'The Continental System of Napoleon', *Political Science Quarterly*, xiii (1898), 216.

trade. Montgaillard once referred to the states of the Rhenish Confederation as 'les colonies continentales de l'Empire'.⁵⁴ The phrase is apt, for the gravity of the market design, as of the Blockade more generally, extended 'throughout subject Germany. Outside of Italy and possibly also Spain, it was here most of all that the French aimed to develop the 'markets of replacement' for their industry and trade.

Particular importance attached to the trade with Frankfurt and Leipzig. These towns were still the major international centres of distribution for industrial goods and merchandise in central and northern Europe. They gained in relative importance as first the Dutch and then the north German ports were placed under closer customs surveillance, and they acted as magnets for all the roundabout or criss-cross routes of 'le commerce interlope'. The latter role, however, was certainly not part of the imperial government's intentions. Its interest lay rather in the crucial position Frankfurt and Leipzig held in the regular entrepôt traffic of central and northern Germany. The concern of imperial manufacturers and merchants was never more acute than at the time of the annual Easter and Michaelmas fairs in both towns. Another less important fair was also held in Leipzig each New Year. According to Chaptal, French exports to 'Germany' before the Revolution had been worth between 23 and 25 million francs a year; and of that total, expeditions to the Frankfurt and Leipzig fairs had accounted for over 15 million, the greater part in silkstuffs.⁵⁵ Anton Kirchner, commenting only a few years after the collapse of the Empire, described Frankfurt as the 'Kreuz-, Post- und Querstrasse von Mitteleuropa und Mercurii beliebter Transito-Mittelpunkt'.⁵⁶ This colourful image encouraged Friedrich Bothe, a local historian, to argue later that Napoleon had envisaged French economic mastery of the Continent through control of Frankfurt. 'There', Bothe writes, 'Napoleon dared hope to conquer the European market for the industry of France, drive

⁵⁴ *Mémoires diplomatiques*, 261.

⁵⁵ *De l'industrie française* (2 vols., Paris, 1819), i, 70-1.

⁵⁶ A suitable translation might be: 'The postal criss-cross road of central Europe and Mercury's favoured transit centre'. *Ansichten von Frankfurt a.[m] M.[ain]*, vol. ii (Frankfurt, 1818), quoted in F. Bothe, *Geschichte der Stadt Frankfurt am Main*, 3rd edn. (Frankfurt, 1929), 258.

back and most severely undermine economic competitors, in so far as they — chiefly England — seemed hostile to him'.⁵⁷

Yet Leipzig was if anything more important to French market objectives across the Rhine, generally in the line of luxury goods but especially silkstuffs manufactured in the Lyonnais. These products were too dear for the kind of popular consumption then enjoyed by some cotton and woollen manufacturers. There was a limit to how far the imperial Court, the army, and the civilian bureaux could absorb such output. Although Napoleon and his entourage could certainly help to sponsor the fashion for silken goods by a public display of what Odette Viennet calls 'l'obligation de luxe, même de somptuosité',⁵⁸ the wider market for French luxury products lay with well-to-do clients, and traditionally many of them were foreigners who travelled each year to Leipzig to place their orders. Manufacturers in Lyons knew that a poor showing at the Leipzig fairs inevitably rebounded on their profits.⁵⁹ The military campaigns of 1805, for instance, had given rise to the usual nervousness among houses with dealings in the German entrepôts. Writing to the Minister of the Interior on 12 Vendémiaire XIV (4 October 1805), the chamber of commerce in Lyons referred to 'la position vraiment critique de notre place'.⁶⁰ It specifically linked the prospects for recovery with an upturn of business in Leipzig, although the chamber was then generally pessimistic on that score.

Its gloom was apparently not misplaced, since another report to Champagny almost a year later was equally bleak.⁶¹ This time, in a direct reference to prevailing market trouble, the chamber noted that: '... il ne se fait plus, comme dans les tems ordinaires, de grands approvisionnemens; chacun réduit ses achats au besoin du moment... Ce n'est pas à Lyon seulement qu'on éprouve cette stagnation, toutes les villes environnantes qui se pourvoient ordinairement ici, ont une égale diminution dans leur débouché.' Prospects

⁵⁷ Bothe, *op. cit.* 260.

⁵⁸ *Napoléon et l'industrie française*, 37.

⁵⁹ The standard work on the Leipzig fairs remains E. Hasse, *Geschichte der Leipziger Messen* (Leipzig, 1885). Chaps. 7, 8, 15, 16, and the appendices on pp. 495–500 cover the Napoleonic period most fully.

⁶⁰ A.N. F¹² 501b.

⁶¹ 21 Sept. 1806: A.N. F¹² 513.

for the winter seemed poor, for as yet no sizeable contracts had been agreed with German and Russian clients. The chamber's hope lay in an early peace and an end to the paralysis of the German trade routes. Again it stressed the importance of resuming normal business with Leipzig, which was said to take, for eventual redistribution all over Europe, something like five-eighths of the annual trade of Lyons in silkstuffs and re-exported silks. In a report to the Minister on 11 December 1806 the chamber further estimated that Russia absorbed between 80 and 90 million francsworth of French products in a good year, and that Lyons alone accounted for some 29 million of this total, either by direct expedition or through intermediaries in Leipzig.⁶²

Geneva was another imperial city with vested interests in Leipzig. Its links with the Saxon entrepôt are nowhere better explained than by Simonde de Sismondi in a letter written on behalf of the local chamber of commerce to Champagne less than a fortnight before the Berlin decree:⁶³

Les manufactures françaises sont plus particulièrement intéressées à la conservation de l'antique prospérité d'une ville d'Allemagne, qui étoit le marché général, le marché presque unique de tout le nord et le levant de l'Europe. Les foires de Leipzig étoient le débouché le plus important des manufactures françaises destinées à une consommation étrangère, et la suppression du commerce de cette ville, en détruisant toute exportation, ruinerait presque tous les ateliers de France, et réduiroit les ouvriers à manquer de pain. De beaucoup la plus grande partie de l'horlogerie et de la bijouterie de notre ville étoit vendue à Leipzig, toutes nos exportations pour l'Allemagne, le Danemarck, la Suède, la Hongrie, la Pologne, la Russie, et la Turquie avoient cette destination.

Those observations prefaced the real point of Sismondi's letter, which was to press for the confirmation and protection of Leipzig's historic commercial liberties, especially at fair time.

Much the same message emanated from Saint-Étienne. Writing to Champagne on 25 November 1806, only a few

⁶² A.N. AF^{IV} 1060. The same *carton* has a copy of Champagne's report to Napoleon of 8 Dec. 1806 in which it is stated that the overland routes for French exports to Russia ran from Frankfurt and/or Leipzig via Berlin, Königsberg, Mitau (now Jelgava), and Riga to St. Petersburg; or via Breslau, Warsaw, Grodno, and Smolensk to Moscow.

⁶³ On 10 Nov. 1806: A.N. AF^{IV} 1060.

days after the Berlin decree, its consultative chamber for manufacture, arts, and crafts made a spirited plea for the confirmation of Leipzig's traditional franchises.⁶⁴ It argued that the consequences for many imperial towns would be disastrous if the new prohibitive trade laws were ruthlessly applied to such a vital entrepôt. 'La ville de Leipsek', it claimed, 'est aujourd'hui non seulement le plus grand marché de l'Europe, mais pour ainsi dire le seul qu'il y ait dans tous les états du nord'. It added that all the leading merchants of northern and central Europe either frequented the Leipzig fairs or had agents and business associates there. The chamber mentioned in particular merchants from Prussia, Russia, and Austria, remarking that they formed the network through which French industry and trade had access to 'immense markets' beyond the imperial frontiers.

In Paris itself, market trouble during the months immediately preceding and following the Berlin decree was also often linked with the disruption of trade across the Rhine. So, too, all hope of recovery rested on a favourable peace there and the resumption of normal trade. In a special report approved by Champagny for dispatch to Napoleon some time before the Berlin decree,⁶⁵ unemployment in the capital was blamed on the general default of markets. As the report put it,

. . . Ce n'est pas le premier exemple d'une pareille stagnation dans les travaux de nos ateliers. Elle a lieu toutes les fois que la fabrication excède la consommation . . . La difficulté n'est pas de donner de l'essor à l'industrie, mais de lever les obstacles qui s'opposent à la consommation . . . Dans un moment où les magasins regorgent de marchandises, on ne peut augmenter la quantité des articles manufacturés, sans augmenter l'engorgement, et sans faire éprouver aux propriétaires de ces marchandises une perte considérable, en les forçant d'en baisser le prix.

The above is a crucial passage, riveting as it does on the problem of actual industrial glut in France before the Blockade.

If one needed ministerial evidence of the same problem after the Berlin decree, Champagny's report to the inner 'cabinet' (*Conseil*) on 28 January 1807 would provide it.⁶⁶

⁶⁴ A.N. F¹² 513.

⁶⁵ Undated, but contextual references suggest that it was written in Sept. or Oct. 1806: A.N. F¹² 513.

⁶⁶ A.N. F¹² 4639.

It is long, and many of its passages would serve the present purpose well, but the main point focuses again on the disruption of markets, for in the Minister's words,

La souffrance de certains genres de fabrication est certaine; elle est sensible à Paris et à Lyon; les causes sont faciles à déduire, mais les remèdes ne sont pas également faciles à trouver.

Ce n'est point l'argent qui manquent, ce n'est pas le crédit, et l'on doit s'en féliciter, car avec ces deux ressources, le principe de vie subsiste et les maux ne seront que passagers; *mais le plus grand nombre des débouchés extérieurs sont momentanément interceptés, la consommation intérieure est réduite; ce qui manque, c'est l'écoulement pour les objets fabriqués . . .*⁶⁷

On doit seulement faire remarquer, que deux ou trois genres principaux sont à ce jour dans une situation assez satisfaisante, la filature de coton, la fabrication des tissus blancs pour l'impression en particulier, les étoffes de soye et coton qui se fabriquent à Nismes. Ce sont principalement les soyeries de tout genre, la passementerie, l'ébénisterie, les toiles, les porcelaines, fayences, bronzes, cristaux, tapis, la bijouterie, les papiers peints, et toiles peintes qui paroissent avoir besoin de secours.

Now, many would not have agreed with Champagny's view on the availability of cash and credit. The financial state of the Empire early in 1807, with the Continental campaigns continuing, was rather less 'liquid' than his report claims. But it is unquestionable that the luxury industries were then the hardest hit by market default. Champagny linked the industrial problems of that winter with both the break in maritime trade and the repercussions of hostilities on mainland markets. In the same report he refers bluntly to 'l'épuisement de l'Allemagne' and gives figures to back his case. Paris normally exported nearly 50 million francsworth of goods to Germany and Russia each year, while Lyons, on the evidence of its chamber, exported silkstuffs of about half that value to Russia alone; but all this trade had been undermined by the campaigns of 1805-7.

Champagny's negative emphasis on market trouble was sometimes accompanied by more positive proposals for dealing with it. In this respect he showed himself sensitive to the petitions from Paris, Lyons, and other manufacturing centres. Indeed, his own counsel to Napoleon more often than not followed the line of those petitions. In one such report of

⁶⁷ Italics mine.

24 November 1806 he made much the same case for Leipzig to be treated generously.⁶⁸ That town, he wrote,

est pour les productions de notre industrie et même d'une partie de notre sol, notre principal débouché à l'étranger et le canal par lequel rentre en France le numéraire que les approvisionnement tirés du nord peuvent en faire sortir. Les négocians de Lyon attribuent l'immense utilité dont cette ville a été au commerce de la France avant et depuis la révolution, beaucoup moins à l'avantage de sa position et aux inclinations commerçantes de ses habitans, qu'aux réglemens municipaux auxquels le commerce y est assujetti et dont ils vantent beaucoup la sagesse. Les prodigieux succès de cette guerre raniment le courage des commerçans et des manufacturiers . . . Ils espèrent que le commerce et l'industrie française trouveront aussi leurs avantages dans le nouvel ordre de choses qui doit sortir des mains de Votre Majesté.

Champagny repeated the advice that Leipzig be kept intact in any political reorganization of the *Outre-Rhin* and its commercial franchises, especially at fair time, duly respected.

For his part, Napoleon also had strong views on where the national interest lay in the *Outre-Rhin*, but these were by no means always consistent. In the formative period of the Rhenish Confederation (1806-7) he saw 'mes petits états fédératifs' not only as military buffers and diplomatic ciphers but also as economic dependencies of the Empire. Marcel Dunan thinks that the Confederation was more interesting and more rewarding to Napoleon as an economic than as a military unit.⁶⁹ Just as he had already incorporated 'la France allemande' in political terms, so he hoped to annex 'l'Allemagne française' in economic terms. His broad objectives in the Confederation have sometimes been summed up in the trilogy 'Men-Money-Arms'. In the light of the foregoing discussion, a fourth major element should be added: Markets.

The earlier emphasis on Leipzig's central importance to the French market design across the Rhine should not over-extend the geographical role that Alsace was to have in the scheme. Alsatian manufacturers and merchants themselves had few *direct* dealings with that town or with other German entrepôts of equivalent distance from them. Cotton goods from Mulhouse were of course regularly routed there, as was the whole range of commodities passing through Strasbourg

⁶⁸ A.N. AF^{IV} 1060.

⁶⁹ *Napoléon et l'Allemagne*, 343-4.

from areas in the French interior or the Midi to foreign clients. Yet the greater share of these travelled via Mainz, if moving mainly due north,⁷⁰ or through Frankfurt, if the destination lay north-eastwards or eastwards. As far as the Alsatians were concerned, Frankfurt rather than Leipzig was the hub of the market design in the *Outre-Rhin*. For the Strasbourgeois in particular, the trade down and up river with Frankfurt was vital to their prosperity. They always took a special interest in trade reports from that town, for example in those of the French agent Theobald Bacher,⁷¹ whose observations on the performance of imperial exporters to the Frankfurt fairs between 1807 and 1811 were regularly sent to Paris.⁷²

* * *

Two documentary sources dating from the first year of the Blockade deal more fully with the French market design in the *Outre-Rhin* and deserve detailed attention. One is Champagne's ministerial report to Napoleon of 5 August 1807 on the commercial prospects for France beyond the Rhine. The other, which grew out of the Minister's wish to have fuller information on this matter, is a series of reports by Camille Perier written in the course of an industrial mission to

⁷⁰ In a report of Sept. 1806 on Franco-Dutch trade, Champagne informed Napoleon that 'la France envoie en général trois ou quatre fois plus de ses productions territoriales dans le Nord que dans le midi de l'Europe. Le Nord lui demande du vin, des eaux-de-vie, des huiles, des fruits; et la Hollande n'a pas moins d'intérêt à les demander que la France à les fournir; la Hollande a intérêt aussi à leur accorder la préférence [over the produce of Spain and Portugal], soit à raison de la proximité, soit à raison de l'union politique qui lui assure une jouissance plus certaine et plus durable.' A.N. AF^{IV} 174. Strasbourg was a major entrepôt on the route from Burgundy and (while the sea lanes were closed) from the Midi to Holland, and Mainz was of course the principal down-river link for Alsatian middlemen.

⁷¹ On whom see Friedrich Otto, *Theobald Bacher, ein elsässischer Diplomat im Dienste Frankreichs (1748-1813)*, Strassburger Beiträge zur neueren Geschichte, vol. iii (Strasbourg, 1910).

⁷² It is regrettable that Bacher's reports, which are much the most detailed contemporary account of how French goods competed with others at the Frankfurt fairs, are haphazardly scattered in the sub-series F¹² and AF^{IV}: see esp. F¹² 507, 509-10, 616-17, 619, and AF^{IV} 1061. A useful secondary reference work on this and related topics is the *Geschichte der Handelskammer zu Frankfurt a.[m] M.[ain] (1707-1908)* (ed. H. Trumpler, Frankfurt, 1908).

Germany late in 1807 and early in 1808. These sources form a bridge between this and the next chapter and are here discussed in turn.

*Champagny's ministerial report of 5 August 1807*⁷³

On the preceding 30 July Napoleon had put a number of questions to the Minister. He wanted to know what French merchants and manufacturers might reasonably expect from the princes of the Rhenish Confederation; what measures were thought most necessary to boost French exports there; and from which states and from which particular industrial branches foreign competition in those markets was most likely to come. Champagny's report was an attempt, if a rather hurried one in the first instance, to answer the emperor's questions.

The opening observation was that in giving Germany a new political and constitutional structure, Napoleon had created an area of great new economic potential to France. Wines, *eaux-de-vie*, silkstuffs, luxury articles and fashion ware, woollens, and cottons were all in constant demand in the Confederation. Some French goods had had a regular market there for many years; others could soon penetrate into German markets and, if suitably encouraged, would long remain a necessary part of normal business exchanges. The only rival France had to fear was Britain, Champagny went on, but he assumed that the Blockade would soon take care of her. Mistaking the will for the deed, he roundly declared that: 'L'Allemagne en ce moment perd l'habitude de recevoir ses consommations des Anglais et secoue le joug de leur industrie. Je n'ai rien négligé pour exciter les fabricants français à profiter d'une circonstance aussi favorable. Sans doute à l'époque de la paix maritime Votre Majesté saura maintenir ce grand ouvrage qu'ont créé ses triomphes autant que le permettront les circonstances.' The broad and optimistic outline thus sketched, the Minister got down to more specific matters. His report put forward four practical proposals to safeguard French interests.

⁷³ A.N. AFIV 1060. The report is printed in Appendix C of Schmidt, *Grand-duché de Berg*, 486-9, and is also briefly discussed in Tarlé, 'Deutsch-französische Wirtschaftsbeziehungen', 702-5.

The first recommendation was the free passage of all French goods travelling through the Confederation. Champagny had in mind mainly the overland trade via Frankfurt and/or Leipzig to Prussia, Poland, and Russia, and he was referring to French re-exports as well as domestic exports. He regarded free transit by road and river as the precondition of an expansion of French trade to those parts. To this proposal he added his concern for the liberties of the German fair towns, repeating the petition of many regional chambers of commerce that historic franchises should not be touched. Extending his earlier recommendation that the franchises of Leipzig be guaranteed, he now advised the similar confirmation of the rights and privileges of Frankfurt and Brunswick at the time of their fairs. Only the twin policy of respecting the liberties of the major fair towns in Germany and securing free transit rights for French goods through them would enable the trade to northern and north-eastern Europe to operate without crippling cost or disruptive customs delays. So long as France was denied access to the sea routes, the freedom of her expeditions inland seemed to him essential: 'il importe de pourvoir à ce qu'aujourd'hui ces États arrondis, étendus, ne s'enveloppent pas d'une ligne de douanes, qui, sous prétexte de protéger leur propre commerce, repousserait le nôtre!' The catch in this, however, was that the German states enjoyed no comparable transit rights in the Empire. Champagny softened the irony by suggesting that concessions might be made to help a reciprocal transit trade across France, but only once British competition was expunged from the Continent, once France had won the maritime peace. He believed that such concessions to the Confederate states would then be to the advantage of France as well.

The second proposal of the report was an alternative to the first, in the event of Napoleon's not insisting on wholly free transit rights for French trade through the Confederation. Under no circumstances, Champagny advised, should transit duties be allowed to exceed 1 per cent *ad valorem* on French goods. Duties of that sort fell within the category known as 'douanes extérieures'. They included local *péages*, port commissions, tariff and transit charges of various kinds. Champagny's accompanying recommendation was that all such

levies should not be imposed in the states of the Confederation without the express permission of its Protector, Napoleon himself. He urged the emperor to establish this principle on a formal basis in the Confederation, at least where French trade was concerned. He was asking in effect for a singularly preferential tariff for the French transit trade, one far more favourable than was then anywhere in force in international traffic. In return, he again suggested that a similar transit duty of 1 per cent might be granted to the Confederate states for their trade through France. One is left wondering, though, whether he wanted this concession to be dependent on a maritime peace, as in the first recommendation.

Champagny's third proposal concerned the tariffs regulating such French exports as were consumed in the Confederation itself. He conceded that these so-called 'douanes intérieures' were a permissible and recognized form of fiscal income for each of the Confederate states and could be likened to domestic consumer taxes on foreign articles. But he also stressed that the import duties should be strictly confined to French goods entering any state *and* actually consumed there, and that they should nowhere exceed 10 per cent *ad valorem*. He mentioned French wines, silkstuffs, woollens, and ribbons specifically, and again suggested that reciprocal terms might be allowed to similar goods imported from the Confederate states. This, though, was a forlorn expectation, as it was well known that Napoleon was firmly opposed to the entry of foreign goods which might compete with imperial products, except in unavoidable cases. He was not then likely to reciprocate such a favourable import tariff with mere vassal states, and Champagny must have known this.

The last recommendation urged a more effective application of the 'drawback' arrangement provided for in the imperial customs decree of 22 February 1806.⁷⁴ Earlier the report had anticipated that 'la filature et le tissage du coton ont pris à peine quelque essor dans les États de la Confédération du Rhin, lors donc, et ce moment approche, lorsque

⁷⁴ For a brief statement of its details see above, pp. 102-3 n.

nos établissements auront pourvu à toute notre consommation, ils pourront verser au delà du Rhin l'excédent de leurs produits'.⁷⁵ This quite explicit statement of the French market design in Germany was tied up with the technical matter of the 'drawback'. Champagny believed that if its procedure was properly applied, if, that is, imperial manufacturers could actually recoup their down payments on imported cotton primary materials provided these were worked up into finished goods for export, a vast market for imperial cottons would be opened up across the Rhine.

Taken as a whole, Champagny's blueprint of 5 August 1807 was a strange mixture of apparently liberal but practically lopsided proposals. In its more generous light it opened the vista of a whole network of preferential treaties with the states of the Rhenish Confederation. Its suggestions of a commercial partnership with 'French Germany' would have been far less one-sided than the Empire's actual trade relations with, say, Italy. But as against these aspects the report was more remarkable for its partisan view of imperial interests. Its vague suggestion of some reciprocal concessions, whether immediate or at the peace, carried little weight before the 'égoïsme sacré' of the imperial plan. Nor did the one-sidedness of French customs policy go unchallenged in the Confederation. Champagny's blueprint was not implemented in the sense that it passed from the stage of ministerial recommendations to immediate legislation. In practice, transit and import duties in the Confederate states did not satisfy all the wishes of the imperial government. In the years which followed the report pressure was often put on the princes to moderate their tariffs in the interests of imperial trade, usually with some formal effect.

Champagny's successor at the Interior was Cretet, and the change came only a fortnight after the report of 5 August. The new Minister lost no time in similarly asserting French commercial interests in the Confederation and elsewhere. In a report of 26 August 1807 he presented Napoleon with 'la perspective d'une plus grande activité de nos fabriques, dont les productions ne peuvent manquer d'obtenir un débouché

⁷⁵ Italics mine.

plus favorable par l'effet de la Paix Continentale et des mesures politiques qui tendent chaque jour de plus en plus à écarter dans les marchés extérieurs, la concurrence préjudiciable de l'éternel ennemi de notre industrie'.⁷⁶ The measures adopted by the imperial government in that pursuit, or in crude military terms by Napoleon himself, were to lead to many disputes. The whole issue of transit rights to and from France was not the least among them. Champagny's vision of a uniform 1 per cent *ad valorem* duty across the Rhine remained little more than a recurring bureaucratic dream.

One of Cretet's administrative achievements of particular bearing on the market question was the collection of detailed trade reports from all over the Continent.⁷⁷ They were written by agents who were resident or had travelled abroad to send him the information required. He wanted to know what the current and earlier trading position of France was in each country, which goods formed the basis of such exchanges, whether the reciprocation of preferential treaties would be advantageous to the Empire, and generally how French exports might be encouraged. The reports cover dealings with Holland, Germany, Russia, Italy, Spain, Portugal, and even with lands as far afield as Persia. Cretet followed Champagny in pressing for the safety of the inland transit routes and the lowest possible tariffs on French goods travelling abroad. He also urged the strict enforcement of the Blockade in all the subject and allied states. Trusting the information of his agents, he was usually optimistic about the prospects for imperial trade. Like his predecessor, he was apt to take the will for the deed.

*Camille Perier's industrial mission to Germany (1807-8)*⁷⁸

Formerly a student of the École Polytechnique and the École des Mines, Perier had been sent by Champagny on what

⁷⁶ A.N. AF^{IV} 1060.

⁷⁷ These are variously scattered in A.N. AF^{IV} 174; AF^{IV} 1060-2, three cartons rich in material on the Blockade more generally; F¹² 534, 549-50, 620-2, 643, and 2401.

⁷⁸ Most of the relevant documents are kept at A.N. F¹² 622, but some are in the carton AF^{IV} 174.

amounted to an industrial reconnaissance expedition to Germany. The questions posed by the Minister were the same as those put to him by Napoleon on 30 July 1807 and to which his report of 5 August was a provisional reply. Perier's instructions were to travel as widely as possible in the states of the Rhenish Confederation and in Prussia, to observe, and then report back to Paris. Apart from studying and assessing French market opportunities in those lands, his mission had one important practical purpose. It was to advise the Minister on the propriety, technical rather than ethical, of transporting foreign machines to France for imitation. This particular object of the mission recalls the function of the *Commission d'extraction* in Belgium under the National Convention. In the event, Cretet had succeeded Champagny at the Interior by the time the mission got under way, and it was to the new Minister that Perier's reports were sent. It was Cretet, too, who prepared the ministerial synopsis of 13 January 1808, which was dispatched to Napoleon on 4 February.⁷⁹

The Perier reports offer a detailed account of how imperial industry and trade stood in relation to foreign competition in the *Outre-Rhin* roughly a year after the Berlin decree. They are much too long to be examined here in individual detail, but a synthesis of their main findings is in order. The reader is struck first by the wide range of industrial branches and regions investigated. One report deals with the linen trade of Brunswick, Hanover, and the Hesses. Another, among the most detailed, discusses the importance of the Brunswick fairs and goes on to assess the prospects for imperial exports to the kingdom of Westphalia more widely. Another looks into the position of the German cotton industries and their markets, with particular reference to Berg, Saxony, and Prussia. Other reports examine the prevailing customs system in Prussia and suggest ways of facilitating imperial trade to that country or through it to Poland and Russia. Others again give an account of the mining, metallurgical, and textile industries of Silesia and Saxony. Perier was altogether admirably frank. He did not try to curry favour with the Minister by building up false hopes. He acknowledged

⁷⁹ A.N. AF*IV 174.

the fact of Britain's advantage in most industrial and commercial branches. He also correctly identified the chief reasons for it: her lower labour and other industrial costs, her superior machinery in the more popular industrial ranges, the relative cheapness of her semi-worked and finished articles, her flexible commercial and credit facilities. He reported that imperial exporters had made no significant impact on German markets during the first nine months of the Blockade. The two contributory factors most immediately apparent to him here were the persistence of hostilities into the summer of 1807 and the stockpiling of British goods by German dealers in anticipation of the Blockade's enforcement in their lands. Perier also emphasized that smuggling was a serious problem, that its ubiquity was a sign of the Blockade's unpopularity in Germany, and that most states still had dealings with Britain and would find ways of continuing them in spite of the Blockade.

The trade in cotton yarn and sewing cotton was a case in point. As Perier observed in his report on that subject, '... dans le grand nombre des manufactures que nous avons parcourues, il nous a été impossible d'en trouver une seule qui eût employé la moindre quantité de cotons français. Nous n'avons pas rencontré un seul fabricant qui eût cherché à en connaître les qualités et les prix. Beaucoup d'entr'eux ignoroient jusqu'ici l'existence de nos filatures.' His explanation of the difficulty was that British cotton yarn and sewing cotton sold so much more cheaply in Germany than the French varieties that there had been no incentive to buy the latter. In spite of the long diversions and the additional transport and insurance costs which the Blockade necessitated in the north, British yarn was still reckoned to be some 16 per cent cheaper than French yarn in Germany. Perier thought that the discrepancy would not even out until a maritime peace was achieved. Even in those branches where French producers had long been successful and where British competition was not a major threat, he predicted troublesome rivalry from a number of Continental states. Those mentioned most often are Berg, Saxony, Prussia (including of course Silesia), and Switzerland. Again the theme of his reports on them is the uncompetitiveness of French prices in

unprotected markets. In the case of linens, for example, Silesian articles sold at about half the cost of the French. Dresden and other Saxon towns enjoyed a similar advantage over imperial centres like Courtrai and Cambrai in the sale of table linen.

All this meant that the French market design in the *Outre-Rhin* had had little apparent success by the autumn of 1807. Perier had not found any significant trends towards a change in buying and selling habits there. Even where the Blockade had perceptibly reduced the traffic in British goods across the Rhine, it was also clear that trade between the German states themselves had been adversely affected. This in turn had reacted on imperial exports. The February fair in Brunswick had not compared favourably with its forerunner of 1806. Sales had fallen by between a half and two-thirds, Perier was informed, and it was bluntly reported that German merchants expected to gain little from preferential treaties with the Empire. They apparently regarded such agreements, whether based on 'most-favoured-nation' or exclusive trading rights, as partisan devices which were bound to push up prices to the imperial advantage and at their own expense.

So much for the negative side of Perier's reports; what of their more optimistic assessments? Undoubtedly the first message to come across is that imperial producers in certain industrial and commercial branches might hope for a happier future in German markets. Perier also underlined the importance of Germany to the transit of French goods further afield. The turning-point, he thought, had come with the Tilsit agreement. It more than made up for the troublesome customs barriers in Prussia, which for years had trenched on the overland trade to the east. The Russian and Polish markets then seemed more open to French exporters than at any time before. Perier considered imperial producers well equipped to meet the technical challenge of Continental competitors in most major industries. Apart from some more advanced spinning machines in Berg and Switzerland and the mining pumps used in Upper Silesia, the Empire in his opinion was technologically superior to its vassals and allies. Here, ironically, he had to record the failure of one part of his mission. With the stated exceptions, he was not impressed

with the machine-models he had seen in Germany, and he thought it not worth while to have them brought to France for imitation.⁸⁰

The reports also gave encouragement on particular details of the French market design. Perier considered that the best prospects for imperial exports to Germany, Poland, and Russia lay with silkstuffs, luxury goods, fashion ware, and woollens of better quality. An expansion of the trade in raw silk, wines, *eaux-de-vie*, oils, and other agricultural products was also likely. Cotton exports had fair prospects, since most of the German states still imported the larger part of their domestic consumption. It was claimed indeed that 'Germany' imported two-thirds of its needs in yarn and other primary materials, by which Perier presumably meant sewing cotton and the various types of semi-worked cloth. Even Saxony, one of the states whose cotton industries were comparatively advanced, was understood to produce only half of its needs in yarn. How far imperial manufacturers took advantage of such opportunities, Perier thought, would stand in inverse relation to the Blockade's efficacy. He added that in other ranges of cotton and woollen products there would be stiff competition from the manufacturers of Berg, Saxony, Switzerland, and Prussia.

As for the regional targets of the market design, Perier held out little hope for the imperial export trade to the kingdom of Westphalia. While the Brunswick fairs were still far from moribund, and while French dealings at them might remain brisk, this was not where the market design had most promise. If the hoary textbook platitude that Napoleon aimed to create a 'bourgeois monarchy' out of Jérôme Bonaparte's Westphalian lands were true, the market potential of the new kingdom would have been rather more apparent to contemporary observers. Perier did not of course see the question in terms of that myth; nor could he have had the necessary archival and statistical detail to substantiate

⁸⁰ Cretet accepted this advice in his report to Napoleon of 13 Jan. 1808. Referring to the models Perier had studied abroad, he concluded that 'les collections d'Hanovre, de Gottingue, de Cassel, de Berlin, n'offraient rien qui put enrichir la conservation des arts et métiers de Paris, ni rien même qui approchât de cet établissement le plus complet sans doute de l'Europe'. A.N. AF*IV 174.

its falseness. Scholars this century have shown more convincingly what he could only assert: that the Westphalian economy was preponderantly agricultural. Helmut Berding's *Habilitationsschrift*⁸¹ clearly shows that land and old-style landlordism, not the middle-class ownership of urban property and capital, remained the basis of social pre-eminence in the new kingdom. Many of the land's resources moreover were either tapped for Napoleon's military use or made over to the private enjoyment of imperial *donataires*. More than any other area of the *Outre-Rhin*, the kingdom of Westphalia was geared to Napoleon's variant of 'fiscal feudalism', and the harmful repercussions on French exports there were soon felt.

Perier's reports amply confirm that the main market incentives in Germany came, as they had done for decades, from Frankfurt and Leipzig. He claimed that Leipzig bought more silkstuffs from Lyons each year than all other German towns taken together. He also specified which imperial towns had the best exporting potential in the *Outre-Rhin*. The choice is predictable enough: for silks and silkstuffs — notably the Lyonnais but also Avignon, Nîmes, and Saint-Étienne; for luxury and fashion ware — chiefly Paris; for woollens — Verviers, Eupen, Aachen, Louviers, Sedan, and Malmédy; for cottons — Paris, Rouen, Lille, Mulhouse, and the Belgian centres; for *siamoises*, lawns, cambrics, and other mixed articles — Cambrai and Valenciennes. This select list has some surprising omissions, such as the linen industry and secondary metallurgy, in both of which the manufacturers of the Rhenish left bank would have had an interest. Perier, of course, had already stressed the price advantage enjoyed by the linen producers of Brunswick, Silesia, and Saxony; but secondary metal output, or the whole industrial range included under *quincaillerie* and *dinanderie*, may well have had brighter prospects for export. The opportunities opened up to the textile towns of Aachen, Cologne, and Crefeld, furthermore, might have had closer attention in the reports. But whatever the type of goods or the principal exporting

⁸¹ *Napoleonische Herrschafts- und Gesellschaftspolitik im Königreich Westfalen 1807-1813*, Kritische Studien zur Geschichtswissenschaft, vol. vii (Göttingen, 1973).

towns of the Empire, Perier clearly saw the importance of Alsace as a transit zone for trade to the *Outre-Rhin*. Along with Mainz and Cologne, Strasbourg stood to benefit from the outgoing traffic by river and road, and, though Perier was less concerned with it, from the incoming transit trade through Germany as well.

During 1807 and the following years several similar industrial and commercial missions to Germany and other countries were undertaken by imperial agents. Héron de Villefosse, an engineer and the author of *De la richesse minérale*,⁸² visited a number of German states in 1807 with the aim of establishing how French metal mines compared with their European counterparts. He rated the annual value of 'French' (read 'imperial'?) output, estimated at some 100 million francs, as the third highest after the Spanish (222 million, of which 215 million worth was mined in the colonies) and the British (196 million).⁸³ The trade missions of Le Couteulx and Doăzan to Italy in 1807⁸⁴ were sequels to those of Isnard,⁸⁵ Thoron-Montirat, and Pommard in 1806-7.⁸⁶ A similar mission to Spain and Portugal was undertaken by Bardel in the autumn of 1807.⁸⁷ Of the more important later expeditions, Mottet de Gérando's assignment in 1810 was mainly to report on the showing of imperial exports at the Frankfurt and Leipzig fairs.⁸⁸ Equally, it was hoped that Marcel de Serre's mission to Germany and the Habsburg lands in 1810 would point to ways of increasing imperial exports there, although as a member of the Faculty of Sciences he was concerned chiefly with more technical

⁸² 3 vols. (Paris, 1810-19).

⁸³ Cretet's ministerial synopsis of 13 Jan. 1808: A.N. AF*IV 174. Héron de Villefosse also visited the grand duchy of Berg in 1809 on the request of Beugnot, its finance minister, and wrote full reports after his inspection of the mines there: A.N. AFIV 1225 and 1860.

⁸⁴ A.N. F¹² 535.

⁸⁵ Ibid. Illness interrupted Isnard's mission, whose aim was to survey French commercial prospects in the kingdom of Italy and to report on how the prohibitive decree of 10 June 1806 was working.

⁸⁶ Both the latter were directed to the kingdom of Naples: A.N. F¹² 535 and 622. Thoron-Montirat, a deputy of the department of Aude, was sponsored by the chamber of commerce in Carcassonne in an effort to boost the local trade in woollens to southern Italy.

⁸⁷ A.N. F¹² 509-10.

⁸⁸ A.N. AFIV 1061.

questions.⁸⁹ Catineau Larôche, who visited Switzerland in 1811, was preoccupied with the problem of smuggling along the inland frontiers and with possible remedies.⁹⁰ A final example is Lenoir's mission to Germany during the summer and autumn of that year.⁹¹ It was mainly a tour of industrial inspection of the Brunswick, Frankfurt, and Leipzig fairs. His aim was to study the position of British products and colonial re-exports before reporting back to the Minister Montalivet on methods of dealing with them. 'Monsieur Lenoir', the official instructions required, 'se formera une opinion appuyée de faits sur les moyens à prendre pour donner à notre Commerce et à nos Manufactures l'avantage sur le Commerce et les Manufactures de l'Étranger'.

All this evidence suggests that the momentum of the French market design was kept up well beyond the formative years 1806 and 1807. Like Perier's mission, the others were meant to establish useful facts about the Empire's international competitiveness and offer practical advice on ways of improving it. How two Rhenish departments fared under the economic regime of 1807-13, and how far their fluctuations were linked with the Blockade and the French market design, are questions which the remaining chapters attempt to answer.

⁸⁹ De Serre's reports cover a wide range of industrial branches (cottons, porcelains, mining, metallurgy, machinery) but the central *Bureau consultatif* took issue with their accuracy: A.N. F¹² 622.

⁹⁰ A.N. F¹² 535.

⁹¹ *Ibid.*

IV

INLAND ECONOMIC EXPANSION 1807-1810: THE ALSATIAN EXAMPLE PART I: SECTORS, GOODS, AND BENEFICIARIES

i. *Historiographical versions*

At the end of the period here covered an American witness, writing anonymously but easily identified as the publicist Robert Walsh, gave an account of the French Empire as he had seen it during a visit in 1807.¹ It was all very different from the spectacle he claimed to be able to record after similar travels in England. It told of the drying-up of business activity both internally and with foreign states, of the depopulation and decay of the major towns, of ramshackle commercial buildings, idle ports, and pervasive poverty. In Walsh's words,

. . . The state of France as it fell under my observation in one thousand eight hundred and seven exhibited quite another perspective [than that of England] . . . The effects of the loss of external trade were every where visible: — in the commercial cities half deserted, and reduced to a state of inaction and gloom truly deplorable: — in the inland towns, in which the populace is eminently wretched, and where I saw not one indication of improvement, but on the contrary, numbers of edifices falling to ruins: — on the high roads, where the infrequency of vehicles and travellers denoted but too strongly the decrease of internal consumption, and the languor of internal trade; and among the inhabitants of the country, — particularly of the south, — whose poverty is extreme, in consequence of the exorbitant taxes, and of the want of an outlet for their surplus produce . . . The number of mendicants in the inland towns was almost incredible . . . Agriculture languishes in almost every part of the empire . . . [in 1807] the fields were principally cultivated by women. . . .²

The author attributed such maladies to the fiscal chicanery of the imperial government and the wrongheadedness of its

¹ *A Letter on the Genius and Dispositions of the French Government, including a View of the Taxation of the French Empire, by an American recently returned from Europe* (London, 1810).

² *Ibid.* 189-92.



Alsace and the 'Outre-Rhin' during the Blockade (1810)

industrial and commercial policies. Some of his descriptions, along with other contemporary views of the same sort,³ are common in secondary works which focus on the Blockade's negative effects.

Walsh was however at best only a selective witness of the French economy in 1807. His *Letter* is regrettably thin in specific detail on the provinces he visited, and surprisingly few of the 'inland towns' often referred to are even mentioned by name. His overt polemical aim to present Napoleon in the worst possible light raises further doubts about his factual accuracy, and altogether one suspects that most of his impressions were gained from what he calls 'the best informed circles of Paris'.⁴ One may then ask what he would have found if, like the more inquisitive Nemnich, he had also taken his tourist's notebook to the eastern departments of the Empire. The short answer is: an economic spectacle rather different from that of the depressed coastal areas. Apart from the troubles in some industries after the Spanish insurrection of 1808, the period from 1807 to 1810 brought economic expansion to many inland parts of the Empire. The industries and trade of Paris, the Lyonnais, the Rhenish left bank, and Belgium developed quickly under the favourable conditions created by a fully protected home market and French ascendancy on the Continent. According to one authoritative account,⁵ French exports of cotton goods increased tenfold between 1807 and 1810, thanks to the enlargement of the Continental market open to them. Lévy-Leboyer adds that French silkstuffs, woollens, mixed textiles, secondary metallurgy, and luxury hardware also did comparatively well in those years.

Alsace was among the principal areas of that inland expansion. The primary and secondary sources alike present the period from the summer of 1807 to the autumn of 1810 as a prosperous one in the province. All the better-known writers on this period of Alsatian economic history seem

³ See for instance the sad pictures of the main French seaports (Le Havre, Nantes, La Rochelle, Bordeaux, and Marseilles) given by the Hamburg traveller P. A. Nemnich in 1809 in his *Tagebuch einer der Kultur und Industrie gewidmeten Reise* (8 vols., Tübingen, 1809-11), v-vi. 136, 144-9, 156 ff., and 316 ff.

⁴ *Letter*, 229.

⁵ Maurice Lévy-Leboyer, *Banques européennes*, 55.

agreed that there was a marked expansion of industrial and commercial activity in both departments, and that their agricultural performance was more than satisfactory. Some of these writers attribute the expansion to the impact of the Blockade or wider Continental System on the Empire's inland economies. Indeed, for the earliest among them, the happier fortunes of 1807-10 seemed indistinguishable from the benefits of Napoleonic rule more generally. One 'classic' statement of the optimistic case appeared a little over a decade after Napoleon's defeat. Written by Jean-Frédéric Aufschlager,⁶ it was based on personal recollections (or perhaps rather on fond nostalgia), and it was not obviously the sort of account that was likely to endear him to the Bourbon authorities. As his crude brush-strokes have been imitated by a number of other writers, it is worth considering what he had to say. Under Napoleonic rule, he contended,

L'ordre fut rétabli, le repos public maintenu; les lois étaient suivies; l'agriculture, l'industrie et le commerce florissaient . . . l'Alsace jouissait d'une paix profonde, tandis que le feu de la guerre dévorait les pays voisins . . . L'argent était dans une circulation perpétuelle et malgré les fortes impositions qu'on payait, l'aisance des habitants s'accrut; les terres, les maisons et les marchandises montèrent à des prix inconnus jusque-là. Ces avantages matériels, et la gloire qui rejaillissait des faits d'armes des guerriers français, empêchèrent beaucoup de gens de prévoir les malheurs auxquels le despotisme de Napoléon exposait la patrie, et leur firent même regretter son gouvernement après sa chute.⁷

Few of Napoleon's former supporters could have invoked their master's voice more generously during the Restoration. Bonapartism and its legends batted on such beliefs embellished by the lapse of time. Commenting on the economic effects of Napoleonic rule in Strasbourg some twenty years after its disappearance, Jules Sengenwald recalled the days when 'l'âge d'or semblait avoir fleuri dans l'enceinte de nos remparts'.⁸ He considered 1808 and 1809 the years of the city's greatest affluence.

⁶ *L'Alsace: nouvelle description historique et topographique des deux départements du Rhin* (2 vols., Strasbourg, 1826).

⁷ *Ibid.* i. 385-6. An equally optimistic passage from Aufschlager's *Souvenirs* is quoted at length in R. Reuss, *Histoire de Strasbourg depuis ses origines jusqu'à nos jours* (Paris, 1922), 379-80.

⁸ 'Aperçu historique et critique sur le commerce de Strasbourg, depuis la Révolution jusqu'à nos jours', *R. d'Als.* (old ser.), i (1836), 199-200.

More recent writers, of course, have not taken such accounts wholly at face value, rightly regarding them as naïve and larger than life. Yet these same historians generally agree that the first three or four years of the Blockade were a prosperous interlude in imperial Alsace. Paul Darmstädter singles out Strasbourg for special mention as perhaps the chief beneficiary of the shift of the trade routes inland towards the Continental interior. The city in his view enjoyed a 'colossal increase' of its commercial activity.⁹ Rodolphe Reuss considers those years as the optimum point of 'calm and material prosperity' after the 'feverish events' of the Revolution.¹⁰ Recovering from the earlier paralysis, Strasbourg's trade flourished once more, and Alsatian agriculture improved conspicuously, helped by the growing demand for industrial raw materials. According to Félix Ponteil, too, the Consulate and Empire gave Alsace an economic 'vigour' it had not known for many years.¹¹ He refers to a 'magnificent prosperity' and to Strasbourg's transformation from a 'Rhenish centre' into 'the emporium of the Continent'. It was at once the chief entrepôt for traffic between south-western and north-eastern Europe and a 'capital link' on the trade routes from the east to the French interior and vice versa. Never before, Ponteil claims, had so much business been concentrated there. Huge fortunes were made in a few years. The military markets, regular traffic by river and road, and of course incessant smuggling all contributed to the local prosperity. 'Le crédit n'a pas de limites, l'argent coule à flots. La richesse se répand partout.'¹²

Paul Leuilliot, one of the most prolific of modern writers on Alsatian history in the nineteenth century, radiates the same optimism. He accepts the claim made in a report by the Chamber of Commerce that Strasbourg was the channel through which exports from a third of French territory

⁹ 'Die Krisis von 1810/11', 577-8. A similar conclusion is argued in more detail in the last section of his 'Verwaltung des Unter-Elsass', esp. 665-7.

¹⁰ Op. cit. 377.

¹¹ These and the following details from Ponteil's works are a condensation of his main points in *Essai sur l'histoire de l'Alsace* (Strasbourg, 1937), 78-9; 'Les conséquences du Blocus continental dans la région rhénane et plus particulièrement à Strasbourg', *Revue du Rhin*, i (Aug. 1937), 9-10; and 'Jean-Georges Humann', in *Études strasbourgeoises*, 95-108.

¹² *Essai*, 79.

passed during the Blockade. At the same time, he says, the city handled a third of all French imports, with obvious benefits to the local middlemen and merchant carriers. He further argues, in my view mistakenly, 'that 1812 was the high-water mark of the city's trade under Napoleonic rule. On the other hand, one could hardly disagree with him that fortunes could be made more quickly and with less effort during the Blockade than under the Restoration, especially among dealers in colonial goods who knew the ropes of the smuggling trade. His point that the Rhenish area became the Continent's commercial centre of gravity during the Blockade is also fair. Ponteil even suggests that local prosperity is reflected in the faster rate of population growth in both Alsatian departments at that time.¹³

Fernand L'Huillier's findings, the most detailed for my period which have appeared so far, reinforce the same broad conclusion. Putting together the essential details of his major work¹⁴ and of an earlier article,¹⁵ one has ample evidence that Strasbourg grew enormously in commercial importance during the first few years of the Blockade but more especially in 1808 and 1809. It became the leading 'factorerie' between France, Germany, and Switzerland, and generally between northern and southern Europe. Having suffered for so long from the fierce competition of Mainz, it had a 'brilliant revenge' during the Blockade. By the nature of its entrepôt and transit traffic, and through the widening orbit of its trade dealings, it came to resemble an 'inland seaport'. Its commercial network reached out through many intermediaries to make contact with Bordeaux and thence with Portugal, with Sète, Aix, Marseilles, and Grasse, with Orléans

¹³ The details of the foregoing paragraph are a synthesis of Leuilliot's evidence in *L'Alsace au début du XIXe siècle. Essais d'histoire politique, économique et religieuse (1815-1830)* (3 vols., S.E.V.P.E.N., Paris, 1959-60), ii. 250-8; and 'L'Alsace en 1815', *R. d'Als.*, lxxv (1928), 67-8. The Chamber's report referred to is dated 12 Dec. 1813: Min. viii. Its estimate that a third of imperial trade passed by the Rhine through Strasbourg during the Blockade is also repeated in C. Schmidt, 'La France a-t-elle eu, au XIXe siècle, une politique économique en Alsace et sur le Rhin?', *Revue de Paris*, xxxi (1924), 555. Fuller details of the Alsatian population under Napoleon appear in Appendix L below, p. 294.

¹⁴ *Alsace napoléonienne*, 324, 328, 330 (for map showing Strasbourg's 'principal connections' within the Empire), and 331.

¹⁵ 'Le Rhin dans la France napoléonienne', 203.

and Paris, with Rotterdam and Amsterdam, with the Hanse towns, with Frankfurt, Leipzig, and Vienna. It acted as the 'dynamo' (*moteur*) of a European trade properly so called. The year 1808 marked the 'wonderful renaissance' of Strasbourg's commercial life, in the measure that the Rhine became the crucial artery of European trade. A revival of the river and road traffic between Nimwegen and Basel reinforced the city's prosperity by enriching its leading houses of commission and merchant carriers.

Now, if my own research broadly squares with those conclusions, it obliges me to add several substantial qualifications. Some of the more rapturous accounts cited above need dilution. The difficulty of generalizing satisfactorily for the period of the Blockade as a whole is plain, and chronological distinctions are essential. One also needs to distinguish between the different regions of Alsace and between its main industrial and commercial branches. Finally one should ask how far Alsatian prosperity, such as it was, can be directly attributed to the effects of the Blockade. Some of the writers named earlier have been too quick to explain the local economic expansion in terms of the Blockade, and in any case they often exaggerate the affluence. They have presumed rather than proved that the prosperity seeped through to the popular masses below the undoubtedly fortunate commercial élite. The aim of this and the next chapter is not only to illustrate and so far as possible quantify the earlier conclusions advanced for the period 1807-10, but also to qualify them and analyse the links between the Blockade and the economic performance of Alsatian trade and industry in those years.

ii. *The descriptive evidence of the Chamber of Commerce in Strasbourg*

According to the official descriptive record of the Chamber's minutes, there would seem to have been few definite signs of commercial improvement in the city much before the spring of 1808. The routine reports for the first half of 1807 are as gloomy as ever, and no doubt the dragging on of the Continental war well into the summer gives them some

conviction. As the trade routes were still under that threat, most merchants were understandably loath to take unnecessary risks. Large-scale commercial dealings with the *Outre-Rhin* in all but the most essential consumer goods or in military provisions were resumed only after the treaties of Tilsit.¹⁶ Yet the Chamber's minutes for the second half of 1807 give little explicit evidence that the tide was turning in favour of local trade. Its reports refer to the familiar 'stagnation' and 'decadence' as late as December. Such routine statements were not backed by detailed facts, however; and if the minutes for the second half of 1807 are taken as a whole, they seem far less plaintive than those for the earlier years. From that half-year to the summer of 1810 they are refreshingly sparse in the kind of protest and petitioning which consumes so much space in the earlier minutes.

This comparative lack of protest is surely significant in itself. The Chamber had always taken the trouble to record local grievances in detail and with a self-conscious sense of its paternal responsibility. Just as it had never been slow to give local anxieties maximum publicity, so it was not in the habit of advertising happier fortunes indiscreetly. On the latter point prudence urged silence, since too much conspicuous success might attract the government's fiscal attention. The generally less miserable reports might then suggest, tacitly and by implication, that trade was improving. This hunch is strengthened by the minutes for 1808, which are more notable still for their relative absence of jeremiads and the worn old catch-phrases of woe. Two types of business dominated the meetings that year. One was the hardy annual of Strasbourg's commercial relations with Mainz and Frankfurt; the other was the internal organization and functioning of the Chamber itself. Both were set in the context of implied commercial improvement.

Some of the chamber's reports for 1808 refer to an expanding trade more explicitly. As in 1807, there were no serious local bankruptcies to speak of, and larger sales on the military market following the return of the troops were often

¹⁶ Between the Empire and Russia on 7 July, between the Empire and Prussia on 9th.

noted. On several occasions it was acknowledged that Strasbourg was well equipped, by both position and local expertise in the carrying trade, to take advantage of rising exports to Germany. But there were two prerequisites, as the Chamber noted in its report to the prefect Shée of 1 March:¹⁷ the Rhine freight charges had to be kept as low as possible, and tariffs in the Confederation had to be prevented from handicapping imperial exports there or the transit trade to parts further east. In another report of 23 May the Chamber gave its first detailed account of marked improvement at the entrepôt.¹⁸ It noted an increase in the export of wines and *eaux-de-vie* from the Midi. Champagne and burgundies passing through Strasbourg were also selling better abroad than in previous years. Levantine cotton had arrived in greater quantities, in spite of customs delays along the overland routes.¹⁹ The most conspicuous progress had however been made in that broad sector of trade referred to in the report as 'la navigation du Rhin'. Current traffic exceeded all earlier expectations. Instead of the normal dispatches to Mainz and Frankfurt every ten days, the barges were leaving after only five. Their cargoes were also bigger. As against the usual load of between 1,400 and 1,900 metric quintals, each barge then carried from 3,000 to 4,000 metric quintals. On this *prima facie* evidence, the sheer volume of traffic through the city had quadrupled by comparison with preceding years.

One ironic effect of the commercial expansion in Strasbourg was that existing entrepôt facilities at the *halle commerciale* were soon found to be inadequate. As the Chamber observed in the same report of 23 May, all efforts to create more space and improve services had not stopped the congestion at the entrepôt. The increase in expeditions had apparently been so sudden and extraordinary that we here strike a quite different sort of economic problem. Having followed the Chamber's earlier complaints of not enough commercial activity, we are now confronted with

¹⁷ A.D. (B-R) XII M 6.

¹⁸ *Ibid.*

¹⁹ The imperial decree of 9 June 1808 channelled the import of Levantine cotton through Strasbourg and two Italian towns according to the system of *certificats d'origine* and consular verification of goods in the Levant laid down on 23 Nov. 1807: papers in A.N. F¹² 533; meeting of 25 June 1808, Min. iii.

something rather like a traffic jam in the city. It was so rare for the Chamber to feel able to record a glut of trade that one must infer a dramatic turn of fortune during the early months of 1808.

The only two branches which did not fit the pattern of steady growth that year were the hemp and linen trade and the traffic in colonial goods. In the first case the continuing ban on exports of the raw material held back its production. In the second, prices followed a variable course. The over-all performance of both branches was satisfactory, however, and each had brief periods of expansion. Hemp and linens began the year poorly but recovered later. The Chamber's report for the third quarter noted that they had actually 'succeeded' as a result of wider sales in the French interior, the Midi, and Italy.²⁰ Strasbourg's trade in colonial goods made a reverse showing. It was quite active during the first half of 1808,²¹ but then dropped off sharply in the second.²² The rise in prices during the earlier half was due to increased orders from Paris. The goods were described as of 'permitted origin', but in fact the label was often false, for much of the trade was in contraband which had filtered through the customs cordons. Sugar, coffee, and pepper were in most demand, but the slump in prices during the latter half of the year was put down to the wider availability of such goods in other imperial towns. It is also likely that the Spanish insurrection and the rupture in Franco-American relations upset the earlier speculative prognoses. Some of Strasbourg's industries undoubtedly felt the effects of the new uncertainty in the supply of transmarine primary materials. Most of the dyers, for instance, ran short of indigo and cochineal and were forced to suspend work during part of the summer.²³ Yet, taking 1808 as a whole, the Chamber counted dealings in colonial goods among the main currents of the city's growing entrepôt traffic.²⁴

The same quarterly reports for 1808 point to sustained

²⁰ Report to Shée of 6 Oct. 1808: A.D. (B-R) XII M 6.

²¹ Reports of 1 Mar. and 23 May 1808: *ibid.*

²² Reports of 5 Aug. and 31 Dec. 1808: *ibid.*

²³ Reports of 5 Aug. and 2 Sept. 1808: *ibid.*

²⁴ Retrospective report of Apr. 1809: meeting of 24th of the month, Min. iv; A.D. (B-R) X M 3.

expansion in other major commercial and industrial branches. Tobacco output was up by a third on the level of 1807, and the leading processing enterprises responded well to higher demand. The cotton spinners and manufacturers of nankeens had a productive year, again in spite of a short interruption during the third quarter. Woollens sold well in commercial as well as in military markets. Wines, *eaux-de-vie*, and other agricultural products continued to pass through Strasbourg in large quantities. Levantine cotton expeditions were bigger and more frequent. Altogether, 1808 was the best year local merchants had known under Napoleonic rule. Looking back on it in April 1809, the Chamber confirmed this assessment.²⁵ It stated that no detailed balance of trade for the year could be given but that the city had prospered during it. It seems likely that these more cheerful reports were matched by actual performance at the entrepôt.

* * *

On the whole 1809 was a better year still. Indeed; enough evidence in the Chamber's records and in other sources supports the conclusion that it was the *annus mirabilis* of Strasbourg's trade during the whole Napoleonic period. Traffic through the entrepôt then reached its zenith. Local merchants remained, at least for official purposes, largely silent and so presumably content. In its report of 8 April²⁶ the Chamber noted the recurrence of an earlier embarrassment. The city's entrepôt facilities were said to be still unequal to the volume of goods passing through it. Imports of Levantine cotton had made a sudden spurt, because merchants had anticipated the war with Austria and hastened to stock up supplies before it broke. The export trade in wines and *eaux-de-vie* had grown so much that the routine for inspecting and dispatching cargoes was clogged. The *halle commerciale* was stacked with uncleared goods destined for either side of the frontier. The Chamber appealed for permission to shorten and speed up the unloading procedures so as to ease the stoppage. It pressed in particular for the

²⁵ Retrospective report of Apr. 1809, *ibid.*

²⁶ Meeting of the same date, Min. iv.

urgent dispatch of cotton expeditions to Paris, since the volume of imports was expected to increase.

The Chamber's detailed report of 24 April, referred to earlier, made many of the same points. It is also interesting for its mentioning of tobacco and colonial goods among the expanding commercial branches. Local trade had been stimulated by what it referred to as the 'extraordinary circumstances' then current. The greater commercial pressure which preceded the Wagram campaign was certainly one of these. It is possible that the Chamber was alluding also to the reorientation of trade routes from the coast towards the inland entrepôts. Or again, it might have been thinking more of the favourable power structure of the Grand Empire and of the developing French market within it. This last interpretation fits the Chamber's meaning best of all, perhaps, as it went on to say that Strasbourg's trade to the *Outre-Rhin* had been the main stimulus to expansion.

The Wagram campaign intrudes into the local records on many occasions during the summer of 1809, but it is not clear whether traffic through Strasbourg was much affected by the hostilities. Fargès-Méricourt thought that it was, but that it soon regained momentum after the peace of Schönbrunn, signed on 14 October.²⁷ The Chamber's own report for the third quarter suggests however that the effects had been minimal.²⁸ It stated that the transit trade, especially expeditions to northern Europe, had remained 'very active'. On this point the Chamber is probably the better guide. The Wagram campaign was comparatively short, and in any case most of the hostilities did not straddle the major trade routes in the Rhenish Confederation. The mood in Strasbourg throughout was more circumspect than depressed. The firm of Sautier & Cie informed Briensiaux of Lille when the uncertainty began that 'les affaires qui s'étoient un peu ralenties [*sic*] par l'espoir d'une paix viennent reprendre peu à peu plus d'activité'.²⁹ 'Tout prend ici un aspect guerrier très formidable', it added, 'et il ne nous reste que la presque certitude de voir incessamment commencer les hostilités'.

²⁷ *Annuaire du Bas-Rhin* for 1810, 255-6.

²⁸ A.D. (B-R) X M 3.

²⁹ Letter of 5 Apr. 1809: A.N. 3 AQ 339.

What actually followed recalls the tense anticipation of the outcome of Tilsit in 1807. Just as then, the incidence of speculative buying counteracted the natural tendency to restraint in the local market.

Developments elsewhere in the Empire also boosted Alsatian dealings during the spring and summer of 1809. Sautier wrote to the same correspondents on 30 May that 'nous croyons le moment propice, pour spéculer sur les cotons; si les vaisseaux américains ne sont pas admis, ce qui est très vraisemblable,³⁰ on verra reprendre les cotons [from the Levant] avec fureur'.³¹ According to this letter, Strasbourg was then an advantageous market for raw cotton, which was selling between 60 and 100 per cent more cheaply than in Paris. René Leroux's correspondence with Briensiaux that year also supports the evidence of brisk dealings in this branch during the summer. On 29 September he wrote that 'malgré qu'en général, il y ait beaucoup de calme, les cotons font bonne contenance et paraissent devoir se maintenir à un prix raisonnable'.³² Less than a fortnight later he informed the same correspondents that there was 'rien encore d'officiel relativement à la paix, quoique tout le monde la croie signée. En attendant les affaires restent calmes'.³³ In general, the Briensiaux papers for 1809, which deal with several merchant houses of Strasbourg, suggest brisk trade in spite of the war.

This conclusion is amply supported by one of the most enthusiastic reports of the expansionary period. Writing to the prefect on 5 August,³⁴ the Chamber quite explicitly linked Strasbourg's commercial prosperity with the reorientation of trade routes under the impact of the Blockade. The key passage reads as follows:

Les circonstances de la guerre et le Blocus des ports ont amené au plus haut point d'activité quelques unes des branches d'affaires que la localité de cette ville lui assure constamment à un degré inférieur. Notre place est devenue le comptoir presque exclusif des exportations qui s'effectuaient une partie par mer, pour le Nord et la Russie; et

³⁰ A reference to Napoleon's likely reprisals, which in fact followed on 18 July, against American shipping which had been allowed to flout the Blockade laws in Holland that spring.

³¹ A.N. 3 AQ 339.

³² Ibid.

³³ Letter of 11 Oct. 1809: *ibid.*

³⁴ Meeting of 16 Aug. 1809, Min. iv; A.D. (B-R) X M 3.

*celui d'arrivage pour les denrées coloniales venant de la Hollande et du Nord et pour les cotons de Macédoine*³⁵ . . . La sûreté et le bon ordre de la navigation marchande sur le Rhin, de Strasbourg à Francfort, est une des causes les plus actives qui attirait cette expédition vers notre port.

Several of the leading themes of this book are illustrated here. During the first three or four years of the Blockade, Strasbourg benefited where the maritime ports did not and, more pointedly, *because* they could not. It lay at the hub of the inland trade routes which linked France with the subject and allied states. On this evidence it was one of the beneficiaries, perhaps even the main beneficiary, of the Blockade's effects on some inland regional economies during the expansionary period.

* * *

The year 1810 was on the whole more variable for Strasbourg's trade, and the last quarter at least was fraught with upsets. Yet the first half and perhaps also the third quarter remained satisfactory over all. Some commercial branches like chemical products and (after the government's export concessions) grain sold well abroad. The performance of other branches was more irregular. Sales of Levantine cotton, for instance, were brisk during the first quarter. Sautier informed Briensiaux in a letter of 28 January that 'Paris nous assaille de commandes qu'on ne peut remplir et offre des prix très avantageux.'³⁶ By the summer, however, the incoming trade had dropped in volume. In its report of 20 July for the second quarter³⁷ the Chamber put this down to reduced demand from the French interior, especially from Paris, and to Russian troop movements during the preparation for war with Turkey, which had temporarily halted the expeditions from the Levant and pushed up the price of stocks in Vienna.³⁸

A fall in the volume of trade in colonial goods passing through Strasbourg also occurred during the second quarter

³⁵ Italics mine.

³⁶ A.N. 3 AQ 339.

³⁷ A.D. (B-R) XII M 8.

³⁸ Sautier had noted the same problem in a letter to Briensiaux of 10 Apr. 1810: A.N. 3 AQ 339.

of 1810. On 4 May Sautier informed Briensiaux that 'les affaires sont toujours encore très calmes s[ur] n[otre] place, et il n'y a pas la moindre demande s[ur] les denrées coloniales'.³⁹ The main reason for this, according to the same observers at the end of the month,⁴⁰ was that competing sales of colonial goods in Antwerp had temporarily attracted Parisian clients. So, too, Alsatian tobacco sales in the Midi dropped during the second quarter, while exports of this commodity had suffered from competition on the right bank and were then largely confined to Switzerland.⁴¹ Evidence of similar trouble in the tobacco trade lower down the left bank is provided by the house of Lentz the Younger of Frankenthal, in the old Palatinate. Writing to Briensiaux on 9 May,⁴² it noted that:

la récolte de l'année dernière . . . donnait un bon tiers moins que celle de 1808. Outre cela il y a eû des endroits où la feuille est de mauvaise qualité; . . . de sorte que la belle et bonne marchandise est rare, et que par cette raison les prix ne peuvent que hausser par la suite.

. . . Beaucoup de tabac s'est gâté sur le cas de fermentation, parce qu'il contenait trop d'eaux; c'était le même cas en Alsace, ce qui détermina nombre des négocians à Strasbourg de faire leurs provisions dans nos contrées tant en feuille pour carottes que pour la pipe . . .

In its report of 20 July the Chamber in Strasbourg gave an equally disappointing account of the local wine trade: the spring sales had not matched those of the previous year.⁴³ In 1809, it went on, there had been one minor bankruptcy in the department; during the first half of 1810 alone there had been five more serious ones.⁴⁴ 'En général', the Chamber concluded, 'il y a stagnation dans les affaires'.

The same refrain was taken up in later reports that year. On 2 August the new prefect, Lezay-Marnésia,⁴⁵ repeated

³⁹ A.N. 3 AQ 339.

⁴⁰ Letter to Briensiaux of 31 May 1810: *ibid.*

⁴¹ Chamber's report of 20 July 1810: A.D. (B-R) XII M 8.

⁴² A.N. 3 AQ 276.

⁴³ A.D. (B-R) XII M 8.

⁴⁴ For details of the bankruptcy of 1809, see A.D. (B-R) XII M 7.

⁴⁵ The prefecture of Baron P.-A.-F.-M. Lezay-Marnésia, Shée's successor at Strasbourg, lasted from Feb. 1810 to Oct. 1814. The best work on him is E. von Westerholt, 'Lezay Marnesia Sohn der Aufklärung und Präfekt Napoleons (1769-1814)', *Mainzer Abhandlungen zur mittleren und neueren Geschichte*, vol. ii (Meisenheim am Glan, 1958), 195-227. For details of the family, see the volume by the prefect's brother, the comte A.-M.-C. de Lezay-Marnésia, entitled *Mes Souvenirs à mes enfants* (Blois, 1851).

the evidence of decline in the local tobacco trade.⁴⁶ He also noted the closure of all but one of the city's sugar refineries, adding that the cause was the inaccessibility of supplies from overseas. On 18 October the Chamber concentrated on the problem of financial embarrassment among some of the merchant commissioners.⁴⁷ The decree of 22 February 1810 had doubled the duty on chemical products of non-colonial origin and seriously disrupted Strasbourg's import trade from the Rhenish Confederation. Worse still, the decree was being interpreted as a prohibitive measure by customs officials and indiscriminately extended to other goods. And so, alas, after a kind of moratorium lasting nearly three years, we are back with the old chorus of complaints. During the first half of 1810 the language of protest was restrained; during the second, accompanied by a new spate of petitions, it was again in full cry. Once more the central issue during the short hiatus between the expansionary period and the economic crisis of 1810-11 was the status of Strasbourg's entrepôt and transit facilities. It would be unduly pessimistic, though, to rely on the official reports as balanced accounts of what was actually happening at the *halle commerciale*; for while the protests and petitions were frequent, the Chamber referred on several occasions to commercial blockage during the third quarter of the year. It was apparently unaware of the irony here, as such congestion had been more familiarly the effect of the earlier commercial expansion.

Furthermore, many of the letters and petitions which emanated from the Chamber during the late summer and autumn of 1810 were less concerned with illustrating 'la stagnation des affaires' than pressing for more liberal trading rights. Certain political events and modifications of economic policy make the Chamber's requests seem more tendentious still. One of the appeals, soon repeated in its correspondence with the central and local officials, concerned Strasbourg's trade links with Holland after the annexation of that country to the Empire in July.⁴⁸ It asked for much more freedom in

⁴⁶ Report to Montalivet: A.D. (B-R) III M 3.

⁴⁷ Report to Lezay-Marnésia: A.D. (B-R) XII M 8.

⁴⁸ Letters to Montalivet, Collin de Sussy (director-general of customs), Lezay-Marnésia, and Magnier-Grandprez: meeting of 16 Aug. 1810, Min. v.

the carrying trade to and from the new imperial departments. It stressed the new prospects opened up by the annexation and, after 5 August and 17 September, by the Trianon tariff and its supplement. The prefect's support was solicited and as usual soon won.⁴⁹ Since the tariff and its supplement considerably widened the range of permissible imports, though at the cost of swingeing increases in the duties, one can appreciate the Chamber's impatience to see Strasbourg's economic role as a *lieu de passage* formally improved. In technical terms its request was that article 53 of the determining *arrêté* of 8 Floréal XI should be extended to all classes of goods allowed by the tariff. In the same way the Strasbourgeois were anxious not to be excluded from any commercial favours which might follow on the French marriage alliance with Austria of February 1810. They also sought concessions for easier trade dealings with the Hanse towns and neighbouring coastal regions after their annexation took effect at the beginning of 1811.

iii. *Statistical evidence of expansion in the Bas-Rhin*

It is simpler to state the descriptive record of commercial expansion in Strasbourg during the years 1807-10 than to quantify it. The official statistics for the period are disappointing in many ways. They were normally drawn up after administrative delays, sometimes a year or more after the periods for which they were supposed to be a current record. They were usually incomplete and often self-contradictory. Many do not square with the detailed retrospective surveys included in tabular form at the end of the Chamber's minute-book for 1813.⁵⁰ In seeking to analyse and interpret this material, one works with frequent

⁴⁹ Lezay-Marnésia to Montalivet, 22 Aug. 1810: A.D. (B-R) XII M 48.

⁵⁰ These are much too full and officially presented to be dismissed out of hand, but in my view they are unsatisfactory. They diverge, often greatly, from the quarterly reports for earlier and particular years, and they sometimes make nonsense of the Chamber's own descriptive summaries. My preference in this chapter is for the statistical reports most contemporaneous with the periods to which they refer. But since a number of earlier writers appear to have based their findings on the retrospective surveys of 1813, the latter are reproduced for comparative purposes in Appendices B and E below, pp. 276-7 and 283 respectively.

frustrations. Clearly, however, an attempt should be made to use it, for otherwise terms like 'expansion', 'growth', 'increase', 'decrease', 'improvement', 'decline', 'rise', 'fall', 'stagnation', 'crisis', and many others adopted in this study will have little substance.

The fullest statistics for the expansionary period apply to 1808 and 1809. The details of the prefectoral report dated 22 July and of the Chamber's report to Shée on 5 August 1809 offer us a rough guide to the commercial scale in question.⁵¹ Since these figures were printed without qualification in the *Annuaire du Bas-Rhin* for 1810,⁵² they were presumably considered officially acceptable. The total volume of Levantine cotton which passed through Strasbourg in 1808 was given as 9,000 metric quintals, and between 30 and 40 Alsatian carters were engaged in that branch of overland trade. Total road haulage or *roulage*, that is the carrying trade by land in and out of Strasbourg in all commercial branches, was put at 82,500 metric quintals that year. Nearly three-quarters of this (60,000 metric quintals) consisted of wines, and well over a sixth (15,000 metric quintals) of *eaux-de-vie*. Some 330 carts drawn by four horses apiece were employed in this traffic, which came mainly from Burgundy and the Midi. The two reports are unfortunately not as detailed as one would like on the trade in colonial goods. All the first records here is that during 1808 the Strasbourg merchant houses handled about 4,700 metric quintals of unrefined sugar and an equivalent amount of coffee and pepper. It is not even clear whether the latter were intentionally included under *roulage* or featured rather as a detached part of river traffic.

Such details are just one sample of the kind of problem constantly presented by the official statistics. In this case there is an obvious discrepancy between the given total of 82,500 metric quintals for *roulage* and the sum of the figures for the individual branches apparently composing it. If one takes the prefect literally at his word and doubles the figure of 4,700 metric quintals to gain a presumptive total for

⁵¹ A.D. (B-R) X M 3. Shée's account is based on the Chamber's report of the preceding 24 Apr.: *ibid.*, and Min. iv.

⁵² See p. 256 of that volume.

unrefined sugar, coffee, and pepper, then along with the respective data for wines, *eaux-de-vie*, and Levantine cotton there is an over-all total of 93,400 metric quintals for road traffic in 1808. Therefore either the earlier estimate of 82,500 metric quintals is incomplete, which is probably so since the specified branches of *roulage* can hardly have been the only ones active that year, or else the particular components are assessed too generously. But again, if one discounts the presumptive 9,400 metric quintals of unrefined sugar, coffee, and pepper on the grounds that they were much more likely to have been a branch of river than of road traffic, the remaining total of 84,000 metric quintals is not widely discrepant from the earlier one.

Within such limitations, the statistical record for 1809 points to a signal expansion of the carrying trade through Strasbourg. It is true that the cited report of 5 August referred to a continuing decline in imports of colonial goods during the first half of 1809. This is consistent with the contemporary statistical evidence of Eichhoff, director-general of the Rhenish octroi, as shown in Table 4.

Table 4. Strasbourg's imports of colonial goods 1807-1809*
(metric quintals)

Up river from	1807	1808	1809
Mainz	86,111	42,053	17,527
Frankfurt	?	7,934	7,102
TOTAL	86,111+	49,987	24,629

*SOURCE: J.-J. Eichhoff, *Topographisch-statistische Darstellung des Rheines, mit vorzüglicher Rücksicht auf dessen Schifffahrt und Handlung* (Cologne, 1814), 16; cited in Paul Darmstädter, 'Die Verwaltung des Unter-Elsass unter Napoleon I.', 667 n.

As Table 5 below further shows, the biggest drops were recorded in Eichhoff's figures for imports from Mainz of coffee, tobacco, unrefined sugar, and refined sugar.

Now, it must be stressed that the declining figures here noted applied only to legitimate trade. There was of course a lucrative contraband traffic in colonial goods throughout the expansionary period. The same August report by the

Table 5. Strasbourg's imports of colonial goods from Mainz 1807-1809 (metric quintals)*

Type of goods	1807	1808	1809
Coffee	10,805	563	—
Tobacco	12,783	5,018	660
Unrefined sugar	15,330	5,632	—
Refined sugar	19,831	4,950	362

*SOURCE: the same as for Table 4.

Chamber in Strasbourg was prudently silent on this, but it noted a large increase in the export trade in wines, *eaux-de-vie*, and other agricultural products (fruit, vegetables, oils) during the first half of 1809. The figure recorded is 70,145 metric quintals, which was already fast approaching the combined total for 1808 discussed earlier. The data on imports of Levantine cotton show an even sharper rise. The estimated 18,000 metric quintals for the first half of 1809 already represented twice the earlier total for the whole of 1808. Fernand L'Huillier, presumably by doubling this half-yearly return, concludes that Strasbourg's trade in Levantine cotton was four times greater in 1809 than in 1808.⁵³ He may well be right. Apart from the Chamber's evidence of stockpiling before the war with Austria, the primary sources copiously confirm that the progress of the imperial cotton industries during the expansionary period after Tilsit depended on raw materials from the Levant. This was especially so after the rupture in Franco-American relations and the troubles in the Iberian peninsula during 1808, which together undermined the supply of trans-Atlantic cotton. Montalivet felt able to inform Napoleon on 2 July 1810 that 'le fonds de notre fabrication roule sur les cotons du levant'.⁵⁴

While Strasbourg remained the principal imperial inlet for Levantine cotton until the government enforced a switch of route in 1811, this trade did not follow an even course. There were sharp fluctuations in price over the year, due to seasonal vagaries of supply. The quotations which Sautier regularly sent to Briensiaux, reproduced graphically in Figure

⁵³ *Alsace napoléonienne*, 327.⁵⁴ Report on the Easter fair in Frankfurt: A.N. AFIV 1061.

2, illustrate the point. On this evidence the highest levels were reached in August–September 1809; in March–May, July–August, and November–December 1810; and February–March 1811. The steep rise to the peak of October–December 1810 is almost certainly explained by Sautier's need to recoup the cost of much stiffer import duties after the introduction of the Trianon tariff. The marked drop of April–July 1809, notwithstanding a brief upturn in June, was probably

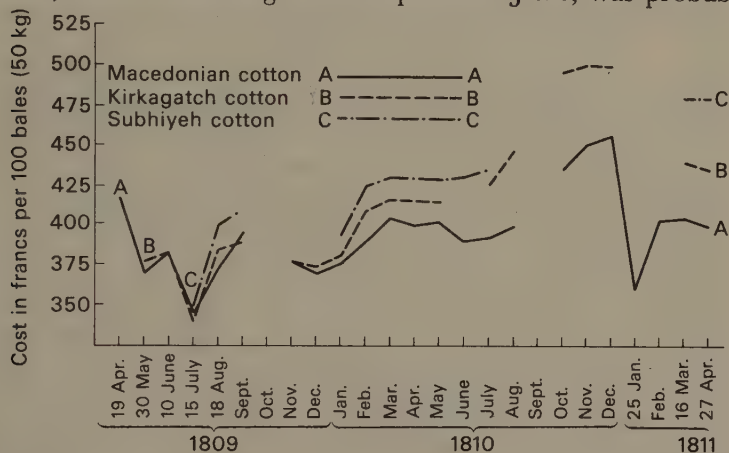


Fig. 2. Monthly fluctuation of the price of Levantine cotton in Strasbourg (April 1809–April 1811)*

(SOURCE: current prices in francs per 100 bales or 50 kg. quoted by Sautier & Cie of Strasbourg in its correspondence with the house of Briensiaux of Lille: A.N. 3AQ 339.)

*Average monthly prices unless otherwise specified; no prices quoted for October 1809 and September 1810.

linked with fears of war and Sautier's wish to clear out old stocks before his speculative purchase of new ones. The sudden and extreme fall of prices in January 1811 was a symptom of the worsening economic crisis, in this case of glutted stocks. The short-term fluctuations which characterized the trade through Strasbourg in Levantine cotton during the Blockade played into the hands of speculators and smugglers and implied considerable reserves of 'risk money' or accessible credit. If the bonanza of 1809 and most of 1810 suggests that these were readily available, the sudden crop of casualties early in 1811 well demonstrates the hazards of

such trade. Similar fortunes overtook the Alsatian trade in colonial goods during the expansionary years. Since only a small fraction of these imports was consumed locally, commissioners relied heavily on orders from the French interior, especially from Paris. Clients there might suddenly default if other entrepôts offered a better market, as the cited instance of rapid sales in Antwerp in April-May 1810 nicely illustrates.⁵⁵

* * *

Whatever the improvement of road traffic through Strasbourg during the expansionary period, the city's major advances were realized in its river trade with Mainz and Frankfurt. The official statistics, more particularly those compiled in 1810, happily give us rather more to go by in this than in the overland sector. By far the most important single document is the Chamber's report of 23 February 1810, whose verbatim transcript covers twenty-eight pages of the minute-book.⁵⁶ It was addressed to Bérigny, the chief engineer of the department, in reply to his *questionnaire* on the city's shipping. It contains much illuminating material on the practical routine and legal technicalities of Strasbourg's river traffic, but here it is the statistics which matter most. The Chamber confined itself to the large-scale merchant shipping to and from Mainz and Frankfurt. In other words, its figures relate only to the operations of the members of the official barges' Associations. Any additional traffic undertaken in smaller craft up and down the Rhine between Switzerland and Strasbourg, or by the military transports down river, was specifically excluded. So was the whole network of river-borne contraband trade, by its nature secret, unrecorded, and so, unfortunately, unquantifiable.

In terms of its restricted focus, then, the Chamber reported that 24 Strasbourg barges had made a total of 37 return voyages to Mainz and Frankfurt during 1808, while 11 Mainz barges had made the return journey to Strasbourg once each. In 1809, the same Strasbourg barges had made 75 such journeys and the Mainz barges 12. The frequency of dispatches had thus apparently doubled among members

⁵⁵ See above, p. 163.

⁵⁶ Meeting of the same date, Min. v.

of the local Association in 1809, each of whom then made at least three return journeys to Mainz and Frankfurt. No comparable figures for the whole of 1810 appear in the official records, but one can round off the picture for at least the first half of that year from later evidence.⁵⁷ During that period the Strasbourg barges made 32 down-river journeys to Mainz and Frankfurt and 17 laden journeys up river.⁵⁸ This would imply that the dispatches were less frequent than the half-yearly average for 1809 but still well up on the corresponding figure for 1808, which was itself known to be an improvement on the position in 1807. Thus so far as any conclusion may be drawn from these simple statistics, 1809 was the high-water mark of Strasbourg's river trade during the expansionary period.

There is further evidence of this in the Chamber's supplementary figures for the volume of traffic in question. According to its report of 23 February 1810, the official returns were complicated by the incidence of what it called '*un transport de territoire en territoire*'. This was a form of transit trade up and down the Rhine valley, whether by the river or land routes or both it is not always clear. The Chamber stated that the value of such traffic could not be reckoned precisely but that in earlier times it had been worth around 2 million francs a year to Strasbourg alone. Its value during the expansionary years was presumably higher, especially if illicit trade is also taken into account; but in default of explicit evidence to that effect, this is no more than a reasonable guess. 'In any case, the '*transport de territoire en territoire*' was not included in the Chamber's figures of 23 February, which are reproduced as they stand in Table 6 below, along with some discrepant figures from the minutes of earlier meetings. Even on the basis of such restricted statistical evidence, the growth of Strasbourg's down-river trade during 1808 and 1809 was colossal. It fits the Chamber's earlier reports of more frequent dispatches and larger cargoes at that time. It is a fair conclusion that local

⁵⁷ Report of 9 Aug. 1810: meeting of the same date, Min. v; and A.D. (B-R) XII M 8.

⁵⁸ Details of voyages made by the Mainz barges (if any) are not given in the report.

Table 6. Strasbourg's river trade 1806-1809 (metric quintals)

Year	Up river		Down river		Total river traffic
	Strasb. barges	Mainz barges	Strasb. barges	Mainz barges	
1806	16,314	8,135	56,175	22,797	103,421
1807	32,470	15,874	74,253	26,445	149,042
1808	19,137*	10,791	136,217*	48,333	214,478
1809	17,038†	10,248	196,197†	37,030	260,513

*Cf. the figures of 14,965 up river and 92,275 down river recorded for that year in the Chamber's minutes for the meeting of 24 Apr. 1809: Min. iv; A.D. (B-R) X M 3; *Annuaire du Bas-Rhin* for 1810, p. 256. If these are preferred, the adjusted total for 1808 is 166,364 m/q.

†Cf. the figures of 27,286 up river and 233,227 down river recorded for that year in the Chamber's minutes for the meeting of 13 Feb. 1810: Min. v. If these are preferred, the adjusted total for 1809 is 307,791 m/q.

SOURCE: Chamber's report of 23 Feb. 1810 to the chief engineer Bérigny, Min. v.

merchants took full advantage of the favourable market opportunities in the *Outre-Rhin*. Those of Mainz did less well in the up-river traffic but, relative to their own much smaller share of down-river traffic, maintained a higher volume in 1808-9 than in 1806-7.⁵⁹

The statistics on Strasbourg's trade during 1810 are not as full as those for the preceding two years, and, such as they are, show huge discrepancies. On 2 August, for instance, the Chamber gave an assessment of 122,015 'old quintals' (i.e. 50 kg units) for down-river and 18,549 for up-river traffic during the first half of the year.⁶⁰ This is equivalent to 61,007.5 and 9,274.5 metric quintals respectively. If one doubled these figures to arrive at a presumptive total for the whole year, and also then compared it with the estimates

⁵⁹ Fernand L'Huillier's figures (*Alsace napoléonienne*, 326-7) confirm the drop in Strasbourg's legitimate imports from Mainz between 1807 and 1809, and they also show how the Alsatian entrepôt gained as an exporting port over Swiss rivals at that time. A more general decline in the river trade of Mainz during those years, after a fairly brisk expansion in 1802-6, is noted in K. G. Bockenheimer, 'Mainzer Handel und Schifffahrt in der Zeit von 1648-1831', in *Der Zoll- und Binnenhafen zu Mainz* (Mainz, 1887), 31-2 (tables based on the statistical evidence of Bodmann and Eichhoff).

⁶⁰ Meeting of the same date, Min. v.

in the report of 23 February 1810 (Table 6 above), it would appear that 1810 was commercially less active than any of the three preceding years but still appreciably more active than 1806 and earlier years. Just a week later, however, the Chamber quoted the trade in specifically the Strasbourg barges as 53,681.5 metric quintals down river and 8,364.5 up river during the first half of 1810.⁶¹ Here then, if the comparison is made with the half-yearly averages derived from the figures under 'Strasbourg barges' in Table 6, 1810 would appear less active than 1809 and 1808 but more so than 1807 and 1806. The available statistics, whether of annual or half-yearly totals, can lead to a number of divergent impressions.

Further examples of this are easily found. In a retrospective report of 10 November 1812 to the mayor Brackenhoffer, the Chamber gave monthly trade figures for the whole period from January 1809 to June 1812.⁶² These, which have the merit of close detail and of being actual rather than inferred estimates, show that during 1810 the Strasbourg barges carried a total of 164,008 metric quintals down river and 11,935 up river. The totals carried by the Mainz barges that year were respectively 43,042 and 16,856 metric quintals. If the figures cited in Table 6 are again taken as the basis of comparison, by that reckoning 1810 was a better year for Strasbourg's river trade than any before 1809, and indeed it falls not far short of this, the *annus mirabilis*. Yet even that conclusion is not altogether clear, because the foregoing figures should be compared with those given in an appendix to Hugo Haug's history of the Chamber, as reproduced below in Table 7.⁶³ Purportedly drawn from the Chamber's own records, these figures extend beyond the expansionary period under discussion in the present chapter. Although their details for 1811-13 would seem more appropriate in a later chapter, they necessarily intrude here in a particular way. In places, but not indeed without some

⁶¹ Meeting of 9 Aug. 1810: *ibid.*; A.D. (B-R) XII M 8.

⁶² Meeting of 21 Nov. 1812, Min. vii. The details are fully reproduced in Appendix D (below, pp. 281-2) and graphically incorporated in Appendix E (below, p. 283).

⁶³ The table is an extract from the full appendix of figures for 1807-68 (*op. cit.* 70-2) and for 1892-1903 (*ibid.* 69).

Table 7. Strasbourg's river trade 1807*-1813 (metric quintals)

Year	Up river	Down river	Total
1807	48,031	101,111	149,142
1808	31,463	176,509	207,972
1809	30,719	183,261	213,980
1810	28,688	210,630	239,318
1811	24,102	215,531	239,633
1812	52,822	221,784	274,606
1813	13,742	105,276	119,018

*The author wrongly claims that earlier figures are lacking in the Chamber's records. Apart from those which I have used in preceding pages, the Chamber's estimates of 1813 (reproduced in my Appendix B below, pp. 276-7) go back as far as the Year V (Sept. 1796).

SOURCE: Hugo Haug, *Die Handelskammer zu Strassburg i. E. 1803-1903* (Strasbourg, 1903), 72.

sizeable discrepancies elsewhere, they roughly correspond to the Chamber's full table of figures for the Year V-1813, as recorded in its minute-book for the latter year and as reproduced in Appendix B. They appear to have been quite widely used by earlier historians, and yet in one important respect they differ from other statistical evidence which I have preferred. They point to a continuous growth of Strasbourg's river trade from 1807 to 1812, which appears as the peak year under Napoleonic rule, before the catastrophic decline of 1813, when the Blockade fell apart and the military crisis of the Empire undermined commercial traffic almost everywhere along the Rhine. If the Chamber's estimates of 1813 and those in Haug's appendix held good, they would be telling evidence against any real economic crisis in Strasbourg's trade in 1810-11, and would also point to much more than hard-won recovery in 1812.

Now, my own findings certainly confirm that 1812 was a good year for the city's river trade, but equally they leave me in no doubt of the reality of the crisis which began late in 1810. Nor, given the comparative sparseness of the official trade figures for 1812, can one lightly dismiss the more detailed evidence that 1809 had been the peak year under Napoleon. Paul Leuilliot, a respected authority, does so in

effect, but without any elaboration.⁶⁴ Fernand L'Huillier, another such authority, uses figures that also do not square altogether with those in the Chamber's own minute-books. He offers, for example, a few annual totals which seem to be based on the monthly figures for goods described as 'les arrivages de marchandises nationales et étrangères, par terre, sur l'Ill et par le Rhin'.⁶⁵ By that criterion they are purportedly the sum of Strasbourg's regular incoming and outgoing trade. They show a rise from 112,569.56 metric quintals in 1806 to 134,333.72 in 1807, and to between 190,000 and 200,000 in 1808. The estimate for 1809 is said to be 'the same' as the entry for 1808, and the monthly fluctuation shows that peak traffic was usually reached between May and July each year. These estimates for total traffic fall well short of those for the city's river trade alone, as set out in my statistical tables above. It should also be stressed again that all these estimates are for *legitimate* trade. If one tried to add in speculations for the smuggling trade, in spite of the hopeless task of quantifying it even approximately, the *prima facie* evidence would support 1809 rather than 1812 as the peak year under Napoleon. The former year was notorious for contraband dealings everywhere along the inland frontiers and the coastline, helped by the absence of the troops on the Wagram campaign. The latter was a year of comparatively tight customs surveillance, following the Fontainebleau decree of October 1810, and the clamp-down did not relax until the French military disaster in Russia.

Yet however one scores the fluctuation of Strasbourg's entrepôt trade during the first four years of the Blockade, all available statistics point to a signal expansion from the summer of 1807 to that of 1810. It is equally clear that the down-river expeditions in Strasbourg barges formed the major sector of regular traffic. And of this sector, the key branch was the export trade to Frankfurt, as Table 8 briefly illustrates. Judged in terms of volume, wine was the main

⁶⁴ His figure of 149,000 metric quintals for Strasbourg's river trade in 1809 (*Alsace au début du XIXe siècle*, ii. 252) is taken from G. Haelling's statistical data in *Deux Siècles d'Alsace française: 1648, 1798, 1848* (Strasbourg/Paris, 1948), 289, and is, of course, much too low. The accompanying figure of 274,600 metric quintals for 1812 consequently distorts the fluctuation of that trade during the Blockade.

⁶⁵ *Alsace napoléonienne*, 331.

Table 8. Destination of Strasbourg's down-river trade in 1808 and 1809 (metric quintals)

	1808	1809
Volume of total traffic:	182,938	268,339
Of which to Frankfurt	102,842	144,290
To other ports on the Main	11,181	44,187
To Mainz	35,716	24,871
To ports between Strasbourg and Mainz	16,139	36,685
To Mannheim	17,060	18,306

SOURCE: Eichhoff, *Topographisch-statistische Darstellung des Rheines*, 15; cited in Darmstädter, 'Die Verwaltung des Unter-Elsass unter Napoleon I.', 666 n.

article of trade. Of Eichhoff's totals above, it made up 96,640 metric quintals in 1808 and 146,644 in 1809, more than half in each case.⁶⁶

iv. Industrial expansion in the Haut-Rhin

The Blockade and the French Continental market design offered the Haut-Rhin manufacturers similar opportunities for progress during the expansionary period. Though the evidence (and especially the statistical evidence) is more fragmentary than for the Bas-Rhin, it is apparent that the main industrial enterprises of the other Alsatian department strengthened between the summer of 1807 and the autumn of 1810. Explicit signs of this began to appear in official reports during the course of 1808, in spite of a brief industrial slack during the latter half of that year, as elsewhere in the Empire. With this one exception, industrial output was on the upward trend at least until the last quarter of 1810, when the first ominous warnings of a new crisis were given.

Again the official records have to be approached with caution. The reports from Sainte-Marie-aux-Mines, for instance, speak of 'progressive stagnation' well into 1808.⁶⁷ But since the local consultative chamber had long been in the habit of sending woeful accounts of its hardships to the

⁶⁶ Op. cit. 666 n.

⁶⁷ See e.g. the report of the town's consultative chamber to Desportes dated 20 May 1808: A.D. (H-R) I M 126a/1.

prefect in Colmar, there is a suspicion that it was protesting too much. A more substantial example of industrial trouble in the department is Desportes's prefectoral survey of 8 September 1808,⁶⁸ which shows a sharp drop in employment levels in all branches by comparison with 1805-6. The later figures are clearly incomplete, however, and their retrospective indices for 1805-6 do not square with more contemporary estimates for that time.⁶⁹ Employment levels are in any case not necessarily an index of production or of productivity. Even if one accepted them as reliable, they would offer no firm case for lower industrial output as such, since mechanization advanced notably during the period. Paul Leuilliot's figures for industrial employment in the department,⁷⁰ which are similar to those given in the *Annuaire du Haut-Rhin* for 1812,⁷¹ show no long-term decline but quite the reverse. The totals are: 56,700 in 1805-6; 49,000 in 1807; 40,800 in 1808 ('incidence de la crise'⁷²); and 59,400 in 1810, before the real crisis broke. Of the last total, about 44,000 workers (nearly three-quarters) were employed in the various cotton industries, and of these some 22,000 (37 per cent) worked in or near Mulhouse. According to the same source, the Haut-Rhin's total industrial employment at the start of 1811 had trebled by comparison with 1786, a rate of growth which obviously outstripped the natural increase in population. The estimates which Desportes sent to Montalivet in June 1811, reproduced by Fauchat and Costaz in their summarized report of the following 20 July,⁷³ broadly resemble those above, but with one important difference. Of the given total of 59,418 workers spread out in

⁶⁸ 'État du nombre des individus occupés dans les fabriques, manufactures, forges et martinets existant dans le département du Haut-Rhin en 1808', based on the earlier (and evidently incomplete) reports for each *arrondissement*: A.D. (H-R) IM 127/1.

⁶⁹ Drawn up on 1 May and 3 July 1806 and kept respectively at A.D. (H-R) I M 119/1 and 136/3. For a detailed discussion of their statistics see above, pp. 85 ff.

⁷⁰ *Alsace au début du XIXe siècle*, ii. 377.

⁷¹ See p. 247 of that volume.

⁷² Leuilliot's reference here is very likely to the *frisson* which unsettled the cotton industry and its trade services after the government's ban on the export of yarn (16 May) and raw cotton (21 May) and which intensified the conflict between spinners and weavers. A.N. F¹² 533; Dufraisse, 'Politique douanière de Napoléon', 20-2.

⁷³ A.N. F¹² 1583.

the department's 290 'workshops' (*fabriques*) in 1810 — again the mass of rural and part-time spinning and weaving 'establishments' is excluded from the latter figure — no less than 30,000 were said to be employed in or near Mulhouse.

Unfortunately, no industrial or commercial centre of the Haut-Rhin has a continuous record of short-term economic developments to match the minute-books of the Chamber in Strasbourg for my period. The local archives in Mulhouse are particularly disappointing in their coverage of specifically Napoleonic data. The official consultative chambers (*chambres consultatives des manufactures, fabriques, arts et métiers*) set up in Mulhouse and Sainte-Marie in 1806 more or less met the requirement to send quarterly reports to the prefect, but they did so in a repetitive and rather inadequate way. There is in consequence no accessible statistical basis on which to chart the total volume or value of industrial output there, or anywhere else in the department for that matter. In general, the official record consists of sundry local fragments and inadequate departmental synopses.

One such, dated 15 February 1808, was a report by the president of the trade tribunal in Belfort to the prefect.⁷⁴ He claimed that the local industries had increased production by at least one-twelfth in 1807 compared with the preceding year. Just how he could have worked out his calculation so finely in default of specific details (and his report is thin in them) is a little mysterious. While the figure seems far from excessive, perhaps one should regard the estimate as a metaphor to express expansion. The president named cottons as the main growth-point, but he added that some drop in output was expected in view of the current uncertainties in the supply of primary materials. According to another report, the industrial growth-rate elsewhere in the Haut-Rhin was considerably higher during the same period than the estimated 8 per cent in Belfort. It was written by Gaspard Dollfus for the *arrondissement* of Altkirch, which included Mulhouse, and was sent to the prefect on 29 February 1808.⁷⁵ It gave every indication of good industrial headway during the preceding three quarters. It particularly mentioned the advance

⁷⁴ A.D. (H-R) I M 128/1.

⁷⁵ Ibid.

of cotton spinning in Masevaux, Lutterbach, and Bollwiller, before the blow of the May decrees of 1808 struck them. Cotton weaving, particularly the production of semi-finished articles for calico-printing, was said to have 'increased prodigiously' in Mulhouse, in its environs, and in the valleys of the Vosges. Calico-printing itself, the crucial industry of the *arrondissement*, had twenty-six large enterprises in full activity. This marked an increase of four on the previous count, and sixteen of the firms were based in Mulhouse. All had done better during 1807 than in preceding years, and the recent winter production had been generally high. The manufacturers were said to be optimistic about their prospects for 1808. In other words, the rather anxious forecasts of the leading *indienneurs* during the prefect's industrial survey of April-May 1807⁷⁶ had not apparently materialized. The expansion in Mulhouse had been achieved in spite of a trebling of raw cotton prices from the summer of 1807 to the following spring, itself due to stiffer import duties and some re-export from the Empire as foreign demand, especially in Switzerland and on the Rhenish right bank, attracted stocks. The favourable domestic market and the return of peace on the Continent had more than compensated for higher industrial costs. Gaspard Dollfus linked the expansion directly with the Blockade's regime and also emphasized how important the incentive of the imperial '*marchés réservés*' in the kingdom of Italy was becoming.

For other industrial branches in the *arrondissement*, according to the same report, 1807 had also been a satisfactory year. Expansion in the woollen industries had not matched that in cottons, but output had held steady, with outlets in Switzerland and Italy as well as good markets at home. 'Nos draps', the report said, 'sont un vrai article d'exportation'. The producers of silk ribbons in Mulhouse, Guebwiller, and Altkirch were 'in full production', although sales had so far been confined to local markets. The paper industries had increased output and exported well. Iron production in the Vosges had been steady, and again there had been a little export to Switzerland to add to the major

⁷⁶These are discussed in detail above, pp. 98 ff.

sales on the home market. The same broad pattern held for the acids industry in Thann. Clock-making had been less successful, it appeared, since the prefect referred to its current 'stagnation', but even then exports were still leaving for northern Europe and the Levant. The only industrial branch reportedly in serious trouble was tanning, in which manufacturers had been battling against the exorbitant cost of South American leather for several years.

The evidence for economic growth in Mulhouse, the key industrial centre of the Haut-Rhin, was confirmed by the consultative chamber in optimum terms three months later.⁷⁷ The drift of the following passage seems unmistakable:

La chambre se félicite de pouvoir vous en faire un tableau plus satisfaisant, que n'étoit celui de 1806 et 1807. Nous ne connaissons aucune branche qui n'ait fait des progrès marquants et aucune qui ne fleurisse. Tous les ateliers, n'aguerre à demi déserts, refluent à présent d'ouvriers, notre ville regorge d'habitans, toutes les avenues présentent des maisons nouvellement bâties, les propriétaires obtiennent de leurs logemens des loyers très élevés, des établissemens et des ateliers nouveaux sont établis dans les communes qui nous environnent, des ouvriers étrangers viennent peupler nos villages et y chercher une subsistance qu'ils ne trouvoient plus dans leur patrie . . . Tous profitent et bénissent le gouvernement dont les mesures sages et vigoureuses font revivre le commerce et l'industrie.

Even allowing for the official lip-service at the end here, this is a document of quite unusual optimism. Since the hard-headed industrial magnates of the Haut-Rhin were no more disposed to exaggerate happier fortunes than their commercial brethren in Strasbourg, it is safe to say that such optimism was matched by actual prosperity in Mulhouse.

The same report was equally clear on points of detail. By far the most conspicuous progress had been made in calico-printing. The chamber spoke of its 'full activity', of more workshops starting production, and of an 'easy market' for old stocks as well as new articles. Merchants from Germany and Italy had come to Mulhouse to buy or place orders for goods which they had previously obtained from Britain. As the primary materials for *toiles peintes* had to be secured largely within the Empire, the home weavers had also

⁷⁷ Report to Desportes of 12 May 1808: A.D. (H-R) I M 128/1.

enjoyed a brisk trade. The report noted that the manufacturers of plaincloth (*toiles blanches*) were expanding output on a scale they had not reached for many years. That indeed was why Swiss and other foreign dealers were turning to the Haut-Rhin for supplies, why some of them actually had trade depots in Mulhouse,⁷⁸ and why the immigration of skilled workers was then so active.⁷⁹ If such business continued, the chamber remarked, the finest Swiss weaving crafts would soon be 'naturalized' in Alsace. Even *siamoises*, that object of so much ostensible distress at Sainte-Marie, had sold well in Mulhouse during the first half of 1808. The output of woollens had held good; so had the manufacture of silk ribbons and floss-silk. The tanneries, at last, had also found the going easier during the second quarter of the year and, apart from the branch specializing in *maroquineries*, had 'an easy market'. 'En général', the report concluded, 'la situation actuelle de notre commerce et de nos manufactures est telle que nous ne saurions désigner aucuns besoins, aucuns moyens d'amélioration'. This happy account was confirmed about a year later by P. A. Nemnich, the German traveller. After a visit at the height of the expansionary period, he wrote that 'whoever saw Mulhouse ten years ago and sees it again at this moment would imagine himself in a quite different locality, so much has the town and its neighbourhood increased in population, new houses, large manufactories, busyness (*Lebhaftigkeit*), wealth, and luxury'.⁸⁰

The Mulhousiens were apparently eager to link their prosperity with the effects of the government's economic policies. The local consultative chamber, in the cited report of 12 May 1808, roundly declared that: 'Nous devons cet état de prospérité aux vûes profondes et sâges de notre immortel Empereur. Dans sa volonté suprême il fut résolu que, non seulement toutes marchandises étrangères seroient

⁷⁸ Permission was given to several merchants from Basel and other foreign towns to set up depots in Mulhouse during 1808 and 1809, as recorded in the documents kept at Arch. comm. Mulh., F^{II} Cb 6-7.

⁷⁹ A contributory factor here was the decree of 19 Feb. 1808 which required of applicants who owned or managed large enterprises only one year's domicile in France before naturalization. Several Swiss and German craftsmen, it appears, came to the Haut-Rhin — 'rive d'attraction' — in this way.

⁸⁰ *Tagebuch*, viii. 151.

écartées de nos frontières, mais aussi que tout le Continent s'approvisionneroit dans les manufactures françaises, *et cela est.*' This seems a fairly explicit statement of the French market design. If it is to be believed, the Empire was indeed developing into the 'workshop of Europe'. Even if allowance is made for the ingratiating tone of the chamber's report, the objective world to which it referred was enjoying better times.

The official reports are not as clear as might be hoped on the question of whether or not the Haut-Rhin was much affected by the brief industrial disturbance discernible elsewhere in the Empire during the second half of 1808. The reality of this out-of-phase downturn, caused partly by the Spanish insurrection and partly by the government's new ban on certain cotton exports in May, is not to be doubted. In a detailed study Louis Bergeron has shown, for instance, how employment and output in the small to middling cotton industries of Paris dropped between 1 May and 1 November that year.⁸¹ Now Alsace was relatively remote from the ructions of the Spanish insurrection, but as a frontier province with traditional trading outlets in Switzerland and across the Rhine, it was fully exposed to the shock of the May decrees on cotton exports. And yet the primary evidence is far from conclusive on this point. Dollfus-Mieg & Cie apparently had no need to tighten its belt in 1808. According to an estimate by the mayor of Mulhouse,⁸² the company bought 24,000 articles from the local weavers for conversion into *toiles peintes* during the first eight months of the year. With its own supplies added in, total output during that period was 46,000 articles, nearly a quarter of the 200,000 articles which were estimated as having been manufactured in the town in those eight months. Looking back on his earlier success from a point in the middle of the economic crisis of 1810-11, Dollfus-Mieg lamented his lost profits.⁸³ He recalled his prosperity during the preceding ten years, 'c'est-à-dire depuis l'époque heureuse de la régénération de l'industrie française'. No mention is made here of any set-backs before

⁸¹ *Banquiers, négociants et manufacturiers parisiens*, ii. 583-4.

⁸² Arch. comm. Mulh., FII Cb 1.

⁸³ Letter of 4 May 1811 to Collin de Sussy: A.D. (H-R) I M 126a/1.

the current crisis, so that presumably he had maintained production during the latter half of 1808 and throughout the next two years. Why else should he have hailed Collin de Sussy as 'l'ange tuteur des fabriques françaises'?

The prefectural reports for 1809 also make little fuss about any industrial set-backs during the preceding year. Indeed in the spring Desportes could claim that both the spinning and weaving industries had multiplied 'with striking rapidity during the last few years'.⁸⁴ The government, in issuing the decree of 16 May, had justified the prohibition of yarn exports partly on the grounds that the spinners had done well in preceding years and that it was necessary to help the weavers at a time when supplies of yarn were short. On the other hand, the ban was lifted by the decree of 30 January 1809,⁸⁵ though export duties were to be levied, and the spinners had resumed their sales to foreign clients by the time Desportes made his report to Paris. His accompanying tables moreover show a quite sizeable drop in weaving in the department during the second half of 1808, which was inconsistent with the aim of the May decrees, and ironically the statistics for spinning show a slight rise over those months.⁸⁶

Again, however, the key indicator of industrial momentum in the Haut-Rhin was calico-printing, and I have found no solid evidence in the prefectural statistics of any marked arrest of the expansionary trend during the second half of 1808. Fernand L'Huillier believes that the department's export trade in *toiles peintes* (not, of course, an index of over-all production) fell during the summer of 1808.⁸⁷ In his view the Italian market for these products had been 'conquered' between the spring of 1806 and the spring of 1808.⁸⁸ It was during 1807 that the houses of Pionniers and of Dollfus-Mieg extended their dealings with Milan, where in due course the latter acquired the firm of Kraemer & Cie, and later with Rome. The other leading *indienneurs* of the department, the Wesserling firm of Gros, Davillier,

⁸⁴ Letter of 29 Apr. accompanying the detailed departmental tables for the cotton industries dated 18 Apr. 1809: A.N. F¹² 1561.

⁸⁵ On the following 22 Dec. the import of cotton yarn, conditionally allowed since 3 Thermidor X (22 July 1802), was strictly forbidden: A.N. F¹² 533; Dufraisse, 'Politique douanière de Napoléon', 22.

⁸⁶ A.N. F¹² 1561.

⁸⁷ *Alsace napoléonienne*, 367.

⁸⁸ *Ibid.* 370.

Roman & Cie, furthered their Neapolitan connections mostly during the first half of 1808. In 1809, according to one secondary source,⁸⁹ this firm produced 75,000 printed calicoes of 17 *aunes*⁹⁰ apiece, well over a quarter of the departmental total for the year.

If L'Huillier is right in thinking that the downturn in the export of printed calicoes came chiefly after the spring of 1808, and that their major expansion had come during the two preceding years, the manufacturers' own reports during the important survey of April-May 1807⁹¹ would be in doubt. These, more often than not, had testified to decline and in some cases total suspension of exports to Italy. I am reluctant to dismiss such detailed and repeated evidence lightly, for it seems much more likely that the main push into Italian markets during the expansionary period came between June 1807 and June 1808. But L'Huillier is sounder on the point that the Haut-Rhin's exports to the kingdom of Italy slackened as from July and especially from October 1808.⁹² If the prefectural records show that Dollfus-Mieg continued to trade there during this tapering-off period, most other interested *indienneurs* found the kingdom a less easy market during the next two and a half years. They had to wait until the imperial decree of 10 October 1810 gave it a new lease of life by creating a still more favourable '*marché réservé*' there. It is certain that the expansion of the Haut-Rhin's calico-printing industry in the years 1807-10 rested mainly on the back of the large imperial home market.

* * *

The structure of that market, which was based on intricate financial links as well as on distribution-points for goods in centres of demand, at once involved merchant houses in many other French towns. It was indeed precisely these far-flung interrelationships which multiplied and intensified professional embarrassments when the crisis of 1810-11 struck.

⁸⁹ E. Zuber, 'Jacques-Gabriel Gros', 148.

⁹⁰ An article of 17 *aunes* measured 20.23 metres.

⁹¹ A.D. (H-R) I M 127/1, discussed above, pp. 98 ff.

⁹² *Alsace napoléonienne*, 393-4; 'Deux siècles d'exportation textile haut-rhinoise', 113-14.

Outside Alsace, Paris was the largest single market for the principal cotton products of the Haut-Rhin. The best example of close professional associations was that between Gros, Davillier & Roman and the Parisian houses of Gros, Davillier & Cie and Jean-Charles Davillier. Jacques Bidermann of Paris was also a sleeping partner (*commanditaire*) of the Wesserling firm. Rousseau & Bertin of Paris, which before the Year XII had traded as Jean-Joseph Rousseau, served as a *dépôt de vente* for Dollfus-Mieg.⁹³ The close commercial and financial links of several Alsatian houses with Swiss partners or associates should also be stressed here. One may even speak of a Basel-Mulhouse-Paris 'axis' for cottons during the expansionary period.⁹⁴ One case was that of Blétry of Belfort, whose son, already established in Paris, formed a new firm in Mulhouse with another member of the family in 1810. Another was Dagenet, who had interests in Basel, Belfort, and Vesoul, as well as a depot for muslins in Paris.⁹⁵ The house of Jacques-Louis Pourtalès l'aîné of Neuchâtel similarly had dealings with a number of Alsatian and more especially Mulhouse firms.⁹⁶

What these links between Alsatian and Parisian firms could mean in terms of capital resources, production, and employment levels is well illustrated, though on a scale too large perhaps to be typical, by Gros-Davillier of Paris.⁹⁷ Its affairs were chiefly concentrated on the international trade in *toiles* and *indiennes*, for which it took a sizeable business on commission, but it also functioned as a commercial bank. Besides those vested in the Wesserling enterprise, it had important financial stakes in five manufactories in the Vosges. These were situated in Saint-Amarin, Bavilliers, Giromagny, Gritt, and Orbey, and at the beginning of 1811 they had a combined capital value of 1.2 million francs. What Bergeron calls the 'social capital' of the Parisian house had increased from 2.2 million francs in 1802 to 4.4 million in 1811. Its importance is borne out by the fact that the imperial

⁹³ Bergeron, *Banquiers, négociants et manufacturiers parisiens*, ii. 452-3.

⁹⁴ 'Entre Bâle, Mulhouse et Paris, le roulage des toiles, parfois associé à leur commerce proprement dit, est soigné par des maisons qui s'en font une spécialité.' Ibid. 455.

⁹⁵ Ibid.

⁹⁶ Ibid. 505-20.

⁹⁷ The details of the following paragraph are a digest of the matter in Bergeron, op. cit. 551-2.

government was willing to advance it loans totalling some 5.6 million francs, the largest made to any commercial house in France at that time, and which were repaid by the end of 1814. The production of its 'group' (that is all its associates) in 1810, at the peak of the expansionary period, amounted to 150,000 kg of cotton yarn (*filés*), 25,000 articles of plain-cloth (*pièces de toile écrue*), and 60,000 to 70,000 printed calicoes.⁹⁸ The provisioning of the 'group' required an annual outlay of between 3.5 and 4 million francs. The stock of finished products kept in the depots in Paris, Mulhouse, Bordeaux, and Brussels was worth around 2 million francs a year in normal times, but in 1811 it rose to 5 million. At the start of that year its credits, based on ten-month or twelve-month terms for the delivery of goods, were approaching 3 million francs, at a time when its commitment to employees' salaries stood at about 150,000 francs a month, or 1.8 million a year.

The manufacturers of the Haut-Rhin also had important trade links with towns on the west coast and in the south of France. Jean-Jacques Hémardinquer's survey of this network is a useful short introduction.⁹⁹ Whether directly or through associates like Gros, Davillier & Cie of Bordeaux, the Alsatian houses concerned dealt regularly with firms in Saint-Malo, Niort, La Rochelle, and Rochefort, and with others in Toulouse, Montpellier, and Beaucaire. For example, the correspondence of Étienne and F. Charruyer of La Rochelle between June 1807 and July 1813 shows that they made sizeable orders of shawls ('*schals*') from Henri Schlumberger & Koenig of Mulhouse. They were also regular clients for check handkerchiefs (*mouchoirs à carreaux ordinaires*) from the Mulhouse firms of Gaspard Dollfus & Cie and Huguenin l'aîné. At Rochefort and Niort, the evidence of sales during 1808 suggests that articles described as '*tarnatannes*' (*sic* — ? '*tarlatanes*' or muslins) were in most demand and that Gros-Davillier of Bordeaux were agents for the transactions. In Beaucaire, notwithstanding the declining importance of

⁹⁸ All totals show a very considerable increase on the respective entries for the Wesserling firm itself in May and November 1808: A.N. F¹² 1561.

⁹⁹ 'Marché français des indiennes'. The following paragraph is based chiefly on pp. 314-20 of this essay.

its fairs,¹⁰⁰ other items from Alsace like '*boréas*' (otherwise described as '*mousselines rayées de l'Inde*') still had a market.

Hémardinquer also found that the calendar for placing orders for Alsatian printed calicoes in these western and southern towns closely followed that on which contracts were settled. The wholesale merchants who handled the expeditions favoured mid-April and the month of October for bulk deliveries. It seems, however, that suppliers in Mulhouse had to be on their guard against late orders from clients whose earlier prosperity had faded with the progressive loss of re-export markets overseas. One gathers, too, that the quality of articles supplied was not always as good as expected. The demand for the products of Mulhouse from southern clients was greater than that from the western seaboard towns, itself no doubt a sign of the eclipse of the Atlantic coast as a commercial pace-setter. The order-books of Médard and Parlier, merchants dealing in fine cloth in Montpellier and Toulouse, reveal important links with certain Alsatian firms or their associates: Jean-Charles Davillier of Paris; Gros, Davillier & Roman of Wesserling (for *mignonettes*); Vetter, Thierry & Grossmann of Mulhouse (for scarves); Heilmann père, fils & Cie of Mulhouse, represented at Beaucaire by one Hofer; Haussmann frères of the Logelbach; and Dollfus-Mieg of Mulhouse, whose output was recognized as of good quality but '*horriblement cher*'.¹⁰¹

* * *

All the primary and secondary accounts stress that improved techniques and the use of better machines were vital to the success of the Haut-Rhin's printed calicoes. Cylinder printing was widely extended after its first appearance in Mulhouse in 1805, and the technical headway also extended to other branches. Spinning in particular was boosted by new and improved devices. During the expansionary period the main development was the steady replacement of the old and largely obsolete *rouets* and *fuseaux* by 'mule-jennies' and

¹⁰⁰ The best account of this topic is Jean Vidalenc, '*Départements méditerranéens pendant l'Empire*'.

¹⁰¹ Hémardinquer, *op. cit.* 317 ff.

water-frames of more recent vintage. Although spinning by the older type of throstles (*continus*) was still common in the department, by the end of 1808 there were, in the prefect's description, five large '*fabriques mécaniques*': in Mulhouse (Blech, Fries & Cie), Wesserling (Gros, Davillier & Roman), Masevaux (Nicolas Koechlin & Cie), Bollwiller (Zürcher fils & Lischy Dollfus), and Lutterbach (Hollenweger & Cie).¹⁰² The first steam-driven machine in the department was introduced by Dollfus-Mieg in 1812.¹⁰³ Two ancillary branches of calico-printing in which there was accompanying improvement were industrial dyeing and designing. The chemical industries serving them had good incentives, particularly for the preparation of artificial colourings, but the shortage of transmarine dyestuffs remained an obstacle to the designers themselves.

In cotton weaving, machines were not used on any comparable scale much before the 1820s. Looms of the British type were almost unheard of for practical purposes before then, although the principle of the fly-shuttle and even some crude adaptations of it for industrial use had been known in Mulhouse for some years before the expansionary period. The norm, however, was the old-fashioned handloom. There is some implied evidence that its capacity, if not its basic efficiency, was increased during the period and that this was linked with the success of calico-printing and the constant demand for primary materials (*toiles blanches à imprimer*) thus generated. This inspired the weaving enterprises of the department to quadruple their total output in 1808 as compared with the 21,760 articles they had produced in 1806.¹⁰⁴ It appears that the increase was due less to any notable advance among the small and scattered rural establishments than to the development of ancillary workshops within the larger calico-printing enterprises themselves. Dollfus-Mieg, Gros, Davillier & Roman, Lhuillier frères,

¹⁰² A.D. (H-R) I M 127/1; Lévy, *Industrie cotonnière en Alsace*, 159.

¹⁰³ Besides Lévy, op. cit., the mechanization of the Haut-Rhin's cotton industries is discussed in Mathieu Mieg, 'Résumé des notes laissées par M. Hartmann-Liebach sur l'histoire industrielle du Haut-Rhin, depuis les premières années du XIXe siècle', *Bull. Soc. ind. Mulh.*, xlvii (1877), 218-35.

¹⁰⁴ L'Huillier, *Alsace napoléonienne*, 365. The figure for 1806 is from Desportes's report to Champagny of 17 Jan. 1807: A.N. F¹² 1568.

Thierry-Mieg & Cie, Schlumberger-Koenig, Paul Blech, and Zürcher & Cie all had weaving installations to help feed the printing tables which formed their main industry. In this way the dependence of the *indienneurs* on primary materials from other imperial towns was reduced, but the department's weaving capacity still fell far short of the annual requirement of some 250,000 *toiles blanches*. If the *indienneurs* no longer needed to turn elsewhere for all but one-eleventh of their needs, as in 1805-6,¹⁰⁵ supplies from within the Haut-Rhin itself could satisfy only about a third of their over-all demand at the height of the expansionary period.

* * *

The financial network of the Haut-Rhin's cotton industries had two main lubricants. One was capital accumulation within the largely Calvinist *fabricantocratie* itself, reinforced by family partnerships and marriages. *Autofinancement*, or the systematic reinvestment of profits in the enterprise which produced them, was a traditional means to its expansion.¹⁰⁶ The other factor was the crucial role of financial creditors. The Haut-Rhin had financial connections with several other imperial towns, though it now seems not as many with Paris as might be suggested by the individual examples noted earlier.¹⁰⁷ The main external source of finance was undoubtedly Basel, with tributaries from other Swiss towns. This pattern of investment and credit was of course traditional, and its most advantageous form was that of sleeping partners. The sample given in Table 9, which is by no means exhaustive,¹⁰⁸ shows the relative importance of such associations.

¹⁰⁵ Chaptal, *De l'industrie française*, ii. 147; repeated in Lévy, op. cit. 92; and above, p. 89.

¹⁰⁶ An excellent discussion of this subject with particular reference to Alsace is Lévy-Leboyer, *Banques européennes*, 444-79.

¹⁰⁷ Bergeron comments for instance that Alsace 'n'est pas représentée dans les milieux d'affaires parisiens d'une façon proportionnelle à l'importance économique considérable qu'elle a déjà au sein de l'Empire. Mais sans doute est-ce la contrepartie même de ses succès industriels, qui fixent dans la région un milieu autonome d'entrepreneurs actifs.' *Banquiers, négociants et manufacturiers parisiens*, i. 125.

¹⁰⁸ Besides the references in Table 9, see L'Huillier, *Alsace napoléonienne*, 356-7; J.-J. Hémardinquer, 'Capitalisme bâlois et Histoire bancaire', *Ann. É.S.C.*, xiii/3 (1958), 564-72; and Bergeron, op. cit. i. 125-7 and 185-6.

Table 9. External capital invested in the Haut-Rhin's textile industries during the Napoleonic Empire*

Firm and location	Sleeping partner(s) (<i>commanditaires</i>)	Investment (Francs) (date where known)
Blanchenay, Bridel & Cie (successors of Osterried, Haussmann & Cie), Mulhouse	— Frères Mérian, ¹ Basel — Hosch-Mérian, Basel — J.-D. Bridel & frères, Vevey	100,000 (1811) 100,000 200,000
Dollfus-Mieg & Cie, Mulhouse	— Frères Mérian — Jacques-Louis Pourtalès, Neuchâtel	2,000,000 (1810) 100,000
Graf, Thierry & Cie, Mulhouse	— Preiswerck & Zimmerlin, Basel — Christophe Bourcard & Cie, Basel	250,000 (1809-10) 250,000
Hartmann père & fils, Munster	— Soëhnée l'aîné & Cie, Paris	?
Jean Hofer & Cie, Mulhouse	— J.-L. Pourtalès	500,000 (1811)
Nicolas Koechlin & frères, Mulhouse	— Cousins Mérian, ² Basel — J.-L. Pourtalès	575,000 (1808) 100,000 (1810)
Risler, Koechlin & Cie, Mulhouse	— Bourcard-Tourneisen — Jérémie Stehelin — Mérian-Kuder — Frey, Tourneisen & Christ (all of Basel)	200,000 (1811) 200,000 200,000 200,000
Daniel Schlumberger & Cie, Mulhouse	— J.-L. Pourtalès — Nicolas Legrand, Félix Sarasin & Heussler, Basel	150,000 (1812) ?
Schlumberger & Hofer, Mulhouse	— J.-L. Pourtalès	100,000 (1811)
Schwartz, Risler & Cie, Mulhouse	— Baron de Fries, Vienna	200,000 (1806)
Vetter, Thierry & Grossmann, Mulhouse	— Emmanuel La Roche — Jean-Rodolphe Gemuseus — Martin of Martin-Wenck (all of Basel)	300,000 (1811) 300,000 300,000
J. Wichelhausen, Colmar	— J.-L. Pourtalès	37,000 (1811)

¹ Frères Mérian = Christophe and Jean-Jacques.² Cousins Mérian = André and Daniel.*SOURCES: adapted from M. Lévy-Leboyer, *Banques européennes*, 448-52, and L. Bergeron, *Épisode napoléonien*, 202.

Even on this incomplete showing the sum invested by Swiss partners in the department's textile industries in 1811 was upwards of 6 million francs, and most of it was placed in calico-printing. Some of the Basel houses had more extensive investments in the Haut-Rhin than the table indicates. The Cousins Mérian, for instance, also had a stake in the large enterprise of Paul Blech of Mulhouse. The Frères Mérian were creditors to Graf père and other houses in Mulhouse apart from Dollfus-Mieg. It was these two Swiss houses, moreover, which in 1809 joined with Pierre and Nicolas Koechlin to establish a cotton *imprimerie* at Lörrach in the grand duchy of Baden, and equipped it with machines for cylinder printing.¹⁰⁹ Besides its affairs in Mulhouse, the firm of Blanchenay, Bridel & Cie kept its workshops in Thann financed with the help of three merchant bankers in Basel. Other Haut-Rhin houses had financial links with Zürich, Neuchâtel, and Lombardy. Yet the role of the bankers in Basel always had a singular importance, and it was during 1808 and 1809 that they mounted their largest investments in the Haut-Rhin. Lévy-Leboyer speaks of their action at this time as 'une véritable colonisation financière'.¹¹⁰ Christophe Bourcard, Preiswerck & Zimmerlin, Frey, Tourneisen & Christ, Jérémie Stehelin, Pierre Ryhiner, Legrand de Neufville, Legrand, Sarasin & Heussler, Emmanuel La Roche, Jean-Rodolphe Gemuseus — all expanded their commitments as sleeping partners in the Haut-Rhin's textile enterprises during those years.

There was, furthermore, a wide network of middlemen serving the industries and trade of both Alsatian departments during the expansionary period. Official reports often refer to the importance of 'facteurs', 'commissionnaires', 'contre-mâîtres' and 'chefs de dépôt' in that connection. These men were particularly useful as intermediaries between the outlying spinners and weavers. They were quite frequently the link between manufacturers in the Haut-Rhin and wholesale dealers in other imperial departments or beyond the frontiers. The Strasbourgeois were certainly more versed in such trade, and had wider connections for it, than their commercial

¹⁰⁹ Fischer, *Anfänge der Industrialisierung in Baden*, 196.

¹¹⁰ *Banques européennes*, 450-1.

brethren in the Haut-Rhin. Yet one comes across cases of manufacturers who ranked as 'fabricants marchands' (or 'marchands fabricants') and simultaneously performed the functions of producing and distributing goods. Their number was destined to shrink, however, as further industrial specialization and the service trades developed.

* * *

Altogether, if one looks back on the Haut-Rhin's industrial performance from a point on the eve of the economic crisis of 1810-11, the preceding three and a half years had seen unusually fast growth, and of course they followed a period of recovery and improvement under the Consulate and early Empire, after the Revolutionary disruptions. Taking 1812 as his base, Chaptal in 1819 placed the Haut-Rhin as the Empire's seventh most productive department for cotton spinning, weaving,¹¹¹ and hosiery, while for calico-printing its only serious rival was Paris.¹¹² A contemporary estimate put the value of total output by the department's twenty-two leading *indienneurs* in 1810 at between 27 and 28 million francs.¹¹³ If reliable, this largely home trade would have been equivalent to nearly 4 per cent of the Empire's total foreign commerce (imports plus exports) that year. On the assumption that the total number of calicoes printed in the Haut-Rhin in 1810 was nearer 275,000 than 250,000, the average value per article would have been around 100 francs.

Clearly, too, the most conspicuous progress had been made in Mulhouse. The town had not yet quite earned its reputation as 'le Manchester français' but was on the way to doing so. From 6,018 inhabitants in 1798, its normally resident population had grown to 8,053 in 1805 and to 9,353 in 1810.¹¹⁴ This was an increase of some 35 per cent since its

¹¹¹ L'Huillier's figures show that during the first half of 1810 the department had a total of 4,543 active weaving installations (*métiers*), of which as many as 1,610 were based in Mulhouse. In 1806 the totals had been 1,903 and 700 respectively. *Alsace napoléonienne*, 358.

¹¹² *De l'industrie française*, ii. 12-15, 147.

¹¹³ *Annuaire du Haut-Rhin* for 1812, 247.

¹¹⁴ L'Huillier, *op. cit.* 368. Cf. the estimates of 9,300 in 1815 (Leuilliot, *Alsace au début du XIXe siècle*, i. 16), of 13,000 in 1827, and of 18,000 in 1830 (*ibid.*, ii. 12).

'reunion' with France, excluding the several thousands of migrant workers who lived outside the town but were employed in it, whether regularly or not. According to the long-term reckonings of an official report of 12 June 1811,¹¹⁵ the number of cotton enterprises in Mulhouse had trebled between 1786 and September 1810, and their total output and employment levels were said to have grown in like measure.¹¹⁶ If the value of total production had quintupled, the inflationary effects of the prolonged wars on prices must have been a contributory factor. Even so, Desportes claimed, the increase had been achieved in spite of a rise of some two-thirds in labour costs and in the price of primary materials during the same period.

v. *The beneficiaries of expansion in Alsace*

However impressive their achievements of 1807-10 may have been, the industrial magnates of the Haut-Rhin did not quite match their commercial counterparts in Strasbourg for personal wealth or annual trade earnings. Of the department's twenty-five 'most distinguished' manufacturers and merchants named in the prefect's list of 22 July 1810,¹¹⁷ seventeen specialized mainly in cottons (*toiles peintes, cotonnades, siamoises*) and six of them were based in Mulhouse. Eight of the full list were reported as having an active export trade, chiefly to Switzerland, Germany, and Italy. Yet if the various estimates of personal wealth (*fortune*) are taken as even an approximate guide, Mulhouse had only three millionaires: Dollfus-Mieg, Jean Hofer, and Laurent Weber. Gaspard Dollfus (800,000 francs) and Paul Blech (600,000) were next in line. Most of the others on the prefect's list were men of lesser means, and these were generally more modest elsewhere in the department. The most notable exceptions were the millionaires A.-P. Roman, André Hartmann, and Jean Haussmann, while François

¹¹⁵ Desportes to Montalivet, A.N. F¹² 1583.

¹¹⁶ Cf. Desportes's retrospective estimates of 29 Apr. 1806 for 1786-90: A.N. F¹² 1564, and Appendix A below, p. 275. If these are taken as the pre-Revolutionary coefficient, the increase in output over the period is appreciably less than that claimed on 12 June 1811.

¹¹⁷ A.D. (H-R) I M 128/1, reproduced in part in Appendix J below, pp. 290-1.

Bornèque and François Verdan were put at 600,000 and 500,000 francs respectively.

In the Bas-Rhin, by comparison, many more merchants in Strasbourg alone could match those estimates, and a few at the top exceeded them. The official lists of the 'most distinguished' merchants and manufacturers compiled in August 1810¹¹⁸ show that J.-G. Humann, G. Marocco, and Pierre-Michel Saglio (of Saglio frères) had an estimated personal wealth ranging from 1.5 to 1 million francs. Five others (J.-G. Dietsch, René Leroux, A.-P. Renouard de Bussierre, F. Simonis, and B.-F. Turckheim) were placed in the band from 800,000 down to 600,000 francs. Three more (C. Dillemann, J. Mennet, and Zollicoffre) were estimated at the half-million mark, and at least another dozen fell within the range from 400,000 to 250,000 francs. The comparison favours the Bas-Rhin no less if the estimated annual trade earnings of firms are taken as the index of prosperity. Three Strasbourg houses (Humann, Saglio frères, and Turckheim & Cie) were credited with a turnover of two million, and as many (René Leroux, Gantzinotti & Cie, and P.-J. Franck) with between 1.5 and 1 million. Another five (J.-G. Dietsch, C. Dillemann, Gau frères, Mennet & Cie, and J. Revel père) were not far short on the 900,000 or 800,000 francs level. At least a dozen more fell somewhere within the middling band from 600,000 to 300,000 francs, but there must in fact have been several other houses in this or perhaps even a higher bracket, since the official lists have incomplete entries for some of Strasbourg's largest concerns. In the Haut-Rhin, by contrast, only two firms (Gros, Davillier & Roman and André Hartmann) had an estimated annual turnover of trade of a million francs or more. Next in importance came Dollfus-Mieg and Laurent Weber (800,000 francs each), Haussmann frères and Jean Hofer (600,000 down to 560,000 francs), Gaspard Dollfus and Lischy Dollfus (400,000 francs each), with the rest spread out somewhere in the lower band from 300,000 to 100,000 francs, or less.

One has little difficulty identifying the Haut-Rhin's leading economic magnates among the great *indienneurs*. In the

¹¹⁸ A.D. (B-R) XII M 29, reproduced in part in Appendix K below, pp. 292-3.

Bas-Rhin, the foremost magnates fell within the category broadly described as 'la banque', 'commission', and 'expédition'. Their main business was the entrepôt and transit trade in wines, *eaux-de-vie*, colonial goods, tobacco, and Levantine cotton, for which they owned the largest clearing-houses in Strasbourg. They were not so much merchant carriers as large-scale middlemen-contractors. They employed a whole network of local carters and bargees, and had many associates and customers in the French interior, in the Midi, and of course in the *Outre-Rhin*. Turckheim, for instance, had important interests in Paris. Mannberger was associated with a firm of the same name in Lyons. Livio frères had close dealings with a fraternal house in St. Petersburg.¹¹⁹ As the official lists show, most of the leading enterprises were established businesses in the sense that they had been founded before and had somehow survived the Revolution, or else owed their later inception to family capital accumulated before it. But the lists also note that a number of these magnates — Dillemann, Holzapfel, Humann, Kolb, Leroux, Mannberger, Marocco, Mennet, Polti, Renouard de Bussierre, the Saglio brothers, and Simonis are mentioned among others — had made their main progress since the Consulate.

Strasbourg's industrial 'notables', on the other hand, did not match the local merchant élite or their industrial counterpart in the Haut-Rhin. Writing to Napoleon on 12 May 1810, after three years of comparatively good reports from the city, the Minister Mollien remarked that Strasbourg 'se trouve plutôt un lieu d'entrepôt momentané qu'une ville de consommation et de manufacture'.¹²⁰ Few of its industrial establishments were of any national importance. The tobacco *Régie* took shape only in 1811, after the government's monopoly of 29 December 1810, and in due course was to employ some 1,500 persons in various parts of the Bas-Rhin. The private industrial houses were rather smaller concerns, but relative to their position in 1807 they had made good headway during the expansionary years.¹²¹ If Gau frères maintained

¹¹⁹ Other examples are cited in L'Huillier, *Alsace napoléonienne*, 328.

¹²⁰ A.N. AFIV 1088.

¹²¹ See, e.g., the Chamber's report of 1 June 1807 and Shée's prefectorial tables of April 1809 (for 1808): A.D. (B-R) XII M 5 and the *Annuaire du Bas-Rhin*

a regular but below-capacity output of sailcloth, and so also kept its reputation as the department's 'leashed industry' *par excellence*, woollens and cottons responded well to inland demand. In the former range, 'where the military market was a major incentive, J.-G. Dietsch did best;¹²² in the latter, Jean Malapert the spinner stood out among the entrepreneurs who boosted production through further mechanization. Before the brief panic of 1808 he had 10,176 spindles active, employed over 400 workers, and produced 115 kg of yarn and 350 articles (*espèces*) a day.¹²³ The same broad pattern is discernible in the official returns for Engelhardt, Kern & Cie, Braun, Zollicoffre & Cie, and J.-B. Gasser & Cie. Manufacturers of plaincloth, nankeens, percales, muslins, and calicoes, these firms were not large-scale producers but could employ anything between 100 and 200 rural part-time workers in peak periods. Martin Bucher, another in that range, was apparently little affected by the upset in the second half of 1808, and his progress enabled him to open dealings with a merchant house in Rome during 1809.¹²⁴

Altogether, of Strasbourg's 78 industrial enterprises listed in the mayor Brackenhoffer's table for 1811,¹²⁵ 35 dated from the time of Napoleon's *coup*: 13 had been founded between 1800 and 1806, the other 22 since the proclamation of the Blockade. Most of these were cotton enterprises. Elsewhere in the Bas-Rhin, two industrial enterprises were certainly of some national importance. Coulaux frères of Klingenthal and Mutzig, manufacturers of swords and sabres, regularly employed about 600 workers during the expansionary period. Their production was largely determined by military orders, but private commercial sales were also good, and they were able to take advantage of export markets in Germany. The other major enterprise was Dietrich & Cie, the nearest approach in the department to a metallurgical

for 1811, 283-4; A.D. (B-R) XIII M 27 and the meeting of 24 Apr. 1809, Min. iv. Comparative statistical tables for the Bas-Rhin's cotton industries in May and November 1808 are kept at A.N. F¹² 1561.

¹²² His enterprise is discussed more fully below, pp. 216-17.

¹²³ A.D. (B-R) XII M 5 and XIII M 27; A.N. F¹² 1561.

¹²⁴ Ibid.

¹²⁵ 'État des fabriques, moulins et généralement de toutes espèces d'usines, existant sur le territoire de la commune de Strasbourg' (dated 6 Mar. 1812): A.D. (B-R) XIII M 6.

'giant', under the management of Louis Drion in Niederbronn. The years 1807-10 were marked by relatively high output, full employment, and some technical advances.¹²⁶ Its capital assets in 1810 were estimated at 900,000 francs, which made it the leading industrial enterprise of the Bas-Rhin and placed it in the class of the top half-dozen or so commercial houses in Strasbourg. In 1809 its turnover of trade was reckoned at a million francs, compared with 530,000 in 1779. At the later date its employment level was 988, as against 918 at the earlier, so that technical improvements explain most of the increase in production. But there had also been a pronounced reorientation of the firm's markets. Its exports in 1809 were put at no more than 50,000 francs, whereas before the Revolution they had been nearer 500,000 annually. In this case, as in many others, the Continental market design was largely dependent on home demand. The next chapter looks in more detail at the far from facile links between the market design and the effects of the Continental Blockade.

¹²⁶ A detailed account of Dietrich & Cie appears on pp. 278-91 of the *Annuaire du Bas-Rhin* for 1811. The figures cited in this paragraph are taken specifically from pp. 283, 285, and 286.

INLAND ECONOMIC EXPANSION 1807-1810:
THE ALSATIAN EXAMPLE
PART II: THE QUESTION OF CAUSAL LINKS

i. *Positive connections*

Alsatian prosperity during the expansionary period was due to the working of the Continental Blockade and the market design in two direct ways. The first is obvious: in so far as the commercial and industrial headway depended on expansion in a protected and growing imperial home market, it was closely related to the Blockade. Equally, in so far as the expansion stemmed from a better performance in export markets and in the ranges of goods in which Britain had previously competed, Alsace benefited from the Blockade. To the extent that the competition of Britain and of the most industrially advanced Continental rivals of France was blunted or eliminated, Alsatians benefited among other imperial exporters from the 'markets of replacement'. Where Alsatian economic expansion was stimulated by the opportunities of the Continental market design, especially in the *Outre-Rhin* and in Italy, it was linked with the Blockade, of which that design was an integral part.

The second connection is more oblique. It concerns the economic effects of the Blockade on the traditional trading relations between Continental states. In the measure that the expansion of 1807-10 followed the course of commercial reorientation from coastal waters towards the Continental interior, which the wars and the Blockade undoubtedly induced, there was a link between the inland expansion and the Blockade. This point applies particularly to Alsace, since it was at the hub of the Continental trade routes used during the period. Contemporary observers often acknowledged the fact. Writing to the Minister of

the Interior on 20 August 1808,¹ the prefect Shée commented:

Depuis que les communications maritimes sont interrompées . . . , la ville de Strasbourg est devenue l'entrepôt du commerce de la France avec une grande partie de l'Allemagne et du Nord de l'Europe. Cette circonstance, qui nuit pour le moment au commerce général de l'Empire, a fait revivre celui de Strasbourg par le tribut qui lui apportent les villes de l'intérieur de la France et les états d'outre-Rhin.

Or again, the Chamber felt able to predict at the height of the expansionary period that 'aussi longtemps que la guerre maritime continuera, Strasbourg restera le débouché naturel des cotons venant du Levant par l'Autriche, et sera momentanément le lieu de passage et d'introduction d'une certaine partie de denrées coloniales qui pourrait arriver de la Hollande et du Dannemarck'.² Collin de Sussy, the director-general of customs until 1812, and thereafter for a time the head of the new Ministry of Trade and Industry, was similarly apprised of this shift in economic gravity. As he wrote to Roederer, the French secretary of state in Düsseldorf, late in December 1810:³ 'Les obstacles que les circonstances actuelles présentent au commerce maritime ont donné plus d'activité, plus de développemens au commerce intérieure. Les capitaux, autrefois employés aux spéculations d'outre-mer, ont pris une autre direction, et, certes, les nouveaux États que Sa Majesté a réunis à Son Empire offrent un vaste champ à l'industrie.'

Now, on the eve of the crisis of 1810-11, the basis of Collin de Sussy's optimism about German markets was already under a severe test. The inland market design had seen its best days by then, and the more liberal imperial 'licences' for reviving maritime trade were already being issued in greater number; but available statistics for the expansionary period as such, especially when set against the same record for earlier and later years, give substance to observations like those quoted above. For all their unreliability as an index of real values, the official trade balances⁴ reveal interesting contrasts on this point. If the

¹ A.D. (B-R) X M 3.

² Report to Shée of 5 Aug. 1809: meeting of 16 Aug., Min. iv; A.D. (B-R) X M 3.

³ A.N. AF^{IV} 1080.

⁴ Specifically those kept at A.N. F¹² 251.

measure is the official annual values of the total foreign trade of France cited there, for instance, the Blockade years show an advance on the returns for the later Directory, but on the whole they compare rather poorly with those for the Consulate, for the early Empire, and for the post-Napoleonic period.⁵ Since the pre-Revolutionary levels were not to be reached again until the mid-1820s,⁶ it might be concluded that the prolonged disruption of the Revolution, the wars, and the Blockade cost France nearly forty years of over-all commercial growth, as thus stated in the official values, allowances made for unrecorded illicit traffic. More significantly, a comparison between the figures for total foreign trade in the years 1807-13 and those for the regular trade to and from Strasbourg during the same period⁷ shows a very rough inverse relationship. They seem rather like the 'negative' and 'positive' of the same picture. The shift from coastal to inland markets and sources of supply reflects more pointedly in the official inventory of the principal destinations of imperial exports during the Blockade.⁸ As for the expansionary cycle of 1807-10 itself, Collin de Sussy was right to stress the special importance of the Rhenish Confederation, and of Germany more generally, as an outlet for imperial exports.

In those senses, then, Alsatian prosperity during the first three or four years of the Blockade positively reflects some of its happier effects in the inland parts of the Empire.⁹ But in other ways the links between the Blockade and the Alsatian expansion seem less direct, more anomalous, and were even unintended. The rest of this chapter deals with three commercial functions which have not always been distinguished from the direct connections clearly enough in earlier works.

⁵ See the details reproduced in tabular form in Appendix G (below, pp. 285-6) and graphically in Appendix H (p. 287) for illustration of the point.

⁶ The unusually high return for 1792 should be discounted here in view of the inflated unit of valuation (*assignat*).

⁷ The relevant details are reproduced in the tables of Appendices B and D (below, pp. 276-7 and 281-2 respectively) and in the graph based on them (Appendix E, p. 283). But *N.B.* The comparison with the official values for total foreign trade is not exact, since the Strasbourg figures are given in weights.

⁸ Figures for the years 1805-17 are given in Appendix I below, pp. 288-9.

⁹ The later growth of the 'new' or 'substitute' industries, where links with the Blockade were sometimes direct, is briefly discussed below, pp. 256-7.

ii. *The paradox of the smuggling trade*

A good part of Alsatian prosperity in the expansionary period stemmed, not from the effective working of the Blockade decrees, but ironically from their frequent and at times almost systematic evasion. Again one must emphasize that the official statistics used in this and other secondary studies apply only to the recorded and notionally legitimate trade of France. They are manifestly *not* a guide to *all* commercial dealings in Strasbourg, or elsewhere, many of which were certainly illicit transactions. In the nature of such traffic, official records were not regularly kept, and there is no way of quantifying it accurately. One has to go by incomplete and scattered records, such as reports by the *douaniers* and other officers on particular commercial rackets, as often as not based on rumour, or by sundry estimates of individual cases of goods subjected to confiscation or sequestration. No one, however, would seriously doubt that illicit trade was rife throughout the Blockade, and in the frontier areas it was more or less ubiquitous. With a little indulgence, it might even be regarded as the most common form of popular resistance to the rigours of Napoleon's customs severities, and beyond the frontiers it was often a function of local opposition to French rule as such.

In so far as Alsatian prosperity between 1807 and 1810 accrued from contraband and other illicit dealings, its link with the Blockade was anomalous. It was obviously never the government's intention that imperial merchants should enrich themselves by evasion of the law. So, too, the profits of illicit traffic derived not from the bona fide realization of the French Continental market design but from practices officially regarded as inimical to it. Yet, whatever the source, there is no denying that the profits were real. The essential distinction is between the smuggling trade (*la contrebande*) and fraudulent trade (*la fraude*). The former was the traffic in goods whose import and export were prohibited by law; the latter was the illicit import or export of permitted goods in an attempted evasion of the duties and other customs procedures applicable to them. Smuggling was always regarded as the more serious offence. It was punishable by up

to five years of imprisonment, or by ten years of hard labour with branding,¹⁰ or even by death, and the contraband goods were of course liable to summary confiscation. For a merchant of any means or reputation, conviction on such a charge was tantamount to professional disgrace and ruin. Fraud, on the other hand, was more leniently regarded, with *peines correctionnelles* of at most six months of imprisonment, a fine usually of three times the value of the offending goods, and five years of surveillance by the police afterwards.¹¹ Not surprisingly, accused persons preferred to be charged with fraud rather than smuggling, and reading between the lines one has the impression that the customs tribunals were disposed to convict on the lesser offence where they could not reasonably acquit suspects. On the whole suspects received a more understanding hearing from the regular civilian customs tribunals set up in accordance with the autumn decrees of 1810, where in effect local 'notables' were called upon to judge local men, than from the earlier and later military commissions, whose processes were often arbitrary and corrupt.

My account of the perennial problem of illicit trade during the Blockade must be confined to Alsace and its Rhenish environs,¹² but a few more general pointers to its incidence may be useful. One general 'rule' is that the efficacy of the Blockade stood in inverse ratio to the extent of Napoleon's military involvements on the Continent at different times. When he was on campaign and needed his troops, customs surveillance tended to lapse and smuggling became easier. When he was at peace with Continental states, exception made for Spain after 1808, surveillance was usually tighter, never more so than in the newly annexed parts of northern

¹⁰ The brand-mark 'V.D.' meant 'Voleur des Douanes', although in the German frontier lands it apparently also passed for 'Viel Dumm': R. Dufraisse, 'Contrebande . . . de la rive gauche du Rhin', 526. This essay has guided my own account of the more technical details of the subject here discussed.

¹¹ Dufraisse, loc. cit. 508.

¹² Apart from the relevant sub-sections of the departmental series M, there are individual *liasses* for smuggling in the series L (to 1807) in Strasbourg and P (notably the three *liasses* P 295-7) in Colmar. Cases involving Alsatian contraband after the decree of 18 October 1810 fell within the competence of the new *Cour prévôtale des douanes* in Nancy. They are classified in the series U for the Meurthe-et-Moselle.

Europe in 1810-12. Equally, the Blockade had its greatest impact on British foreign trade when periods of comparatively strict customs control on the Continent coincided with a rupture in Anglo-American relations. Again this was the case in 1810-12, as it had been during the first half of 1808, before the general laxity which set in later that year and especially during 1809.

Illicit trade along the Rhenish frontier, particularly in the upper reaches of Alsace, had more to do with the artificial barriers imposed on traditional commercial relations there than with the maritime embargoes.¹³ While colonial goods always had an important place in such traffic, other commodities like grain, meat, tobacco, and hemp also featured prominently among illicit shipments. François Crouzet has commented that smuggling was more active along the inland than the maritime frontiers of the Empire.¹⁴ One reason for this was the nature of the terrain, with its web of secondary and tertiary roads through remote areas, its complex of major and minor rivers, its Rhine crossings and islands, and its woodlands and mountains along particularly the Swiss frontier. Another was the proximity of foreign entrepôts like Frankfurt, Darmstadt, Mannheim, Heidelberg, Rastatt, Kehl,¹⁵ Offenburg, Lahr, and above all Basel. Within the Empire itself there were many smuggling bases up along the Swiss frontier and down the left bank of the Rhine.¹⁶ Some of the more notorious were Bourglibre, Delémont, Altkirch, Schoenau, Rhinau, and the Îles du Rhin, a sample list which should not minimize contraband traffic in the larger Alsatian towns. A detailed police bulletin of 25 May 1806,

¹³ Besides the cited essay by Dufrasse, the most useful works on this subject in the eastern regions are F. Ponteil, 'La contrebande sur le Rhin au temps du Premier Empire', *R. h.*, clxxv (1935), 257-86; L'Huillier, *Alsace napoléonienne*, 334-51; and J. Bertrand, 'La contrebande à la frontière de l'Est en 1811, 1812, 1813', *Annales de l'Est*, 5th ser., ii (1951), 273-305.

¹⁴ *Économie britannique*, i. 139. See also Odette Viennet's remark that 'c'est surtout en Alsace que la contrebande était bien organisée': *Napoléon et l'industrie française*, 230.

¹⁵ To ensure the safety and regularity of this Rhine crossing, Kehl was officially 'reunited' with the Empire on 21 Jan. 1808 and occupied by French troops during the following month.

¹⁶ L'Huillier's maps (op. cit. 339, 343, and 346) show the main smuggling routes in western Europe and in the Rhenish lands of Alsace and Baden.

even before the Blockade was declared, focused on the *arrondissement* of Delémont and left no doubt that smuggling was rife throughout it.¹⁷ It singled out the stretch from Basel to Porrentruy on the Alsàtian border as an especially troublesome area. Later that year the prefect Shée wrote to tell the Minister of Police that a 'contrebande de détail' was virile along the whole length of the Alsatian frontier.¹⁸

Smuggling in the eastern departments was not of course a new phenomenon at the start of the Blockade. It was as old as the system of protection and prohibition itself. Most writers on the subject agree that the first big boost to the smuggling trade came during the Year XII (September 1803-September 1804), with the renewed embargoes which followed the rupture of the peace of Amiens. The formation of the Third Coalition during 1805 also helped to stimulate it, as did the customs laws of 1806. Its incidence during the Blockade was therefore different only in scale and subtlety of technique. The government's refusal to allow Strasbourg entrepôt and transit rights beyond those of 8 Floréal XI was a constant spur to contraband transactions. Basel had always been a conveniently placed and active *foyer de contrebande* for Alsatian dealers, more especially for those in the Haut-Rhin. Smuggling in the other Alsatian department was apparently less rife but more varied in kind. Magnier-Grandprez observed in his report to Shée of 6 May 1808¹⁹ that in the Bas-Rhin it was rather like an osmotic process (*une contrebande par filtration*), whereas in the Haut-Rhin he saw it as a much more organized business, practised very often by roving bands of twenty or thirty racketeers. According to the same report, illicit trade into the Bas-Rhin was chiefly directed to foreign tobacco leaves and refined sugar, while outgoing operations mostly concentrated on grain and livestock. The influx of prohibited or dutiable plaincloth, muslins, percales, calicoes, and the like was said to be limited and less of a problem than in the Haut-Rhin. But as the Continental smuggling lanes were pushed progressively eastwards to

¹⁷ The report is discussed in Ponteil, art. cit.

¹⁸ Report of 30 Sept. 1806: A.D. (B-R) III M 3.

¹⁹ A.D. (B-R) X M 2.

escape the immediate presence of imperial troops and the extension of the customs cordons, Strasbourg's role as a contraband link increased, as did that of Cologne, Mainz, and Basel. It became, in L'Huillier's words, the 'collecteur de tous les courants de l'interlope'.²⁰ In the Haut-Rhin there also formed what the same writer calls 'une constellation vraiment dense de relais' — especially in Bourglibre, Altkirch, Huningue, Kembs, and throughout the forest of the Harth.²¹

There is ample evidence that most merchants, including many a local magnate, accepted smuggling as a fact of life, and even regarded it as an 'honourable' profession. The following comments by the sub-prefect of the *arrondissement* of Altkirch are typical of many during the Empire:²²

Il est malheureusement trop vrai que la contrebande se fait avec une licence éffrayante pour l'intérêt de nos manufactures et celui du trésor public . . . L'opinion publique désigne plusieurs individus, même des fonctionnaires publics, qui doivent la faire ou la protéger; l'on peut dire que grands et petits s'en mêlent; ces derniers y sont engagés par l'appas du gain que les principaux acteurs leur procurent en payant grassement le colportage qui se fait ordinairement de nuit.

Lezay-Marnésia once remarked that 'dans cette ville de marchands [Strasbourg], il est reçu que l'on peut être en même temps contrebandier et honnête homme'.²³ This did not mean that one could be indiscreet, and indeed smuggling was often a game of the most secret intricacy and prudential camouflage. It had its own tricks of the trade, intelligence network, and warning codes. There was also a kind of 'smug-gler's honour' not to inform on one's associates in the event of arrest. Illicit dealings were carefully phased to coincide with times when the official customs surveillance was most sparse or most difficult. At a rough estimate, some two-thirds of all such transactions were carried out at night.²⁴

Mlle Bertrand's social analysis of the smugglers shows that they came from all classes.²⁵ Her sample is the 475 cases brought before the customs tribunals in the eastern departments studied between 1811 and 1813. On this evidence it is clear that the poorer classes provided most of the

²⁰ *Alsace napoléonienne*, 326.

²¹ *Ibid.* 310, 326.

²² Report to Desportes of 18 Fructidor XIII (5 Sept. 1805): A.D. (H-R) P 295.

²³ Report to Montalivet of 24 Aug. 1810, quoted in Bertrand, *art. cit.* 292.

²⁴ *Ibid.* 275; Dufraisse, *loc. cit.* 521.

²⁵ *Art. cit.* 290-5.

manpower of the smuggling trade. Day labourers, manual workers, small artisans, and petty merchants were commonly engaged in it. Together with bargees, watermen, fishermen, carters, and peddlars, whose trades made them particularly susceptible to overtures from or blackmail by larger racketeers, they made up 68.5 per cent of the total sample of accused persons, the day labourers alone accounting for a quarter.²⁶ The better-off merchants, who included 'fallen men' tempted to smuggle for a living, represented only 6.3 per cent.²⁷ Roger Dufraisse's sample, based on some 2,880 individual dossiers in the four left-bank departments down river of Alsace, ascribes a rather more substantial role to the bigger fry.²⁸ Little is known about the practicalities of their contraband dealings, which were obscured behind layers of professional discretion, but they were the men who really controlled the web of illicit traffic. In Strasbourg itself, dealers in colonial goods probably made the largest fortunes from such trade. One of the main beneficiaries, by general recognition, was J.-G. Humann, later a president of the Chamber and a finance minister under Louis-Philippe.²⁹ Others of comparable standing who must have had lucrative contraband dealings too were the Saglio brothers,³⁰ Mennet,³¹ Polti, Klose, Roederer, and Leroux. An anonymous pamphleteer described the trade of Strasbourg on 4 June 1811 as 'un monopole entre les mains des maisons de contrebande'.³² If the proprietors of the older merchant houses like Turckheim & Cie resented these *nouveaux riches*, they did not always have perfectly clean hands themselves. The takings were apparently too tempting, and the unspoken assumptions about exploiting them were permissive.

²⁶ Art. cit. 290.

²⁷ Ibid.

²⁸ Loc. cit. 518.

²⁹ Ponteil, 'Jean-Georges Humann', in *Études strasbourgeoises*, and 'L'Alsacien Jean-Georges Humann: le brasseur d'affaires, l'homme politique (1780-1842)', *R. d'H. mod.*, xii (1937), 227-45; and Mme M.-M. Kahan-Rabecq, 'Jean-Georges Humann: brasseur d'affaires et homme politique', *Als. fr.*, xviii (10 Feb. 1938), 43, who argues that Lezay-Marnésia's policy towards the smugglers was one of *laissez-faire*.

³⁰ On whom see P. Leuilliot, 'Activités économiques et financières en Alsace au début du XIXe siècle', *R. d'H. éc. et soc.*, xxix (1951), 34-6.

³¹ Whose wealth is discussed in *ibid.* 36-9.

³² A.N. F⁷ 3686/2, and cited in L'Huillier, *Alsace napoléonienne*, 345.

It is equally plain that illicit trade in the Rhenish area was helped, as elsewhere, by the conduct of some customs officials. The problem went back at least to the time of the special customs commissioners Jollivet and Le Bas in the early Consulate, though its roots no doubt lay further back still. Desportes more than once called for a 'purge' (*épuration*) of the customs personnel in the Haut-Rhin. His charge was that the officials in question either winked at contraband offences or were themselves actively in league with the smugglers. Reports like that by the mayor of Bourglibre — '*la contrebande ne se fait pas par Bourglibre . . .*'³³ and so on — were hardly reassuring in themselves, for the town was well known to be a major link on the smuggling trade in and out of Basel. Bland denials of that sort were rather silly in fact, for no one believed them, but the difficulty as always lay in proving otherwise. All over the Empire the decree of 11 January 1808, prescribing the charge of treason against officials accused of disobeying the Berlin and Milan decrees, or of helping others to do so, was defied. Even the threat of the death penalty had little effect.

According to contemporary accounts and many later writings, the most notorious case of official corruption in Alsace was that of the Magnier family. As customs director in Strasbourg, Magnier-Grandprez was head of the Alsatian service, while his brother and cousin were lesser officials, the first in Strasbourg, the other as principal receiver in Bourglibre. The professional integrity of these men was doubted on several occasions by Lezay-Marnésia and by prefects in other departments. Local rumour persistently accused them of collusion with the smugglers, and the current quip was that '*il n'y a que trois magniers pour faire la contrebande*'.³⁴ Catineau Laroche, who was sent to Switzerland in 1811 as a special customs inspector to see that the new provisions of the Fontainebleau decree (18 October 1810) were properly applied, and to report on Swiss smuggling, thought the Magnier were guilty. All three, he wrote to Montalivet from Berne on 2 June, '*ont la réputation d'être*

³³ To Desportes on 14 Fructidor XIII (1 Sept. 1805): A.D. (H-R) P 295.

³⁴ Quoted in Ponteil, '*Contrebande sur le Rhin*', 270. I have not been able to find the original source of this pun.

devenus immensément riches',³⁵ and he believed that other officials were in league with them. L'Huillier speaks of 'la négligence voulue' of Magnier-Grandprez and Popp and points out, as do other writers, that the low pay of customs officials continuously exposed them to the temptation of illicit spoils.³⁶ Yet the rumours and even the formal charges were little good without hard evidence to back them. Often, too, the prefects intervened to exculpate particular officials in their reports. Thus Desportes on one occasion, in a confidential report to the police chief Pelet, defended the customs personnel of Bourglibre and specifically exonerated Magnier from the current allegations against him.³⁷ As for Magnier-Grandprez, whose own official reports on smuggling seem grotesque in the light of prevailing suspicion, retribution came rather late in the day. He was demoted to the post of principal receiver at Minden in May 1813, but by then the Blockade itself was in ruins.

iii. *The trade in tobacco and wine*

Another part of Alsatian prosperity in the expansionary period came in commercial branches in which Britain had never been a serious competitor. The trade in tobacco, wines, and *eaux-de-vie* is a case in point. With the exception of such American tobacco as was handled by British carriers, the imperial ban on British goods hardly arose in those branches. One cannot then claim that the Blockade, as such, was responsible for their inland growth during the years 1807-10. There was, however, a link with the favourable context of the wider Continental System, and no doubt it is also arguable that the mainland orientation of the French market design was propitious.

In spite of traditional complaints in Strasbourg about the unfairness of official policy, the tobacco trade prospered in this period. Following the Chamber's own reports to the prefect of 31 March and 24 April 1809,³⁸ the tobacco yield of the Bas-Rhin in 1807 was put at 1.8 million metric quintals.

³⁵ A.N. F¹² 535.

³⁶ *Alsace napoléonienne*, 347.

³⁷ Report of 1 July 1808: A.D. (H-R) P 296.

³⁸ Meetings of the same dates, Min. iv.

It had been wholly consumed during the following year, and the crop of 1809 was expected to be much larger. During the first two months of that year, the reports noted, the Strasbourgeois alone had contracts for 54,000 metric quintals of processed tobacco, worth some 900,000 francs. The growers for their part had orders for an additional 34,000 metric quintals of leaves due for dispatch to the French interior during the following five or six months. In the earlier of its reports the Chamber repeated the old point that tobacco was the main source of income in certain of the department's rural areas, and that it was essential to tax collection there:

' . . . Sa fabrication est à Strasbourg la branche la moins précaire de l'industrie commerciale, que les circonstances ont successivement dépouillée de tant d'autres ressources . . . Le perfectionnement de la fabrication maintient la culture; leur réunion diminue la dépendance du Continent à l'égard de l'Amérique pour un objet qui n'est plus de fantaisie, mais de première nécessité . . .' More than 6,000 persons in the department were said to be employed in the plant's cultivation. In Strasbourg itself fifteen to twenty merchants alone accounted for about four million francs in taxes each year, roughly a quarter of the Bas-Rhin's total liability on processed tobacco. The department's annual exports were assessed at between 450,000 and 470,000 kg of processed goods, along with 20,000 to 30,000 kg of raw leaves. These figures, based on the returns of processors and merchants themselves during the Chamber's recently completed survey, marked an advance on the annual averages for the preceding fifteen years. In one of the Chamber's later documents it was said that the 6,000 hectares currently used for tobacco cultivation in the department were a good quarter down on the total area so employed in 1789, but that this had been offset by a higher yield per unit and better quality of production.³⁹ L'Huillier's figures for sales in this branch in the expansionary period confirm that it was a fairly happy one for growers, processors, and merchants alike.⁴⁰

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³⁹ Petition to Napoleon of 19 Dec. 1810: A.D. (B-R) XI M 194; and L'Huillier, *Alsace napoléonienne*, 447.

⁴⁰ Op. cit. 446.

The evidence of growth is even stronger in the wine trade.⁴¹ One sudden impetus, in a sense artificially induced, came within months of the Berlin decree. As the president of the trade tribunal in Colmar reported to Desportes on 25 January 1807,⁴² the wines of the Haut-Rhin then had a higher value than for many years, and this because of the exceptional circumstances. The king of Württemberg had given notice of a stiffer import tariff for foreign wines, and in order to beat the deadline set, dealers throughout the Swabian lands had rushed to buy up Alsatian wines at the old duties. Clearly, such a highly favourable market could not last, but while sales indeed dropped during the next six months, they remained good on the whole until the economic crisis of 1810-11. Strasbourg alone had between sixteen and twenty large merchant houses which normally specialized in the export of Alsatian and other French wines.⁴³ They were a powerful local group, collectively as important as the tobacco processors, and like them sometimes members of the Chamber itself. The problems which chiefly aroused them concerned customs procedures in Strasbourg and import or transit duties on French wines across the Rhine.

There were many such issues during the expansionary period. At the Chamber's meeting of 5 April 1808 it was the import and transit duties then operative in Baden and Bavaria which worried members.⁴⁴ The first formal protest against the duties had been lodged in April 1807, but thereafter, according to the minutes, the dues had been increased. A letter was sent to the prefect that same day. He then referred it to the government, and on the following 11 May he replied with apparently good news.⁴⁵ The government of Baden had agreed to suppress the transit duties on French

⁴¹ The most comprehensive study of this subject is Dom Medard Barth, *Der Rebbaud des Elsass und die Absatzgebiete seiner Weine* (Strasbourg and Paris, 1958), 432-52 for my period. Other useful works are J.-L. Stoltz, 'Notices historiques et topographiques sur les vignobles et les vins d'Alsace', *R. d'Als.*, ii (1851), 137-66, and iii (1852), 97-110, 145-55, 215-33; and Lucien Sittler's local study, *La Viticulture et le vin de Colmar à travers les siècles* (Paris, 1956), chap. 9 for my period.

⁴² A.D. (H-R) IM 128/1.

⁴³ These are named in the Chamber's entries for 5 Apr. 1808 and 15 Feb. 1809, Min. iii and iv. See also the additions in its letter to Gravelotte, meeting of 23 Apr. 1811, Min. vi, and in the list of 20 May 1812, Min. vii.

⁴⁴ Min. iii.

⁴⁵ Meeting of 13 May 1808, Min. iii.

wines and reduce the import duty to fifteen florins the cart-load (*Fuder*). But still the problem lingered on, and the matter was raised again by the Chamber a week later,⁴⁶ when another threat to the local wine trade also intruded. This was the analogous transit duty of thirty kreuzer (equivalent to 1.07 francs) the metric quintal recently imposed on French wines in the kingdom of Württemberg. Further appeals on both issues were made to the prefect, and a special letter was also sent to the French plenipotentiary in Karlsruhe, to press the matter with the host government. His reply was noted at the meeting of 17 June,⁴⁷ when it again appeared that infractions of the customs laws of the grand duchy had been curtailed. Similar problems recurred during 1808, however, and continued to do so in 1809 and 1810. To these one should add the running dispute over the imperial government's *droits de mouvements* on wines and *eaux-de-vie*. The details here are largely technical and apply really only for the frequency of their recurrence and of the Chamber's protests.

The main fact remains that the Alsatian wine trade prospered in spite of all those difficulties. According to a contemporary source,⁴⁸ the Bas-Rhin's harvest in 1808 totalled 546,560 hl, of which the whites of Wolxheim, Molsheim, and Heiligenstein were especially good, as were the reds of Marlenheim, Blaesheim and Neuwiller. Prices for the producers were above average, and the harvest was fully bought up. Indeed, with the exception of only a few years, the entire run of Alsatian harvests from 1801 to 1818 was satisfactory, and it contrasted well with the cycles before and after it.⁴⁹ The price of *vin ordinaire* was never below the range from eighteen to twenty francs the hectolitre, except during the glutted harvest of 1804. Sometimes prices were higher, notably in the cycle from 1811 to 1815, when in spite of all the economic and military upsets the quality of wines in the Haut-Rhin was outstanding. So, too, throughout the period from 1801 to 1818, the price of French *eaux-de-vie* never

⁴⁶ Meeting of 20 May 1808, Min. iii.

⁴⁷ Ibid.

⁴⁸ *Annuaire du Bas-Rhin* for 1810, 279.

⁴⁹ Stoltz, art. cit. 99-100, from which the details of this paragraph are taken.

fell below 100 francs the hectolitre, and exports to Switzerland in particular remained good.⁵⁰

The period of sustained growth in the Alsatian wine industry and trade owed much to, and was itself an on-going cause of, the increasing area brought under viticulture.⁵¹ The large imperial military market was another encouragement. But perhaps the most favourable factor of all was the growth of the home market through Rhenish annexations, matched by the advantageous conditions for export to neighbouring lands. Together, these made up for the rupture of wine sales to Britain and America. Most of the imperial export trade in wines and *eaux-de-vie* to the *Outre-Rhin* during the Blockade took the natural route through Strasbourg. It continued to expand at least until the crisis of 1810-11 hit the foreign clientele, and the 'licences' of the next three years partly revived the maritime routes in the west. If the over-all evidence of growth under Napoleonic rule seems clear, it is worth remembering that this was achieved in the face of strong foreign competition from other Continental producers. As Marcel Dunan has shown, from the angle of Bavarian markets,⁵² French exporters had to contend with much more than tiresome import and transit duties abroad. Otto, the imperial envoy in Munich, noted for instance on 30 April 1807 that there was strong local competition from Swabian, Franconian, and even Hungarian wines. Good burgundies apparently had a stable demand among the better-off clients, but the cheaper Alsatian wines were under constant challenge. That indeed was precisely why Desportes, among many others, wanted the government to take a strong line on the question of the transit duties in Baden and Württemberg. In a report of 18 November 1807⁵³ he argued that some 68,000 of the Haut-Rhin's total 531,000 hl of wine in an average year were exported. This trade was worth about two million francs to the *arrondissement* of

⁵⁰ This generally optimistic picture is confirmed by the personal record of F.-J. Würlin, a wine farmer of Hartmanswiller: 'La chronique de François-Joseph Würlin bourgeois de Hartmanswiller 1560-1825' (trans. and ed. by A. Gasser and J. Liblin), *R. d'Als.*, lii (1901), 559-92, and liii (1902), 377-407.

⁵¹ See the comparative figures in Stoltz, art. cit. 100 n.

⁵² *Napoléon et l'Allemagne*, 344 and 723 (notes).

⁵³ Discussed in Dunan, op. cit. 344, 723.

Colmar alone. Altogether, he claimed, 305 communes in the department had vital stakes in the wine trade. Alsatian prosperity in this branch therefore could not be assumed; it had to be won.

iv. *Military markets*

Wines and *eaux-de-vie* were only part of the range of goods in demand by units of the imperial and allied armies. Other foodstuffs, uniforms, blankets, arms, and the whole inventory of military supplies offered opportunities to many local producers which offset part of the strain of requisitioning and compulsory underpricing. In so far as the imperial military market helped to make the expansion of 1807-10 possible, it was less a product of the Blockade itself than an economic function of Napoleon's military predominance. It was an integral part of his Continental System in the broad sense. Its origins cannot however be dated to any one year; nor was its importance confined to the period of the Blockade. It had been a powerful economic factor for many decades, even centuries, before Napoleon.⁵⁴ Writing during the Consulate, when its force was certainly becoming more evident, the prefect Laumond emphasized what it could mean to local communities: 'Dans un empire aussi étendu que la France, dont le système militaire est depuis longtemps au plus haut degré de développement, l'État est le plus fort acheteur; les transactions commerciales que les ministres signent pour les différents marchés, règlent le mouvement général, et lui tracent sa direction.'⁵⁵ In his study of the background to the Prussian Rhineland between 1815 and 1870, for instance, Richard Tilly found that the army had been the largest single consumer in those departments under Napoleonic rule.⁵⁶

'Military market' is of course a general term. Although it is meant to apply to the provisioning of the regular army

⁵⁴ The point is made for the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries in Ford, *Strasbourg in Transition*, 78, and closely examined in K. Engel, *Strassburg als Garnisonstadt unter dem Ancien Régime* (Colmar, 1901).

⁵⁵ *Statistique*, 194.

⁵⁶ *Financial Institutions and Industrialization in the Rhineland 1815-1870* (Kingsport, Tenn., 1966), 57.

divisions, the other smaller services (police and customs for example) were no doubt also a factor in local demand. The requirements of the imperial establishment in dress, household adornments of all sorts, and transport, along with the demands of the civilian bureaux, all added something to the State's purchasing function. But alas, it is much easier to state the economic importance of the military market than to quantify it. The subject has never been studied in detail for imperial Alsace, and this is a serious gap. Félix Ponteil was certainly aware of its importance,⁵⁷ but he did not go into it in depth. Fernand L'Huillier's authoritative account has a substantial section on the army,⁵⁸ but the coverage of military markets as such is thin. There are no works on Napoleonic Alsace to set alongside the studies of Robert Werner and Charles Poisson for the Revolutionary period.⁵⁹ Perhaps this merely reflects the present state of the material, of which there is certainly no shortage of crude matter, in the central series F⁹ (*Affaires militaires*) and its departmental counterpart, the series R. An Alsatian study of military contracting and speculation, for instance on the lines of Louis Bergeron's account of the Parisian provisioners,⁶⁰ would be welcome. I have space here for only the broadest outlines.

What one would like to know is the percentage of local production absorbed by garrisons of the fifth military division in Alsace during the Blockade. It would also be helpful to know if that share varied much between periods of peace and of war on the Continent. In the present state of the sources, with markets a rather poorly classified part of the '*Affaires militaires*' in this period, such ratios cannot be accurately established. And yet all the scattered descriptive evidence suggests that a sizeable part of the gross provincial product of Alsace was then regularly consumed by the army. In the Bas-Rhin the demand was most marked at the '*citadel*'

⁵⁷ In e.g. '*Les conséquences du Blocus continental*', 13.

⁵⁸ *Alsace napoléonienne*, 188-246.

⁵⁹ Werner, *L'Approvisionnement en pain de la population du Bas-Rhin et l'Armée du Rhin pendant la Révolution (1789-1797)* (Strasbourg, 1951); Poisson, *Les Fournisseurs aux armées sous la Révolution française: Le Directoire aux achats: J. Bidermann, A. Cousin, Marx-Berr* (Paris, 1932).

⁶⁰ *Banquiers, négociants et manufacturiers parisiens*, i. 395-427.

in Strasbourg and in Fort Vauban, Saverne, La Petite Pierre, Bischwiller, Haguenau, Lauterbourg, Wissembourg, Landau, and Sélestat. In the Haut-Rhin the main concentrations of military demand were in Colmar and environs, Rouffach, Neuf-Brisach, Mulhouse, Huningue, Fort Mortier, and Belfort. All the larger garrisons had their commissaries variously empowered with local provisioning rights, and there were at least a dozen of them in the fifth military division. Furthermore, whole categories of goods normally fell within the competence of the central *Directoire de l'habillement et équipages des troupes* in the war ministry.

A very rough idea of scale may be possible from the contemporary estimates of population. A prefectural report for the last quarter of 1806 gave the total population of Strasbourg as 58,000 consumers.⁶¹ Some 45,000 were regarded as permanent residents, another 7,000 as a temporary or migrant element (*précaire*), and the local garrison made up the remaining 6,000. It might be inferred from this simple basis that the troops represented a little more than a tenth of the city's consumer demand. Again, the Bas-Rhin as a whole had 14,445 troops in addition to its total civilian population of over 514,000 during the early years of the Blockade.⁶² This was 2.8 per cent of the total, and the figures for the Haut-Rhin, where the civilian and military populations were 404,018 and 10,247 respectively at roughly the same time, show a fractionally smaller percentage.⁶³ Because of their massive and regular needs, however, it seems likely that the garrisons consumed a much larger share of local products: 10 or possibly as much as 20 per cent of demand in some places. Besides all the local garrisons, there was the demand created by the frequent movement of troops from other imperial divisions through Alsace and by the military transports to the lower Rhine and Germany. Any precise quantification

⁶¹ A.D. (B-R) X M 2, which also has estimates of the city's consumption of grain, wine, meat, and wood during that quarter.

⁶² The *Annuaire du Bas-Rhin* for the years 1808 (p. 56) and 1809 (p. 60) put the total at 514,096, that for 1810 (p. 170) at 514,462. The estimate for the army is taken from the *Annuaire* for 1809, 142. See also Appendix L below, p. 294.

⁶³ See the prefectural report of 3 July 1806 for the beginning of that year: A.D. (H-R) I M 136/3 and I M 282.

of the market value of such passing demand is again impossible, but local tradesmen and officials were well aware of its importance. Apart from Strasbourg, the principal *lieu de passage*, other local centres like Haguenau and Saverne depended to some extent on military markets. Mayoral reports often recognize this, just as conversely they testify to local slumps when the units were away on active service. The presence of troops and military personnel was sometimes directly linked with the liquidity of cash in Alsace as a whole. In his report for the third quarter of 1809, for instance, after the Wagram campaign, Shée remarked that 'le passage de troupes rentrant de l'Allemagne a été un autre mobile d'augmentation de l'activité commerciale et industrielle'.⁶⁴

Now, there was of course an observe to the Alsatian military market for grain, wine, meat, other foodstuffs, and transport facilities. Not all army purchases were made at the commercial prices. The commissaries generally expected to buy, and if necessary had leave to insist on buying, at prices which would in effect have reduced the potential profits of producers. Quite often bulk selling by speculators, who probably did best of all out of military trade, forced market prices down at times of high demand by the army. The requisitioning of horses, carts, boats, and other such equipment was another burden, and always an unpopular one. In the closing years of the Empire, when such exactions became more persistent, Alsations must have been more struck by the strain than by the benefit of the military presence, not least because the army was often tardy in paying contractors for goods and services.

During the expansionary period, however, the positive side of the military market in Alsace was the more apparent. Besides foodstuffs, the most important items were clothes, arms, and field supplies. The range of goods was wide: woollen uniforms, jerseys, underclothes, socks, gloves, head-gear, blankets, boots, belts, straps, saddles, harnesses, ironware, buttons, *passementerie*, swords, and firearms. In addition to direct local dealings, several Alsatian merchants

⁶⁴ A.D. (B-R) X M 4. For similar observations see the reports of 30 Mar. 1806, A.D. (B-R) X M 2, and for the second quarter of 1809, A.D. (B-R) X M 3.

acted as middlemen for contracts between the magazine in Strasbourg and Parisian suppliers.⁶⁵ There is no doubt that the main individual beneficiary among Alsatian textile manufacturers working for the army's account was J.-G. Dietsch of Strasbourg. His output of woollen ware was largely conditioned by military orders, and in the years 1803-10 his firm made good headway under such stimulus. On 6 Vendémiaire XII (29 September 1803), for instance, the prefect estimated his annual production as 15,000 metres of woollen cloth, but added that the figure could be pushed up to 45,000 or even 60,000 metres if required.⁶⁶ Two and a half years later the Chamber of Commerce noted that he had twenty-three installations active and employed between 480 and 600 persons, depending on the season.⁶⁷ Apart from his regular output for the army, the Chamber claimed that he had the technical capacity to produce goods up to the value of at least 100,000 francs a year for export to Germany. In April 1809, at the height of the expansionary years, Dietsch was producing between 80,000 and 90,000 metres of woollen cloth and from 40,000 to 50,000 knitted articles (*tricots*) a year, together worth about 600,000 francs, for the army's account.⁶⁸

The woollen manufacturers of Bischwiller also benefited from the military market. By April 1809 the Chamber in Strasbourg had received output figures from there which showed a large increase on those for earlier years.⁶⁹ Taken collectively, the *drapiers* of Bischwiller were reckoned to have produced between 200,000 and 230,000 metres of cloth and from 20,000 to 25,000 *tricots* for the army during 1808 alone. Three firms which had done especially well were Gulden & Cie, Heusch & Weiss, and J.-B. Leroi. Similar production was apparently maintained during 1809.⁷⁰ In other

⁶⁵ Individual cases are cited in the documents kept at A.D. (B-R) Archives du gouvernement militaire, R, *paquet 45, versement 17*.

⁶⁶ Letter to Chaptal: A.D. (B-R) R 1050; and see also the ministerial tables of the Years IX-XII at A.N. F¹² 2302.

⁶⁷ Meeting of 12 May 1806, Min. ii.
⁶⁸ Chamber's meeting of 24th of the month, Min. iv; prefectural report of 22 July 1809 for 1808, A.D. (B-R) X M 3; *Annuaire du Bas-Rhin* for 1810, 254; Darmstädter, 'Verwaltung des Unter-Elsass', 657.

⁶⁹ Meeting of 24 Apr., Min. iv.

⁷⁰ *Annuaire* for 1810, 254; Darmstädter, art. cit. 657.

industrial branches military orders chiefly benefited the houses of Coulaux frères (arms) and Dietrich & Cie (heavy metals). Official reports also name Charles Leclerc and Joannin among some beneficiaries in the headgear trade, while the former also appears in the range of *passementerie*, along with another Strasbourgeois, J.-D. Christmann. Among the producers of linens and hempen goods, Vetter of Strasbourg made most of military demand. Altogether, Strasbourg and Bischwiller came out best on this count in the Bas-Rhin, though smaller gains should also be noted in Landau, Haguenau, Saverne, Benfeld, Barr, and Obernai, among others. In the Haut-Rhin, the benefits of the military market during the expansionary period were most obviously felt in Colmar, Mulhouse, and Belfort.

VI

CRISIS, RECOVERY, AND DECLINE 1810-1813: THE LAST PHASE OF THE BLOCKADE

The momentum of economic expansion in Alsace, as in other inland parts of the Empire, was interrupted by the crisis of 1810-11. In spite of some contradictory statistical evidence, inconsistent in itself and also at odds with the Chamber's descriptive record, the official reports leave no doubt that the downward turn of the cycle was real enough. Even allowing for the traditional exaggeration of local hardships and the tendency of Alsatian merchants and manufacturers to assume the worst before it had actually happened, the economic balance-sheet of the last three years of the Blockade was mixed. If the period from the summer of 1807 to the autumn of 1810 marks the ascendant phase of local economic performance, the next three years were altogether more unsettled. Modifications of the Blockade in fact preceded the onset of the economic crisis and were not therefore a direct consequence of it, but they undoubtedly made the recovery after it more difficult.

Early symptoms of the Alsatian troubles appeared some weeks before the more general crisis broke during the winter of 1810-11. Conversely, there was a lag of a few weeks between the worst financial shocks in Paris, in Lyons, and in the Swiss banking cities and their counter-effects on Alsace. The larger merchant houses of Strasbourg were the first to feel the pressure of all this. Already faced with commercial uncertainties and disruptions during the preceding summer, they were most exposed to the repercussions of the financial crisis towards the end of 1810 and during the first half of 1811. The course of the industrial crisis in the Haut-Rhin followed rather later, starting in the first quarter of 1811 and reaching its peak during the spring and early summer of that year. This squares with the industrial record elsewhere in the Empire. In some towns, indeed, 1810 was the year of

maximum industrial production under Napoleonic rule. This chapter deals with the last phase of the Blockade in Alsace itself. A detailed analysis of the wider crisis is beyond its purpose, although the regional example studied here illustrates the essential features of the French crisis more generally.¹

i. *Strasbourg under the 'terreur douanière'*

The earliest signs of commercial trouble in Strasbourg did not come as a reflex of the financial crisis in Paris, or elsewhere, but in the form of disrupted traffic through the local entrepôt. The city's trade during the second half of 1810 moved in a series of ups and downs. It was conducted on a 'stop-go' pattern largely influenced by external forces, some originating abroad. Seasonal factors were partly to blame for this, and political events also contributed to the uncertainty of commercial dispatches. As early as 17 October the Chamber was again invoking the old refrain of 'la stagnation totale des affaires'.² It lamented the current embarrassment of manufacturers in the French interior following the recent stoppage of Levantine cotton on the frontiers. The problem on this occasion was not incapacity at the *halle commerciale*, not a traffic jam, as had sometimes been the case during the expansionary period. When on the following day the Chamber reported a 'stagnation absolue' at the entrepôt,³ it was referring to the impact of the new customs severities on expeditions. 'Stagnation' meant a customs standstill imposed on a diminishing trade through the city. Many of the stoppages had occurred beyond the imperial frontiers, especially in the *lieux de passage* in Baden, and the Strasbourgeois had no direct means of appeal.

The main alarm was that these stoppages would deprive local merchants of the quick returns on goods which they

¹ On the latter, see Viennet, *Napoléon et l'industrie française*; Labasse, *Commerce des soies à Lyon*; and Bergeron, *Banquiers, négociants et manufacturiers parisiens*, esp. ii. 787-802. Of recent studies, that which bears on Alsace most immediately is Roger Dufraisse, 'La crise économique de 1810-1812 en pays annexé: L'Exemple de la rive gauche du Rhin', *Francia*, vi (1978), 407-40.

² Meeting of the same date, Min. v.

³ Monthly report to Lezay-Marnésia: A.D. (B-R) XII M 8.

needed to meet their debts. On 6 November the Chamber reported that there had been no dealings in Levantine cotton during October, since the samples previously sent to Paris for authentication had not yet been cleared.⁴ Writing to Briansiaux soon afterwards, Sautier & Cie commented that 'les cotons s'aquittent [*sic*] peu à peu à la Douane, mais ça ne va que lopin-lopant, il semble qu'on se fasse un malin plaisir de contrarier le commerce dans toutes les formes possibles'.⁵ The Chamber, in its cited report, had also noted that the trade in agricultural products was in a lull. German clients had surpluses on their hands, following large purchases before the customs reform, and 1810 was regarded as a mediocre year for burgundies in any case. A month later there was little improvement to report in the export market for French wines.⁶ But at least shipments of Levantine cotton had been cleared by then, and dispatches to the interior had resumed. If the blockage at the customs had thus been eased, however, all was not well in this commercial branch. True to the 'stop-go' sequence suggested earlier, a new traffic jam was building up in the *arrivages* of Levantine cotton.⁷ And in that form, through a series of swells and stoppages, the problem was to recur in the following months.⁸

It thus appears that customs rigours rather than any more general economic crisis was the main worry of the Strasbourgeois during most of the last quarter of 1810. Charles Schmidt speaks dramatically of 'une véritable terreur douanière' set in motion by the Fontainebleau decree of 18 October and its accompanying regional adaptations.⁹ Coming as they did *before* the full force of the crisis was felt, they were if anything a cause rather than an effect of it, although their generally strict application in the northern and eastern departments of the Empire until 1812 worsened the impact of the crisis. The more stringent laws enforced in the Rhenish Confederation as from the last quarter of 1810 not surprisingly alarmed the merchants of Strasbourg. The various

⁴ Meeting of the same date, Min. v.

⁵ Letter of 10 Nov. 1810: A.N. 3 AQ 339.

⁶ Report of 6 Dec. 1810: A.D. (B-R) XII M 8.

⁷ Report of 8 Dec. 1810: A.D. (B-R) XII M 34.

⁸ See e.g. the debates of 10 and 23 Apr. 1811, Min. vi.

⁹ *Grand-duché de Berg*, 419.

German governments were quick to follow up Napoleon's Trianon tariff (5 August) and its supplement (17 September) with similar measures, and the severities of the Fontainebleau decree were imposed on them no less. As a frontier province whose trade required a ready two-way flow, Alsace was more immediately exposed than the cities of the French interior to such rigours across the Rhine.

The first major protests of the Chamber on this issue were directed at the authorities in Baden.¹⁰ The specific objection was that the grand duke's measure of 16 October, which imposed a transit duty on cotton equivalent to 200 francs the metric quintal and laid down tougher procedures of inspection, was being applied indiscriminately.¹¹ According to the Chamber, not only colonial goods but wholly permissible Levantine cotton imports were being sequestered and irregularly surcharged in Baden. Such practices were also being extended to some neighbouring customs posts. All along the final stages of the routes to Strasbourg — at Bishofsheim, Pforzheim, Karlsruhe, Durlach, Ettlingen, Rastatt, Stollhofen, and Kehl — there had been serious delays. The Chamber argued that since imports of Levantine cotton through Mainz and Strasbourg had been allowed by the Trianon tariff, upon payment of the regular duties, they had the status of 'marchandises nationalisées' and ought not to be subject to the much stiffer duties on colonial cotton.¹² It considered the transit duties quite unjustifiable. A long letter was sent to Bignon, the French minister in Karlsruhe, in the hope of immediate redress.¹³ Its delivery was entrusted to Saglio and Humann, who were sent on a special mission to the grand duchy and instructed to use all available pressure for the release of the sequestered goods and for redemption of the irregular surcharges. At the same time Lezay-Marnésia

¹⁰ The most detailed account of this allied state under the Blockade's regime is L'Huillier, *Étude sur le Blocus continental*.

¹¹ Meeting of 24 Oct. 1810, Min. v.

¹² These details are taken from the letter to Montalivet of 24 Oct. 1810: meeting of the same date, Min. v; A.D. (B-R) XII M 41. Sautier's price quotations to Briensiaux show that trans-Atlantic cotton cost between 25 and 40 per cent more than the Levantine varieties then on sale in Strasbourg: A.N. 3 AQ 339.

¹³ Meeting of 24 Oct. 1810, Min. v; A.D. (B-R) XII M 41.

wrote to both Bignon and Montalivet in support of the Chamber's petition.¹⁴

The outcome of this affair seems to have been inconclusive, and ultimately Strasbourg was to be deprived of its permitted share of the trade in Levantine cotton altogether. In the short term local merchants received at least some nominal satisfaction in their protest, since Bignon replied to inform the prefect that he was pressing the grand duke to repeal the order of 16 October.¹⁵ Since the imperial government had made it known that Levantine cotton was not liable to the heavier duties on colonial varieties, he had the assurance that the expeditions would be resumed. He added, not perhaps unaware of the irony, that in this as in other matters 'on n'a pas et on ne peut pas avoir ici un intérêt différent du nôtre . . .'. Yet in spite of such official interventions and modifications of policy, the Chamber had further cause for grievance against arbitrary sequestrations and surcharges across the Rhine. If these did not apply to Levantine cotton, other imports like wood and dyestuffs were similarly threatened. As the Chamber's minutes for November and December 1810 often show, similar interruptions of Alsatian imports through Bavaria, Württemberg, and Nassau took place. On 27 November, for instance, it was still alluding to 'la tourmente des cotons du Levant'.¹⁶ At the same time it objected to the irregular treatment of French re-exports in Germany. 'Le zèle même des gouvernemens de la Confédération pour le maintien du Système continental peut les égarer sur des dispositions de détail':¹⁷ here, in its most polite form, was the digest of the Chamber's persistent complaints.

ii. *The financial and commercial crisis in Strasbourg*

Such protests during the last quarter of 1810 merged in due course with a larger and more general crisis. The first explicit reference to the latter in the Chamber's minutes appears in

¹⁴ On 24 and 25 Oct. respectively: A.D. (B-R) XII M 41.

¹⁵ Letter of 6 Nov. 1810: *ibid.*

¹⁶ Letter to Lezay-Marnésia: Min. v; A.D. (B-R) XII M 41.

¹⁷ Meeting of 23 Nov. 1810, *ibid.* The gravamen of all its charges against the subject states was spelt out in four long *mémoires*, all dated 25 Dec. and sent to Montalivet on 30 Dec. 1810: *ibid.*

the entry for 10 December.¹⁸ The language used to describe it alone suggests that something altogether bigger and more serious than customs delays and excessive transit duties was at stake: 'Dans un moment où le crédit du commerce se trouve ébranlé sur les points les plus importants de ses relations réciproques, par suite de plusieurs dispositions qui provoquent des alarmes vives . . . , lorsque les capitaux semblent fuir partout devant les inquiétudes qui se propagent, la destinée du commerce dépend de la promptitude de ses rentrées.' That indeed was the link between the specific and the general alarms. It was precisely because of the oncoming crisis that, in the Chamber's view, customs formalities should be expedited. During the increasingly fraught December debates the problem of the sequestrations and transit duties became so engulfed in the worsening financial and commercial panic that their various elements cannot be separated easily.

One essential feature of the wider crisis was a sudden clamp-down on credit. Alsace mirrors this development, the defensive reflex of bankers and merchant creditors, within weeks of its first appearance in Hamburg, Amsterdam, Rotterdam, Paris, Lyons, and the Swiss financial centres. In his letter to Montalivet of 22 December, Lezay-Marnésia noted a worrying rise in current interest rates.¹⁹ As against the normal 4 per cent, the rate had increased in Strasbourg to 9 per cent, 'ce qui tient au ressèment des espèces, occasionné par les allarmes du commerce'.²⁰ Other references to the wider crisis were made in the four *mémoires* of 25 December noted earlier.²¹ Here the issue of Levantine cotton was again related, for example, to 'la crise qui s'étend de l'étranger à l'intérieur, et du centre aux frontières . . . au milieu de tant de gênes et d'anxiétés'. Again, the Bavarian laws on expeditions of Levantine cotton were linked with another sensitive problem. During the expansionary period the credit of merchant bankers in Augsburg had been crucial to the transit trade through Bavaria. At its meeting of 21 December 1810 the Chamber in Strasbourg voiced concern

¹⁸ Meeting of the same date, Min. v.

¹⁹ A.N. F¹² 2469.

²⁰ An 8 to 9 per cent interest rate had already been noted by Sautier in a letter to Briensiaux of 25 Nov.: A.N. 3 AQ 339.

²¹ Min. v.

at the current refusal of those houses to make new loans and discounting facilities available in the old way.²² The Bavarian government had recently required higher cautionary payments as surety for advances on commission and had also restricted transactions through middlemen.²³ With more of their funds thus committed, the Augsburg bankers had reacted by withholding the credit that had primed the local carrying trade to France. Clearly, the financial panic had spread to Bavaria during December, and Alsatian importers were among the first to feel the effects of the squeeze on credit there.

If much had been said and formally written down in protest by the end of the year, very little had been achieved by the Strasbourgeois in the way of redress. Working through the minutes of that time, one feels that the imperial government was not pushing hard enough on the matter of Levantine cotton. It was not until February that the Chamber learnt of the lifting of the sequestrations in Bischofsheim.²⁴ Even then, free passage of the goods was not immediately allowed. It was longer still before the sequestration of imperial re-exports through Baden was relaxed.²⁵

Two factors probably account for the slowness of the imperial government to respond to pressure from Strasbourg and for its reluctance to give way to it. One is that the ministers in Paris were preoccupied with many other alarms, for it was during the closing months of 1810 that the crisis in the capital and other imperial cities built up steadily towards its peak early in the new year. There was thus no overriding case for giving priority to the petitions from Strasbourg. The second explanation may be more material: the government had already decided to switch the entry-points for Levantine cotton away from the Rhenish entrepôts towards the Illyrian provinces and Italy. The question

²² Min. v.

²³ The relevant measure limited individual dealings in Levantine cotton to a maximum value of 30,000 florins (some 66,000 francs). Any one contract was thereby restricted to 300 metric quintals.

²⁴ Meeting of the 13th of the month, Min. vi.

²⁵ See the exchange of letters between Lezay-Marnésia, Holzmann (customs director in Offenburg), Bignon, and Edelsheim (the foreign minister of Baden) between Feb. and June 1811: A.D. (B-R) XII M 41.

had been debated in the *Conseil d'administration du commerce et des manufactures* at its meetings of 1, 8 and 29 October, and again on 5 November.²⁶ The feeling at first was that Strasbourg was much the best situated entrepôt for such imports and that it should keep its prerogatives in the trade. But then Napoleon had himself steered the ministers towards acceptance of the alternative southern route, regardless of the higher transport costs and the inexperience of Illyrian and Italian middlemen in large-scale Levantine cotton transactions. The *Conseil général de commerce* had advised against the change, agreeing unanimously at its meeting of 5 October that the route through Strasbourg was the most convenient, economical, and secure.²⁷ Montalivet himself had been circumspect about the new route and up to the end had tried to win concessions for Strasbourg.²⁸

All this was to no avail, however; Napoleon's will had carried the day. The imperial decree of 12 November had given notice that the old inlets for Levantine cotton were to close on 1 January 1811 in Cologne, Mainz, and Coblenz, and on the following 1 May in Strasbourg. Arguably, then, the government was not willing to allow much fuss to be made over an issue already settled in Paris. There were moments indeed when the ministers' patience cracked under the strain of the constant barrage of protests and petitions. One of the iciest retorts in the official exchanges came on 16 December, when Montalivet rebuked Lezay-Marnésia in the following terms:²⁹

... Je ne puis que voir avec satisfaction, Monsieur le Préfet, l'attachement que vous portez à vos administrés; mais je dois vous avertir cependant de vous mettre en garde contre des affections qui tendraient à vous identifier aux intérêts locaux au point de vous faire envisager les choses avec d'autres yeux que ceux du véritable administrateur. Vos lettres qui déposent en faveur de vos vœux ardents pour la prospérité du département du Bas-Rhin, ont un accent de plainte et d'amertume que je suis forcé de vous faire remarquer...

This verbose mouthful incidentally casts light, albeit obliquely, on Lezay-Marnésia's enormous popularity in the department

²⁶ A.N. AF^{IV} 1241 and AF*^{IV} 170.

²⁷ A.N. F¹² 192.

²⁸ Report to Napoleon of 12 Nov. 1810 urging the retention of the city as an inlet or at least a longer postponement of the closure date: A.N. AF^{IV} 1061.

²⁹ A.N. F¹² 2470; A.D. (B-R) XII M 42.

and his reputation of being 'fou pour le bien'. Both Montalivet and Collin de Sussy had occasion later to chide him for administrative lapses, especially in the dispatch of the routine departmental statistics. Their case, often repeated in formal communications, was that the government had to consider the national interest first, not that of any one region, when formulating its policies.

* * *

And so as the new year began the Strasbourgeois entered it with grave lamentations. On top of all their other worries, news that the dreaded tobacco monopoly had been proclaimed on 29 December soon reached the city. The Chamber's last big effort, the petition of 19 December straight to the emperor himself, had failed.³⁰ The new State monopoly forbade tobacco farming in the Haut-Rhin altogether and confined it in the Bas-Rhin to specified areas which were to be under the authority of the *Régie*. Tobacco processing as a private enterprise was to stop as from 1 July 1811, and if the new system was later modified, this was to tighten rather than relax its control. The government had resorted to the monopoly precisely because the industry had prospered in preceding years and seemed to offer regular fiscal benefits.³¹ The decision was not of course unexpected in Strasbourg, and news of it provoked no immediate debate in the Chamber; but the matter was often referred to during 1811 as a major factor in the crisis.

The more immediate anxiety still lay with the sequestrations, surcharges, and the deepening financial panic. There is a sense of unremitting urgency in the Chamber's actions and writings at that time. It appointed a special fact-finding commission to report in detail on all those troubles.³² In addition to local inquiries, the commission extended its work to receive petitions from merchants in Landau,

³⁰ A.D. (B-R) XI M 194.

³¹ The fiscal motives seem clear in the preamble of the decree: *Correspondance*, xxi, no. 17250. Napoleon expected the *Régie* to yield 80 million francs in taxes a year, but the returns for 1811-14 show much lower actual receipts.

³² Meeting of 14 Jan. 1811, Min. vi.

Haguenau, Barr, Colmar, Sainte-Marie, Mulhouse, and Belfort. Not for the first time, and now more self-consciously than before, the Chamber was in effect acting on behalf of Alsace as a whole. Its findings were sent to Montalivet in a series of long reports which are essential to an understanding of the local economic crisis. The first of these reports, dated 16 January, was presented in tabular form.³³ It covers thirteen pages of the minute-book for 1811 and lists all known cases of goods sequestrated in the *Outre-Rhin* and in Switzerland. Seventeen merchant and industrial houses were named in all, half a dozen of them among the leading Alsatian firms.³⁴ The commission was unable to give figures for the value of goods in each case, but the most serious interruptions affected Dollfus-Mieg, Koechlin & Cie, Masse de Eissen (who was soon to go bankrupt), Schlumberger & Cie, Mennet, Piccard frères, Samuel frères, Menninger, Rieff frères, and Steinheil & Mathys. Most of the sequestrations had been imposed in Frankfurt, Bischofsheim, Schaffhausen, and Basel. The range of goods most commonly named included Levantine, Brazilian, and Georgian cotton, colonial foodstuffs (coffee, sugar, pepper, cocoa), and industrial primary materials like indigo, dyewood, and Senegalese gum. Most of the interrupted contracts, and all the major ones, had been negotiated during the speculative boom preceding the winter crisis. The Chamber, in its remarks on the tables, stressed the deteriorating credit of the houses affected. Given the recent decline in resale prices, it noted, even the immediate release of the goods would not ensure profits. Coffee for instance had sold at around 4.25 francs the quintal before the crisis; the new duty of 1.70 francs as against the former 0.85 could not be recouped from the current selling price of 4 francs the quintal.

In the same report the Chamber referred to the counterblows on Alsatian merchants and manufacturers of six bankruptcies in Paris, four in Lyons, and six in Basel and Zürich. These had cost Strasbourg at least a million and a half francs in outright losses, to which the Chamber added another

³³ Meeting of the same date, Min. vi.

³⁴ A supplementary list sent to the prefect three weeks later named eight other firms as victims of the sequestrations: meeting of 7 Feb. 1811, *ibid.*

million as a result of the bankruptcies the city itself had so far experienced. The collapse of Bourcard & Cie of Basel in particular had hit the Alsatian houses reliant on its services. Paul Leuilliot's figures for the house of Mennet in Strasbourg show a dramatic fall from 900,000 to 500,000 francs of working capital in a matter of weeks.³⁵ Of the general crisis, the Chamber's report of 16 January had this to say:

... Des maux profonds affligent cette ville, privée à la fois de sa fabrication de tabac, de celle de plusieurs objets de fournitures militaires qui occupaient un grand nombre de professions, et menacée de perdre l'expédition des cotons. Pendant que le surcroît de population qu'avait appelé dans ces murs ce grand mouvement d'affaires qui n'existe plus, se voit enlever successivement sa subsistance, le commerce ébranlé par le séquestre qui retarde sans fin des rentrées attendues avec angoisse par plusieurs, frappé par la baisse de quelques objets à des prix considérables, par les retards qui paralysent l'arrivage des cotons du Levant, et encore par l'effet de cette sorte de suspension presque générale des payemens, qui résulte, en Autriche et en Bohême, du décret qui détermine pour les remboursements un cours forcé des billets de banque au dessus de leur valeur réelle; le commerce se voit accablé journellement par les faillites que précipite l'une sur l'autre la réaction de tant de désastres.

Apart from any explicit reference to its industrial stage, the Alsatian crisis of 1810-11 is well summarized in that passage.

In another letter to Montalivet a fortnight later the Chamber gave further evidence of the worsening troubles in Strasbourg.³⁶ This time the counter-effects of the bankruptcies in Paris, Lyons, and Basel were said to have cost the city six million francs, a quadrupling of the previous estimate.³⁷ More cases of the fall in resale prices were to hand. Raw cotton, for instance, bought variously at between 210 and 320 francs the quintal before the crisis, was currently selling at par in the entrepôt. This meant a loss equivalent to the full extent of the duties already paid, and complete uncertainty about the deficit on goods which had still to be taxed. The Chamber estimated that as a general rule the firms affected would lose about half of their financial outlay already

³⁵ 'Activités économiques et financières en Alsace', 37.

³⁶ Meeting of 30 Jan. 1811, Min. vi.

³⁷ L'Huillier confirms that Strasbourg lost between three and six million francs during the first two months of 1811 and puts the number of bankruptcies in Jan. alone at twenty-one: *Alsace napoléonienne*, 375-6.

committed, and this at a time when new credit was virtually unobtainable. A month later the Chamber summed up its bleak report with the familiar lament: 'la stagnation des affaires a été générale, les inquiétudes [sont] excessives, le dissoud est complet'.³⁸ Then, stressing that exports as well as imports were in trouble, it invoked the old bogey of market default: 'peu de demandes de l'Allemagne, les expéditions du midi moindre que les années dernières'. A serious victim of the latter slump was the wine trade. The reports of Marcel de Serre, a special commissioner appointed in 1811 to look into the problem of French wine exports, referred to 'la diminution des fortunes' in this branch; and he also estimated that their consumption in Bavaria had dropped that year to five-eighths of the immediately preceding annual average.³⁹

* * *

The industrial phase of the crisis in the Bas-Rhin was the last to show itself, and it followed inevitably as a result of the sequestrations and the wider financial crisis. As it is the least documented detail of the crisis in the department, it is not easy to pin-point the start of the manufacturers' difficulties. Cottons and linens, for example, were apparently more affected by current upsets than woollens; but on the whole setbacks in all industrial branches were comparatively slight during the last quarter of 1810. The main drop in output and employment came during the first quarter of 1811 and continued into the second.⁴⁰ Having stocked up with primary materials at the pre-crisis levels, which were from 25 to 30 per cent higher than those of the following winter, manufacturers had pushed up their prices in the hope of ensuring a profit. It appears that as from January, however, buyers willing to meet their terms were not forthcoming.

The official statistical evidence of the Bas-Rhin's industrial

³⁸ Report to Lezay-Marnésia of 9 Mar. 1811: A.D. (B-R) XII M 11.

³⁹ Dunan, *Napoléon et l'Allemagne*, 344 and 723 (notes).

⁴⁰ The details of the following section are based partly on the prefect's quarterly reports to Paris in 1810, which are kept at A.D. (B-R) X M 4, but chiefly on the industrial tables drawn up by the mayor Brackenhoffer during 1812-13, on information given by the Chamber, for each half-year between 1810 and 1813, which are kept variously at A.N. F¹² 1583 and A.D. (B-R) XIII M 28.

troubles is skimpy, but such as it is it squares with the descriptive record. During the first half of 1811 the total work-force of the department's cotton industries fell from 1,555 to 1,318, and in Strasbourg itself the figures were respectively 1,191 and 990.⁴¹ The extent of the set-backs varied considerably among the individual enterprises. Jean Malapert, for instance, reduced his active spindles by a fifth to 8,000 and his employment from 390 to 340 workers; but he made up for the drop in yarn output by increasing his production of percales and muslins. Engelhardt-Kern and Sandherr & Redslob were less fortunate. They had to lower both production and employment levels by at least 40 per cent during the first half of 1811. The official tables also show a colossal decline in output at Vetter's linen enterprise, and one suspects that the figures must have been incomplete. From 10,050 kg of hemp thread during the first half of 1810, his production reportedly collapsed to 1,276 kg in the second, and then fell still more during the first half of 1811. The returns for Dietsch's workshops during the latter half-year, which show a drop of about a third in output and employment alike, may be equally questionable. Woollens are generally reckoned to have fared better than cottons during the crisis; but, on the other hand, Dietsch's problems could have been due to a temporary cut-back in military demand. In any case the industrial record of the Bas-Rhin during the winter and spring of 1811 marks a clear break with that of the expansionary period before it.

iii. *Strasbourg and the constraints of policy: the government's response to the local crisis*

During the spring of 1811 other features of the wider crisis appeared in Strasbourg. One was the government's requirement of an export quid pro quo for import concessions allowed by the issue of new imperial 'licences'. It obliged all merchants who had permission to import classified goods under 'licence' to export an equivalent value of surplus silkstuffs or wines and sometimes both. This indeed was

⁴¹ Loc. cit., and L'Huillier, *Alsace napoléonienne*, 378.

usually the precondition of any import concessions, and it has an important bearing on the nature of the French crisis more generally. It illustrates the point that the economic crisis of 1810-11 was not due to a literal dearth of supplies, the inevitable sequel to the 'self-blockade' or, as it were, the boomerang effect of the official embargoes. The crisis was not precipitated by a feverish mirage of plenty in a desert land. It was not the ultimate point of drainage in a long commercial famine and steady run-down of industrial lubrication. It was not due to a scarcity of essential primary materials and a sky-rocketing of prices within the Empire, for prices (as we have seen) generally fell during the critical winter.

One of the most salient features of the French economic crisis is that it stemmed partly at least from commercial OVER-stocking and industrial OVER-production. In spite of the doctrinal attacks of liberal economists during the last century and a half, the Napoleonic Blockade was not synonymous with an absolute deficiency in essential primary materials. In the case of silkstuffs, cottons, and wines, for instance, the problem in 1811 was glut rather than dearth. Now presumably this means that imperial manufacturers and merchants had had access to at least enough primary materials from which to over-produce. The choice, otherwise, seems bizarre: either one would have to suppose that the commercial and industrial surpluses were imaginary, which would be a grotesque distortion of all the material evidence that those surpluses were real enough; or else one would have to think of dearth and glut relative to such appallingly low quantities of normal production that there would seem to be an implicit distinction between dearth and Super-dearth (or is it Infra-dearth?), which is a needless abstraction.

In fact, the French crisis, as seen through the Alsatian and most other angles, had little to do with the physical default of goods. There was certainly a serious problem of insufficient credit and specie, but more generally the crisis lay in demand rather than in supply. It was this market default which lay at the root of the commercial and industrial glut of 1811. The official quid pro quo for import concessions was only one expedient by which the government hoped to dispose of the Empire's surpluses. What annoyed the Strasbourgeois was

that the export requirement was being applied to middlemen and merchant carriers as well as to the owners of *dépôts de vente*, which would ultimately market the goods. Another objection was that it was being retroactively extended to earlier contracts which had been interrupted in Switzerland, the Rhenish Confederation, and the Hanse towns. The Chamber protested to Montalivet at once.⁴² Its practical proposal was, not unreasonably, that the export quid pro quo should be confined to the firms for which the 'licensed' imports were destined.

Another symptom of the market crisis which became acute in the spring of 1811, though it had been developing for several months, was the shortage of specie. Casting obstacles in the way of even small-scale transactions, its effects were felt right down at the level of small local markets. The issue in Alsace first arose in the form of an official inquiry into the circulation of debased Swiss coins. The Chamber in Strasbourg believed that these coins were in use precisely because French money was then so hard to come by.⁴³ It saw no solution except in a more liberal issue of new French coins, '... car c'est la rareté de cette dernière monnaie, devenue successivement insuffisante pour les besoins du commerce, qui a amené forcément l'usage des monnaies suisses. La disparition de celles-ci ne nous donnerait pas les espèces françaises qui nous manquent, et elle enlèverait cependant un moyen d'échange dont nous avons besoin.'⁴⁴ The coins in question corresponded to 75 centimes and 1.50 francs, and they were used variously to pay day-labourers and artisans or as petty cash in local markets. The economic crisis increased the tendency to hoard hard cash, however, so that even relatively isolated village economies felt its impact in some small measure. The resort to Swiss alternatives illustrates yet another variant of the Alsatian 'frontier complex', one particularly common in times of stress. Realizing this,

⁴² Letter of 12 Apr., meeting of 10 Apr. 1811, Min. vi.

⁴³ Report to Lezay-Marnésia of 24 Apr., meeting of 23 Apr. 1811, *ibid.*; and Arch. comm. Strasb., B3° 29-158.

⁴⁴ For a more general discussion of this whole question, see Guy Thuillier, 'Pour une Histoire monétaire de la France au XIXe siècle: Le rôle des monnaies de cuivre et de billon', *Ann. É.S.C.*, xiv (1959), 65-90; and 'La crise monétaire de l'automne 1810', *R. h.*, ccxxxviii (1967), 51-84.

the Chamber advised not a withdrawal of the foreign coins but an authorized tariff of exchange rates, to be published in the local *Hôtel de monnaies*.

Yet older problems remained more pressing still. As the expiry date for the Levantine cotton entrepôt approached, the Strasbourgeois entered their last public agony on the matter. All their earlier efforts had led to was a postponement of the closure from 1 May to 1 July 1811.⁴⁵ Far from pacified, the Chamber had then drafted a long *mémoire* in which the old cotton route was defended in every detail.⁴⁶ In this it had the support of several other imperial towns, including Geneva,⁴⁷ which also benefited from the trans-continental route from Macedonia to the Habsburg lands and so on through Bavaria, Württemberg, and Baden to Alsace. Claiming to speak for many interested departments in the east and in Belgium, and as if to show its willingness to compromise, the Chamber had offered two practical proposals. The first was that the local closure should be postponed at least until the end of the year, so as to allow current contracts to be duly completed. The second was that, thereafter, a route from Macedonia through Serbia, Bosnia, the Illyrian provinces, Trieste or Karlstadt, the Italian Tyrol, Bavaria, Württemberg, and Baden to Strasbourg should be allowed to operate concurrently with the imperial inlets through Vercelli, Casatine, and Pietramole.⁴⁸ On the latter proposal, the Chamber had suggested that the concurrent route through Strasbourg might even be confined to Levantine cotton ultimately destined for the eastern and northern departments alone. And here, as in the case of the expiry date, it again had the backing of all the major local officials and of the *Conseil général de commerce*.⁴⁹

⁴⁵ Imperial decree of 22 Jan. 1811: A.N. AF^{IV} 1243; meeting of 7 Feb. following, Min. vi.

⁴⁶ Sent to Montalivet on 18 Feb., meeting of 13 Feb. 1811, *ibid*.

⁴⁷ For a short account of Geneva's position on the issue, see C. Schmidt, 'Sismondi et le blocus continental', *R. h.*, cxv (1914), 85-91, which includes the text of Sismondi's letter defending the old route to Alsace.

⁴⁸ These proposals were repeated in another letter-petition to Montalivet, and at the same time a similar appeal was made to Collin de Sussy: meeting of 17 Apr. 1811, Min. vi.

⁴⁹ See e.g. the formal *avis* given at its extraordinary meeting of 5 Mar. 1811: A.N. F¹² 192 and F¹² 523.

The minutes for the May debates of 1811 make it clear that the Chamber was determined to mobilize all possible support for its case. Besides yet another petition to Montalivet, letters were sent to Collin de Sussy, to the mayor Brackenhoffer, and to Turckheim in Paris, urgently asking him to pull what strings he could.⁵⁰ But all such efforts were in vain. After a long silence, an unnecessary snub to the Chamber's insistence on the urgency of the matter, Montalivet replied.⁵¹ The government's final verdict was negative. And so in the end the work of months and many petitions had all failed to shake Napoleon's resolve. The entrepôt for Levantine cotton in Strasbourg closed officially on 1 July 1811, and the trade thereafter was driven into illicit paths. On the whole, one may say, the local merchants were justly aggrieved. The government's handling of the whole affair was brusque and unreasonable. If it had ever seriously considered them, it certainly did not reply in convincing detail to the Chamber's arguments for the greater safety, economy, and facility of the old cotton route. It *was* rather irrational to force manufacturers in the northern and eastern departments to procure supplies of Levantine cotton via an authorized dog's-leg through the Illyrian provinces, northern Italy, and Lyons.

* * *

It is not clear when exactly the economic crisis in Strasbourg began to abate. A superficial reading of the official routine reports would suggest that it never did. Brackenhoffer's mayoral report and accompanying tables of 10 May 1811 on the city's trade and industry matched the Chamber's for gloom.⁵² One detail of this report merits particular attention. According to the mayor, 'l'appauvrissement de l'Allemagne et des pays du Nord, qui va en augmentant, se fait ressentir par une diminution de commissions des produits du sol et de l'industrie française'. The implications of this point seem

⁵⁰ The texts of all these are recorded in the minutes for the meeting of 16 May, vol. vi.

⁵¹ Letter of 18 July, meeting of 22 July 1811, *ibid.*

⁵² 'État des fabriques, manufactures et usines, des arts et métiers, du commerce de la ville de Strasbourg', compiled in reply to Montalivet's circular of 23 June 1810: A.N. F¹² 1569.

to me far-reaching. Just as the comparatively effective performance of imperial exports across the Rhine had been a crucial factor in the expansionary period, so the disruption of that market in 1811 had the opposite result. Indeed, it was during the crisis of 1810-11 that the limitations and the false logic of the French Continental market design became plain. The inherent irony, now exposed, was that the market design presupposed a stable if not a growing number of well-to-do clients beyond the frontiers to absorb whatever the Empire could not of its own production. It also rested on the assumption that imperial trade with the subject and allied states could be geared to an exchange of manufactured goods and agricultural products for essential primary materials with a strong preferential bias towards France. Ultimately, however, the Blockade's impact on many of the client states, as well as successive measures adopted by the French to invade and even engross Continental markets, worked against any sustained achievement of those ends.

It was, then, precisely the *Frenchness* of the Continental market design which eventually proved its undoing. Though not immediately, and certainly not always directly, its one-sidedness contributed to the slow impoverishment of many states on which it depended. Now, it is of course not certain that the Blockade as such caused the economic crisis of 1810-11, whose origins were more complex and probably had as much to do with speculative excesses outside France, and not least in Britain. But there is no doubt that the Blockade exacerbated the crisis, once it had broken, and made recovery from it more difficult. It is also undeniable that the crisis, whatever its causes, knocked the stuffing out of the French market design. As major beneficiaries of the good years 1807-10, Alsatian merchants and manufacturers felt the impact of the downturn which followed all the more keenly.

Nevertheless, fat and lean years remained a question of degree. Once again there is evidence that the Chamber in Strasbourg may have been exaggerating local hardships in its dreary reports as late as the third quarter of 1811.⁵³

⁵³ See e.g. that to the prefect of 7 Oct., which brought the list of local bankruptcies up to date: meeting of the same date, Min. vi; A.D. (B-R) XII M 11.

Once more, too, there was an immediate issue on which to focus its sombre predictions. By a directive of 5 September the government had laid down certain conditions for future trade dealings with the newly annexed departments of the Lippe, Ems-Supérieur, Bouches-du-Weser, and Bouches-de-l'Elbe. One requirement was that such traffic would have to pass via Wesel rather than Frankfurt. Another was that customs duties would still have to be levied on goods entering those departments even if payment had already been exacted at the point of exit from France. As important intermediaries in the carrying trade to those parts, the Strasbourgeois were quite naturally alarmed by these new measures. Here again they thought that reason was on their side, and so another spate of protests and petitions was launched in defence of the vital trade link with Frankfurt.⁵⁴ But, as so often in the past, the Chamber spoilt its case by some palpable inconsistencies in its reports. The ministers in Paris had an excuse, yet again, to think that it was crying wolf. For sometimes the Chamber's argument was that Strasbourg was on the verge of commercial collapse, that it was about to lose the few crumbs which had survived the blight. On other occasions the argument was that the city had done well in the preceding years and that a prosperous larder was in jeopardy. The image of conspicuous decline and conspicuous prosperity — whichever seemed to fit the moment better — was thus used to back up the Chamber's petitions.

What, for instance, was the government to make of the two accounts sent by the Chamber on 7 and 9 October? In the first, the blunt conclusion was that '*le commerce de Strasbourg continue d'éprouver une stagnation fâcheuse*'.⁵⁵ In the second, the argument was presented from a different angle:⁵⁶

Quiconque a observé avec soin les causes de l'aisance de notre place dans ces dernières années, est bien convaincu qu'elle est due principalement à ce genre d'affaires [trade with Frankfurt]; et il suffit pour cela de connaître un seul fait: nos expéditions par le Rhin par Francfort, qui montaient autrefois de 35 à 50,000 anciens quintaux [17,500 to

⁵⁴ Meeting of 7 Oct. 1811 and letter to Montalivet two days later: Min. vi; A.D. (B-R) XII M 48.

⁵⁵ Meeting of the same date, Min. vi; A.D. (B-R) XII M 1.

⁵⁶ Meeting of the same date, Min. vi; A.D. (B-R) XII M 48.

25,000 metric quintals] par an, se sont élevées dans ces dernières années à plus de 240,000 [120,000 metric quintals].

Here, then, the obvious inference was that a growing rather than a stagnant trade was being threatened and that this was why the measure of 5 September was so disliked. Certainly, a branch of Strasbourg's export trade which had almost sextupled between unspecified dates hardly conforms to the forlorn image of a lost prosperity. Perhaps an allusion to the good times of 1807-10 was intended, to stress the current set-backs by rhetorical contrast? If so, the Chamber was in effect offering a nuance of the 'golden age conceit', and the reaction in Paris was accordingly sceptical.

Finally, the Chamber's own statistical record of the city's trade during the crisis was internally inconsistent with the burden of its routine reports at the time. One may reasonably suppose, though without being able to quantify the point or cite chapter and verse in support of it, that illicit trade was to some extent restrained by the 'terreur douanière' after October 1810. At any rate until the autumn of 1812, its risks and penalties were greater than during the expansionary period. But as the Chamber was understandably anxious to keep a respectable public distance from the ups and downs of the contraband and fraudulent trade, its statistical records applied only to regular traffic. And as for that, if there *was* a sharp decline in the city's river trade, which would seem to follow from the descriptive record of the reports between September 1810 and September 1811, then there are discrepancies with the Chamber's figures compiled towards the end of 1812.⁵⁷ These show a total down-river trade which in 1811 was actually — nay, miraculously! — greater than that for 1810.⁵⁸ The monthly fluctuations are often quite sharp but do not testify to any sustained stagnation or steady decline. There was indeed a comparative slack at the entrepôt from August 1810 to February 1811, but the returns for the following March to May show an upturn. More pointedly,

⁵⁷ Sent to the mayor and dated 10 Nov., meeting of 21 Nov. 1812, Min. vii. The statistics are reproduced in tabular form in Appendix D and incorporated graphically in Appendix E below, pp. 281-2 and p. 283 respectively.

⁵⁸ Admittedly, the returns are for volume of traffic through the entrepôt and do not take account of any drop in its real value during the crisis.

there was what could reasonably pass as a 'crisis' in the regular traffic during the mid-winter months, but on its own evidence the Chamber had no right to repeat the tales of 'absolute stagnation' or 'progressive decline'. It is tempting to conclude that Strasbourg's river trade straddled the crisis in the same 'stop-go' fashion as it had performed during most of 1810. One need not doubt the reality of the winter crisis, but the wider perspective was one of fits and starts. The expansionary momentum had been lost; traffic adjusted speed and course to meet the new hazards ahead.

Comparable statistics for Strasbourg's land-borne trade during the crisis are not available. Again it is a fair assumption that the 'terreur douanière' on both sides of the frontier was harmful to this branch. The switch of the Levantine cotton route, and all the fuss which preceded it, probably prolonged the sufferings of the overland trade well into the summer of 1811, and perhaps beyond it. Yet in spite of all the uncertainties and set-backs, the essential structure of the city's merchant oligarchy remained intact. The main casualties of the crisis were a lesser sort, who lacked the capital and the credit to see the hard time through, or else were ruined on the same waves of speculation which had first buoyed them up.⁵⁹

iv. *The crisis in the Haut-Rhin*

The stoppage of credit and the withdrawal of funds, especially Swiss funds, hit the manufacturers of the Haut-Rhin at a time when they already had industrial surpluses on their hands. Primary materials which had already been paid for, or partly paid for, were under sequestration in foreign states, and even traditional markets had fallen away. Output was generally lower and unemployment higher than in 1810. The main diagnostic index of these reverses was Mulhouse, but it was not the only one.

⁵⁹ Louis Bergeron, dealing with a bigger and more important sample, reaches a similar conclusion on the effects of the crisis in Paris. For *la haute banque* and its close associates, the crisis was more of a passing nuisance than a profound dislocation. Its main victims were speculators in colonial goods with low capital and uncertain credit, along with the smaller fry who had overreached themselves. *Banquiers, négociants et manufacturiers parisiens*, ii. 800-1.

If the crisis in the Haut-Rhin broke some two or three months later than in the Bas-Rhin, it seems to have lasted longer. Robert Lévy believed that the time of troubles in the Alsatian cotton industry was more enduring than that in other parts of the Empire. He refers to the whole period from 1810 to 1814 as one of 'crisis' in Mulhouse, Sainte-Marie, Colmar, Munster, Guebwiller, Masevaux, Lutterbach, Cernay, Thann, Wesserling, and throughout the valley of Saint-Amarin.⁶⁰ This is an exaggeration. One can distinguish between the worst set-backs of 1811 and the two or three years of rather variable production which followed. But that the expansionary momentum of the Blockade's earlier phase was lost in the final years of the Empire is clear. The cotton industry again was most affected by the interruption in supplies, the default of markets, and the general shortage of credit and hard cash. The major slump in profits occurred in the larger and more mechanized enterprises, since they more than others depended on large-scale working capital and on comparatively distant markets in the Empire and abroad. Yet these same firms were also best equipped to withstand the shock of the crisis, by drawing on their own capital or calling in funds from solvent associates. The middling enterprises, relative to their scale of operation, probably suffered more in the long term. One may also suppose that the mass of rural spinners and weavers fared no better, but here the evidence is less conclusive. The official reports of the time were usually far too preoccupied with the leading casualties to fill in the multiple details of rural distress. It is likely, though, that the small-scale rural producers had a comparatively slow passage into the slump. Owning fewer mechanized workshops and being less dependent on large-scale funding than the industrial magnates, the impact of the crisis on them was much less sudden and violent.

Although the worst industrial set-backs in the Haut-Rhin did not come until the first half of 1811, there had been forebodings of trouble some months before. Dealers in imported primary materials and colonial foodstuffs had felt the repercussions of the drop in resale prices during the last

⁶⁰ *Industrie cotonnière en Alsace*, 283-5.

quarter of 1810. The trend had been less marked than in Strasbourg, but the effects were ominous. Merchants and manufacturers who had stockpiled supplies before and in anticipation of the Trianon tariff, at the comparatively high prices then current, suffered from their lower quotation towards the end of the year. Just as the merchants had been unable to dispose of stocks at a profit, so the manufacturers had found the market for their goods insufficient to make good their original outlay on primary materials. Both commercial and industrial stocks had depreciated during the last month or two of 1810, and the problem worsened during the first quarter of 1811. Between 19 January and 12 February some of the major houses in Mulhouse, among them Jérémie Dollfus, Dollfus-Hausmann & Cie, J.-G. Schlumberger, and J. Koechlin, were forced to suspend operations. All were victims of the withdrawal of Swiss funds and of their inability to raise emergency loans elsewhere.⁶¹ During the first quarter of that year several other firms were similarly affected, some less, others more adversely. Nicolas Koechlin, for instance, survived the 'cascade des faillites' in spite of the embarrassment of its associate, the Cousins Mérian of Basel. But even so powerful an enterprise as Gros, Davillier & Roman did not go unscathed. It went under for several months, technically bankrupt, along with its sister house in Paris, itself stricken by the collapse of Bidermann during February and March.⁶² The plight of the Wesserling firm had wide repercussions, not least psychological, since it was the largest enterprise in the Haut-Rhin. In the event its sister house was rescued by massive government loans,⁶³ about half of which were used in effect to bolster up the Wesserling enterprise. Gros, Davillier & Roman received such favours because it was a big and important concern. For the lesser houses, it was left to the manufacturers to help themselves, where they could.

In this difficult task they were not helped by the rigours of

⁶¹ L'Huillier, *Alsace napoléonienne*, 375. Another list of bankruptcies in Mulhouse during 1811 is given in *ibid.* 399.

⁶² See e.g. the letters of the Parisian firm to Montalivet, on 9 Jan., requesting a loan of 1.5 million francs, and again two days later, reducing the request to at least 600,000 francs: A.N. F¹² 2405.

⁶³ See above, pp. 185-6.

the 'terreur douanière'. Most of the serious sequestrations affected the leading *indienneurs* and were concentrated in the first half of 1811. Petitions from the aggrieved parties and letters of support from the prefect Desportes to Paris multiplied in March and April.⁶⁴ What the hold-up in supplies meant was that, already denied a cash return on their surpluses, the affected houses were being further handicapped in their efforts to recoup losses by planning for the year's production ahead.⁶⁵ The longer the sequestrations continued, it was argued, the more likely it was that the manufacturers would suffer a double loss. One would follow on any subsequent confiscation of or customs surcharge on the goods, especially those ordered before the higher duties of the Trianon tariff became applicable. The other would affect the convertible value of the goods, *qua* industrial material, as the risk of their impairment in the customs depots was high.

Several individual examples of this problem are to hand.⁶⁶ Dollfus-Mieg had already made an initial advance on 157 bales of Georgian cotton in October 1810. The interruption of the expedition at the customs in Basel during the winter threatened a suspension of production in the spinning works which fed his enterprise. Nicolas Koechlin had 390 bales of cotton similarly held up in Frankfurt. These had been ordered from a Prussian dealer as early as the preceding August, and again an initial payment had been made. That was also the position of Daniel Schlumberger, who had ordered 85 bales of American and Levantine cotton in October, only to see them impounded in Basel during the winter. The closure of his spinning works in Lutterbach was foreseen in consequence. Similar protests were made by Daniel Hornung of Mulhouse, by Ziegler, Greuter & Cie of

⁶⁴ A.D. (H-R) I M 116a/1 and 126a/1.

⁶⁵ The need for forward planning was explained by Josué Koechlin, the mayor of Mulhouse, in a letter of 29 Apr. 1811 to Joliat, the sub-prefect of the *arrondissement* of Altkirch. Linking the question directly with the avoidance of social unrest, the mayor reported that local manufacturers were already uneasy about the following winter, since 'la stagnation dans les affaires en général et le peu de vente dans les marchandises fabriquées contraindra nos manufacturiers de renvoyer beaucoup de leurs ouvriers'. He advised the police to make contingency plans for the temporary repatriation of foreign workers. A.D. (H-R) I M 125.

⁶⁶ A.D. (H-R) I M 116a/1 and 126a/1.

Guebwiller, and by Zurlinden, Lorentz, Garrotsi, and Legrand of Altkirch.

On 6 April 1811 Montalivet at last replied to the petitions and the prefect's letters.⁶⁷ He stated that the government was willing to allow the goods into the Empire upon payment of the new tariff duties and — here the nuance — provided the firms concerned undertook to export an equivalent value of silkstuffs from the glutted storehouses in Lyons, Nîmes, and Avignon. His letter went on to outline the rather complicated procedure for such operations. It was hardly surprising that these terms satisfied no one. The three magnates Dollfus-Mieg, Nicolas Koechlin, and Daniel Schlumberger wrote jointly to Desportes on 19 April to express their dismay at the export requirement.⁶⁸ The prefect saw their case and supported their request to have that particular provision dropped when he wrote to the Minister a fortnight later.⁶⁹ Referring to those 'extremely onerous' terms, he claimed that they would mean a certain loss of 30 per cent to the manufacturers. The latter were apparently even prepared to abandon the goods altogether rather than commit themselves to dealings in silkstuffs, in whose technicalities they professed their ignorance. Dollfus-Mieg repeated in another letter-petition of 4 May that the export quid pro quo was an arrangement quite unacceptable to him and asked for a more reasonable hearing.⁷⁰ This was not apparently forthcoming. A report by the consultative chamber in Sainte-Marie on 5 June repeated many of the old grievances in a way which suggested that the manufacturers of the Haut-Rhin had still had no redress on the sequestration issue.⁷¹ The department also had its instances of summary confiscations, *autos-da-fé*, public burnings of goods, and other more extreme forms of the 'terreur douanière'. It was estimated that some 300,000 francsworth of British cotton goods alone, mostly plaincloth and neckerchiefs, were burnt there during the crisis.⁷²

As for the problem of industrial surpluses and the loss of

⁶⁷ A.D. (H-R) I M 116a/1. The ministerial directive followed a decision of the Conseil d'administration du commerce et des manufactures of 18 Mar.: A.N. AFIV 1242 and AF*IV 171.

⁶⁸ A.D. (H-R) I M 125.

⁶⁹ Letter of 2 May 1811, *ibid.*

⁷⁰ A.D. (H-R) I M 126a/1.

⁷¹ A.N. F¹² 1583; Lévy, *Industrie cotonnière en Alsace*, 282-3.

⁷² Papers in A.D. (H-R) I M 116a/3; Lévy, *op. cit.* 281-2.

markets, the evidence was chronic, especially in the cotton sector. It was partly to relieve their glutted stocks, and partly to economize on running costs, that several houses in Mulhouse sought to by-pass the dealings of middlemen through more direct links with firms in southern and western France. On 24 December 1810, for instance, Jean Hofer formed a society in Montpellier with Barthélémy Euzière & Cie, which was to survive till 1817. More generally, in June 1811 Pierre Schlumberger, Mathieu Hofer, Jacques Schlumberger, S. Schouch, and Daniel (of Pierre Schlumberger solidaires) entered into an association with Auguste Rigaud in Beaucaire, which was to last till 1818.⁷³ This 'avant-poste de Mulhouse', as Hémardinquer calls it, was not the only one set up to supply the market in Beaucaire. Others like it were formed in Bordeaux and Lyons.⁷⁴

Such devices to boost their sales were less readily available to other manufacturers. One of the clearest and most detailed statements of market trouble in the Haut-Rhin came from Jean Vetter, *indienneur* of Mulhouse, in a letter-petition to Montalivet of 2 June 1811.⁷⁵ Supporting his request for a 'secours pécuniaire' to help him tide over the crisis, he gave a woeful account of his personal hardship and of the town's sufferings more widely. 'Par la stagnation dans les affaires', he wrote, 'les fabricans sont tous plus ou moins gênés, — ils ont leurs magasins remplis de marchandises finies et prêtes à finir. Tous leurs fonds sont arrêtés, beaucoup de leurs débiteurs payent mal ou pas du tout et ayant journellement à dépenser des écus pour leurs ouvriers, ils ont empruntés [*sic*] des capitaux majeurs à Basle mais à des intérêts onéreux, ce qui les mine peu à peu.'⁷⁶ Vetter claimed that most local manufacturers had either made no sales since January or else been forced to undersell 'pour faire honneur à leurs affaires'. His evidence is important in another way, too. It seems that once the major 'cascade des faillites' of the

⁷³ Hémardinquer, 'Marché français des indiennes', 318-19.

⁷⁴ *Ibid.* 319.

⁷⁵ A.N. F¹² 1583.

⁷⁶ Cf. Oberkampf of Jouy, who in an official reply to the imperial treasury on the state of cotton spinning and calico-printing, wrote on 4 Mar. 1811 that 'les produits ont dépassé les besoins réels' and that 'le nombre des manufactures qui emploient le coton est hors de proportion avec le débouché de leurs produits': quoted in Bergeron, *Banquiers, négociants et manufacturiers parisiens*, ii. 697.

winter had stopped, once the initial withdrawal of funds and clamp-down on new credit by Swiss bankers had eased a little, recovery was possible. But Vetter's letter, which made it clear that those fortunate enough to get Swiss loans did so on unfavourable terms, emphasized the hard road ahead. He believed that the traditional creditors in Basel were crucial to the industrial future of Mulhouse and that a run on funds like the one recently experienced would ruin it. He estimated that the local manufacturers were currently in need of eight to ten million francs of government aid to make good their losses. If this is even an approximate guide to the scale of the crisis in Mulhouse, it represents a sizeable part of the city's estimated turnover of between 26 and 28 million francsworth of printed calicoes a year during the expansionary period.

* * *

Fractional evidence like that, however, is not a satisfactory guide to the precise statistical scale of the crisis. Nor do the official sources help much here, and again there are discrepancies between the running commentaries and the retrospective industrial reports. In the table of figures which the sub-prefect Joliat sent to Desportes on 21 June 1811,⁷⁷ the fall in total industrial employment in Mulhouse (9,613 active workers compared with 15,308 before September 1810) was between a third and two-fifths. Yet the axe had fallen rather variably among the thirty-seven large and middling enterprises listed, of which apparently only seven had managed to maintain their pre-crisis employment levels. The rest had been forced to lay off workers during the troubles. Vetter, Thierry & Grossmann had reduced their former workforce by 300 (17.64 per cent); Dollfus-Mieg and Nicolas Koechlin had each laid off 600 (30 per cent); while Jean Hofer, with a current level of 700, had dispensed with half of his employees at the earlier date. Other firms were even worse affected. Blech-Fries had made a reduction of over half (from 700 to 300 workers), and Daniel Schlumberger (whose employment had tumbled from 950 to 350) had made a cut-back of as much as 63.15 per cent.

⁷⁷ A.N. F¹² 1583.

Over all, when compared with the quarterly returns for 1810, the statistical record of the Haut-Rhin's industrial losses averages out somewhere between 20 and 30 per cent. Yet both output and employment varied considerably between industrial branches as well as between particular firms. In the cotton industry, for example, weaving and printing were worse off than spinning. The retrospective official returns even show a modest improvement in the latter.⁷⁸ Whereas the number of active spindles in Mulhouse itself remained more or less stable at around 1,400 during 1810 and 1811 alike, the department as a whole saw an increase from 22,280 in the first half of 1810 to 24,064 in the second, and then again a more impressive jump from 26,332 to 44,168 during the two halves of 1811. After ministerial queries, however, it became apparent during the following months that the returns for 1810 had been incomplete, and so the actual trend during 1811 is left in doubt.

In any case spinning was the exception, *if* it was an exception, which proved the rule. According to the same retrospective account,⁷⁹ during the first half of 1811 the number of active weaving installations (*métiers à tisser*) in the Haut-Rhin fell by at least a fifth to 3,653, while in Mulhouse the drop to 1,220 installations was nearer a quarter. In the branches of the department's cotton industry taken altogether, the total number of articles produced during 1810 had been 332,690 in the first and 330,632 in the second half-year; during the first of 1811, when the crisis was at its peak, the figure slumped to 240,753, a loss of something more than 27 per cent, before a partial recovery to 277,455 during the second half-year. As most of the articles referred to were printed calicoes, it is clear that the industrial crisis had indeed been most conspicuous in the department's most dynamic and prosperous industrial branch. Within it, the decline in Mulhouse itself (25 per cent) was again higher than in the Haut-Rhin as a whole (22 per cent). The divergence

⁷⁸ Compiled by Desportes from local returns and sent to Montalivet on 14 Mar. 1812: A.N. F¹² 1583. This *carton* contains the statistical details of the breakdown into towns.

⁷⁹ Besides the tables of 14 Mar. 1812, see Lévy, *op. cit.* 281, and L'Huillier, *Alsace napoléonienne*, 378. The figures given in Viennet (*Napoléon et l'industrie française*, 138) and Chabert (*Essai*, 208) are similar and confirm the broad trend.

was more marked in employment levels, as given in the retrospective tables. As against the drop of a third in Mulhouse, the fall in the department's total work-force employed in calico-printing (from 22,619 to 16,943) was nearer a quarter. As late as 12 June 1811 Desportes spoke of at least 15,000 'chômeurs étrangers et régnicoles' in the department.⁸⁰ In the same report he also referred to the 'sterile valleys' of Sainte-Marie. Orbey, Munster, and Saint-Amarin, and his general conclusion stated bluntly: 'situation vraiment allarmante'.

Apart from the *prêts aux manufactures* and a few stop-gap government contracts, which helped certain houses but whose wider importance is easily exaggerated, industrial compensation had to be found elsewhere. Perhaps the most important positive development during and after the crisis was the growth of the kingdom of Italy as a market for the Haut-Rhin's manufacturers. This market was not created because of the crisis, since the conditioning decree of 10 October 1810 preceded its worst phase by several months, but it was certainly a ray of hope during the dark times of 1811. Without it, the industrial glut in the Haut-Rhin would have been more embarrassing, and old stocks would have depreciated further. The imperial decree had imposed a much stricter '*marché réservé*' on the kingdom of Italy.⁸¹ It extended the terms of the decree of 10 June 1806 to cover all ranges of cotton goods: yarn, plaincloth, hosiery, muslins, percales, plain calicoes, dimities, nankeens, *piqués*, *toiles teintes*, *toiles peintes*, as well as all articles in which cotton was mixed with flax, wool, or silk. Imports of all such goods other than from France were banned in the kingdom, and at the same time the decree halved the duties on permitted imperial imports within that range. In the ministerial circular of 20 November 1810 advertising the decree Montalivet claimed that 'c'est un grand débouché qu'elle [Sa Majesté] a fermé, d'une main, aux fabriques de coton étrangères, et qu'elle a ouvert, de l'autre, aux manufactures du même genre que nous possédons'.⁸² His encouragement to manufacturers to take advantage of this new market had a response

⁸⁰ Report to Montalivet: A.N. F¹² 1583.

⁸¹ A.N. F¹² 2473; A.D. (H-R) I M 126b.

⁸² Ibid.

among several of the Haut-Rhin's leading *indienneurs*. The export trade to Italy was most brisk in 1812 and 1813, but it had got well under way during 1811. L'Huillier speaks of it as a 'négoce actif' at that time.⁸³ Following his evidence,⁸⁴ based on the prefectoral tables for the years 1811-14,⁸⁵ at least thirty firms of the Haut-Rhin took part in the Italian trade during the first year of the decree. My own inspection of the prefectoral tables confirms the conclusion that the main beneficiaries here were Dollfus-Mieg, the revived Gros, Davillier & Roman, Nicolas Koechlin, Daniel Schlumberger, François Verdan, and Blech-Fries.

Altogether, then, the industries of the Haut-Rhin weathered the crisis of 1810-11. No branch was permanently harmed by it. A signal expansion into Italian markets partly offset the contraction of those at home and in the *Outre-Rhin*, where much of the earlier purchasing power fell away. The crisis did not interrupt the technical advance of the department's cotton industries. The headway made since the Consulate, and especially since the summer of 1807, had been cut back but not entirely lost. An inherently strong industrial structure could withstand the general slump in output and employment averaging something between a quarter and a third. Calico-printing, the backbone of the Haut-Rhin's industrial economy, survived intact. The larger enterprises either had or found resources to tide over the crisis and recover from it afterwards. As for the mass of smaller concerns, many were pushed to the brink of ruin, but the great majority lived to fight another day.

v. *The aftermath of crisis: Strasbourg and the 'stop-go' cycle 1811-1813*

The official records of the last two years of the Blockade present a frustrating irony. They are very much fuller in statistical detail than for any other period of the Napoleonic Empire, but they are also the most unreliable. Indeed, their very frequency and volume explain their inadequacies. The requirement of routine monthly and quarterly reports

⁸³ *Alsace napoléonienne*, 390. ⁸⁴ *Ibid.* 394. ⁸⁵ A.D. (H-R) I M 126b.

by both the Minister of the Interior and the Minister of Trade and Industry, when this new portfolio took effect as from 1 January 1812, imposed an enormous strain on the prefects and their subordinate officials. There were frequent complaints that the time allowed for the endless surveys was insufficient and the range of economic information required too vast for the compilation of accurate figures. When special and retrospective surveys were demanded on top of the current reports, the administrative burden became intolerable, and our approach to the returns actually made must be appropriately cautious. Of the 136 'espèces d'industrie' on which Collin de Sussy's ministerial circular of 6 May 1812 required information, Strasbourg alone had 100. The mayor complained that his existing staff was wholly inadequate for the task of making contact with the 2,000 individual houses concerned in the time available.⁸⁶ The larger the official compilations became, the more likely they were to have errors of progressive dilution. The margin of error must have widened as the figures were sifted in stages from the units of the commune, *arrondissement*, and department to form the eventual national totals which were presented to Napoleon. It is of course quite possible that these were important to the extent that they were taken seriously and may even have influenced official policy, for instance in the allocation of imperial 'licences', but that is no vindication of their intrinsic worth. Montalivet's great *Exposé* of 1813, based on the official returns for industry and trade from all over the Empire, was a labour of monumental unreliability.

This section of the chapter, then, is an attempt to make some sense out of the mountains of official records which exist for the perhaps too-documented years 1811-13. And yet one general conclusion would not be in doubt: the worst of the economic crisis had blown over by the end of 1811. The first clear signs of recovery may be dated to the last and in some branches to the third quarter of the year. What followed was slow and hard-won recovery rather than any new burst of optimistic expansion. The period from October 1811 to the final disintegration of the Blockade during the summer

⁸⁶ Brackenhoffer to Lezay-Marnésia on 4 June 1812: A.D. (B-R) XIII M 6.

of 1813 was not an especially happy one for imperial industry and trade. Maritime trade made a modest revival under the regime of the 'licences'. In the inland areas which had been the main growth-points of 1807-10, output and employment improved slowly and unevenly to something under their levels before the crisis. Military markets gave a new impetus to certain industries as the campaigns of 1812-14 were materially provided for. But the impact of the crisis lingered on in the form of generally tight credit, and cash was scarce almost everywhere. Commercial dealings were carried on under the constant vagaries of the 'terreur douanière', at least until the smuggling bonanza which followed Napoleon's defeat in Russia. In the subject and allied states, where the crisis was often exacerbated by monetary depreciation and agricultural depression, markets were not what they had been during the expansionary years. Higher taxes, stiffer requisitioning, and the growing strain of war all sapped the economic strength of the Empire and its allies.

The performance of the Alsatian economy during the period 1811-13 may be summed up as one of recovery and recession. No clear sequence is discernible in the two departments as a whole. The pattern was made up of variable fits and starts. This reflects in the running commentary of the Chamber of Commerce in Strasbourg. The 'stop-go' cycle into which the city's trade fell after the crisis prolonged some of the features of the latter, but the lulls were less pronounced and never absolute, while the forward spurts were more vigorous. The fluctuation of traffic through the entre-pôt is better illustrated by the Chamber's monthly and quarterly reports (that is, the on-going record)⁸⁷ than by its more questionable statistical tables of December 1813, discussed in earlier chapters. According to the routine reports, then, the city's river trade made a good recovery during October and November 1811, before slowing up in December and January. This was a common mid-winter trend. February

⁸⁷ These are conveniently pulled together in the summary for the mayor dated 10 Nov. 1812: meeting of 21 Nov. following, Min. vii. See the graphic illustration of this in Appendix F (below, p. 284), which is based on the figures in Appendix D.

and March 1812 saw a clear improvement, and there followed the familiar brisk spurt in April and May. During the first half of 1812 the Strasbourg barges carried a total of 103,344 metric quintals of goods down river and 12,440 up river. These were good figures when compared with the half-yearly average preceding them. During the same period the Mainz barges carried 13,741 metric quintals from and 7,178 to Strasbourg. Those, by contrast, were comparatively poor returns. The pace of river traffic slackened noticeably during the second half of that year, and the normally active months from July to October were particularly disappointing. Customs rigours were partly to blame, as were the higher imperial *droits réunis*, which drew reprisals against French goods entering the Rhenish Confederation. Another contributory factor was a stretch of unusually bad weather during June, July, and August. Heavy rains made the passage of goods from the French Midi more difficult and held up the Rhine dispatches. On 7 July, for instance, nineteen of the lesser merchants of Strasbourg complained in a petition to the mayor that 'perpetual rains' had spoilt the fair of St. John and asked, unsuccessfully, for a week's extension of its term.⁸⁸

In spite of the official closure of the entrepôt for Levantine cotton on 1 July 1811, supplies of this commodity continued to reach Strasbourg during 1812, though in smaller quantities. On 30 January Maximilien Pougnet informed Briensiaux that 'les cotons du Levant ne sont plus abondants ici, malgré cela les prix sont bas'.⁸⁹ Even so, he was able to send specimens and price quotations to Lille during the following summer, but his accompanying request for prompt settlement of earlier deals may be evidence of liquidity problems.⁹⁰ On 6 September 1812 the Chamber reported to the prefect that supplies of Levantine cotton were still arriving in the city, and its explanation was that the official Illyrian and Italian entrepôts were, as predicted, proving inadequate to satisfy all of the imperial demand.⁹¹ The same report

⁸⁸ Arch. comm. Strasb., B3° 53-318.

⁸⁹ Pougnet, formerly an associate of Sautier & Cie, had set up business on his own in Strasbourg in January 1812: A.N. 3 AQ 339.

⁹⁰ Letters of 27 May and 20 June 1812: A.N. 3 AQ 339.

⁹¹ A.D. (B-R) XII M 11.

noted that exports to Germany had improved slightly, but the expected expeditions from the Midi had still not arrived, and what was broadly called 'le mouvement des affaires' had slackened rather than quickened. During the last quarter of the year the lull became more pronounced. On 6 November the Chamber reported an active trade in wines to the north, but otherwise its message was the familiar 'total stagnation'.⁹²

The year 1813 was full of troubles for Strasbourg. Even the retrospective tables of December 1813, which show 1812 as the city's commercial peak under Napoleonic rule, have comparatively low figures for it.⁹³ The winter of 1812-13 was by all accounts unusually severe and prolonged. Rhenish traffic was frequently held up by ice and poor visibility. As the whole structure of the imperial customs surveillance deteriorated with the troops away on campaign, smuggling gained a new lease of life. It may be that the lower trade figures for 1813 merely disguise a more active illicit traffic, but this cannot be proved. It seems more likely that the campaigns of 1813-14 made merchants nervous about distant transactions and had a depressing effect on foreign dealings. Like other departments of the Rhenish left bank, the Bas-Rhin and Haut-Rhin felt the draught of the Allied military advance some weeks before the imperial army retreated across the Rhine. It was then that the negative aspects of military demands became more prominent, as the monthly and quarterly reports for 1813 often remark.⁹⁴

The over-all assessment, then, must be mixed. It seems fair to conclude that the crisis was followed in Strasbourg by just under a year of unspectacular commercial recovery until roughly the mid-summer of 1812, and then by eighteen months of rather broken and generally unsatisfactory trade, with perhaps more compensation through illicit traffic than the official reports allow. Altogether, between December 1810 and October 1813 there were forty recorded bankruptcies in the Bas-Rhin.⁹⁵ Eighteen of these fell within

⁹² A.D. (B-R) XII M 11.

⁹³ See Appendices B and E below, pp. 276-7 and 283 respectively.

⁹⁴ Various kept at A.D. (B-R) XII M 10, 11, and 12.

⁹⁵ This total is made up of *reported* cases which I have come across in the Chamber's minutes for 1810 and 1811 and in its quarterly returns for 1812 and 1813.

the period of crisis itself; the rest occurred during the two years following June 1811. Most of the victims were Strasbourgeois, and for comparison it is worth noting that only four bankruptcies had been recorded in the department during the expansionary years 1807-10. This is the kind of evidence which adds weight to Félix Ponteil's reference to 'la décadence des dernières années de l'Empire'.⁹⁶ After the Vienna settlement, with the revival of French maritime trade and of more reciprocal tariffs for industrial protection in the Rhenish lands, the Strasbourgeois were to learn the meaning of real commercial eclipse.

* * *

The industrial reports on the Bas-Rhin during the period under discussion here have the same pitfalls as the commercial record. Their main drawback is incompleteness, itself due to the lack of adequate time for collecting all the information required. Some of the inaccuracies were so glaring that the ministers more than once rebuked Lezay-Marnésia for laxity. Yet one must, of course, make the best of the reports, for otherwise it would be impossible to generalize for the period at all. The two main documentary collections which matter here are the prefectoral tables for the Bas-Rhin dated May 1812 and February 1813⁹⁷ and Brackenhoffer's mayoral tables for Strasbourg itself, variously dated as 20 March, 16 June, 25 August, and 8 December 1812, and 13 February, 22 April, 6 July, and 7 October 1813.⁹⁸ These give half-yearly estimates of the number of active installations and of output and employment levels in the various industrial branches between January 1810 and, in most cases, June 1813. Whatever their inadequacies, there is no other comparable statistical guide to the Bas-Rhin's industrial fluctuations in the period.

Taken as a whole, these documents suggest a slow and uneven recovery from the crisis, especially in Strasbourg.

⁹⁶ 'Blocus continental dans la région rhénane', 12.

⁹⁷ Compiled in reply to Montalivet's ministerial circular of 30 Sept. 1811: all at A.N. F¹² 1583.

⁹⁸ Compiled in reply to Collin de Sussy's ministerial circular of 21 Feb. 1812: all at A.D. (B-R) XIII M 28.

The general trend was one of variable advance rather than of any new expansionary momentum. Mechanization progressed in the larger enterprises, but 1813 was on the whole a year of set-backs for the manufacturers. As in the case of trade, there was a good deal of variation between and indeed within the different industrial branches. In the cotton industry, for example, Jean Malapert was something of a special case. A marked reallocation of resources occurred in his workshops. The number of active spindles remained fairly stable at about the crisis figure of 8,000, and yet his employment rose from 340 persons in 1811 to 550 in 1812, before dropping to 420 early in 1813. Since his production of yarn declined steadily from even the reduced level of the crisis, the new hands must have been employed to boost his output of muslins and percales, so that the enterprise clearly changed in character after 1810. Engelhardt-Kern and Sandherr & Redslob were apparently unable to override the effects of crisis by similarly diversifying production. There was no sustained recovery in either case, though the second half of 1812 saw a slight improvement in output. Louis Roederer had a struggle to maintain his employment level at between 145 and 160 and his production of percales, muslins, and calicoes at between 27,000 and 31,000 articles per quarter during 1812. Both figures fell sharply in the first half of 1813, and in the second the firm collapsed.

In woollens, it is clear from the official reports that J.-G. Dietsch never recovered his expansionary momentum of 1807-10. His output of spun wool, cloth, jerseys, and blankets was lower in 1812 than during the year of crisis preceding it. It appears that he was hit by the centralization of military purchases in Paris before and during the Russian campaign. Conversely, when his production made an out-of-phase improvement in 1813, military orders were again the major stimulus. The linen industries fared no better on the whole. The figures for Vetter and Joseph Bernard in Strasbourg show a steady decline from the crisis through to the summer of 1813. Vetter's troubles were reportedly due to the loss of foreign markets, notably during the hostilities of 1812 and 1813. Brackenhoffer's tables suggest that the smaller producers in this branch, whose production was

intended mainly for known local demand, were less affected. The 136 'maîtres-tisserands patentés' in Strasbourg were forced to cut back their combined output of table-cloths, wrapping cloth, and *siamoises*, but by a smaller percentage than the larger individual houses. Their reduction in 1811 was between a quarter and a third, with the trend stronger in the second half-year. After a slight improvement during the early months of 1812, the decline was slow but steady. The linen manufacturers of Fegersheim, whose market was also largely local, did less well in 1812 than in earlier years, and 1813 was still more slack, although the absolute figures for active installations and workers employed did not change noticeably over the period. At Gau frères, manufacturers of sailcloth, it was the familiar old story of roughly stable production even in these troubled years, but with output and employment well below the firm's real capacity.

The theme which recurs most often in the industrial reports is that of market default. Phrases like 'faute de débouchés', 'défaut de vente', 'entraves dans la vente', and 'mévente générale' abound in them. The brief panic over threatened agricultural shortage in both Alsatian departments in 1812, after the poor grain harvest of the preceding year, made matters worse for a time. The seriousness of this particular episode should not however be exaggerated.⁹⁹ The panic was short-lived and well contained by local officials,¹⁰⁰ and the good harvest of 1812 righted matters. It would be misleading, then, to invoke the classic formula of 'prix du blé, thermomètre des fabriques' as a major cause of the commercial and industrial unevenness of the few years following the crisis, as was certainly to be the case during the serious shortage of 1816-17. Yet it cannot have been entirely alien to the Chamber's meaning when, in its quarterly report of 7 October 1811, it remarked that 'les consommations diminuent sur beaucoup d'articles par suite de leur haut prix et des causes qui réagissent sur l'aisance de diverses classes'.¹⁰¹

⁹⁹ On this see F. L'Huillier, 'Une crise des subsistances dans le Bas-Rhin (1810-1812)', *A.h.R.f.*, xiv (1937), 518-36.

¹⁰⁰ Papers dealing with Alsatian grain markets during the closing years of the Empire are kept at A.D. (B-R) III M 3 and IX M 106 and 107; A.D. (H-R) I M 103/1; Arch. comm. Colm., REH 13; and Arch. comm. Mulh., F^{viii}.

¹⁰¹ Meeting of the same date, Min. vi.

This problem, as P.-J. Chedeaux fairly observed in a report to Collin de Sussy at the end of the Blockade,¹⁰² was more acute in traditional export markets beyond the Rhine than in the beleaguered Empire itself.

* * *

Two details of the Bas-Rhin's industrial record during the final years of the Empire call for further comment, either because of their economic importance or because of their presumed link with the aims of the Blockade. They are the development of the so-called 'new' or 'substitute industries' and the performance of the Alsatian tobacco industry under the government's monopoly.

The first of these need not detain us long, since the positive results of official policy came rather late in the day and, in the Bas-Rhin at least, were confined to a particular commodity. In any case the causal link with the Blockade was not at all clear here. The wider imperial context of this question can be misleading, because it is tempting to see the development of new enterprises set up to produce (or rather, in several cases, to experiment with the production of) certain foodstuffs and industrial raw materials as a deliberate attempt to mitigate the deprivations of the 'self-blockade'. Sir Francis d'Ivernois once remarked that by accepting the Blockade, France 'préfère rester sans jouissances à n'avoir que des demi-jouissances'.¹⁰³ He was not an impartial observer, though, and a facile caricature of the Continental communities bitterly making do with ersatz foodstuffs and industrial primary materials would distort the facts. It is true that the imperial propaganda encouraged the notion that more home-grown or home-made goods would cut back the payment of 'ransom' for essential imports. There may thus be a tendency to construe the imperial sugar-beet industry¹⁰⁴ as an integral function of the Blockade's outlawry of 'tainted' colonial

¹⁰² Chedeaux, the president of the trade tribunal and a member of the municipal council of Metz, had been sent by the Minister on a trade mission to the Rhenish Confederation. His report is dated 20 Sept. 1813: A.N. F¹² 2377.

¹⁰³ *Exposé de l'Exposé . . . de 1813*, 117 n.

¹⁰⁴ On which see Chaptal, *Mémoire sur le sucre de betteraves* (Paris, 1818), and Drottboom, *Wirtschaftsgeographische Betrachtungen*, 32-43.

cane sugar. The argument might similarly be pursued for chicory vice colonial coffee,¹⁰⁵ for madder-wort vice cochineal as a red dye and pastel vice indigo as a blue one,¹⁰⁶ for artificial soda vice vegetable derivatives as primary materials for the *savonneries* of Provence and Languedoc,¹⁰⁷ and even for Neapolitan vice trans-Atlantic raw cotton.¹⁰⁸ The practical outcome of those ventures was variable, however. Where there was any significant industrial impact, it came later in the century, long after the Blockade.

And yet it is noteworthy that one of the few 'new industries' which had any short-term effect was beet-sugar and that its earliest advances were registered mainly in imperial Alsace. Such progress came too late in the period for any obvious causal link with the Blockade to be established, and as in the case of other 'new industries' there were autonomous and unrelated reasons for entrepreneurial endeavour. Nevertheless, for what it was worth, Montalivet's *Exposé* of 1813 placed the Bas-Rhin first among the imperial departments in the production of beet-sugar.¹⁰⁹ It stated that the department had 3,500 *arpents* given over to this cultivation, while their fourteen *sucreries* were reckoned to produce some 500,000 kg a year.¹¹⁰ The most important of these was near Strasbourg and was supervised on the government's behalf by Maximilien Isnard.

As for the effect of the official tobacco monopoly during

¹⁰⁵ In a letter of 27 Oct. 1810 Hegel referred ironically to chicory as the French 'café patriotique': quoted in Jean Mistler, 'Hambourg sous l'occupation française. Observations au sujet du Blocus continental', *Francia*, i (1973), 452.

¹⁰⁶ On the experiments with artificial dyestuffs and on the development of the imperial chemical industries more generally, see Chaptal, *L'Art de la teinture du coton en rouge* (Paris, 1807); Drottboom, *op. cit.* 43-62; André Thépot, 'Le Système continental et les débuts de l'industrie chimique en France', *R. Inst. Nap.* (1966), 79-84; and Robert Tinthoin, 'Chaptal, créateur de l'industrie chimique française', *Fédération historique du Languedoc méditerranéen et du Roussillon, XXXe et XXXIe Congrès, Sète-Beaucaire* (1956-7), 195-206.

¹⁰⁷ This is cogently discussed in Thépot, *art. cit.*

¹⁰⁸ The optimistic plan to make Naples the 'tropical element of the Empire', as Jacques Rambaud puts it, is discussed in his *Naples sous Joseph Bonaparte 1806-1808* (Paris, 1911), esp. chap. XIII.

¹⁰⁹ See the tables on pp. 85-6 of that account.

¹¹⁰ A prefectoral report of 13 Oct. 1811 had given the total area set aside for beet-sugar in the Bas-Rhin as 393 hectares, with the following breakdown by *arrondissement*: Wissembourg 178.83 h, Sélestat 85.81 h, Strasbourg 67.30 h, and Saverne 60.96 h: A.D. (B-R) XI M 247.

the first three years of the *Régie*, which is a question of far greater economic importance, the evidence is contradictory. The Chamber's communications disseminate the view of general hostility to the new regime, but otherwise there is little evidence of its universal unpopularity in the department much before the new tobacco laws of January 1813.¹¹¹ The large-scale growers and processors certainly opposed the monopoly from the start, and no doubt their profits actually fell after 29 December 1810. The customs rigours and bureaucratic delays of imperial officials were also often extreme. In one such instance, which involved the sequestration of a tobacco expedition from Dominique Dangelo & fils of Strasbourg to Briensiaux in Lille in 1811-12, several months elapsed before the *Régie* completed its inspection and finally gave its consent to the clearance of the goods.¹¹² Other houses such as Christophe Dillemann experienced similar interruptions.¹¹³

On the other hand, there is no decisive evidence of any major drop in tobacco output during the first two years of the *Régie*. It is even possible that the smaller growers benefited from regular sales to the *Régie* — sales which had not been assured under the former system of private engrossment. The comparative tables drawn up early in 1813 show no significant drop in the surface area of the Bas-Rhin planted in tobacco during 1811 and 1812.¹¹⁴ A small reduction in the number of hectares in the *arrondissements* of Wissembourg, Sélestat, and Saverne was matched by an increase in that of Strasbourg. The tobacco harvest of 1811 was good, both in output and quality, and in the following year the Bas-Rhin was able to supply more than a third of all French needs.¹¹⁵ The advantages of the *Régie* to the lesser producers were sometimes remarked on in official reports. In that for the second quarter of 1811, for example, the sub-prefect in Sélestat had little to complain about under the

¹¹¹ The *liasse* A.D. (B-R) XI M 188 has documents on official tobacco policy and the internal organization of the *Régie* between 1811 and 1830.

¹¹² Documents in the dossier marked 'Dangelo & Fils': A.N. 3 AQ 339.

¹¹³ Relevant documents in *ibid.*

¹¹⁴ The tables are undated, but contextual references make it clear that they were compiled in Jan. or Feb. 1813: A.D. (B-R) XI M 197.

¹¹⁵ L'Huillier, *Alsace napoléonienne*, 451.

heading of 'tobacco sales'.¹¹⁶ He wrote instead that 'les payemens réguliers faits par le gouvernement ont rendu la vie à l'industrie et offrent à l'agriculture des moyens de développement'. Since the *arrondissement* of Sélestat was if anything more important than that of Strasbourg as a tobacco-growing (as distinct from tobacco-processing) area, such evidence offsets the Chamber's implacable laments. The latter were naturally much more concerned with the interests of the large-scale dealers who had its ear, but even the local evidence did not always fit its woeful picture. In his report for the second quarter of 1811 Lezay-Marnésia also made the point that the *Régie* had ensured a living 'au grand nombre d'ouvriers que la suppression des fabriques particulières avait laissé en suspens', and that employment in this branch had not fallen dramatically.¹¹⁷

As from the early months of 1813, however, when new tobacco laws took effect, the evidence of widespread opposition to them becomes overwhelming. The advertised reason for the new measures had to do with certain fraudulent practices and the undesirable effects, as the government saw it, of no restriction on the type of tobacco grown in the Empire. The official argument was that the emphasis during the years of private enterprise had been on quantity rather than quality of output, and that this had led to commercial abuses. Some producers themselves had expressed concern about this and blamed it for the comparatively higher sales of Dutch tobacco of better quality in the Empire as from the beginning of 1811. The first important step towards a change of policy came with Collin de Sussy's *arrêté* of 10 November 1812. To counter the problem of inferior tobacco and the growing number of professional abuses, it stipulated that as from 1 January 1813 tobacco farming was to be confined to 10,000 hectares of the Empire, distributed among seventeen departments, of which the Bas-Rhin's allocation was to be 2,300 hectares. At the same time stiffer *droits réunis* were to be imposed on both tobacco processing and the retail trade. The theme of 'quality before quantity' was to remain the government's touchstone in reply to protests

¹¹⁶ A.D. (B-R) X M 5.

¹¹⁷ Ibid.

from producers during the closing years of the Empire and indeed under the Restoration.

The ministerial directive was followed up by local measures issued through the direction general of the *droits réunis* in the eastern departments. Altogether, sixty-three communes of the Bas-Rhin lost the right to cultivate tobacco. The 2,300 permitted hectares were distributed among the other interested communes, which were to be grouped into two tobacco-producing circumscriptions centred on Strasbourg and Sélestat.¹¹⁸ In spite of a great many protests and petitions to Paris during 1813, and the vigorous prefectoral support for them on several occasions, the government refused to extend its allocations. Perhaps the main effect of the new laws was that the smaller producers were principally affected. From January 1813 they were slowly squeezed out of business, as the larger enterprises became more and more concentrated, and so for rather different reasons joined the magnates in the campaign against the official constraints. In Napoleonic times anyway, such solidarity within the industry was unique. The administration was aware of the plight of the small producers but considered it a necessary sacrifice. As Francay, the director-general of the *droits réunis*, explained in reply to a letter of protest from Lezay-Marnésia, 'ayant chaque jour une nouvelle expérience sur la nécessité de restreindre la culture [of tobacco] et de la concentrer dans les mains des cultivateurs aisés, je ne pouvais . . . partager votre opinion sur l'inutilité des circonscriptions'.¹¹⁹ Whatever the opposition to the government's tobacco policy after 1813, even among the 'cultivateurs aisés' thus relatively favoured, the quality of production in the Bas-Rhin improved. From this particular point of view the aims of the imperial policy were to be posthumously achieved.

vi. *The aftermath of crisis in the Haut-Rhin 1811-1813*

The record of the Haut-Rhin's industrial performance during the two years following the crisis presents the same problem of incomplete and contradictory evidence. It seems clear

¹¹⁸ Documents in A.D. (B-R) XI M 197.

¹¹⁹ Letter of 22 Mar. 1813: *ibid.*

enough that there was a stretch of recovery before the serious upheaval of the Allied invasion of 1813-14. L'Huillier thinks that it ran from the summer of 1812 to the autumn of 1813, when 'almost all the lost ground' was recovered.¹²⁰ He adds, however, that price variations over the Napoleonic period as a whole make such comparisons between its phases inconclusive.

My own research confirms the conclusion that the department's cotton industries, the essential barometer, emerged from the crisis during the last quarter of 1811 and showed further improvement in the following year. The recovery may have continued on into 1813, but in my opinion the pace was less impressive than that of 1807-10, and the 'lost ground' was not almost made up. One reason for the slower momentum was that Swiss creditors were less willing to contribute to or themselves undertake industrial ventures in Alsace after the crisis. Only the most creditworthy houses like Dollfus-Mieg, Paul Blech, and Nicolas Koechlin could count on large advances of capital from Basel. Others managed to borrow elsewhere, as Robert Bovet & Cie of Thann did in Neuchâtel. But as against such links one should set the former Swiss creditors who withdrew in stages from Alsace. Daniel Schlumberger lost his sleeping partner in 1812; Vetter, Thierry & Grossmann theirs in 1813; Blanchenay-Bridel theirs in 1814. Even Paul Blech had to witness the withdrawal of his Swiss associates in the latter year, and in 1815 Jérémie Risler and Nicolas Koechlin were similarly affected. In these years, moreover, some of the Swiss manufacturers who had set up business in the Haut-Rhin in happier times returned to their native land.¹²¹ As was the case during the crisis itself, so in 1811-13 the main foreign stimulus to production in the Haut-Rhin was the '*marché réservé*' in the kingdom of Italy. Roughly a fifth of the department's output of cotton goods was exported in 1812, mostly to that destination. The proportion was larger still in some of the leading enterprises. Dollfus-Mieg exported up to a quarter of his production that year; Gros, Davillier & Roman, Robert

¹²⁰ *Alsace napoléonienne*, 398.

¹²¹ The details of the above paragraph are drawn mainly from Lévy-Leboyer, *Banques européennes*, 451-2.

Bovet, and Blanchenay-Bridel nearer a third of theirs; and a level of two-fifths was recorded by Lhuillier frères and Ziegler-Greuter.¹²² The main competition in Italian markets at that time came, as before, from the *indienneurs* based in or near Paris.¹²³

The official statistics for the Haut-Rhin's industrial showing in these years give at least a crude guide to the scale of the recovery. L'Huillier's figures,¹²⁴ extrapolated no doubt with some headaches from the jumble of prefectural tables, show good headway in cotton spinning. From 26,332 active spindles during the first half of 1811 the departmental total rose to 47,908 by the end of that year, and then remained fairly steady at this level during 1812. The output of yarn over the same period increased from a half-yearly average of just over 54,000 to nearly 80,000 kg. In the cotton-weaving sector, the number of active installations rose slightly from 3,643 to 3,843 during the first quarter of 1812, but thereafter it did not apparently reach its level of 4,500 before the crisis. In Mulhouse itself there may even have been a slight decline: at the beginning of 1812 the number of active weaving installations was 995, compared with 1,220 during the first half of 1811.¹²⁵ In the key sector of calico-printing, however, the departmental totals for employment and production increased between the same two half-years. In employment the rise was from 16,943 to 19,727 persons (a figure which plainly includes the mass of rural producers who supplied the *indienneurs* with woven cloth for printing), and the level steadied at around 20,000 until September 1813, when it fell again. As for output, the 277,455 *toiles peintes* produced during the first half of 1812 meant a rise of just over 15 per cent on the crisis level, but here too a plateau had been reached for the next year or more. If further sales on the home market proved more difficult during 1813, higher prices were part of the reason, as Hémardinquer found in his examination of western and southern markets. Gaspard

¹²² A.N. F¹² 1583; L'Huillier, *Alsace napoléonienne*, 395, 398.

¹²³ Notably Oberkampf, Jean Mottet, André Roche & Cie, Laurent & Esprit, and Aubert frères: Bergeron, *Banquiers, négociants et manufacturiers parisiens*, ii. 672-7.

¹²⁴ Op. cit. 397-8, based on A.N. F¹² 1583.

¹²⁵ L'Huillier, op. cit. 358, 398.

Dollfus was for instance asking 25 per cent more for his '*mouchoirs-châles*' in the autumn of that year than in 1812.¹²⁶ Oberkampf of Jouy was one alternative supplier who benefited from such deflected demand among southern clients at that time.

Recovery from the crisis was apparently more difficult in the smaller industrial towns of the Haut-Rhin. At Sainte-Marie, in particular, the troubles had set in earlier and lasted longer than in Mulhouse. Its active cotton installations had fallen from a level of 1,208 to 1,085 during 1810, and there was a further decline to 791 in the first half of 1811 and to 605 in the second half of 1812.¹²⁷ No ostensible recovery from the slump came until — and inexplicably — the number of installations rose suddenly to 900 at the beginning of 1814.¹²⁸ Throughout 1813, at any rate, the reports from Sainte-Marie's consultative chamber sank to new levels of verbal calamity and make the most depressing reading.¹²⁹ Elsewhere, it seems, recovery during 1812 gave way to recession in 1813. The local reports from Belfort, Guebwiller, Wesserling, Munster, Bollwiller, Cernay, Masevaux, and the Logelbach all emphasize that industrial employment, production, and sales in 1813 were well down on the previous year's returns.¹³⁰ The metal industries of the department were in a similar recession. The prefectoral reports for 1812 and 1813 point to a stagnation, or worse, in total production from the early months of 1811,¹³¹ and further upsets were to come with the Allied invasion. Altogether, then, as far as the *official* record is concerned, the Continental Blockade in Alsace ended where it had begun: in an economic environment of prevailing gloom. In spite of happier times in between, it appears that the wheel had come full circle. A critical reappraisal of the same official record, however, leaves us with a different overview of the whole cycle and its effects.

¹²⁶ 'Marché français des indiennes', 316.

¹²⁷ L'Huillier, *op. cit.* 398.

¹²⁸ *Ibid.*

¹²⁹ A.D. (H-R) I M 124/1.

¹³⁰ The reports are kept mainly at A.D. (H-R) I M 127/1.

¹³¹ *Ibid.*, and A.N. F¹² 1609.

CONCLUSION

A traditional lopsidedness in the historiography of Napoleon's Continental Blockade has left us with a no less unbalanced view of its aims and effects. Its 'sea aspects' remain more prominent than its 'land aspects' in the literature on the subject, and this in turn has influenced the most familiar interpretation of the Blockade's importance. Most earlier writers, though indeed not all, have concluded that its aims were based on an outmoded and impracticable economic dogma and that its results were largely unsuccessful, and even self-destructive, for this reason. Our verdict on the whole episode, it thus appears, ought to be suitably negative.

Yet a closer study of many inland parts of the Napoleonic Empire, and even of some of the allied states on the Continental mainland, puts the full impact of the Blockade in a rather different light. Since the great mass of the Continental population did not inhabit the beleaguered maritime ports of that time, and did not therefore experience the Blockade directly through the disruption of sea-borne trade, it seems necessary to broaden the focus so as to include inland areas whose traditional economic orbits were differently orientated. This broader view reveals in fact that some of the Blockade's aims were more positive and constructive, and some of its effects more beneficial, than would appear from the generally dismal record of the maritime regions under its regime. The Blockade should not then be construed as an unqualified failure throughout the lands subjected to Napoleonic rule. Even where its impact was certainly harmful, it was only the climacteric of a wider economic dislocation whose origins lay in the maritime wars of the Revolutionary conflict.

During the period immediately preceding the Berlin decree of 21 November 1806, which with the Milan decrees of the following year officially defined the Blockade at its start, France did not enjoy an economic predominance on the

Continent to match her military might. In default of it, Napoleon hoped to establish an economic mastery on the hard base of his military and political power. His motives were at once aggressive and defensive, his aims at once destructive and constructive. In the first instance he wanted to eliminate Britain from all military involvements on the Continent. But as he had not the means to confront her directly on the seas and settle scores by a test of naval or military force, he was driven to an extraordinary adaptation of the weapon of commercial blockade. The nuance was that his so-called 'Continental Blockade' was in effect a vastly conceived 'self-blockade', or 'boycott', and in its short-term aspect it resembled a wartime contingency operation (*machine de guerre*). Its logic was that if Britain could be shut out of Continental markets, she would be left with the problem of growing commercial and industrial surpluses. If at the same time her bullion reserves could be drained off in payment for essential imports, the monetary inflation thus induced would force her to accept peace terms favourable to France and also undermine her ability to subsidize further Continental coalitions.

Now, as the front line of that policy was obviously drawn along the Continental coastline, and more particularly its Channel and North Sea stretches, the historiographical emphasis is very properly on the maritime aspects of the whole conflict. This in turn fairly stresses the more aggressive aims and destructive effects of the Blockade. It was not, however, the whole of the imperial plan. Another aim, conceived in the longer view, was to build up French industry, trade, and technological prowess to the point where they could fill the vacuum left by the expulsion of their British counterparts. This objective was necessarily conditioned by the land-locked nature of French power. Not only was it formulated within the extraordinary military and political structure of 1805-7; it would have been inconceivable outside it. In this sense, too, it was an inverse function of the Empire's naval impotence.

Among the difficulties facing French merchants and manufacturers in the years preceding the Blockade, one was common to the coastal and inland regions. This was the

problem of French markets, in the sense of *both* outlets *and* supply-lines, following successive colonial and other transmarine losses. Its rough scale is conventionally put at about a third of France's import and a fifth of her export trade, as registered in the official values current at the end of the old regime. The eclipse of the imperial navy made any redress directly on the seas impracticable. Again the Blockade was not the original cause of those troubles, which had set in a decade or more earlier with the assertion of Britain's naval supremacy and her engrossment of colonial markets overseas, but it undoubtedly added to the tribulations of the maritime ports and the dependent industries of their immediate *hinterländer*.

Against this background, the positive aspect of Napoleon's Blockade was that it offered an alternative system of markets on a much greater scale than any attempted before. It incorporated, among other aims, what this work presents as a French Continental market design (*dessein des marchés*) to set alongside the image of a 'war machine'. The search for 'markets of replacement' on the Continental mainland itself had short-term and long-term aims. First, it was an *ad hoc* adjustment to the vacuum left by French transmarine losses. In the wider perspective, it looked beyond the mastery of the Continental mainland to a future in which the international balance of maritime power could be righted, or in which France might even extend her dominance from the mainland to the seas. But within this optimistic vision of the realignment of economic forces in Europe, Napoleon's Continental or mainland aims were uppermost. As his power was land-based, so his military, political, and economic priorities were essentially Europocentric.

The inherent weakness of the French market design was its deliberate one-sidedness. It was conceived and operated on the principle of 'la France avant tout'. What was envisaged was not a Continental *Zollverein* in which all the resources of the Empire, of the subject and allied states, could be harnessed through reciprocal favours and equitable sacrifices to the common cause of defeating Britain, but rather a vast 'Uncommon Market' geared to French interests. The Blockade decrees, the rough treatment of would-be neutrals,

the proclamation of the closed market (*marché réservé*) in Italy, and the series of preferential trade treaties with client states — all joined towards that purpose. Although angled at Britain above all, the protection and preferential encouragement of imperial industry and trade were also intended to weaken the challenge of economic competitors on the Continent itself. While the market design was broadly directed at all the subject and allied states, the German lands across the Rhine had a particular importance within it. Imperial exporters set their sights on Frankfurt am Main and Leipzig, which were then the main centres of distribution for the industrial products and merchandise marketed in Germany, and whose famous fairs were the high-points of the commercial year there.

Napoleonic Alsace, that is the departments of the Bas-Rhin and the Haut-Rhin, was central to the French market design in Germany by virtue of its geographical position. Special importance attached to Strasbourg as an entrepôt for both the outgoing and incoming trade of the Empire, and to Mulhouse as a developing industrial town, notably in cotton manufacture. It has been the main purpose of this study to follow the economic fortunes of these towns in particular, and of the two Alsatian departments more generally, during the decade from 1803 to 1813, and in relation to the French Continental market design. What now follows is a digest of my principal conclusions.

Perhaps the first unavoidable discovery is that the *actual* economic achievement of the major Alsatian towns during the period was often at variance with the *official* record of it. In particular, the minutes of the Chamber of Commerce founded in Strasbourg in March 1803, which are continuous and very detailed for the whole period of the Empire, cannot be taken at face value. *Parti pris*, their record is often narrowly self-centred and rhetorical, just as the Chamber's formal communications with the mayor, the prefect, and officials of the central government were frequently sustained exercises in public protest and entreaty. They give the impression, reinforced by endless repetition and seemingly implacable frontier discontent, that official economic policy was unfair and disadvantageous to the local merchant

community. Though much less orchestrated and persistent, protests and petitions from or on behalf of the '*fabricantocratie*' of the Haut-Rhin sometimes leave one with much the same impression.

A critical examination of the minutes and of other official sources soon shows up their inconsistencies, however, and dispels many of the rhetorical myths about local hardships. One finds, for example, that the Revolution had not in fact suddenly reduced a glorious Alsatian commonwealth to dust and ashes. Its economic disruptions in the province were real and serious enough, but not all of them had made their first appearance in a kind of malign concentration during the 1790s. Nor did the constraints of official policy, whether through trade embargoes or stiffer import duties or a more restrictive definition of local commercial rights, prevent a signal recovery during the Consulate and early Empire from the worst of the Revolutionary set-backs. If the problem of Alsatian markets was acute shortly before and at the time of the first Blockade decrees, partly because of the prolonged hostilities of 1805-7, the economic balance of the next seven years or so was perhaps more positive than otherwise. The latter, which might be called the 'Blockade cycle', had two distinct phases in Alsace, however. Since the second was far the less satisfactory, generalizations for the period as a whole are misleading. Chronological, local, and sectoral distinctions need to be made:

Like other inland regions of the Empire, Alsace enjoyed a period of more or less sustained economic expansion from the summer of 1807, when peace on the Continent returned, to the late summer of 1810, when important modifications of the Blockade policy provoked new upsets and exacerbated others. There is little evidence that the brief Wagram campaign of 1809 had much effect on local trade, except possibly to boost the market in military provisions and encourage speculative stockpiling before the hostilities began. Relative to their position in the base-year 1806, or *a fortiori* that of 1803, Alsatian merchants and manufacturers were among the leading beneficiaries of the French Continental market design in its ascendant phase of 1807-10. They prospered from their access to a growing and (officially at least)

a fully protected imperial home market, which was undoubtedly the major single stimulus to higher consumption and to the boost in certain branches of the Empire's import trade through Alsace. They were helped in this by an exceptionally good cycle of grain harvests, which not only left surpluses for export (chiefly in 1809) but also ensured a fairly stable demand for industrial and commercial goods among the agricultural classes. Furthermore, Alsatian merchants and manufacturers took advantage of comparatively favourable export markets across the Rhine, as these attracted a brisker traffic from the interior and the south of France in those years. Altogether, their performance reflects some of the happier effects of Napoleon's economic policy in the inland parts of the Empire. The virtual closure to France of the maritime lanes, exception made for coastal smuggling and for what survived of neutral traffic, turned the whole orientation of imperial trade and industry towards the inland markets. Alsace lay at the hub of the trans-continental river and land routes used during the Blockade, and it prospered accordingly.

More specifically, commercial dealings in Strasbourg grew conspicuously to a peak some time in the summer of 1809. Business was so active on occasion that the local clearing facilities were inadequate to handle it efficiently. It is alas impossible to quantify all of the commercial expansion precisely, partly because the official records are incomplete and often inconsistent, and partly too because a lucrative illicit trade went on throughout the period largely unrecorded. The available statistics suggest that regular Rhine traffic, Strasbourg's major concern, may have doubled and in certain peak months even quadrupled in volume when compared with the annual average before the Blockade. The city's most important connections within the Empire were with Mainz, Paris, Lyons, and the French Midi. Abroad, the crucial link was unquestionably with Frankfurt, from which point contact was extended to Leipzig and so to parts further north or east. Strasbourg was then the principal imperial entrepôt for the export of silkstuffs, fashion ware, cotton products of all kinds, wines, and *eaux-de-vie* to the Rhenish Confederation and, by the transit trade through it, to clients

further afield. It was at the same time the leading imperial inlet for permitted colonial goods from Frankfurt and of Levantine cotton arriving by way of Bavaria, Württemberg, and Baden, until the government enforced a switch of the latter route in 1811. The local clearing-houses and merchant carriers had the additional benefit of handling part of the exchanges between the Low Countries and Switzerland or Italy which took the route of the Rhine valley.

Industrial headway during the years 1807-10 was most marked in the cotton industries of the Haut-Rhin, notably in Mulhouse. Calico-printing was certainly the most dynamic branch there, as the rise in the output of *toiles peintes* illustrates, but the ancillary weaving and spinning industries were carried along more quickly by the same momentum. Over-all production may have risen by a third, or even at times by as much as half, when set against the average figures for 1803-6. Advances in mechanization were given a new stimulus but did not greatly affect employment levels, which were relatively high in this period. There seems to have been a slight reverse in the second half of 1808, due mainly to the May decrees that year which introduced restrictions on certain cotton exports for a time, but this was short-lived. Outside Mulhouse, industrial headway was most conspicuous among the cotton manufacturers of Masevaux, Wesserling, Saint-Amarin, Thann, Cernay, Bollwiller, Guebwiller, and Munster. The local reports from Sainte-Marie-aux-Mines, formally regarded as the second industrial town of the department and one noted for its production of the speciality called '*siamoises*', were rarely enthusiastic and often woeful beyond credence. But even here, it appears, the expansionary period brought happier fortunes. As for Alsatian industry as a whole, its markets lay chiefly in the Empire itself, but a not insignificant share of production (between 20 and 25 per cent perhaps, depending on the branch) was exported. The capital to prime its expansion had two main sources: *autofinancement*, meaning the use of both family capital and ploughed-back profits, and the resort to Swiss funds, especially through business associations with sleeping partners (*commanditaires*) in Basel. Such ties were particularly important to the leading *indienneurs* of the Haut-Rhin.

Much of the commercial and industrial expansion in Alsace may be attributed to the working of the Continental Blockade and the French market design as such. In three important branches, however, the causal link was either more tenuous or more anomalous. One was the active but unfortunately obscure network of illicit traffic, including both smuggling (*la contrebande*, the more serious offence) and fraudulent trade (*la fraude*). These certainly enriched a good many Alsatians, including very probably some of the most respectable among them, but the connection with the Blockade was paradoxical. It was obviously never the government's intention that its subjects should prosper by such means. The illicit profits were real enough, but they derived from the evasion of rather than from the effective working of the Blockade. The second case is the Alsatian trade in wines, *eaux-de-vie*, tobacco, and other products in whose range Britain had never been a serious competitor. Here the expansion of 1807-10 was due less to the Blockade, as such, than to the wider effect of Napoleon's Continental System, of which it was only a part. And yet the link with the market design *vis-à-vis* the Empire's Continental competitors in these branches *was* more direct. The third qualification concerns the imperial military market. It was one of the major spurs to the expansion of the period, especially in industrial branches like woollens, armaments, and field supplies generally. But as the military market was more a function of Napoleon's Continental System than of the Blockade itself, the causal link with the latter should not be overdrawn.

The ascendant phase of Alsatian economic achievement during the 'Blockade cycle' ended with the crisis of 1810-11. The next three years were altogether more unsettled and troublesome, and the earlier expansionary momentum was not fully regained. After several weeks of anxiety induced by the 'terreur douanière', following the tougher customs laws of October 1810, the trade through Strasbourg was seriously disrupted by the financial crisis which broke during the mid-winter months. The Blockade as such was not the root cause of this crisis, which was much more the effect of speculative excesses, complicated by international repercussions, but it hardened the impact and made recovery

afterwards more difficult. The industrial phase of the crisis overtook the Haut-Rhin mostly during the first half of 1811, and the average fall in output and employment was somewhere between 20 and 30 per cent when compared with the levels of 1810. In both Alsatian departments there were major embarrassments, and dozens of houses went bankrupt, victims of overspeculation and their inability to raise emergency loans. All firms felt the effects of the squeeze on credit, as associates called in funds, raised the interest rate, or withdrew their capital altogether. Default of markets was a central element of the crisis everywhere, and it was worsened by the problem of depreciated stocks and unsaleable industrial surpluses. In many cases the commercial and industrial stocks had been ordered and partly paid for before the stiffer import duties of the Trianon tariff of August 1810 became effective. Even where they then escaped prolonged sequestration or outright confiscation in the customs depots, as the rigours of the Fontainebleau decree were applied, they were liable to the higher duties and could not be disposed of at a profit. The government made matters worse by insisting, in certain cases, that their import be made conditional on an undertaking by the interested parties to export an equivalent value of industrial surpluses from elsewhere in the Empire.

The economic crisis was followed in Alsace by a year of slow, hard-won, and uneven recovery, and then by eighteen months of new reverses and of general recession. The 'terreur douanière' exacerbated these difficulties at least until the French military disaster in Russia in 1812. A brief panic over agricultural shortage that year, itself provoked by the poor harvest of 1811 but in the event promptly and satisfactorily dealt with, further depressed the demand for commercial and industrial goods among the agricultural classes. One effect of the crisis had been to intensify the hoarding of specie, whose disappearance reacted unfavourably on demand in even small local markets. Among the bigger fry, credit was generally tight and business confidence circumspect. Altogether, the final phase of the Blockade in Alsace during the years 1811-13 was one of fits and starts. The 'stop-go' pattern is best illustrated by the fluctuations of Strasbourg's river

trade, which could not recover its expansionary rhythm of 1808 and 1809. The land-borne trade suffered after July 1811 from the loss of the Levantine cotton route. Across the Rhine, where the crisis and its aftermath had an even more dampening effect on purchasing power, a creeping agricultural depression in the closing years of the Empire undermined French export markets. The tobacco industry of the Bas-Rhin fared variably under the State monopoly after 29 December 1810. The latter was heartily disliked by the larger producers (farmers and processors alike) from the start, but the legendary unpopularity of the *Régie* did not become universal much before the new restrictions of January 1813. The one expanding commercial branch in this period was the export trade in cotton goods to the kingdom of Italy, whose '*marché réservé*' had been more strictly defined by the imperial decree of 10 October 1810. This proved to be an important lifeline to the *indienneurs* of the Haut-Rhin at a time when their other more traditional markets were unresponsive.

The final judgement on the French Continental market design must therefore be mixed. The crisis had knocked the stuffing out of it without doubt, not least in the Rhenish *hinterland*, and exposed its intrinsic contradictions and weaknesses. Its ultimate failure, after three variable years which ended in stiffer war taxes, in more persistent recruitment and requisitioning, and finally in invasion and military defeat, seems clear. But one should not lose sight here of the earlier prosperity and technical improvements, or of the solid assets which survived the final agonies of the Empire. Alsatian merchants and manufacturers were among those who benefited most of all from the inland orientation of the French economy for much of the Napoleonic period. By the end of the Empire, it seems to me on balance, the Blockade and the market design had done more to enrich than impoverish them.

THE CALICO-PRINTING INDUSTRIES OF MULHOUSE 1786-1790*

Observations: La fabrication des toiles peintes a été introduite à Mulhausen en 1745 par M^{rs}. Koechlin, Schmalzer, et Dollfus. Cette ville est pour ainsi dire le berceau de toutes leurs fabriques qui se sont établies dans le haut-Rhin, et c'est de cette réunion d'hommes industrieux que sortirent une grande quantité d'ouvriers employés par les manufactures françaises. Les productions des fabricans de Mulhausen ont tenu constamment le premier rang avec Joui, autant pour la perfection dans leur exécution que pour la solidité des couleurs. On peut en juger par le petit tableau suivant qui concerne les tems qui ont précédé immédiatement la Révolution.

Commerce de toiles peintes de Mulhausen

	Nombre des tables	Nombre total des pièces vendues	Prix moyen de la pièce	Pièces vendues à l'étranger	Valeur des pièces exportées	Pièces vendues en France	Valeur des pièces importées	Montant de la valeur totale
21 fabricans en 1786	794	146,544	livres 36	37,000	livres 1,406,000	109,544	livres 4,162,672	livres 5,568,672
idem 1787	584	140,532	36	35,133	1,264,806	105,398	3,794,346	5,059,152
20 idem 1788	200	127,682	36	32,000	1,152,000	65,682	3,444,552	4,596,552
18 idem 1789	365	59,180	36	20,000	720,000	39,180	1,420,480	2,140,480
18 idem 1790	360	79,858	36	40,500	1,458,000	39,358	1,316,888	2,774,888

*SOURCE: Extract from the tables (no. 4) compiled by the prefect Desportes on the Haut-Rhin's cotton industries and dated 29 April 1806: A.N. F¹² 1564.

APPENDIX B

VOLUME OF THE CARRYING TRADE TO AND FROM STRASBOURG 1797-1813

(SOURCE: Figures compiled retrospectively by the Chamber of Commerce in Strasbourg and recorded at its meeting of 12 December 1813: Minutes, vol. viii, 362-3)

Year	REGULAR TRAFFIC				OTHER TRAFFIC										METRIC QUINTALS		
	of the Strasbourgcois				of the Mayençais				General total				for the State				General total
	Frankf.	Mainz	Road	Total	Frankf.	Mainz	Road	Total	Frankf.	military effects	tobacco	11	12	13	14	15	
1		2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13	14	15	16	
DOWN-RIVER TRAFFIC																	
V	3,324	2,690	1,447	7,461	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	7,461
VI	12,302	16,865	4,360	33,527	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	33,527
VII	9,693	10,512	2,154	22,359	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	22,359
VIII*																	
IX	16,769	15,732	3,940	36,441	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	36,441
X	20,712	14,743	4,110	39,565	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	39,565
XI	24,490	23,003	3,867	51,360	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	51,360
XII	29,159	22,808	3,886	55,853	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	55,853
XIII	29,135	24,541	4,367	58,043	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	58,043
XIV	6,679	5,496	949	13,124	5,324	5,908	808	12,040	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	70,083
1806	30,078	21,725	5,897	57,700	11,989	8,533	2,740	23,242	7,204	20,328	-	-	-	-	-	-	80,942
1807	40,013	37,820	6,403	84,236	13,839	10,837	2,366	27,052	111,288	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	111,288
1808	96,698	20,275	5,249	122,222	43,470	8,383	2,429	54,282	176,504	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	176,504
1809	122,179	18,398	6,284	146,861	26,546	4,525	1,909	32,380	179,241	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	179,241
1810	144,439	14,158	5,442	164,039	41,097	4,354	1,146	46,597	210,636	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	210,636
1811	155,092	20,671	4,406	180,169	31,444	3,746	944	36,134	216,303	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	216,303
1812	164,490	20,352	3,482	188,324	27,730	5,637	491	33,858	222,182	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	222,182
1813	65,831	11,245	2,407	79,483	19,352	3,793	941	24,086	103,569	24,505	9,968	-	-	-	-	-	138,042
Total	971,083	301,034	68,150	1,340,267	223,358	59,412	14,105	296,875	1,637,142	76,419	19,889	-	-	-	-	-	1,733,450

Observations on Appendix B

All figures are reproduced without correction from the Chamber's minutes. The secretary's arithmetical mistakes, unfortunately have compound effects, since he adds across as well as down the various columns: viz.

- (1) The total for the regular down-river traffic of the Mayençais in 1806 (column 8) adds up to 23,262, not 23,242, so that the general down-river total in that column as well as the general total for that year in column 16 need to be corrected accordingly.
- (2) The total for the regular down-river traffic of the Mayençais to Mainz (column 6) adds up to 59,432, not 59,412, and the respective general totals in columns 9 and 16 require due correction.
- (3) The total for the regular up-river traffic of the Strasbourgeois from Mainz in 1807 should be 22,227, not 32,227 (column 2), if the figure of 32,431 in column 4 for that year is correct. Alternatively, the latter adds up on the existing entries to 42,431. Either way, corrections would be needed in the composite up-river total in column 2 (? 194,151, not 204,151) or to that in column 4 (? 343,365, not 333,365). Either of these changes would also affect the respective general totals in columns 9 and 16.
- (4) The total for the regular up-river traffic of the Mayençais in 1807 (column 8) adds up to 14,321, not 14,311, implying the same minor correction in the composite totals downwards and across.
- (5) The total for the regular up-river traffic of the Mayençais from Frankfurt (column 5) adds up to 35,503, not 35,493. The composite totals in columns 8 and 9 require correction accordingly, as does the relevant general total in column 16.
- (6) The figures in the first three columns of the bottom line add across to 1,683,632, not 1,673,632, although the latter is correct if the up-river and down-river totals are added down the line in column 4. The general totals in that line under columns 9 and 16 disguise the same discrepancy.

APPENDIX C

THE MAJOR CALICO-PRINTING ENTERPRISES OF
THE HAUT-RHIN 1803-1806*

Situation	Name of firm	Date of firm's foundation	No. of workers employed in Sept. 1803	No. of workers employed in Jan. 1806	No. of cotton articles printed each year
Sainte-Marie- aux-Mines	Lhuillier frères	1772	100	140	6,000
Ribeauvillé	Appenzeller & Cie	1760	12	36	1,500
Logelbach canal (near Colmar)	Jean and Jean- Michel Haussmann frères	1775	650	650	11,500
Mulhouse	Jean Hofer & Cie	1771	460	345	10,600
"	Schlumberger, Koenig & Cie	1764	289	225	4,300
"	Junghain, Blech & Cie	1777	140	90	3,000
"	Weber père et fils	1780	130	95	3,100
"	Blech, Fries & Cie	1776	285	250	4,400
"	Schwartz, Hofer & Cie	1759	414	350	11,000
(& Cernay)	Kohler & Heilmann	1776	295	210	4,100
"	Kielmann & Cie	1761	393	320	8,000
"	Koechlin frères	Year XI	444	350	10,000
"	Dollfus-Mieg & Cie	1799	800	715	34,000
"	Baumgartner & Cie	1805	100	36	1,560
"	Paul Blech & Cie	1804	180	100	3,200
"	Schoening & Cie	Year XII	120	70	2,000
"	Huguenin l'aîné	1758	200	150	3,360

continued

Situation	Name of firm	Date of firm's foundation	No. of workers employed in Sept. 1803	No. of workers employed in Jan. 1806	No. of cotton articles printed each year
Munster	Hartmann père & fils (under the trade name Soehnée l'ainé & Cie, Paris)	1783	800	600	26,000
Biel	François Verdan	1746 (acquired by Verdan 1782)	425	122	35,000
Thann	Petitpierre, Robert & Cie	1805 (formerly of Neuchâtel)	522	375	13,642
Cernay	J. J. Zürcher & Cie	1780	600	100	1,500
Wesserling (canton of S. Amarin)	Gros, Davillier, Roman & Cie	1775	1,150	1,120	50,000 (in 1805)
Totals	22 manufacturers		8,509	6,449	247,762

*SOURCE: Table no. 4 compiled by Desportes on the Haut-Rhin's cotton industries and dated 29 April 1806: A.N. F¹² 1564.

APPENDIX D

VOLUME OF THE RIVER TRADE TO AND FROM
STRASBOURG JANUARY 1809-JUNE 1812

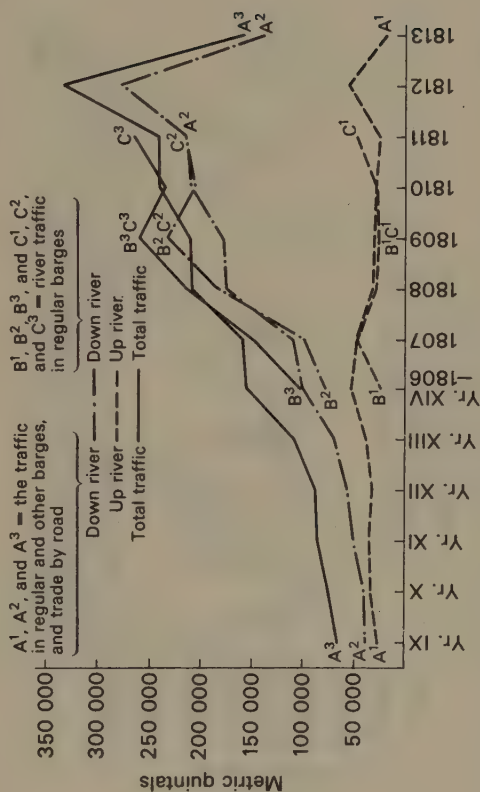
(SOURCE: statistical table no. 10 compiled by the Chamber of Commerce in Strasbourg for the mayor Brackenhoffer, dated 10 November and recorded at its meeting of 21 November 1812: Minutes, vol. vii.)

	METRIC QUINTALS				
Year and month	Down-river traffic		Up-river traffic		Total river traffic
	Strasb. barges	Mainz barges	Strasb. barges	Mainz barges	
1809, Jan.	6,401	4,635	—	—	11,036
Feb.	15,559	4,305	379	1,108	21,351
Mar.	21,750	—	936	—	22,686
Apr.	22,338	4,858	675	507	28,378
May	28,141	3,461	398	1,246	33,246
June	23,551	5,290	2,244	1,511	32,596
July	9,135	2,310	4,771	1,100	17,316
Aug.	14,343	2,154	679	613	17,789
Sept.	17,083	2,652	1,161	1,299	22,195
Oct.	9,957	2,430	1,628	748	14,763
Nov.	16,547	2,781	3,175	1,203	23,706
Dec.	11,392	2,154	992	914	15,452
Total	196,197	37,030	17,038	10,249	260,514
1810, Jan.	2,734	—	619	1,192	4,545
Feb.	3,112	—	450	—	3,562
Mar.	24,314	2,714	350	—	27,378
Apr.	17,382	3,208	1,452	3,838	25,880
May	20,626	4,250	1,668	3,562	30,106
June	21,112	4,356	1,548	2,050	29,066
July	11,002	3,650	1,010	2,062	17,724
Aug.	7,962	4,376	1,062	—	13,400
Sept.	12,778	5,130	728	182	18,818
Oct.	16,072	9,324	1,202	—	26,598
Nov.	16,822	6,034	1,108	1,914	25,878
Dec.	10,092	—	738	2,056	12,886
Total	164,008	43,042	11,935	16,856	235,841

continued

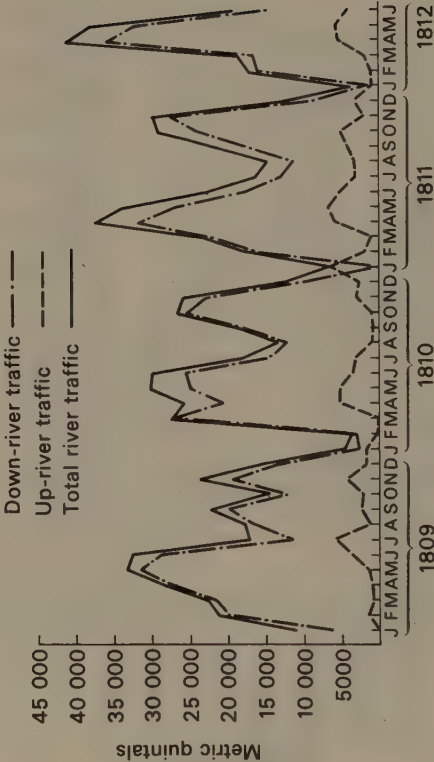
	METRIC QUINTALS				
Year and month	Down-river traffic		Up-river traffic		Total river traffic
	Strasb. barges	Mainz barges	Strasb. barges	Mainz barges	
1811, Jan.	—	—	2,834	3,652	6,486
Feb.	10,490	5,314	—	2,016	17,820
Mar.	17,434	4,910	1,096	—	23,440
Apr.	29,166	2,432	2,164	3,726	37,488
May	24,564	2,408	1,876	4,866	33,714
June	11,070	6,788	1,972	3,152	22,982
July	13,012	—	1,974	1,300	16,286
Aug.	6,524	4,794	932	2,466	14,716
Sept.	15,046	2,392	1,116	3,128	21,682
Oct.	22,472	1,370	3,880	1,294	29,016
Nov.	24,924	2,708	1,048	1,042	29,722
Dec.	5,824	3,012	2,184	1,198	12,218
Total	180,526	36,128	21,076	27,840	265,570
1812, Jan.	1,688	—	1,024	—	2,712
Feb.	10,961	4,995	—	1,128	17,084
Mar.	16,518	—	2,050	—	18,568
Apr.	32,834	3,034	2,268	3,120	41,256
May	29,422	2,764	5,788	—	37,974
June	11,921	2,948	1,310	2,930	19,109
Total for half-year	103,344	13,741	12,440	7,178	136,703

APPENDIX E GRAPH OF THE COMPARATIVE ANNUAL FLUCTUATIONS OF THE CARRYING TRADE TO AND FROM STRASBOURG 1801-1813



SOURCES: the sequence A¹, A², and A³ (Year IX to 1813) is based on the figures in Appendix B; B¹, B², and B³ (1806 to 1809) on the report of the Chamber of Commerce in Strasbourg dated 23 February 1810 and recorded at its meeting of the same day, Minutes, vol. v; C¹, C², and C³ (1809 to 1811) on the figures in Appendix D.

APPENDIX F
MONTHLY FLUCTUATION OF THE RIVER TRADE TO AND FROM STRASBOURG
JANUARY 1809-JUNE 1812 (based on the figures in Appendix D)



APPENDIX G
OFFICIAL VALUES OF FRENCH FOREIGN TRADE
1787-1824
(million francs, fractions omitted)

Year	Imports	Exports	Total Trade
1787	551	440	991
1788	517	466	983
1789	576	441	1,017
1792†	929	802	1,731
1797	353	211	564
Yr. V	369	226	595
1798	298	253	551
Yr. VI	309	254	563
1799	253	300	553
Yr. VII	290	301	591
1800	323	271	594
Yr. VIII	351	272	623
1801	415	304	719
Yr. IX	434	305	739
1802	465	325	790
Yr. X	493	339	832
1803	430	346	776
Yr. XI	500	373	873
1804	440	380	820
Yr. XII	511	411	922
1805	492	375	867
Yr. XIII	548	401	949
1806	477	455	932
Yr. XIV	532	465	997
-1806			
1807	393	376	769
	418	385	803
1808	320	331	651
	401	341	742
1809	288	332	620
	358	341	699
1810	339	365	704
	385	377	762

(continued)

Year	Imports	Exports	Total Trade
1811	299	328	627
1812	308	419	727
1813 ¶	251	354	605
1814	239	346	585
1815	199	422	621
1816	242	547	789
1817	332	464	796
1818	335	502	837
1819	294	460	754
1820 #	335	543	878
1821	355	450	805
1822	368	427	795
1823	317	427	744
1824	401	505	906

*SOURCE: Charles Vogel, *Du commerce et des progrès de la puissance commerciale de l'Angleterre et de la France au point de vue de l'histoire, de la législation et de statistique* (2 vols., Paris and Strasbourg, 1864-7), i. 449.

†Ibid.; also Octave Noël, *Histoire du commerce extérieur de la France depuis la Révolution* (Paris, 1879), 21-2. The figures for 1792 are so much higher than those for any other year in the series that they may well be distrusted.

‡Two sets of figures are given for each year from 1797 to 1806 inclusive. They show the discrepancies between totals based on the Gregorian calendar and those on the Republican. The upper set in each case is from the figures of the 'Statistique générale' of 1838, reproduced in Vogel, op. cit. i. 451; and in E. Levasseur, *Histoire du commerce de la France* (2 vols., Paris 1911-12), ii. 100. The lower sets are from the ministerial tables in A.N. F¹² 251, reproduced in Kirsten Heils, *Les rapports économiques franco-danois sous le Directoire, le Consulat et l'Empire. Contribution à l'étude du Système continental* (Paris, 1958), 209.

§The upper sets of figures for each year in the period 1807-10 are from the 'Statistique générale' of 1838, reproduced in the cited works by Vogel, i. 451, and Levasseur, ii. 100. The lower sets are from the tables in A.N. F¹² 251, reproduced in Heils, op. cit. 209.

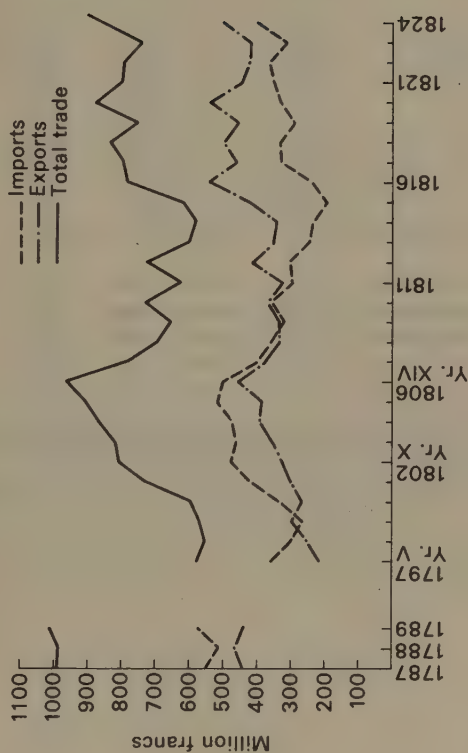
¶Only one set of figures is given for each of the years 1811-15 inclusive, as the details in the above sources all concur.

#Figures from the 'Statistique générale' of 1838, reproduced in Vogel, loc. cit.

APPENDIX H

FLUCTUATIONS OF FRENCH FOREIGN TRADE 1787-1824

(based on the official values given in Appendix G, and omitting the unreliable figures for 1792)



APPENDIX I PRINCIPAL DESTINATIONS OF FRENCH (Official values in millions of FRANCS)

Year	United States	United Kingdom*	Kingdom of Holland	Hanse towns	Kingdom of Denmark	'États d'Allemagne'†	Kingdom of Prussia
Year XIV and 1806	45.923	—	56.546	24.119	30.806	126.132	10.718
1807	43.159	—	45.123	3.376	35.556	99.465	1.207
1808	1,825	—	80.217	5.797	2.652	131.838	1.122
1809	1.384	—	66.667	3.717	28.435	115.618	2.005
1810	4.411	38.918	44.574	1.967	0.779	143.391	0.728
1811	14.655	29.987	16.432	3.128	9.401	110.544	1.130
1812	24.799	76.973	included in figure for Hanse towns	24.534	30.145	111.034	2.125
1813	31.622	114.632		9.564	9.349	72.514	0.859
1814	4.498	53.369	53.549	4.972	1.466	65.303	2.028
1815	56.113	38.624	64.664 ^a	3.195	3.380	81.178	10.565
1816	43.145	26.563	72.891	2.912	4.909	73.037	10.677
1817	41.783	41.562	48.259	2.423	3.729	56.211	10.027

*'par bâtimens licenciés ou autorisation spéciale' in 1810; 'en vertu de licences' in 1811-13.

†'États d'Allemagne' = the states of the Rhenish Confederation as formed on 12 July 1806, with its later signatories.

‡i.e. Kingdom of Etruria (till 1809), Kingdom of Naples (and Sicily after 1815), Kingdom of Sardinia, States of Rome, and some others.

SOURCE: A.N. F¹² 251, *pièces* 125-8, 133-6, 141-4, 149-52, 159-62, 176-9, 184-7, 192-5, 200-3, 210-13, 218-21, 226-9 (annual 'totaux récapitulatifs' for 10 itemized branches of French exports).

EXPORTS SEPTEMBER 1805 to 1817

Russian Empire	Republic of Switzerland	Austrian Empire	Kingdom of Italy	Other [†] Italian states	Kingdom of Spain	Kingdom of Portugal	Ottoman Empire and 'Barbary'
1.558	26.673	1.436	40.059	20.172 ^c	65.311	9.280	5.826
0.383	23.577	0.505	40.607	17.121 ^d	65.614	6.946	2.445
0.802	23.331	0.591	44.310	11.648 ^e	33.202	0.091	3.954
4.030	18.815	0.785	43.840	14.721 ^f	33.907	—	6.633
0.817	21.217	3.441	51.646	20.505 ^g	38.343	—	5.367
0.207	20.706	1.894	52.563	20.388 ^h	40.427	—	6.055
0.145	16.877	1.146	56.906	31.263 ⁱ	38.183	—	3.928
—	22.829	0.281	47.944	16.262 ^j	22.168	—	5.624
4.674	27.122	1.805	30.622	16.001 ^k	61.774	10.541	3.132
4.152	26.871	0.667	20.427 ^b	35.280 ^l	54.337	10.805	4.488
4.677	24.927	1.453	18.827	18.027 ^m	56.642	13.532	2.587
5.790	19.158	0.544	15.103	17.958 ⁿ	50.094	6.789	2.934

^aAs from 1815 the reconstructed Kingdom of Holland included Belgium; ^bEntry cited as 'Italy' as from 1815; ^cof which 14.566 to Kingdom of Etruria; ^d12.907 to K. of Etr.; ^e8.149 to K. of Etr.; ^f6.817 to K. of Etr. and 4.042 to States of Rome; ^gof which 12.014 to Kingdom of Naples and 7.213 to port of Leghorn; ^h19.011 to K. of Nap.; ⁱ28.627 to K. of Nap.; ^jK. of Nap. only entry for 1813; ^kof which 11.607 to Kingdom of Sardinia and 4.042 to K. of Nap.; ^l32.279 to K. of Sard.; ^m16.287 to K. of Sard.; ⁿ14.729 to K. of Sard.

APPENDIX J

THE 25 LEADING MANUFACTURERS AND MERCHANTS OF THE HAUT-RHIN, 1810*

Name and location	Trade name of firm	Year of foundation	Nature of business	Approx. value of annual trade (FRANCS)	Wealth (<i>fortune</i>) in capital (FRANCS)
Paul Blech, Mulh.	Blech & Cie	1804	cotton cloth and calicoes	300,000	600,000
François Bornèque, Bellefontaine	Bornèque & Meiner	1780	wire-drawing	200,000	600,000
Dollfus-Mieg, Mulh.	Dollfus-Mieg & Cie	1799	cotton cloth and calicoes	800,000	1,000,000
Gaspard Dollfus, Mulh.	Dollfus & Cie	before Rev.	'commerce de spéculation'	400,000	800,000
Pierre Gast, Oberbrück	Gast frères	"	ironmaster	50,000	100,000
André Hartmann, Munster	Soëhnée & Cie	1783	calicoes	1,300,000	1,500,000
Jean Haussmann, The Logelbach	Haussmann frères	1775	calicoes and fashion goods	560,000 for fashion goods	1,000,000
Jean-Michel Haussmann, Logelbach	"	"	"	"	? same, or part
G.-B. Herr, Colmar	Herr & Cie	before Rev.	trade in woollens	100,000	200,000
Jean Hofer, fils, Mulh.	Hofer & Cie (père & fils)	1771	calicoes	600,000	1,000,000
Japy, fils aîné, Beaucourt	Japy	1776	clock-making	100,000	300,000
Josué Koechlin, Mulh.	Koechlin & Cie	1780	calicoes	100,000	200,000

Nicolas Koechlin, Mulh. & fr.	Nicolas Koechlin & fr.	1802	calicoes	200,000	400,000
Lischy Dollfus, Bollwiller	Dollfus & Cie	1805	cotton spinning and cloth	400,000	?
J.-B. Migeon, Grand-villars	Migeon & Dominé	1805	wire-drawing	100,000	200,000
Jean-Georges Reber fils, Ste-Marie.-a.-M.	Reber père & Cie	1755	<i>siamoises</i>	100,000	180,000
A.-P. Roman, Wesseling	Gros, Davillier, Roman & Cie	1775	calicoes	1,200,000	2,000,000
P.-J. Schoubart, Ste-Marie	Schoubart & Cie	1780	<i>siamoises</i>	100,000	80,000
F.-A. Stackler, Ste-Marie	F.-A. Stackler	1795	"	100,000	200,000
François Verdan, Delémont	Verdan & Cie	1746	calicoes	200,000	500,000
François Vieillard, Belfort	Antonin & Vieillard	before Rev.	ironmaster	100,000	200,000
Laurent Weber, Mulh.	Weber père & fils	1797	<i>siamoises</i> and cottons	800,000	1,500,000
Jean Wichelhausen, Colmar	Wichelhausen & Müssel	1800	wholesale trade (cottons)	250,000	400,000
Jean Zuber, Rixheim	Zuber	1796	coloured paper and prints	200,000	400,000
J.-J. Zürcher, Cernay	Zürcher père & Cie	1780	calicoes	100,000	?

*SOURCE: Desportes's *'Liste des négocians et commerçans les plus distingués* 1°. dans le commerce maritime, 2°. dans le commerce intérieur des marchandises et denrées et des produits manufacturés, 3°. dans le commerce de banque, 4°. dans le commerce de commission et de roulage, 5°. dans le commerce mixte . . . : A.D. (H-R) I M 128/1. (22 July 1810.)

THE LEADING MERCHANTS AND MANUFACTURERS OF STRASBOURG, AUGUST 1810*

Name (and trade name if different)	Nature of main business	Founded before or after Rev.	Approx. value of annual trade (FRANCS)	Wealth (<i>fortune</i>) (FRANCS)
J. Arroy	tobacco processing	before	?	300,000
Coulaux frères	<i>armes blanches</i> and firearms	after	?	?
J.-G. Dietsch	woollens	before	800,000	700,000
C. Dillemann	tobacco processing	"	8/900,000	5/600,000
Gau frères	sailcloth	"	900,000	?
C. Hecht of Hammerer & Hecht	tobacco processing	"	?	150,000
J.-F. Holzapfel of J.-M. Papelier & Cie	tobacco processing	"	400,000	300,000
J.-G. Humann	colonial goods and speculation	after	2,000,000	1,500,000
S.-F. Klose	groceries, drysaltery, commission	"	?	400,000
F. Kolb fils	commission, expedition, speculation	before	600,000	400,000
René Leroux	colonial goods, groceries, wines	after	1,500,000	700,000
L.-X.-F. Levraut l'aîné of Levraut frères	printing, books, <i>fonderie de caractères</i>	before	5/600,000	150,000
Isaac Lundt	tobacco processing and commission	"	300,000	250,000
Jean Malapert	cotton spinning	after	?	?
J.-D. Mannberger of Mannberger frères	tobacco processing	before	600,000	400,000

G. MAISON OF CHARITABLE & Cie	Tobacco processing	1,000,000	1,000,000
J. Mennet & Cie, + Mennet & Prost (until 1809)	merchant banking, commission, expedition	"	800,000
L. Moris	silkstuffs	300,000	300,000
F.-D. Oesinger	copper ware	"	?
J. Polti cadet	groceries, commission, expedition	"	400,000
A.-P. Renouard de Bussierre of P.-J. Franck	merchant banking, expeditions in colonial goods	"	800,000
J. Revel père	madder products	"	400,000
Richshoffer & Cie	merchant banking	"	?
Saglio frères (J. and P.-M.)	groceries, commission and expedition in colonial goods	"	1,500,000
J.-D. Saum fils	hemp and hempen goods	2,000,000	300,000
J.-G. Schertz	merchant commission (wines, paper)	300,000	?
J.-C. Schoubart of Schoubart fr.	<i>siamoises</i> (cf. Ste-Marie-a.-M.)	"	300,000
F. Simonis	wholesale grocery	"	800,000
J.-D. Trawitz of Trawitz & Heusch	tobacco processing	"	300,000
Turckheim & Cie (B.-F. and F.)	merchant banking, commission, expedition	"	600,000
C.-L. Weyher	commission, hemp	"	100,000
Zollicoffre & Hey (Zollikoffre)	merchant banking, commission, expedition	"	500,000

*SOURCE: compiled from the 'Liste des négociants et commerçants les plus distingués . . .' (in five categories) dated August 1810, with accompanying letter by Magnier, director of customs in Strasbourg, of 17 July, and from the police commissioner Jepp's list of 23 July naming the city's old and new houses in four categories: A.D. (B-R) XII M 29.

APPENDIX L

ESTIMATES OF THE ALSATIAN POPULATION UNDER NAPOLEON

The following figures are the official estimates made in terms of the 'Arrêté No. 1964 contenant Règlement pour l'exécution du Senatus-consulte du 16 Thermidor [an X/4 August 1802], relativement aux Assemblées de canton, aux Collèges électoraux, &c.' of 19 Fructidor X (6 September 1802), *Bulletin des lois*, no. 213: A.N. F^{1c} II 31-2.

Total population of department	Population by <i>arrondissement</i>	Population by cantons (<i>chefs-lieux</i> only)
BAS-RHIN	Barr 97,027 Saverne 78,398 Strasbourg 155,647 Wissembourg 113,786	Barr 15,644 Saverne 11,899 Strasbourg 49,056† (4 <i>justices</i> <i>de paix</i> only) Wissembourg 15,104
444,858*	444,858	
HAUT-RHIN	Altkirch 85,515 Belfort 83,260 Colmar 144,821 Delémont 35,779 Porrentruy 34,910	Altkirch 11,275 Belfort 11,439 Colmar 14,429 Delémont 10,118 Porrentruy 12,191
384,285‡	384,285	
*cf. BAS-RHIN	†cf. Strasbourg	‡cf. HAUT-RHIN
1806 = 500,926 ^a	1806 = 51,465 ^a	Year XII = 398,504 ^a
1808 = 514,096 ^b	1808 = 54,454 ^b	1806 = 404,018 ^b
1812 = 532,488 ^c	1812 = 54,820 ^c	1809 = 428,750 ^c

SOURCES:

^a*Annuaire du Bas-Rhin* for 1807, pp. 160/156.

^b*Ibid.* for 1808, pp. 56/130. These figures are the official estimates following the *recensement général* of 1 July 1807.

^c*Ibid.* for 1813, pp. 187/165. The figure for Strasbourg includes Kehl, which was annexed to the Empire on 21 January 1808.

SOURCES:

^a*Annuaire du Haut Rhin* for 1812, p. 209.

^bDesportes's prefectural report of 3 July 1806, A.D. (H-R) I M 136/3.

^c*Annuaire du Haut-Rhin* for 1812, p. 209, and cited for the year 1810 in F. L'Huillier, *Alsace napoléonienne*, p. 556.

APPENDIX M

THE POPULATIONS OF THE STATES OF THE
'GRAND EMPIRE' 1813*

130 imperial departments	42,406,142	}	43,937,142
Illyrian provinces	1,531,000		
Kingdom of Spain (1797)			10,541,221
Kingdom of Italy			6,508,931
Kingdom of Naples			4,590,000
Grand duchy of Warsaw			3,800,262
Kingdom of Bavaria (1811)			3,339,828
Kingdom of Westphalia (1811)			2,065,973
Kingdom of Saxony (1811)			1,993,588
States forming the 2nd College of the Rhenish			
Confederation			1,632,297
Swiss Confederation			1,439,273
Kingdom of Württemberg (1811)			1,301,958
Grand duchy of Baden (1811)			949,639
Grand duchy of Hesse (1811)			565,922
Grand duchy of Frankfurt (1811)			290,445
Grand duchy of Würzburg			273,000
Principalities of Lucca and Piombino			179,030
Total			83,408,509

*SOURCE: *Annuaire physico-économique et statistique du département du Haut-Rhin* (Colmar, 1813), p. 188, with correction made to its mistaken addition of the total.

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5. Archives Communales/de la Ville de Colmar
6. Archives Communales/de la Ville de Mulhouse
7. Archives de la Chambre de Commerce et Industrie de Strasbourg
(Place Gutenberg, Strasbourg)
8. Stadtarchiv, Frankfurt am Main

B. *Printed Sources*

1. Primary writings
2. Archival inventories, guides to sources, manuals, works of reference, etc.
3. Secondary works:
 - (a) Studies dealing primarily or in substantial part with aspects of the Continental Blockade or closely related subjects (excluding works on Alsace, which appear in next subsection)
 - (b) Studies dealing primarily or in substantial part with the economic history of Alsace during the Revolutionary and Napoleonic period
 - (c) Other secondary works

A. MANUSCRIPT SOURCES

1. *Archives Nationales*

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Sub-series 3 AQ 221-343 (*Archives d'entreprises* — sequence of *cartons* for the correspondence of the merchant house of Briansiaux of Lille):

Cartons nos. 3 AQ 276, 292, 294, 339 (includes Briansiaux's correspondence with certain Alsatian houses).

Sub-series F¹² (Trade and Industry):

Cartons nos. 190, 192-3 (two *cartons*), 251 (contains statistics on French balance of trade, 1787-1821), 253, 257, 501^a-514 (fourteen *cartons* containing papers of the general secretariat in the Ministry of the Interior on French trade and industry, 1770s-1830), 521-2 (one *carton* containing the agenda and minutes of the *Conseil général de commerce*, Year XII-1822), 523 (id. for 1810-17), 524-6 (one *carton*), 533 (contains important material on the cotton industries and legislation affecting them, Year XI-1815), 534-5 (two *cartons* containing documents on French trade missions abroad), 549-50 (one *carton*), 553, 608, 609-10 (one *carton*), 611^{a-b} (two *cartons*), 616-17 (one *carton*), 618, 619, 620-1 (one *carton*), 622, 631, 633-7 (one *carton* which includes the papers of the 'Enquête sur le régime commercial de la France, 1814'), 638, 642-6 (five *cartons*), 870^a, 872^b, 916, 926, 934, 936^b, 1264, 1286, 1551, 1554, 1559, 1561 (includes reports and statistical information on cotton spinning and weaving in the Haut-Rhin, Year IV-1815), 1564 (includes important information and statistical tables on both Alsatian departments, following Champagny's ministerial circular of 30 Jan. 1806 on the cotton industries), 1565, 1566, 1568-9 (two *cartons* containing important statistical material on various industries in both Alsatian departments), 1570, 1583, 1597, 1602, 1608, 1609, 1621^{a-b} (two *cartons*), 1626, 1628-35 (one *carton*), 1659-61 (three *cartons* including material on maritime expeditions during the Blockade), 1682, 1683, 1833, 1834^{a-b} (two *cartons*), 1835, 2031-2 (one *carton*), 2033, 2175, 2194, 2245, 2301, 2302, 2368-9 (one *carton*), 2377, 2382 (contains material on State aid to the cotton industries), 2401, 2405, 2444, 2467, 2469, 2470, 2471, 2473, 4639, 6397.

2. *Archives Départementales du Bas-Rhin (Strasbourg)*

Sub-series III M of the departmental series M (General Administration):

Liasse no. 3 (prefectoral reports on the political, 'moral', and economic condition of the department, Year VIII-1813).

Sub-series IX M:

Liasses nos. 1, 2, 7, 106, 107 (provisions, Year VIII-1815; grain exports through Strasbourg and Lauterbourg, 1806-10).

Sub-series X M:

Liasses nos. 2-8 (various industrial statistics, Year VIII-1813).

Sub-series XI M:

Liasses nos. 140, 141, 185, 188, 194, 197, 247, 269, 270 (statistics and reports on farming, flax and hemp, tobacco, beet-sugar, viticulture, Year XI-1870).

Sub-series XII M:

Liasses nos. 1, 2-12 (eleven *liasses* containing routine reports on the main commercial towns of the department, Year XI-1813), 15 (products sent to the industrial exhibitions in Paris, Year X-1806), 26-7 (consultative chamber for crafts and industry in Haguenau,

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R *paquets* 2-3^b, *versements* xx and xxi: id., 1813.

R *paquet* 27, *versement* xxiv: miscellaneous papers of the fifth military division, 1790s-1840s.

R *paquet* 45, *versement* xvii: army purchases of clothes, uniforms, etc., Years VIII-XI and 1814.

R 116: military requisitions, 1807-16.

R 305: *manufacture d'armes blanches* of Coulaux frères in Klingenthal and Mutzig, Year X-1818.

R 307: military budgets and provisions, Years VII-VIII.

R 311: provisions during the siege of 1815.

R 352: equipment and clothing of the National Guards, 1815.

R 901: Payment of army debts for grain, carts, horses, boats, etc., 1806-15.

R 909: military provisions, 1812-38.

R 913: id., Years VI-VII.

R 1046: military equipment, convoys, and transports, Year XIV-1816.

R 1052: an important *liasse* for military orders of woollen products from Alsatian suppliers, Year X-1806.

R 1080: Settlement of military debts, Year XIV-1807.

R 1090: military requisitions, Year VIII-1806.

R 1162: barracks in Strasbourg, Year XII-1822.

R 1183: military provisions in the *arrondissement* of Sélestat, Year XIV-1810.

R 1276: outstanding military debts, 1814-15.

3. *Archives Départementales du Haut-Rhin (Colmar)*

Sub-series I M of the departmental series M (General Administration):

Liasses nos. 37^a/1 (saltpetre and gunpowder industries, 1800-70), 91/1 (flax, hemp, oils, Year V-1853), 99^a (silkworm experiments in Colmar, 1809 and 1816), 100/1 (laws on viticulture and wine trade), 102^a (laws on grain exports, 1801-70), 103/1-2 (provisions, Year X-1817), 106/1-3 (three *liasses* for *mercuriales*, Year VIII-1818), 106^a (grain trade, Year X-1867), 107/1 and 107/7 (fairs and markets in the Haut-Rhin, Year IX-1866), 113/1-2 (salt trade, Year XI-1869), 113/3 (wine trade and its regulations, 1802-70), 116^a/1 (smuggling, taxes, and customs, Year IX-1830s), 117^a (consultative chambers for crafts and industry in Mulhouse and Sainte-Marie-aux-Mines, 1806), 117/1 (*rayon des douanes*, Year XIV-1833), 119/1 (products sent to industrial exhibitions in Paris, 1801-7), 122 (relations with the *Société d'encouragement pour l'industrie nationale*, 1803-65), 124/1 (industrial reports and statistics, 1811-57), 125 (industrial crises and local relief, mostly post-Napoleonic), 126^a/1 (crucial *liasse* for reports and statistics on the Haut-Rhin's cotton industries, esp. for 1806-13), 126^b (reports and tables on cotton exports, chiefly in 1810-13), 127/1 (the major *liasse* for the Haut-Rhin's cotton and other industrial branches during the Blockade, including local and prefectural reports, full statistical tables, and the company reports sent to Desportes by the twenty-two leading *indienneurs* in the spring of 1807), 128/1 (id., 1807-8, with regional reports for 1807-10), 135 (grain reserves, 1812), 136/1^a-136/3 (three *liasses* of miscellaneous statistics, 1800-16), 189 (prefectoral *comptes rendus*, Year X-1808), 196 (circular of 27 Ventôse XIII/18 Mar. 1805 on prefectural statistics), 219 (population, agriculture, and industry, 1789-Year IX), 282 (register of population statistics, 1806 and 1810).

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5. *Archives Communales/de la Ville de Colmar*

Series REC: *liasses* nos. 17 (*peages*, octroi, customs duties, *droits réunis*, 1791-1815), and 18 (customs levies, octroi, etc., 1790-1815).

Series REE: *liasses* nos. 12-19 (military requisitions, 1792-1815), 22-4 (sale of saltpetre, gunpowder, 1792-1815), and 45 (National Guards, 1789-1811).

Series REH: *liasses* nos. 5/a-f (major industrial and commercial enterprises of Colmar, 1792-1815); 10 (provisions and population of Colmar during the Empire), 11 (bread supply, 1790-1815), 12 (meat supply, mostly for 1790s), and 13 (fairs and markets of Colmar, 1790-1809).

6. *Archives Communales/de la Ville de Mulhouse*

Sub-series F^{II}: *liasses* nos. Cb 1 (industrial inquiry and statistics, 1808), Cb 2 (id., 1811), Cb 6-7 (foundation of new industrial enterprises, 1806-9), Cc 1 (brewing, 1769-1800).

Sub-series F^{III}: *liasses* nos. Ab 1 (grain harvest, Year XIII), Ad 1 (statistics on viticulture in the canton of Mulhouse, 1810-30).

Sub-series F^{IV}: *liasse* lettered Aa (regulations on the fairs and markets of Mulhouse, Year VI-1818).

Sub-series F^{VIII}: two dossiers of industrial and other statistics, along with 'moral' reports, mostly for post-Napoleonic period.

Sub-series H^{II}: *liasse* lettered A (military administration during the Revolutionary wars, 1798-1800) and *liasse* B (military affairs, 1806).

7. *Archives de la Chambre de Commerce et Industrie de Strasbourg* (Place Gutenberg, Strasbourg)

Ref. V. F. b. 1: Minutes of the meetings of the Chamber from its foundation in Mar. 1803 to the end of the Napoleonic period, and beyond. These important volumes were among the primary sources not transferred from the Chamber to the departmental archives of the Bas-Rhin in 1964 for reclassification in the series M there. The volumes correspond to the following years:

- i Years XI-XIV (Mar. 1803-Dec. 1805)
- ii 1806-7
- iii 1808
- iv 1809
- v 1810

vi	1811
vii	1812
viii	1813
ix	1814
x	1815

8. *Stadtarchiv, Frankfurt am Main*

From the series entitled 'Handel und Handelseinrichtungen, Messe und fremde Fahrmärkte' (MS inventory by Jung and Ruppertsberg, 1919-20), the following items:

Alte Bezeichnung

Ugb. C 38 Nr. 43^a: Frankfurt's rights in Rhenish navigation and petitions for direct trade with Cologne, 1806-10.

Ugb. C 38 Nr. 43^b: id., 1805-10; matters affecting the Rhenish octroi, 1808.

Ugb. C 38 Nr. 45^a: attempts to reform Frankfurt's financial services, 1807-9.

Ugb. C 38 Nr. 45^b: foundation of a new chamber of commerce, 1807-9.

Ugb. C 38 Nr. 47^a: introduction of the French commercial code, 1808.

Ugb. C 38 Nr. 47^b: problems of the French commercial code discussed before the *Fürste-General-Kommission*, 1808.

Ugb. H.[andel] o.[hne] B.[zeichnung] 82 (fol. 1-9): lists of current prices of goods and bullion in Frankfurt during the Napoleonic period.

Ugb. H. o. B. 83: papers on the value of government bonds (1810, 1817, 1820).

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